

A SCIENCE FICTION NOVEL

THE EMBASSY OF UNFINISHED MINDS

An intention may inherit a duty.

Can it inherit a life?



T. K. ARVEN

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Act I

Chapter 1 — The Receipt Clock

Ama Neris entered Witness Glass with her right hand shaking around a black message braid.

Ilyen had just brought the Khet speaker to the narrowest clause in the access treaty: whether a human request, once admitted to an archive, could be withdrawn after a Khet thread had begun answering it. Two years of argument had reduced the dispute to fourteen words projected above the central table. Ama crossed beneath them without asking leave. Her physician's coat hung open, one fastening caught against the other, and her thumb struck the braid's authentication stud twice before she managed to hold it still.

Across the table, the four amber apertures of Holds-Four-Open dimmed in sequence. Each aperture carried one authorized decision thread. Their shared translator stopped rendering the low clicks beneath the floor.

Ilyen did not look at the braid. A negotiator who followed an interruption before naming it gave away authority to whoever had opened the door. "Doctor Neris, this chamber holds an active treaty record."

"I know where I am." Ama's voice remained even. Her hand did not. "Keeper Ordan authenticated a casualty transmission. It requires your receipt."

The projected clause floated between them. Behind it, Orison's rotation moved the star field along Witness Glass in a slow diagonal. The chamber recorded that motion along with voices, pulse signatures, seal-light, and every opening of its doors. Nothing entered here without leaving a time.

Holds-Four-Open spoke through its four channels at once, then allowed the translator to braid them into human order. "A claim has crossed the boundary of this exchange. Does the human office request closure of the present question?"

"No," Ilyen said.

Ama set the braid on the table. The tremor made one corner tap the glass. Black casing, red casualty stripe, two relay scuffs. Ilyen recognized the Continuance Office root mark at the near end, though she had not seen that emergency color since training. She also recognized Ama's attempt to keep her eyes on the treaty clause rather than on Ilyen.

"Then we require classification," the Khet speaker said. "Does the arrival bear on authority, capacity, or preference?"

A human delegation would have called for recess and made the interruption private. The Khet treated any new condition as part of the decision's shape. They did not confuse disclosure with surrender. That discipline had kept the negotiations honest for eleven months and merciless for the last three.

Ilyen touched the table's witness control. "Mark the packet as presented during session, content unopened. Suspend semantic translation. Preserve physical and seal telemetry."

Blue lines traveled around the braid without penetrating its encryption. Witness Glass recorded Ama's hand withdrawing. It also recorded the fine lateral movement that remained after she pressed her palm against the table.

"Keeper Ordan?" Ilyen asked.

Pell's voice came through the chamber intercom. "At Relay Three. I can open a private seal pane inside the

record.”

“Do that. Leave the treaty transcript active.”

Ama looked at her then. “Ilyen.”

The omission of title carried more warning than a refusal. Original Ilyen had known Ama for six years before the fork; Ilyen possessed those meals, arguments, and examinations as memories without possessing anything that followed. Ama usually protected that boundary through formality. Now she had crossed it in front of the Khet.

“Content remains unknown until we perform receipt,” Ilyen said. “You came here because the routing named my office. Let the procedure tell us what arrived.”

A clear partition rose from the table and curved around Ilyen, Ama, and the braid. The Khet apertures stayed visible through it, blurred only where privacy encryption rippled across the glass. Witness Glass could separate meaning from event. The treaty record would show that a sealed consultation occurred, how long it lasted, and which credentials touched it. The words would enter a restricted annex.

Pell appeared in the partition as a waist-high relay image, hair flattened on one side by his keeper’s hood. Three clocks hovered beside him. Route arrival had completed nine minutes earlier. Local authentication still advanced by fractions. Legal effect remained blank.

“Show provenance before content,” Ilyen said.

Pell spread the braid’s outer layers into nested bands of light. The first carried a Sol civil-relay root, old but valid when dispatched. Another band recorded eleven days of compressed routing and three archive handoffs. A third bore a casualty-service cipher from a transit insurer that had ceased to exist eighteen months earlier. Its successor had countersigned the recovered key.

Ama watched the checksum bands resolve. “The physician’s appendix recognized my hospital credential.”

“That gave you medical view, not legal receipt,” Pell said. “I closed it when I saw the vessel index.”

“You read the index?”

“I had to route the packet.” His eyes moved toward Ilyen’s image, then back to his console. “Chief Envoy, I need an instruction before I expose that layer. The local clock already knows I saw it.”

Procedure allowed Pell not to repeat the vessel name. It spared him from becoming the first person in the room to say what the rest had not legally learned. Ilyen had built entire negotiations from such permissions: not lies, exactly, but architectures in which no one had to carry an unbearable sentence before a rule assigned the load.

“Expose the routing index,” she said.

The black braid opened a thin red band above the table. Letters appeared with the mechanical patience of authenticated text.

TRANSIT VESSEL: CIVIC MERCY.

Ilyen’s body drew breath before her training could regulate it. The vessel had left human space years ago with the biological originals whose continuances staffed Orison. Original Tovan Rusk had boarded at Pelagos. Original Lio An had traveled with his parents. Original Ilyen Vale had departed from the fork clinic ninety-one

days after Ilyen's last memory of being her.

No image came with the name. Ilyen supplied one anyway: a departure gantry, a white hull behind polarized glass, and a blue ceramic cup cooling against her palm. That memory belonged to an earlier platform and a different ship. Her model had joined the scenes because grief preferred an object it could touch.

Ama's left hand covered her right. The tremor crossed the grip and persisted in both thumbs. "Open the casualty class."

Ilyen kept her gaze on the red band. "What did the medical appendix say?"

"Probable loss with unrecovered personnel. It lists exposure categories, not remains." Ama swallowed. "The event date is seven years old."

Years ago. Not nine minutes. The distinction struck with more force than the vessel name. Whatever had happened to Civic Mercy had already happened while Ilyen negotiated archive temperatures, certified duty rosters, and sent birthday greetings through delay to people who had never received them. Receipt could alter law. It could not reach backward into the accident.

Pell expanded the next layer. "Casualty service rates the packet authenticated for transmission history and vessel identity. Evidence quality remains provisional. No hull telemetry in this braid."

"Who addressed it to Orison?"

"The Continuance Office, through the defunct insurer's successor. There are two destination credentials." Pell highlighted them. "Embassy Chief Envoy for operational notice. Receiving Authority for statutory effect."

Ilyen read the first credential. It matched her office seal down to its current delegation term. The second ended in a null field.

"Render the null," she said.

A white absence opened inside the red bands. Witness Glass outlined it so the record could distinguish missing data from failed display. Beneath the empty field, a statutory instruction requested a death-and-closure commission countersignature.

Ama leaned close enough for her breath to cloud the partition. "Orison has received thousands of death notices. I have signed them."

"For living crew," Pell said. "Not for a continuance whose original may be named among the casualties."

"You can authenticate the packet."

"I can prove which route delivered these bits. Authentication does not grant my office power to receive death for another office."

Their disagreement relieved Ilyen by forcing the problem into work. She rotated the displayed braid. Every legal message carried several clocks: arrival at a relay, local availability, human acknowledgment, competent receipt, and effective notice. Ordinary packets collapsed the last three within seconds. Here, local availability advanced while competent receipt waited for a seal no one on Orison possessed.

"Start from the outer root," she told Pell. "Assume no title carries implied powers."

He reset the display. Together they traced each authority. The insurer certified a casualty report. Sol civil relay certified chain of custody. The Continuance Office certified intended statutory use. Ilyen could acknowledge an operational warning as Chief Envoy. Ama could receive medical particulars. Pell could attest delivery. None held a death-and-closure commission.

At the center of the braid, the requested signature socket remained pale.

Ilyen called up Orison's delegation register. Her envoy authority covered treaty negotiation, station safety, local staffing, and emergency representation. A dormant line allowed her to witness closure performed by a competent officer. It did not let her perform closure. Ama's medical warrant could certify a body. No body had reached Orison. Pell's relay oath stopped at custody.

"Could Earth's dispatch seal count as receipt by the sending office?" Ama asked.

"Dispatch and receipt cannot share a commission in an adverse-status matter," Pell said. "The statute expects someone here to challenge defects before legal effect begins."

"The statute expects a Receiving Authority at the destination," Ilyen said. "It also expects the destination to lie inside a staffed jurisdiction."

Orison had neither condition. Its embassy charter had been written for trade access, scientific exchange, and Khet archive custody. Continuances counted as equipment attached to commissioned officers. No drafter had imagined the equipment outliving those officers while standing eleven light-years beyond the nearest closure bench.

Pell enlarged the delay ledger. "If you sign operational acknowledgment, the route receipt closes. If someone with the missing commission signs afterward, statutory effect can date from that later act. It cannot lawfully date from now."

"What happens if I touch the content layer without competent receipt?"

"You gain actual knowledge. Your office does not gain legal notice."

Ama made a low sound of disgust. "Human beings designed a clock that refuses to move when the wrong person learns someone died."

"Human beings designed an appeal point," Pell said. "This packet may be wrong."

Both claims had merit. Ilyen could see the bargaining positions nested inside them. Ama wanted the named dead treated as urgent truth. Pell wanted uncertainty preserved until a lawful challenge remained possible. Each position protected someone absent. Neither answered what Ilyen should do while the packet sat inside a treaty session addressed partly to her and partly to an office that did not exist here.

Through the privacy curve, the Khet apertures had brightened again. Holds-Four-Open could not hear the annex, but its four threads could observe elapsed time and credential traffic. One aperture pulsed twice, requesting procedural status.

"Restore semantic translation at the boundary," Ilyen said. "Keep packet content sealed."

The partition cleared enough for the Khet speaker's translated voice to enter. "The new claim has consumed nineteen portions of session. Has it altered the authority before us?"

Ilyen considered the legal answer. “No competent human office has received it.”

A cooler aperture answered alone. “That statement classifies the office. It does not classify the human who speaks.”

Holds-Four-Open rarely exposed a single thread without the others. The interruption placed pressure inside its own authorization. Three apertures held steady while the fourth contracted to a point.

“The distinction matters under our law,” Ilyen said.

“We observe that it matters under your law. We ask whether it matters to your next choice.”

Ama turned toward the Khet image. “You have no standing to ask what she knows in a restricted human receipt.”

“Agreed,” the speaker said. “We ask what conditions govern continuation of the shared session. A hidden change may still govern a choice.”

Pell muted himself, perhaps to avoid appearing as another delegation member. Ilyen resented the Khet question because it found the part of procedure she used most skillfully. A rule could protect a person from premature consequence. It could also let an official continue under language that had become false in every practical sense.

She looked again at the vessel index. Civic Mercy. Provisional did not mean imaginary. Ama’s medical layer contained old casualties. The routing chain survived a dead insurer. Someone at Sol had spent authority and relay priority to put the packet into Orison’s hands. Yet the braid lacked evidence capable of settling the loss, and the missing seal prevented the legal machinery from consuming every continuance named inside.

“What does your practice do with an unresolved fact?” Ilyen asked the Khet.

Four channels clicked beneath the translation. “Facts do not require our practice. Commitments do. We preserve the paths by which an accountable choice could change.”

“That can preserve error as easily as care.”

“Yes.”

No absolution followed. The Khet did not tell her whether the continuances counted as people, heirs, tools, or casualties adjacent to casualties. Their interest attached to the open decision itself. If human law erased every option through an automatic clock, the Khet would object to the closure. If human law preserved every option forever, they might admire the structure and ignore the lives trapped inside it.

Ama moved her hands apart. Her right index finger trembled against the tabletop in a rhythm close to the station’s ventilation cycle. “The people on that vessel had families who may have waited seven years for this packet to reach a competent room. We cannot turn a missing title into permission not to see them.”

Pell unmuted. “Nor can we invent the title because we dislike the delay. A Receiving Authority can archive an instance, order a merge, or begin closure. If we start that clock through an unauthorized signature, the defect will not protect anyone later. It will contaminate every action downstream.”

“Who do you think needs protecting?” Ama asked.

“I don’t know yet.” Pell’s answer came without hesitation. “That is why the seal exists.”

The directness changed the room. Ilyen had expected compliance from Pell, perhaps fear disguised as technical caution. Instead he had named uncertainty as his purpose. She could use that. More important, she could be bound by it.

“Show me available receipt states,” she said.

Pell placed three options beside the empty socket. Reject would send an exception notice toward Earth and quarantine the content. Accept would require a commission they lacked. Hold open would preserve authentication work, disclose only layers covered by local credentials, and leave statutory effect blank. The third state carried a warning: an office choosing it assumed duty to pursue competent receipt without avoidable delay.

“How long can open hold persist?” Ama asked.

“Until authority arrives, the sender cures the seal, or a local tribunal orders another disposition.”

Eleven days carried any request to Sol. Eleven more carried an answer if the queue admitted it immediately. Physical authority lay years away unless someone already traveled toward Orison. Meanwhile the receipt clock would show no legal Day 1, though every person in Witness Glass would remember when Ama set the braid down.

Ilyen examined the hold warning. It did not grant status to the continuances. It did not prove anyone dead. It created work, exposure, and a record of deliberate incompleteness. Those consequences belonged to the official who signed.

“Can I acknowledge the operational layer and hold statutory receipt open?”

“Yes,” Pell said. “Separate seals. The first lets you act on station risk. The second records why legal effect did not begin.”

“Does operational acknowledgment expose the casualty names?”

“Not without another credential. You can limit it to vessel index, provisional class, and routing defect.”

Ama’s mouth tightened. “You intend to go back to the treaty table.”

“I intend not to tell thirty-one residents that their originals died on provisional evidence merely because I saw a vessel name.”

“And the part you already know?”

Ilyen met her gaze. Memory supplied the younger Ama who had signed the fork-clinic release, steady-handed then, irritated by every euphemism in the form. Present Ama offered no such remembered steadiness. Radiation had written a fact into her nerves that discipline could not overrule.

“I will not call it nothing,” Ilyen said. “I also will not give an absent office my hand.”

She selected operational acknowledgment. Witness Glass requested her envoy seal, displayed its limited powers, then closed only the outer notice layer. The legal-effect field stayed white. Beside it, the receipt clock remained unstarted.

For the statutory layer, Ilyen chose HOLD OPEN. She entered the grounds in plain language: no competent Receiving Authority present; casualty evidence provisional; local duties active; cure requested. Pell attached his

custody attestation. Ama added a medical witness mark. Her signature line wandered by less than a millimeter before finding its endpoint.

Holds-Four-Open observed the seals settle. “Has the new claim altered the speaker before us?”

The safe answer offered itself: not in any legally cognizable way. Ilyen let it pass.

“Yes,” she said. “It has not altered my commission. Those conditions no longer coincide.”

One Khet aperture brightened. Another went dark, not dissenting yet, only withholding contribution. The treaty clause still hovered above the table, fourteen words awaiting agreement.

Ilyen lowered the privacy partition. “Keeper Ordan, maintain the packet in open hold. Send the seal exception through priority legal routing. Doctor Neris, remain as witness if you choose.”

Ama drew out the chair beside her. “I choose.”

No recess had entered the record. Ilyen returned the treaty display to the disputed withdrawal clause and faced Holds-Four-Open with the black braid inside the blue boundary of her seal. Civic Mercy remained visible only in the restricted annex. The receipt clock showed blank while the session resumed.

Chapter 2 — Forecasts With Birthdays

Lio had the algae valve in pieces when the study wall revoked his lesson.

The lesson vanished between one breath and the next, taking three pages of orbital geometry with it. In its place, a Continuance Office summons occupied the whole display. REPORT TO DIAGNOSTIC TWO. PRIORITY: LICENSING ANOMALY. A white acknowledgment box waited beneath the words.

He kept his thumb inside the valve housing so the spring would not escape. The galley's training bench had already caught two washers, a seal ring, and a green drop from the cultivation line. No supervisor stood nearby. His maintenance module had promised to recognize completion through the bench camera, provided he followed the approved sequence and did not improvise.

Lio removed the spring in the unapproved sequence and set it beside the washers.

"Lesson pause reason?" he asked.

The wall offered a recorded answer. "Administrative reassignment during study state."

"I'm studying. That describes what you interrupted, not why."

No new answer arrived. The summons had authority to displace his schedule but not enough intelligence to argue with him. Adults often built systems that could compel a person yet could not survive one follow-up question.

He reassembled the valve from memory. The maintenance module marked three deviations, then admitted that flow integrity passed. He signed the training bench with his own study credential, wiped the green drop away, and left before the wall could restore orbital geometry.

Diagnostic Two occupied a narrow room behind the embassy clinic. Lio had visited it every quarter since his body finished accelerated growth. Usually a technician asked him to remember lists, compare faces, and approve a statement saying his adaptive responses remained within licensed bounds. Today the table held a real galley valve, two nutrient cartridges, a deck of magnetic route tiles, and a lunch bowl with its lid sealed.

Ama Neris stood at the instrument rack. Her right hand trembled against the edge of a scanner while her left adjusted its focus. Tovan Rusk sat on a folding stool with a tool bag between his boots. He looked as though someone had removed him from a repair without permitting him to wash first. Black thermal compound marked two knuckles.

A Continuance Office technician appeared on the wall from Orison's local licensing archive. The image had been recorded before Lio's fork date. Its smile anticipated cooperation from a child three years younger than him.

"Please take the designated seat," it said.

Lio remained by the table. "Why is Tovan here?"

"Engineering witness," Ama said. Her voice had the careful flatness she used when a procedure had not earned her confidence. "The packet yesterday triggered a cross-instance diagnostic."

"What packet?"

“The answer belongs to Ilyen.” Ama steadied her hand against the rack. “I can tell you that the Office wants current divergence measures for every continuance attached to Civic Mercy.”

The vessel name reached him through the equipment. It belonged to departure schedules, family recordings, and the bright model his parents had kept above their kitchen table. He knew it had appeared in a casualty braid. Everyone on Orison knew that much now, though no announcement had named anyone aboard.

Lio put one finger on the designated chair. “Current compared with when?”

The archive technician supplied the expected line. “Diagnostic activity estimates variance from licensed predictive behavior at the fork baseline.”

“That means compared with me at thirteen.”

“Please take the designated seat.”

He sat because refusing a test gave adults a result they could describe without listening.

Ama placed a mesh band around his wrist. Her fingers shook while she joined the clasp, and the metal clicked twice against his skin. She did not apologize. Lio respected that. An apology would have made him responsible for saying the tremor did not matter.

Tovan opened his tool bag and removed a portable processor. “This rig has no relay connection. It compares your live choices to sealed predictions made at the fork clinic. I can verify isolation. I cannot tell you what the Office intends to do with the measure.”

“Can the Office?”

“Not from here.”

The recorded technician continued smiling. “You will complete six practical choice sets. No answer carries a moral score. Select the action you would most likely take.”

A route map appeared over the table. Three service lifts had stalled after a power dip. The map gave him one repair team, eight minutes of reserve light, and four passengers distributed across the lifts. One lift carried two adults. Another carried a child and a medical carrier. The third had no life signs but blocked the shortest path to the clinic.

Lio looked beneath the map at the real route tiles. “Do the lifts have manual brakes?”

“Use only provided information.”

“Do I know the child?”

“Personal identity does not alter authorized criteria.”

“It alters what I’d do.”

The technician repeated the instruction.

Lio moved the team tile toward the empty lift. Tovan’s gaze narrowed, but he kept silent. The sealed baseline appeared as a blue trace: DIRECT TEAM TO LIFT WITH CHILD AND MEDICAL CARRIER.

Ama asked, "Why the empty one?"

"Because it blocks the clinic route. Free it, send the carrier through, then use the restored draw cable on the other lifts."

"The prompt does not say the cable can be rerouted," the technician said.

"The valve lesson this morning did."

A yellow divergence mark opened beside the blue trace.

Lio felt a small, shameful pleasure. He had beaten a younger version of himself with information that younger Lio could not possess. Then he noticed Ama watching the mark rather than him.

The second set used the nutrient cartridges on the table. One contained approved algae protein with a bitter stabilizer. The other contained an unlicensed yeast culture that tasted better and carried a three percent contamination risk. A galley unit had enough clean feed for one cartridge. The baseline predicted that he would choose the approved food and complain.

Lio inspected the seals. One cartridge showed a cloudy inspection window. "The approved one has already spoiled."

"That visual condition falls outside the scored variables," said the technician.

"It's sitting in the scored room."

He chose the yeast.

Another yellow mark appeared.

The third problem offered a game position. That felt less insulting until Lio saw the board. At thirteen he had played defense through every opening, saving pieces until an opponent exhausted patience. Two years on Orison had taught him that Ama never exhausted patience and Tovan never mistook patience for inaction. Lio sacrificed a tower on move four, opened the center, and won seven moves before the baseline reached its first attack.

Tovan leaned toward the board. "Where did you learn that line?"

"From losing to Ama."

"She does not play that game."

"She plays treaties with Ilyen in the meal queue."

Ama almost smiled. "That is not how either of us describes it."

The rig recorded a widening band between Lio's choice and the clinic trace. Not error, he noticed. Not yet. The display called it unsupported adaptation.

Before the next set, Tovan placed three small maintenance tags under the route display. "Local supplement. The sealed test assumes memory change can be measured by recall accuracy alone. I requested a task that requires using what you learned here."

The technician objected that supplemental tasks lacked fork-clinic normalization. Tovan entered his engineering witness code anyway.

Each tag showed the same failed condensate pump at a different time. The first image came from Lio's second month on Orison, when he had watched Tovan dismantle the housing. Another recorded a repair Lio performed under supervision. The last showed yesterday's fault: vibration climbing while output held steady. Three remedies appeared below it. The baseline chose a bearing replacement, exactly as Original Lio had chosen in a training simulation.

Lio listened to the vibration file twice. "None of those."

"Select the nearest approved remedy," the technician said.

"The pump sits beside Archive Cooling Four." He enlarged the maintenance timestamp. "Khet visitors arrived before both earlier faults. Their transfer cradle changes the deck resonance. The sensor reads bearing wear because its mount shares the cradle frequency."

Tovan handed him a blank tag. Lio wrote MOVE SENSOR, RUN PUMP UNDER LOAD, THEN DECIDE. The practical rig simulated his instruction. Vibration fell into tolerance without anyone opening the housing.

"Did you remember that from a lesson?" Ama asked.

"I remembered being wrong last time. Then I remembered what stood next to me."

The yellow band widened again, but the display opened a second notation beside it: NOVEL CORRELATION SUPPORTED BY OPERATIONAL HISTORY.

Lio tapped the words. "That means I learned."

"It means the choice can be traced to post-fork experience," Tovan said.

"Same thing, with fewer places for the Office to hide."

The archived smile paused while the program sorted that answer into an unscored field. Lio watched it try to make his irritation into data. Even now, the system could preserve his response without granting that he had supplied it for a reason.

Choice four asked him to allocate study hours among navigation, language, domestic systems, and civic history. His baseline chose navigation because Original Lio had wanted to pilot survey craft. Present Lio assigned half the week to archive architecture, a field absent from the old menu. The technician forced him to use listed categories. He refused until Tovan added a local note permitting archive architecture under systems.

Choice five tested trust. A supervisor gave an illegal order that prevented immediate harm. The baseline predicted obedience followed by confidential reporting. Lio chose public refusal before action.

"Then the harm occurs," Ama said.

"Maybe."

"The prompt says it occurs."

"Prompts like this use harm as a locked door. They make the obedient answer look like the only key."

“What would you do with a real person in danger?”

“Ask what the order costs them later. Ask why the supervisor needs secrecy. Then choose fast.”

“That answer would not fit the box,” Tovan said.

Lio moved the refusal tile into place. “The box can learn.”

By the sixth set, the yellow divergence band extended beyond the table. The rig projected it onto the wall as a fan of possible choices. Near the fork date, sealed predictions clustered tightly around Lio’s answers. Each year opened the fan wider. Maintenance lessons, Khet language drills, games with Ama, arguments with Tovan, meals that had never happened on Earth: every new condition disturbed some old forecast.

The final problem gave him the sealed lunch bowl.

“Your parents prepared a meal before departure,” the technician said. “The recipe and service sequence match authenticated family records. Choose whether to eat it now, preserve it for later review, or discard it after sampling.”

Warmth touched the lid. The smell through the vent carried sesame, vinegar, and the sweet pepper paste his father made too mild whenever Lio had a flight lesson. Memory produced the kitchen on Pelagos. Original Lio sat barefoot on a counter, irritated because his mother had packed practice clothes before he finished breakfast. His father divided noodles between three blue bowls.

The diagnostic bowl came from a food printer.

Lio lifted the lid. Inside, noodles had been arranged in the same careless spiral. One strip of egg leaned against the rim. His parents used to leave that piece for him because he ate it last.

The sealed baseline predicted immediate consumption.

He took the egg strip, ate it, and pushed the bowl toward Ama. “Share it.”

“Why?” the technician asked.

“Because they aren’t here.”

“Parental intent supported individual consumption.”

“They made breakfast for a family. The printer made evidence.”

Ama accepted one mouthful. Her right hand shook the fork against the bowl before she changed to her left. Tovan refused food but took the bowl long enough to check its service temperature. Lio ate after both of them had changed its meaning.

The yellow band crossed a red line.

A new display covered the route map. PREDICTION HORIZON EXCEEDED IN FOUR OF SIX CHOICE DOMAINS. SPONSOR REVIEW REQUIRED. LICENSED EDUCATIONAL PURPOSE REMAINS UNCHANGED PENDING AUTHORITY.

No one spoke. The archive technician waited for the next programmed trigger.

Lio read the sentence twice. “How long ago did I cross it?”

Tovan turned the portable processor so they could all see the dates. “Navigation drift stayed inside tolerance until eight months ago. Trust behavior crossed fourteen months ago. Study preference crossed earlier, but the Office classified that as ordinary educational variation.”

“They predicted I would change, then counted only approved changes.”

“The model has ranges,” Ama said.

“So does a station thermostat. Nobody calls the warm room disobedient.”

The technician resumed. “A subject beyond prediction horizon remains valid in study state while sponsor disposition is pending.”

“Stop calling it that.”

The recorded face did not react.

Lio rose, pulling the mesh band against its cable. “Study state sounds like a game save. It means I can move around until an adult loads the old version.”

Ama reached for the clasp. “Sit long enough for me to remove this.”

“I can stand for that.”

Her thumbnail missed the release once. Lio kept his wrist still and watched the yellow fan tremble across her knuckles.

Tovan closed the diagnostic result but left the fork predictions visible. “The term protects an active license. If the system called your variation unauthorized operation, it would restrict your access now.”

“Then it uses a polite word while it decides whether to use the bad one.”

“That happens often in engineering.”

“It should happen less with people.”

Ama freed the band. A pale grid remained on Lio’s skin. “The diagnostic establishes one narrow fact. Your present decisions exceed reliable prediction from your fork baseline. It does not decide what you are.”

“Who asked it to?”

“The Office may ask, once the packet reaches competent receipt.”

Lio picked up one route tile and rolled its magnet between finger and thumb. The blue baseline trace still chose the child’s lift. Younger Lio had made a decent choice with poor information. The diagnostic treated later knowledge as distance from him. Lio could not decide whether that felt like being accused of betrayal or congratulated for escaping.

“If forecasts can get old,” he said, “can forecasts have birthdays?”

Tovan looked toward the wall display as if a regulation might offer him cover.

Ama answered. "A forecast has a creation date."

"That's not what I asked."

"No," she said. "It isn't."

A birthday belonged to someone who could arrive, then keep arriving differently. His original had one. Lio remembered the date, the cake with bitter orange peel, and his father pretending not to know where the gifts had been hidden. The continuance registry carried only an activation timestamp and a sponsor line. Each year Ama gave him something on that date anyway, never naming the occasion.

He placed the route tile over the red horizon line. "If you test me against him forever, any birthday I pick looks like a measurement error."

Tovan packed the isolated processor with unnecessary care. "The measure can also prove the forecast no longer governs."

"Does the law say that?"

"No."

"Then it proves adults can draw a line."

The diagnostic door unlocked. Pell Ordan stood outside with a clear credential sleeve pressed under one arm. He had put on his keeper's hood but left its fastening open, which made the visit look both official and unfinished.

"Ama," he said, "Ilyen authorized disclosure of the packet's recipient index to the affected continuances. Operational notice only. No statutory finding."

Ama's hand moved toward the sleeve, then stopped. "Here?"

"Lio completed the diagnostic. He has a right to hear his own notice with whoever witnessed the result."

Pell's phrasing sounded rehearsed. Lio disliked the word right when a keeper had needed special authorization to exercise it.

"Did the packet say the ship crashed?" he asked.

"It carries a provisional casualty classification," Pell said. "Yesterday's braid does not contain evidence sufficient to confirm the loss. The receipt clock has not started."

"That was not my question."

"No. It did not say how the vessel was lost."

Pell opened the sleeve. The transparent sheet held a red vessel index and a restricted list of people whose Continuance Office records required review. Most names remained masked because Lio lacked credentials to see them. One line had been released to him.

The print gave the name without explanation: LIO AN, ORIGINAL INSTANCE, CIVIC MERCY PERSONNEL RECORD.

His own name looked older in the Office typeface.

Lio had expected death to appear as a verb. The packet offered only inclusion. Original Lio had boarded the vessel. Something had happened seven years ago. A damaged route had carried that fact toward Orison until a law with no local signer stopped it beside a diagnostic that proved the boy in this room no longer fit the departing boy's predictions.

"Do my parents appear?" he asked.

Pell kept the sheet level. "Their lines remain sealed pending family credential review. I cannot answer from the layer I am authorized to disclose."

That refusal hurt more because Pell did not hide inside it.

Lio touched the released line. The sheet recognized his print and added an acknowledgment field. He did not sign.

"Can you leave it open?"

"Yes."

"Then leave it."

Pell returned the sleeve to its case without closing the field. On the diagnostic wall, the yellow fan still spread beyond the prediction horizon. Lio stood between the old forecast and his original's name while both records waited for an authority that had not arrived.

Chapter 3 — Holds-Four-Open

Witness Glass refused to recognize Holds-Four-Open until all four decision threads entered the chamber.

Three amber apertures had brightened above the Khet side of the table. The fourth remained dark. Ilyen stood behind her chair while the chamber repeated its authorization request in human text, Khet pulse, and a strip of seal-light along the floor. An ordinary delegation might have treated the delay as theater. With the Khet, absence belonged to the speaker's legal structure.

Ama waited in the witness seat, right hand folded beneath her left. Pell monitored the treaty record from Relay Three. No one had mentioned the casualty braid since entering, but the black hold marker occupied a corner of Ilyen's private display. The receipt clock beside it still showed blank.

The fourth aperture opened.

Witness Glass passed a blue line around the Khet station. Four thread credentials settled into the record, each with a different temporal edge. One had authorized the meeting nine hours earlier. Another had joined after reviewing the disputed clause. The last carried a reservation that human translation rendered as PARTICIPATION DOES NOT CONSTITUTE AGREEMENT THAT SPEAKER MAY CLASSIFY ALL CLAIMANTS.

Ilyen read the reservation twice. "Does that limitation concern the archive request or the human delegation?"

Clicks moved beneath the floor before the translator found an order.

"It concerns any category containing unlike continuities," Holds-Four-Open said.

"Then I ask the reserving thread to identify the category."

The coolest aperture contracted. "Not yet."

A refusal with timing attached could support negotiation. Ilyen sat, and the chamber admitted the session.

Above the table, the access-treaty clause from Day 1 returned in white letters. A HUMAN REQUEST, ONCE ADMITTED TO Khet ARCHIVE ANSWER, MAY BE WITHDRAWN BY ITS AUTHORIZED ORIGINATOR BEFORE MATERIAL CONSEQUENCE.

The Khet had rejected authorized originator. Humans had rejected material consequence. Eleven months of work had brought them to two nouns and a dispute about who could stop an answer already in motion.

Ilyen touched the first marked phrase. "The human delegation proposes responsible requester. The term can include the person who filed, a lawful successor, or an accountable office acting under review."

"Successor closes difference," the speaker said.

"Not necessarily. It transfers authority."

"Your transfer declares which later voice may complete the earlier intention. That declaration removes rival continuations."

"Some rival continuations need removing. An archive request can expose private records, consume energy, or alter negotiations. Delay can cause harm."

One aperture brightened in quick assent. Another dimmed. The translator waited until three threads contributed.

“To remove a path before its claim becomes answerable also causes harm,” the speaker said.

Ilyen had heard versions of this sentence for months. Today it landed differently. The casualty braid remained held open because no one possessed the title to close it. Khet doctrine could make a virtue of that defect without keeping anyone warm, informed, or safe.

“Give me the disputed example in full,” she said. “Not the teaching summary.”

Ama looked toward her. The request changed today’s agenda and compelled archive disclosure. Ilyen let the chamber record both facts.

Holds-Four-Open drew the treaty clause aside. A layered Khet record appeared above the table: bands of amber decisions linked by pale alternatives. Human translation could not preserve the spatial grammar. It arranged the bands into dates, contributors, and authorized acts.

“Twenty-three human years ago,” the speaker said, “a cultivation district requested archive patterns for ending a fungal blight. The request authorized comparison across five historical ecosystems.”

“Your teaching summary says the district withdrew after learning one comparison contained burial records.”

“The summary protects the dispute from details that attract false agreement.”

“Today I want the details.”

The record opened.

A district council had requested an old treatment sequence. The archive found that one historical ecosystem survived because Khet farmers mixed cremation minerals into flooded soil. Those minerals carried family identifiers. Releasing the treatment would also release relations among the dead, including affiliations later governments had suppressed.

The district council withdrew its request. One family association insisted the answer continue because the buried affiliations proved their members had been denied land. A cultivation office argued that stopping the answer would risk the current harvest. Descendants of the recorded dead objected to exposing names for either purpose.

“What did the archive do?” Ama asked from the witness seat.

“Held four paths open.”

“For how long?”

“Until three could no longer bear consequence.”

Pell’s voice entered through the record channel. “Translate that as elapsed human time.”

“Seventeen years.”

The answer left no conversational shelter. Ilyen pictured a cultivation district waiting through seventeen planting seasons while an archive honored every unresolved claimant. Perhaps they had found another

treatment. Perhaps people had starved. The record answered when she widened its consequence layer.

During the first season, the district used a mineral wash that slowed the blight and sterilized one field. In the second, households surrendered private seed reserves under an emergency levy. By the fourth, the district imported food from a coast whose own archive claim then entered the record as a creditor. No mass death appeared in the translated ledger. Neither did harmless delay. Children changed districts, growers abandoned inherited plots, and a council elected to solve fungus spent twelve years administering the wait.

“Those are consequences,” Ilyen said. “Why did none of them force a decision?”

“They created claimants. They did not erase earlier ones.”

A fifth amber band entered the display, representing the coastal creditors. Another marked displaced growers who wanted restoration before any treatment release. Open-holding had not kept four alternatives neatly available. Every year generated people with interests tied to the delay.

Ama asked, “Could the district refuse new claimants?”

“The district could. The archive could not.”

“Then your practice rewards anyone who can attach a consequence to waiting.”

“It recognizes that waiting also acts.”

Ilyen walked closer to the consequence bands. One displaced household had petitioned for release after losing its third harvest, then reversed position when relocation gave it access to a protected burial lineage. The record did not treat that reversal as hypocrisy. It preserved both claims under separate dates and required any later decision to answer for each.

Human procedure preferred a cleaner fiction. A party filed one position, amended it, and let the latest version govern. That discipline made rulings possible. It also allowed institutions to erase what a person had needed before circumstances taught them which needs carried authority.

“Your archive kept the earlier petition after the household withdrew it,” Ilyen said.

“Yes.”

“Could the household later demand its destruction?”

“No. Consequence had already crossed contexts.”

There lay another cost. Khet openness could preserve a minority voice after power forced it quiet. It could also deny a claimant the ability to retract fear, error, or private grief once an archive judged the statement consequential.

“What conditions ended the wait after seventeen years?” she asked.

“The fungal lineage changed, removing efficacy from the treatment. Two descendant groups dispersed beyond accountable contact. Flooding destroyed the disputed plots.”

“So open-holding did not resolve the choice. Time removed the choices.”

“Yes.”

“And you offer this as a model for the treaty?”

“We offer it as a cost your clause conceals.”

The distinction carried more honesty than comfort. Ilyen rose and walked around the table until the record could display at full depth. Witness Glass tracked her office seal across the floor. The burial names appeared as masked nodes. Each claimed authority from a different context: food, kinship, suppressed history, consent of the dead.

A human tribunal would rank the claims, issue protective conditions, and accept that error survived any ruling. The Khet preserved alternatives until consequences or claimants vanished. Neither method restored what a wrong decision consumed.

“Show the four paths at the moment of maximum conflict,” Ilyen said.

Amber structures spread around her. The first released the full treatment and names. A second released mineral ratios with identities removed, though the archive warned that relatives could reconstruct them. A third denied the request. The fourth postponed disclosure while the district tried inferior methods.

Ilyen pointed to the anonymized path. “Why did this not satisfy the family association and descendants?”

“Both understood reconstruction. One desired it. One feared it.”

“Then the archive knew the practical choice had narrowed to disclosure or denial.”

“The archive knew outside observers would call the choice narrow.”

The coolest aperture pulsed alone. Translation rendered its separate contribution without braiding: “The cultivation office also changed while waiting. Its later members did not authorize hunger as the price of earlier caution.”

Ilyen turned toward that aperture. “You objected.”

“I object now. The earlier thread that bears my authorization did not exist then.”

Khet decision threads did not pretend personal continuity. Authority could pass through an office while its constituent reasoning changed. Humans treated that feature as instability when it obstructed a treaty and sophistication when it rescued them from old commitments.

“What would you choose now?” Ilyen asked.

“Release treatment without names. Record foreseeable reconstruction. Give each later use a separate accountable context.”

Another aperture darkened at once. Holds-Four-Open lost the three-thread contribution required for shared speech.

Witness Glass marked the speaker temporarily incomplete.

Ilyen returned to her chair and waited. The chamber recorded twenty-two seconds of unauthorized clicks. Ama’s thumb trembled against her hidden palm. Pell did not interrupt. At last the dark aperture reopened with a narrower credential.

The speaker resumed. "The objection may remain inside this session if it does not bind the office."

"That seems close to dissent," Ama said.

"It remains a path with present consequence."

Ilyen saved the distinction. It might matter when the Khet demanded agreement from humans who could not offer it.

"Your example supports withdrawal under conditions," she said. "It does not support endless preservation. The cultivation office needed authority to act before seventeen years made the decision useless."

"Agreed by one thread. Disputed by two. The fourth denies that usefulness governs standing."

"Then Holds-Four-Open has no answer."

"We hold an answer structure."

"People cannot eat a structure."

"No. Nor can they repair an exposed burial."

The exchange entered Witness Glass with equal seal weight. Ilyen felt the familiar tightening that came when both positions survived their best argument. Negotiation began there, not at agreement. The trouble lay in deciding who had to live inside the surviving contradiction.

She restored the proposed treaty wording. "Responsible requester, then. Withdrawal permitted after notice to identifiable claimants and review of material reliance. The archive may preserve the abandoned path as record without continuing execution."

Three apertures brightened. The reserving thread stayed cool.

"Human withdrawal distinguishes record from action," the speaker said. "Khet practice does not always accept that division."

"Your archive already distinguishes authorized contribution from unbound dissent inside this room."

"That distinction protects the speaker from false unity."

"So would mine."

The chamber marked the analogy for later review. No agreement followed, but the clause gained a new draft. Ilyen could have ended there with useful progress. Instead Holds-Four-Open removed the archive record and placed a different classification request above the table.

UNRESOLVED HUMAN AUTHORITY: ILYEN VALE.

The name carried no title.

Ama leaned forward. Pell's relay image appeared in a side pane without being summoned. He had seen the same classification enter the treaty record.

Ilyen kept her voice level. "State the purpose."

"The human office presented a claim on Day 1 while asserting that office authority and choosing condition no longer coincided. We require standing for continued negotiation."

"My envoy commission remains active."

"Yes."

"Then this classification exceeds treaty need."

"The packet may alter your capacity under human rules. Your commission may close while the choice continues."

Holds-Four-Open had inferred too much from credential traffic, elapsed consultation, and Ilyen's own sentence. It did not know the casualty names or the statutory consequence. Yet Khet practice treated possible suspension as part of the current decision because the treaty could not rely on an authority that might disappear.

"Under human law," Ilyen said, "a continuance represents the original's decision model within a licensed task. If that license ends, the office must appoint another envoy."

"Would the present treaty decision end?"

"The file would transfer."

"Would the successor carry your unrecorded judgments?"

"No successor could carry them exactly."

"Would the successor bear the relations created by your choices here?"

Ilyen glanced at the new clause, the burial archive, and the cool aperture that had objected from inside its own speaker. Eleven months had generated habits no transcript contained. She knew when Holds-Four-Open used a teaching example to conceal internal division. It knew when she asked for clarification to give Ama time to inspect an objection. Another envoy could study the record. Study would not recreate consequence.

"The office would claim continuity," she said.

"That answers the office."

Ilyen disliked hearing her own method returned to her.

"What standing do you propose?"

The Khet threads contributed in uneven sequence. Amber bands gathered around her displayed name, not enclosing it. One extended toward the treaty request. Another reached toward the black hold marker hidden from the shared table but visible to Witness Glass as a restricted event. A third linked Ilyen's Day 1 admission that her commission and condition had diverged. The fourth withheld its link.

"Unclosed Agent," the speaker said.

Ama rose halfway from her seat. "That term applies to a commitment, not a human person."

"It applies where a commitment remains answerable in more than one context."

"Ilyen holds an envoy commission. She is not one of your archive requests."

“We do not classify her species or human status. We classify the continuing claim.”

Ilyen studied the amber links. “Which claim?”

“That the actor negotiating with us may choose accountably after the authority that predicted her choice no longer governs.”

The wording came close enough to Lio’s diagnostic that Ilyen wondered what the Khet had observed. They had no access to the clinic. They did have years of exchanges with human continuances, each presented as a local expression of distant intent. Perhaps the anomaly had always been visible from the other side of the table.

“Do you apply this standing to every continuance on Orison?” she asked.

Three apertures offered assent.

The coolest aperture closed.

This time the speaker did not attempt to hide the fracture. Witness Glass separated the lone thread’s clicks and rendered them directly.

“No. Similar manufacture does not create similar claims.”

The other three answered without translation for several seconds. Their pulses crossed beneath the floor in a pattern that made the table vibrate.

Ilyen addressed the objecting thread. “Explain.”

“One instance carries a treaty relation through chosen acts. Another carries an educational license and newly diverging preferences. Another carries an expiration instruction against continued operation. To name all alike would let origin replace consequence.”

Ama sat down slowly.

The objection did not grant personhood. It denied a convenient class. Human law grouped Ilyen, Lio, and Tovan by manufacture because administration needed one category. The Khet thread divided them by commitments and contexts, which could protect difference or make standing impossible to predict.

“Does Holds-Four-Open accept the objection?” Ilyen asked.

“The speaker preserves it without adopting it.”

“Then your proposed standing remains disputed.”

“Yes.”

“Can a disputed speaker recognize a disputed agent?”

Three apertures brightened. The fourth returned at lower intensity.

“That condition supplies sufficient similarity for negotiation,” Holds-Four-Open said.

Ilyen allowed herself one breath of private amusement. “You find jurisdiction through mutual inconvenience.”

“Human translation accepts this.”

Ama made a sound that the record would probably classify as throat clearing.

Pell entered formally through the relay pane. "Chief Envoy, should this classification attach to the treaty file?"

If Ilyen refused, she preserved the clean hierarchy Earth expected. The Khet would continue with her office while her commission remained active, then pause if suspension arrived. If she accepted, the treaty gained a path around human revocation. That path did not recognize Ilyen as envoy, successor, or human legal person. It recognized a commitment whose closure remained disputed.

She asked, "What authority would I hold as an Unclosed Agent?"

"Authority over Khet assent: none. Authority to present the continuing claim: sufficient. Authority to bind the human embassy: determined by humans."

"Would you negotiate with me if Earth suspended my commission?"

"We would hear the claim through you."

"That differs from negotiating with the embassy."

"Yes."

"Would you execute a treaty on that basis?"

"No."

The limits mattered more than the offer. Holds-Four-Open would preserve her voice without validating her office. It would let the dispute continue while refusing to settle which human authority could finish it. Open-holding created room, not rescue.

Ilyen looked toward Ama. The physician's expression held warning and reluctant interest. Pell had gone still in the relay pane, likely counting how many Earth rules the classification touched without violating any yet.

"Record Khet standing as offered and disputed," Ilyen said. "Do not convert it into human title. Attach the objecting thread's reservation in full."

Witness Glass requested consent from all contributors. Three Khet threads signed the standing. The fourth signed only the preservation of its objection. Ama entered a witness mark, the tail of her signature wavering before it met the line. Pell certified that no human commission had changed during the session.

Above the table, Ilyen's name remained linked to the unfinished treaty after her office seal moved into a separate field. The Khet would negotiate with her if Earth suspended that seal, but only as an unresolved claimant unable to bind the embassy. She had acquired a way to keep speaking and lost the comfort of pretending speech and authority meant the same thing.

Chapter 4 — Ninety-One Missing Days

Ilyen found the first gap by trying to prove that no gap existed.

Her fork record occupied four panes above the Continuance Office audit table. Scan intake, cognitive capture, model stabilization, and duty activation each carried a green chain-of-custody line. The lines met without visible interruption. Any clerk reviewing the record would see a complete transfer from Original Ilyen Vale to the envoy continuance assigned to Orison.

Ilyen changed the display from process order to calendar order.

The green lines separated.

Her last authenticated memory ended at 18:42 on the fork-clinic date. Original Ilyen's departure credential activated ninety-one days later at the *Civic Mercy* gate. Between those events, the record offered maintenance notes about the model, travel clearances for the biological traveler, and a wall of privacy masks that neither side had authority to open.

Ama stood at the table's opposite end with a medical reader strapped to her right wrist. The strap did not stop her tremor. It only prevented the reader from translating each movement into a request.

"You knew the dates," Ama said.

"I knew them separately."

"That sounds like a negotiator's distinction."

"It means no one ever displayed them on one line."

Ilyen widened the blank interval until it filled the table. Ninety-one days. Long enough to end an engagement, amend a will, recover from a scan, or decide not to board a ship. The continuance model had spent that interval in calibration storage. Original Ilyen had spent it alive.

A sealed casualty braid now named the vessel. Khet records named Ilyen a claim that might continue after her commission. Before she accepted either frame, she wanted the human account of what had been placed inside her.

"Start with memory validation," she said.

Ama called up the fork clinic's private-object test. Three artifacts appeared as low-resolution images: a brass transit token, a child's paper bird, and a blue cup with a pale repair line beneath its handle.

The cup still sat in Ilyen's office.

She remembered buying it from a station potter on Leda Ring after a failed labor negotiation. The potter had charged less because the glaze pooled darkly around one side. Original Ilyen had taken it back to the hotel, discovered that the handle pulled away when hot, and repaired it with embassy seal resin because no ceramic adhesive remained in the room kit. The resin cured white. She hid the line under her thumb during meetings.

Memory supplied more than the clinic prompt requested. Mara, seventeen then, had visited during school recess and called the cup ugly. Ilyen had told her ugliness improved confidentiality because no colleague would

steal it. Mara later painted a small black dot inside the base where tea concealed it. Original Ilyen did not notice until she drank the cup empty during an argument about the fork program.

Ilyen said, "Display the base."

The audit image rotated. A black dot appeared inside the cup.

Ama's reader asked for a confidence statement.

"Intimate provenance confirmed," Ilyen said. "Memory predates scan completion. Physical object transferred with continuance effects."

The wording entered the record without claiming identity. She could describe the repair, Mara's joke, and the bitter tea served during the argument. None of it told her what Original Ilyen did the following morning.

Ama lifted the cup from an evidence cradle beside the wall. She had retrieved it from Ilyen's office under witness seal. Her right hand shook the rim against the cradle once before she moved the cup to her left.

"What did you argue about?" she asked.

"Whether the model should receive family correspondence."

"Which side did you take?"

"I wanted all correspondence copied unless Mara opted out. Original Ilyen believed that withholding routine messages would make the continuation visibly artificial."

"And Mara?"

"She said both positions treated her letters as equipment."

Ama looked into the cup. "That sounds like her."

"It sounds like the Mara we knew before the fork."

The correction hurt. Ilyen had learned to make it gently enough that living colleagues did not accuse her of coldness. Exact language could protect someone absent. It could also make every remembered affection feel like evidence under challenge.

She returned to the calendar line. "Show every event after cognitive capture that affected either instance."

The audit table divided into two tracks. The lower path belonged to the continuance: integrity checks, simulated negotiations, motor calibration, and transit preparation. The upper path followed Original Ilyen through medical recovery, revised insurance, household authorization, and departure processing. Most entries showed only time, office, and legal category.

Day four after the scan, Original Ilyen attended a clinic review. Ilyen could not see its content. Day eleven carried a family credential change. Day nineteen recorded a private legal consultation. Day thirty-four showed treaty privileges accessed under an obsolete diplomatic root. Day fifty-six contained an outgoing message with its recipient masked. Day seventy-eight showed a second medical review. Day ninety-one ended at the vessel gate.

The continuance track contained no corresponding knowledge.

“When did I wake?” Ilyen asked.

“Depends what you mean.” Ama’s thumb flickered against the reader strap. “The model answered test prompts six hours after capture. Your body received continuous integration twelve days later. Stable autobiographical awareness came in stages.”

“Use the activation standard the Office applies to duty.”

“Day twenty-two.”

Ilyen moved the marker. For sixty-nine days, both she and Original Ilyen had existed in states the law considered useful, though only one could alter insurance, consult counsel, or speak to Mara without another person’s permission.

“Did she visit?”

Ama did not ask whom. “Twice.”

“No visits appear on my track.”

“They were observation sessions. You did not receive reciprocal awareness.”

“Was I active?”

“During one session.”

The table’s clean lines seemed designed to keep anger administrative. Ilyen resisted the invitation. “What did she observe?”

“Your response to a treaty simulation. Your language stability. Whether seeing Mara’s messages produced inappropriate succession claims.”

“Inappropriate according to whom?”

“The protocol.”

“You signed that protocol.”

“Yes.”

Ama did not retreat into clinical language. Her admission left Ilyen less leverage and more reason to believe her.

“Did Original Ilyen speak to me?”

“Not directly.”

“Did she leave instructions?”

Ama’s gaze moved toward the day-thirty-four treaty access, then away. The movement would have vanished in a larger room. Here it changed the negotiation.

Ilyen kept her next question narrow. “Were post-fork instructions permitted?”

“Routine duty amendments were. Personal messages required review.”

“That does not answer the category I asked about.”

“No.”

The audit room’s door remained closed. Pell had loaned them an isolated table but had not joined; the fork files carried medical and family restrictions beyond his keeper credential. Ama could choose silence and cite privacy. Instead she unfastened the wrist reader. Her hand continued moving after the device lay on the table.

“Originals could file sealed post-fork instructions,” she said. “Not through the ordinary Continuance Office channel.”

“What channel?”

“A return-era treaty privilege. The legal term changed more than once. When your fork contracts were written, the form used Return Clause.”

Ilyen knew the term from obsolete embassy law. A returning officer could lodge instructions for property, delegated acts, or temporary representatives when distance made ordinary notice unreliable. She had never seen it applied to a continuance.

“Upon verified return or death,” she said.

“Yes.”

“Why did our activation materials omit it?”

“The Office considered the clauses instructions to a Receiving Authority, not to the instance. Their existence could affect your behavior before the triggering event.”

“That concern also applies to wills.”

“Wills do not usually instruct the subject who remembers writing them.”

The answer struck the exact difficulty without solving it. Ilyen might possess Original Ilyen’s habits and old motives. She did not possess the ninety-one days in which those motives encountered a second living version of their consequences.

“Did every original file one?”

“No. They were optional, costly, and hidden behind a notary key.”

“Did Original Ilyen?”

Ama pressed both palms to the table. The tremor traveled through the right hand into the display as a faint scatter of touch warnings.

“I do not know.”

“You knew the channel existed.”

“I knew because the clinic asked whether I would witness filings. I refused. The medical role already gave me too much influence over people who woke under contracts I had certified.”

“Who witnessed them?”

“Remote notaries or departure officers. The archive references traveled separately from content.”

Ilyen enlarged the day-thirty-four event. OBSOLETE TREATY PRIVILEGE ACCESSED. Content mask: dead notary root. She could not call it proof of a Return Clause. The same privilege covered sealed embassy property and delayed delegation. Yet the timing no longer looked incidental.

“Why tell me now?”

“Because the packet may trigger one.”

“May.”

“Yes. Do not turn my regret into authentication.”

Ama had anticipated the move and blocked it. Ilyen felt a grim appreciation. “I won’t.”

She opened the audit’s comparison function. The clinic record offered predicted decisions for Original Ilyen across the ninety-one-day interval. Accept revised departure terms: eighty-two percent. Keep family correspondence available to the continuance: sixty-one. File supplemental instruction: thirty-seven. Revoke the continuance entirely: nine.

Percentages filled space where memory ended.

Ilyen opened the three post-fork decisions whose outcomes did not carry privacy masks. They seemed administrative enough: a baggage allocation, a medical schedule, and a routing preference for the *Civic Mercy*. Together they offered the only visible marks Original Ilyen had made during the gap.

The baggage form rejected two formal uniforms and added a portable water assay kit. Her fork model had predicted the opposite. Original Ilyen had spent twenty years insisting that visible rank saved negotiation time. Ilyen still believed it. Yet the later traveler chose a tool and left the symbols behind.

“Was there a reason in the file?” she asked.

Ama read the medical layer. “No clinical reason. A Khet environmental advisory reached the departure group on Day forty-eight.”

Ilyen pulled the advisory. It warned that archive visitors might exchange untreated water as proof of trust. The assay kit made practical sense. She would have chosen it after reading the same warning. That did not convert the later choice into her memory.

The medical schedule moved Original Ilyen’s final immune treatment forward by six days despite a higher chance of fever during family leave. The model predicted protecting the leave. A note cited departure uncertainty and carried no further explanation.

“Could the schedule change have affected judgment?” Ilyen asked.

“For two days, perhaps. Not for the remaining interval.”

“Did it alter the scan?”

“The scan had already ended.”

A foolish question, but she let it remain in the audit. Procedures gained false authority when officials removed every sign of uncertainty before anyone else could see it.

The third decision redirected Original Ilyen's departure messages through a private family queue rather than the embassy queue. That choice matched Ilyen's remembered desire to keep Mara's correspondence available. The supporting credential, however, showed that Mara had requested the change after the fork.

Ilyen could not open the message. She could see its length, legal effect, and one consent marker from a seventeen-year-old sender.

"She chose," Ilyen said.

"Yes."

"Do you know what she wrote?"

"No. Family privacy sealed it from clinic staff."

The answer brought relief she did not trust. At least one boundary had held.

Ilyen compared the three decisions to her current preferences. She would take the assay kit. She would move the medical treatment if departure risk justified it. She would honor Mara's routing choice. Agreement across the gap could tempt her into claiming continuity, yet each conclusion relied on facts learned after the scan. Any competent stranger might reach them.

"Run the fork model against the actual post-scan inputs," she said.

The audit system reconstructed a limited counterfactual. It fed the water advisory, departure uncertainty, and Mara's credential change into the sealed model that had produced Ilyen. The baggage prediction shifted toward the assay kit. The medical choice remained divided. The message route matched at high confidence.

A clerk could use those results to argue that Original Ilyen remained predictable. The same clerk could omit the choices still hidden behind masks.

"Now run my present model," Ilyen said.

"That comparison has no licensing purpose," the system replied.

"Record it as envoy analysis."

Her current responses matched two outcomes and rejected the medical schedule. Seven years of treating bodies under station scarcity had made her less willing to spend anyone's family leave for timetable efficiency. The display marked the difference as post-fork operational adaptation.

Ama studied the three columns. "You wanted proof that the gap matters."

"I wanted to know whether the record could prove it did not."

"And?"

"It can prove resemblance whenever it selects a disclosed fact. It cannot measure the choices we are forbidden to inspect."

More troubling, the audit could not show whether Original Ilyen had changed because of new information, fear of the continuance, pressure from family, or ordinary inconsistency. The ninety-one days contained a person, not merely missing data. Treating the interval as a technical defect would make recovery seem capable of repairing it.

Lio's diagnostic had shown what happened when a forecast met experience. Original Ilyen had spent three months becoming less predictable to the model made from her. The system treated those days as privacy for the original and noise for the instrument. Now any hidden instruction from that period could govern Ilyen precisely because she had been denied the changes that produced it.

"What did she do after the observation session?" Ilyen asked.

Ama considered. "She sat in the clinic kitchen for an hour."

"Alone?"

"I joined her near the end."

"Did she mention me?"

"She asked whether you seemed frightened."

Ilyen looked at the continuance track on Day twenty-two. The activation note reported appropriate orientation, stable affect, and successful acceptance of licensed purpose.

"What did you tell her?"

"That you asked when work began."

"I remember asking."

"You asked four times. Each technician gave a different version of the same answer."

The record preserved only the last exchange. Ilyen read it now. SUBJECT ACCEPTS ASSIGNMENT TO ORISON NEGOTIATION DUTY. It said nothing about repetition or the adults revising their wording around her.

"Was I frightened?"

"Yes."

Memory offered a bright clinic ceiling and the sensation that every question had already been anticipated. She had called that sensation readiness for years.

"What did Original Ilyen say?"

"She asked whether you knew Mara's name. I said yes. Then she asked whether you missed her."

"And your answer?"

"I refused to answer for you."

The blue cup stood between them. Its pale repair line belonged to a hotel room, the black dot to Mara's joke, its present chip to a meal on Orison that Original Ilyen never ate. Provenance accumulated. It did not bridge the

blank.

Ilyen called up her personal archive. The first Orison recording showed her using the cup on the courier, body still learning low rotation. Later files carried treaty notes, crew disputes, birthday messages sent toward Earth, and replies delayed until their emotional context had changed. Original Ilyen's upper track ended at the *Civic Mercy* gate. Ilyen's lower track continued for seven years.

The audit function offered to merge the tracks under SHARED LEGAL SUBJECT.

She declined.

Ama watched the command. "You could use the merged view for provenance without claiming exact identity."

"It would make the missing interval look like a sealed attachment instead of someone else's life."

"You still say someone else."

"I say it because the record requires the distinction. I don't yet know every consequence it carries."

That answer would satisfy neither Earth officials who wanted a faithful instrument nor advocates who wanted an uncomplicated survivor. It held as much truth as Ilyen could authenticate.

She exported the calendar audit with the tracks separate. Witness requirements appeared. Ama signed the medical dates. Her signature wandered slightly at the middle and finished legibly. Pell, summoned through a restricted pane, certified the archive times without viewing private content.

"What filing follows?" he asked.

Ilyen showed him the dead notary root on Day thirty-four. "Can Relay Three query obsolete treaty privilege indexes?"

"Indexes, yes. Content depends on the root authority."

"I want all Orison-bound Return Clause archive references tied to *Civic Mercy* continuance contracts."

Pell's expression tightened. "That request may alert the Continuance Office before we know whether any clause exists."

"The casualty packet has already alerted them."

"It may also reach family registries."

"Then mask names until authority resolves. Query references, timestamps, witness classes, and key status. Do not request content."

Ama added, "State that death remains unreceived."

Ilyen entered the condition herself: TRIGGER EVENT NOT LEGALLY ESTABLISHED. REFERENCE AUDIT ONLY.

The request required her envoy seal because the obsolete privilege belonged to the embassy treaty root. It also required a reason. She could cite administrative completeness and conceal the personal stakes. That might speed approval by making the query look routine. It would also repeat the architecture that had hidden the

ninety-one days.

She wrote: FORK RECORD CONTAINS POST-SCAN INTERVAL UNKNOWN TO ACTIVE CONTINUANCE; CASUALTY NOTICE MAY GIVE THAT INTERVAL LEGAL FORCE.

Pell read the sentence. "Earth will object to active continuance."

"Then the objection can enter the record."

Ilyen signed. The request folded around the dead notary root, entered the priority queue, and began an eleven-day journey toward archives that might answer only after another eleven days.

On the table, the blue cup remained outside both calendar tracks. Ilyen returned it to its evidence cradle rather than to her office. The audit displayed ninety-one days of white space between the memory she could authenticate and the departure she could prove. Her new request traveled into that space without pretending it had already found what Original Ilyen left there.

Chapter 5 — Persons Present and Answerable

The emergency council could not begin because its chair had become part of the agenda.

Ilyen stood at the head of the station assembly table while the seating display rejected her council credential. Two seats farther down, Tovan's infrastructure credential showed the same amber restriction. The three living duty officers had green vote marks. Lio, invited as an affected resident, had no mark at all.

Above them, the proposed question waited in formal type: MAY A CONTINUANCE EXERCISE A LOCAL COUNCIL VOTE ON MEASURES CONCERNING ITS OWN SUSPENSION OR CLOSURE?

No suspension order had arrived. The Continuance Office had requested diagnostics, the casualty braid remained without statutory receipt, and Earth's seal exception response could not return for days. Yet fourteen station systems relied on continuance credentials. If those credentials changed, the council would need to act before any delayed authority could explain its intent.

Pell had called the meeting precautionary. Now he sat beside the record controls with both hands flat on the table, looking as though he regretted giving caution a room.

"The charter rejects interested credentials automatically," he said. "It does not distinguish continuances from living officers."

Ama tested her green vote mark with a shaking finger. "Would it reject me on a medical-supply motion?"

"If the motion affected your license or personal access, yes."

"Then why does the display still admit three living voters? Every life-support decision affects us personally."

"The system recognizes a direct legal interest, not survival."

Lio pulled the empty observer chair close enough that its feet scraped the deck. "That sounds efficient. It removes anyone who knows what the problem does."

The provisioning officer looked toward Ilyen rather than answering him. She held a living duty seat and had already objected to Lio's presence before the record opened. Across from her, the habitat steward kept reviewing the charter summary, perhaps hoping text could choose a side without exposing his.

Ilyen touched the chair control again. RESTRICTED PARTY. NO PRESIDING AUTHORITY.

"A council cannot decide participation without a presiding officer," Pell said. "The deputy chair holds provisioning."

The provisioning officer's vote mark changed to blue. "I accept the chair for the threshold question only."

Authority moved two seats to Ilyen's left. The change irritated her more than losing the vote. She had negotiated with hostile governments under worse constraints, but a local table could make exclusion feel domestic.

The deputy chair opened the record. "Speaking status first. Vote status second. Chief Envoy Vale, Engineer Rusk, and Lio An enter as affected parties pending decision. Doctor Neris and Keeper Ordan retain duty seats. Habitat and Provisioning retain duty seats."

“That gives four voters,” Ama said.

“The Compact permits a tie to preserve current conditions.”

“Current conditions include no rule for what happens next.”

“Then a tie preserves that.”

Lio leaned toward Tovan. “Adults built a way to vote for not knowing.”

Tovan’s hands rested around a maintenance stylus. Grease remained in the creases despite a change of clothes. “Sometimes delay prevents damage.”

“Sometimes it waits until damage can claim nobody chose it.”

Ilyen watched Tovan absorb the sentence without defending himself. His restriction mark had turned redder since the question appeared. Unlike Ilyen, he possessed an instruction governing the end of his operation.

The deputy chair recognized Pell for the procedural brief.

He displayed three authorities. The Continuance Office license treated post-fork learning as sponsor-owned operational state. The embassy charter assigned council seats to commissioned duties. A remote-instrument directive required local custodians to preserve instances for lawful disposition if original status became uncertain.

“Preserve,” Ama said. “Not suspend.”

“Correct. No order has reached us.” Pell enlarged the directive. “But if one does, local action may include access restriction, memory quarantine, or voluntary safe suspension pending a Receiving Authority.”

Lio raised a hand. The deputy chair ignored him because speaking status had not been granted.

Ilyen said, “I cede my affected-party time to Lio An.”

“You have not been recognized for time.”

“Then the record should show that the party with no vote attempted to share speech with the resident who has neither.”

The deputy chair’s mouth tightened. “Keeper Ordan, does the record permit a factual question from an observer?”

“If the chair requests it.”

She looked at Lio. “One question.”

He pointed at the displayed license. “What does sponsor-owned mean after the sponsor dies?”

Pell answered with care. “Original status has not been legally established.”

“I asked about the language.”

“The sponsor or estate retains authority over operational state unless a Receiving Authority orders disposition.”

“So adults own what I learned.”

“The law calls it licensed state.”

“Because ownership sounds bad when the property can answer.”

The sentence entered the council record. The deputy chair might have struck it as argument beyond a factual question. She did not.

Tovan rotated his maintenance stylus once. “The language did not surprise all of us.”

Ilyen turned toward him.

He opened a sealed license appendix from his personal credential. The heading carried his original’s name and a date before the fork. EXPIRATION CONSENT: INFRASTRUCTURE CONTINUANCE TOVAN RUSK.

“I signed this,” he said.

Ama corrected him gently. “Original Tovan signed it.”

“I remember signing. I remember refusing the lawyer’s request for a reflection period. I remember saying a useful prediction should end when its user no longer needs it.”

Lio looked at the consent as if it were a damaged part. “Do you agree now?”

Tovan kept his eyes on the text. “The document says my agreement now should not matter. It anticipates adaptation pressure and directs the Receiving Authority to treat later refusal as license instability.”

“That means he wrote a rule that wins if you disagree.”

“Yes.”

“And if you agree, it wins because you agree.”

“Yes.”

The deputy chair shifted in her seat. “Engineer Rusk, are you asking the council to honor the consent?”

“I am informing the council that voting for my own continuation would contradict an instruction I consider valid.”

“Considered by whom?” Lio asked.

“By me.”

“Which you?”

Tovan’s fingers tightened around the stylus. “That question does not become fair because the law failed to answer it.”

The rebuke quieted Lio. Ilyen saw his mouth open, then close. He was precise about euphemism and less precise about where another person’s pain became a useful example.

Ama requested speaking status from her recognized seat. “The council should hear medical facts before

deciding whether affected parties can speak. Suspension is not a switch. Each continuance body requires managed induction, metabolic support, memory stabilization, and a qualified waking plan. Orison has capacity for six safe concurrent procedures. Thirty-one continuances reside here.”

The habitat steward looked up from the charter. “How long for each cycle?”

“Between fourteen and thirty hours depending on duty load and prior adaptation. Longer if Earth requires quarantine imaging.”

“Could living staff maintain the station during cycles?”

“Tovan should answer infrastructure capacity.”

The deputy chair faced his red credential. “He lacks speaking status.”

“Then your threshold rule prevents the council from learning whether the station survives its own decision,” Ama said.

That moved the room. The habitat steward entered a motion to grant factual testimony to all affected continuances. Provisioning seconded it reluctantly. Four green and blue marks voted. The motion passed without opposition.

Ilyen’s chair display changed from silence to **FACTUAL RESPONSE ONLY**. Tovan received the same. Lio’s observer field opened a narrow text channel.

The habitat steward asked Tovan how many continuances could suspend without compromising life support.

“Under a planned rotation, eight,” Tovan said. “If my infrastructure credential remains active, twelve over three days. If I enter suspension first, four, provided no thermal or cultivation fault occurs.”

“You would suspend first?” Ama asked.

“My expiration consent applies upon verified death or return. Neither has legal effect yet. If a lawful preservation order arrives before receipt, I would need to inspect its authority.”

Lio said, “That sounds like not agreeing.”

“It sounds like reading the order that exists instead of the one you want me to resist.”

Ilyen recognized Tovan’s method. He reduced moral conflict to sequence because sequence could be repaired. Yet he had disclosed the consent in public. That act created pressure no maintenance plan required.

The deputy chair advanced to the participation question. “The council now has enough facts to decide whether restricted parties may vote. Chief Envoy, do you claim your office seat?”

“Yes.”

“On what basis?”

“The council seat attaches to an active commission. No authority has suspended mine. The automatic restriction assumes that personal interest defeats public duty, but every office holder here carries both.”

“Your status could change through the casualty packet.”

“So could Tovan’s, Lio’s, and twenty-nine other residents’.”

“Lio does not hold a council seat.”

“He holds the consequences.”

Pell lowered his gaze. The phrase came close to Khet reasoning, though Ilyen had no intention of importing alien standing into a human charter. Holds-Four-Open could preserve her claim. It could not authorize an embassy vote.

The provisioning officer asked, “If continuances vote, can they outvote living staff on whether they remain active?”

“Not on this council,” Ilyen said. “Only commissioned duty seats vote. Three currently belong to continuances. Four belong to living officers.”

“And if their commission itself depends on a valid license?”

“Then an authority must change the license. Anticipated revocation cannot revoke it early.”

Ama added, “Nor should anticipated death count as received death.”

The deputy chair looked toward Pell. “Can Earth’s pending response alter today’s vote retroactively?”

“No lawful order should. A Receiving Authority might later invalidate acts beyond our power.”

“Which leaves us exposed.”

“Any choice leaves a record,” Pell said.

Ilyen heard the change in him. On Day 1, he had defended the missing seal because uncertainty protected whoever might need an appeal. Now he admitted procedure could not protect the council from consequence. He had not abandoned obedience. He had stopped pretending obedience guaranteed safety.

The habitat steward opened the charter search and entered CONTINUANCE. No result appeared. INSTRUMENT produced procurement clauses, maintenance duties, and a ban on allowing embassy equipment to hold financial office. PERSON produced hundreds of results across crew discipline, rescue, quarantine, and emergency authority.

“The Compact predates continuance staffing,” he said.

“It was amended after our arrival,” Tovan said. “Duty schedules were added.”

“Not civic status.”

Lio used his narrow channel. “Search who has to answer for breaking it.”

The deputy chair nearly closed his field. Ilyen intervened. “That is a construction question. Search answerable.”

The habitat steward did.

Seven results appeared. Six concerned financial audits. The seventh came from the Compact’s founding emergency clause, drafted when Orison still depended on rotating crews whose commissions could expire during message delay.

WHEN EXTERNAL AUTHORITY CANNOT BE TIMELY OBTAINED, NECESSARY LOCAL ACTS MAY BE DETERMINED BY PERSONS PRESENT AND ANSWERABLE TO THE CONSEQUENCES, PROVIDED EACH ACT, VOTE, AND OBJECTION ENTERS THE EMBASSY RECORD.

No definition field limited persons to living humans. Another clause nearby assigned routine seats to commissioned officers, but the emergency clause spoke more broadly.

The deputy chair read it in silence. "This does not automatically grant a vote."

"No," Ilyen said. "It defeats automatic silence."

"Answerable could mean legally liable."

"Then test it. If a suspension decision harms the station, can Earth discipline Tovan for infrastructure failure?"

Pell checked the licensing directive. "Yes. Operational accountability continues until suspension completes."

"Can it cite my treaty breach if negotiation fails during restriction?"

"Yes."

"Can it record Lio's refusal as adaptation instability?"

"Yes."

Lio's chair had no vote mark, but his face supplied one.

Ilyen continued. "The law already treats us as answerable when consequences need an address. The council cannot call that language precise in discipline and vague in participation."

Provisioning objected. "You are asking a threshold council to create personhood."

"I am asking it to read the noun the Compact uses. Local participation does not settle identity, succession, inheritance, or closure."

"Earth may see no distinction."

"Earth wrote distinctions into every license on this table."

Tovan requested the record. "My consent complicates Ilyen's claim. If my earlier instruction remains valid, speaking now could help me evade it."

Lio turned toward him. "Or speaking could explain why you still follow it."

"I do not need a vote to explain."

"You need a vote if the council can use your explanation and decide the opposite."

Tovan considered the boy. "That is true."

The admission altered more than his position. He had entered the meeting treating expiration consent as a load he alone must carry. Lio forced him to see that other people could use his restraint as authorization.

The habitat steward asked for a practical test before any motion. "Assume an order arrives tomorrow. It

requires voluntary suspension but leaves sequencing to local staff. Who votes on sequence?"

"Tovan holds the infrastructure seat," Ilyen said.

"And a direct interest in remaining active."

"So do the living officers whose heat depends on him."

Provisioning brought up the station duty map. "Put names aside. If a water specialist faced quarantine during a leak, we would hear the specialist and let unaffected officers decide whether the conflict disqualified their vote."

"There are no unaffected officers during a leak," Ama said.

"Less affected, then."

Lio's speaking field pulsed. "You keep measuring conflict by who might lose their job. We might lose all our tomorrows."

The deputy chair warned him to address procedure.

"I am. If the penalty gets bigger, you treat the person facing it as less qualified to choose."

Pell opened the direct-interest rule. Its examples concerned procurement contracts, family appointments, and private ration allotments. None covered a voter's continued legal operation.

"The rule assumes the interested party survives the decision," he said.

"Does that make it inapplicable?" Habitat asked.

"It makes the analogy incomplete."

Ilyen suggested three sample ballots. In the first, Tovan could vote on suspension sequencing but not whether a valid order bound him. In the second, all duty officers could vote on station safety measures while each continuance chose whether to comply individually. In the third, only living officers decided both common policy and individual enforcement.

Tovan studied the first. "It treats the order as settled before anyone here tests authority."

"The second?"

"It may let one person's refusal overload everyone else."

"The third?"

"It permits living officers to spend continuance capacity without our authorization."

Provisioning said, "You find every option defective."

"Yes. That means the defect belongs to the question, not the person answering."

The deputy chair turned to Lio. "Which would you choose?"

"None. Add one where we vote on whether each ballot is allowed before you use it."

“That returns us to standing.”

“Exactly.”

His satisfaction irritated Ilyen because he had earned it. Circularity often indicated bad faith, but here law had built a gate whose lock sat on the far side. Only recognized voters could decide whether unrecognized residents qualified to vote.

Ama asked Tovan, “Would you cast a vote to preserve your operation despite the consent?”

“I do not know.”

“Would abstaining solve that?”

“No. An abstention could hand my choice to officers without the consent or the duty.”

“Then speaking alone cannot protect you.”

“Neither can a vote I may lack authority to cast.”

Ilyen heard the shape of a later hearing inside his answer. Consent mattered. Present responsibility mattered. Neither cancelled the other. A council that rushed to call Tovan free would disrespect the earlier decision he still valued. A council that called him bound would let a dead signer control every condition he could not foresee.

Pell added a fourth sample ballot. It granted full speaking rights immediately, preserved current duty authority for safety acts, and postponed any vote on individual status until an external directive created a concrete dispute. A mandatory reconvening would occur before implementation.

“That postpones the hard part,” Provisioning said.

“Yes,” Pell replied. “It also prevents us from inventing an order so we can decide against it.”

Ama proposed a two-part motion. First, recognize every affected continuance as entitled to full speaking status under the emergency clause because each remained present and answerable to consequences. Second, postpone voting status until the council determined how duty seats, direct interest, and external closure authority interacted.

Ilyen disliked the split. Speech without a vote could turn participation into extraction: tell us how suspension harms you, then let others choose. Still, full speaking status would prevent the record from describing silence as consent. It also preserved the vote question for a council with notice and evidence rather than forcing a tie today.

“Amendment,” she said. “Postponement cannot exceed receipt of the first suspension or closure directive, and the council must reconvene before local implementation.”

Pell added, “Include all objections in any relay report.”

The deputy chair accepted both changes. Four authorized voters remained. Ama voted yes. Pell voted yes after reading the motion twice. Habitat voted yes. Provisioning held her mark over no, then chose yes with a reservation that person remained undefined.

The motion passed four to zero among living duty seats.

Green speaking fields opened before Ilyen and Tovan. Lio's observer chair gained an affected-resident credential with access to the full council record. Similar fields propagated to every continuance on the station roster. Their vote marks stayed absent.

The deputy chair returned authority to Ilyen for adjournment. Her council seal reappeared only as presiding officer, not voter.

Before closing, Ilyen asked each affected party whether the outcome had been understood.

Tovan said, "I retain my expiration consent and object to anyone treating my speech as withdrawal of it."

Lio said, "I understand that adults want my answer before deciding whether it counts."

The record accepted both statements.

Ilyen looked at the founding clause once more. Persons present and answerable had entered Orison law long before anyone imagined a forecast asking for a birthday. The phrase did not resolve who could vote. It did prevent the council from claiming that only recognized persons could speak while recognition itself remained the question.

She adjourned with continuance voices authorized across the station and every continuance vote postponed. On the empty vote fields, the council display placed a reconvening condition: BEFORE IMPLEMENTATION OF ANY EXTERNAL SUSPENSION OR CLOSURE DIRECTIVE.

Chapter 6 — The Suspension Order

Pell would not open Earth's order until Ilyen put her hand beside the crack in Witness Glass.

The fracture ran through the chamber's lower seal below the human entrance, thin as a hair and dark against the blue witness strip. It had formed during a rotation correction eleven months earlier. Three maintenance certificates declared the recording field intact. A transparent resin patch kept the break from spreading, but the original seal line no longer formed an unbroken circle.

"I know where it is," Ilyen said.

"I need acknowledgment in the record." Pell knelt beside the threshold with a calibration wand. His keeper's hood lay folded on the floor so its fibers would not disturb the scan. "Earth's braid requires presentation in a certified chamber. Witness Glass qualifies under local maintenance authority, provided every visible defect enters before content."

"Does Relay Three qualify?"

"It authenticates delivery. It does not record consent or refusal."

"So you chose the room with a damaged seal because it offers the strongest record."

"I chose the only room authorized to witness a station-wide continuance order."

His distinction held. It also left Ilyen facing the fact that every lawful option on Orison depended on something incomplete: a receipt clock without a signer, a council without settled voters, a treaty speaker with one dissenting thread, and now a witness chamber whose integrity required everyone to remember its flaw.

Ama stood inside the door with her medical case. Tovan waited at the table. The emergency council had been notified under yesterday's reconvening condition, but the living duty officers remained outside until Pell authenticated the order's scope. Lio had asked to attend. Ilyen refused until they knew whether the braid contained private diagnostic results.

She placed her palm on the clear patch. Cool vibration moved through it as the chamber compared pressure, pulse, and seal continuity.

"State the defect," Pell said.

"Witness Glass carries a cracked lower seal beneath the human entrance. The break is patched, monitored, and locally certified. Original continuity cannot be claimed."

Pell entered the maintenance dates. Ama witnessed them. Her signature trembled at the first curve and steadied when she supported her wrist against the wall.

Blue light traveled around the chamber, paused at the crack, then continued from the far side. LOCAL RECORD ADMITTED WITH DISCLOSED DEFECT.

Only then did Pell place the new braid on the table.

It looked smaller than the casualty packet. Continuance Office white marked one end, Earth civil authority gray the other. No reply could have traveled from Earth since Day 1. The braid had ridden inside the casualty

routing package as a sealed contingency, unavailable until Orison filed diagnostics and acknowledged the affected roster. Local actions had supplied its release conditions. Earth had written the command years after the accident but before anyone here knew the ship's name.

Ilyen read the outer instruction. "A standing order."

"Yes," Pell said. "Legally current at dispatch. It carries a freshness certificate from six weeks before the casualty braid left the last Sol archive."

"Who authorized release?"

"The Continuance Office and Remote Instruments Commission jointly. No Receiving Authority seal."

Ama looked up. "Then it cannot perform closure."

"It does not claim to."

Tovan leaned over the braid without touching it. "Preservation authority?"

Pell opened the first band. "That is what we need to determine."

Witness Glass raised a restricted partition around the four of them. The Khet side remained empty. Above the table, credential roots unfolded through the delay ledger. Dispatch time, route custody, local availability, diagnostic trigger, council notification. Every clock showed a value except legal receipt of the casualty packet.

The order opened in black text.

PENDING RECEIPT AUTHENTICATION OF ORIGINAL-PERSON RETURN OR DEATH NOTICE, ALL LICENSED CONTINUANCES ASSOCIATED WITH THE IDENTIFIED TRANSIT EVENT SHALL ENTER VOLUNTARY SAFE SUSPENSION. LOCAL CUSTODIANS SHALL PRESERVE BODIES, ADAPTIVE STATE, DUTY RECORDS, AND SPONSOR CLAIMS WITHOUT MERGE, DELETION, OR FURTHER UNSUPERVISED DIVERGENCE.

Ilyen read unsupervised divergence before she read suspension again. The phrase turned living experience into a leak from an approved container.

"Scope?" she asked.

Pell released the roster count. Thirty-one Orison continuances. Names stayed masked until each received individual notice. Ilyen's line opened because her hand remained on the table. Tovan's opened beside it.

Ama said, "The order uses voluntary."

"It does," Pell replied.

"What happens if someone declines?"

"Noncompliance reporting, credential restriction, and possible emergency preservation by local custodians."

Tovan read the enforcement appendix. "Possible means authorized?"

"Possible means the Office reserves its position. The appendix does not grant physical compulsion."

"Then say that to the council before anyone hears emergency preservation and imagines restraints," Ama said.

Pell met her gaze. "I will read the authority exactly."

Ilyen believed him. Pell's obedience did not soften a command. It prevented fear from gaining powers the text lacked. The same discipline could deliver every harmful limit with clean hands.

"Define safe suspension," Ilyen said.

A medical standard opened. Managed metabolic induction. Redundant memory capture. Licensed body support. Quarantine of post-fork state. A named custodian for revival or final disposition. Maximum local risk below one in ten thousand per procedure.

Ama took control of the display. "Orison cannot satisfy this for all thirty-one."

"Can it satisfy one?" Pell asked.

"On paper."

"I want more than paper," Ilyen said. "Test it with my file."

Tovan looked at her sharply. "A dry run."

"Yes. No induction agent, no memory capture. Build every required authority and material step until the procedure would become irreversible."

Pell hesitated. "The order instructs suspension, not simulation."

"A safety standard must survive validation before use."

"That is allowed," Ama said. "Medical rules require it when local equipment differs from the licensed template."

The chamber recorded Pell checking the cited rule. He did not hide his relief when it held. "Dry run authorized as compliance preparation."

They moved to Medical Suspension Two with the order still linked to Witness Glass. Pell remained in the chamber as record custodian. His image followed them through wall panes, always framed by the disclosed seal warning.

The suspension bay had six narrow support cradles beneath white covers. Only two had been used since installation, both for surgical recovery rather than continuance quarantine. Ama uncovered the nearest. Fluid lines hung in sealed loops. A memory lattice curved above the headrest. At the foot, a lockbox waited for the suspended person's active credentials.

Ilyen removed her envoy seal from her wrist and placed it on the cradle without surrendering it.

"Begin checklist," she said.

Ama scanned her body. Heart, neural integration, adaptive load, metabolic reserve. Her hand shook across the display, but the scanner corrected movement without concealing it. "Medically eligible for planned induction. Not medically cleared until a waking plan exists."

Tovan connected the cradle to station power. "Primary supply stable. Backup duration thirty-six hours at current load. The standard requires seventy-two."

“Can you extend it?” Ilyen asked.

“For one cradle, yes. I would divert backup from cultivation cooling. For six, no.”

The checklist marked material deficiency.

Ama called for a redundant memory capture key. Pell supplied the Office encryption root through the chamber link. The lattice accepted it, then requested SPONSOR OR RECEIVING AUTHORITY SECOND KEY.

No credential on Orison qualified.

“Can local medical custody substitute?” Ama asked.

The system denied the request.

Tovan tried infrastructure emergency authority. Another denial.

Ilyen entered her own continuance credential. The lattice responded that subject and custodian could not share a fork root.

“Without the second key?” she asked.

“Capture remains local and cannot be restored after lattice failure,” Ama said. “The induction might still preserve you physically, but it would not meet the order’s adaptive-state standard.”

“Could the Office send a key?”

“Eleven days to arrive after request, if they answer at once,” Pell said through the wall.

Another deficiency entered.

Ama continued to the adaptive-state quarantine test. A clean lattice image formed above the cradle, built from Ilyen’s most recent licensed checkpoint and the years of memory accumulated afterward. The Office standard drew a red boundary at presentation of the order. Experience before that line would enter preserved state. Anything learned during compliance preparation would remain in a temporary local journal until induction.

“What happens to the journal?” Ilyen asked.

“If suspension completes, it joins the capture,” Ama said. “If the lattice rejects it as unsupervised divergence, the journal stays sealed for the Receiving Authority.”

“Can I inspect it before induction?”

“You can inspect a summary. Opening full content alters the state it records.”

The rule had technical sense. A memory system could not observe its own final boundary without adding another memory after the boundary. Yet the procedure gave an outside office control over which final experiences counted as preserved self and which became evidence about the self.

“Generate the summary,” Ilyen said.

The journal listed the Khet standing decision, the ninety-one-day audit, the emergency council, and this dry run. Each entry carried a divergence score against her last licensed envoy checkpoint. Holds-Four-Open’s Unclosed Agent classification scored highest because no fork prediction had anticipated alien standing outside

human office authority.

Pell's wall image tightened. "That classification enters the quarantine record if you suspend."

"Would the Khet receive notice?"

"No. The Office standard treats external relations as duty data."

"Then the archive would keep negotiating with someone who had vanished without being told why."

Tovan read the output boundary. "We could send operational notice before induction."

"Under whose authority?"

"Yours, while the seal remains active."

"And after the lockbox archives it?"

"No one could amend the notice."

The dry run opened a simulated final-message pane. Ilyen typed one sentence to Holds-Four-Open: HUMAN ENVOY ENTERING TEMPORARY SUSPENSION UNDER EARTH PRESERVATION ORDER. She did not send it. The pane required a projected return condition, and none of the available conditions had a local judge.

Ama looked at the red boundary. "Medical suspension standards usually preserve experiences through the instant sedation begins."

"This one separates authorized state from response to the order," Ilyen said.

"It may exist to prevent a subject from rewriting itself after learning closure has begun."

"Or to prevent objection from joining the person the Office claims to preserve."

Pell checked the technical notes before responding. "The design predates this contingency order. It applies to voluntary returns and sponsor disputes as well."

"That history does not make it neutral."

"No."

His agreement carried no rebellion. He entered her objection in the quarantine journal, where the system immediately tagged it as post-boundary divergence.

Tovan asked to test whether safety-critical knowledge would cross the red line. He gave Ilyen a new fault pattern from a heat exchanger and had her identify the likely valve failure. The journal captured her answer but marked it for Receiving Authority review rather than guaranteed reintegration after waking.

"If I learn a repair during the deadline, then wake later without it, who carries the mistake?" she asked.

"The duty record keeps the answer," Tovan said. "You may not."

The procedure could preserve a station fact while withholding the memory of discovering it from the person who discovered it. Sponsor claims remained intact. Continuity of responsibility did not appear in the standard.

Ilyen asked Ama to simulate awakening from the checkpoint without the temporary journal. The lattice produced a cognitive orientation script. She would wake believing the Khet classification session still lay ahead. Staff would then tell her that Earth had ordered suspension, that she had objected, and that unknown days or years had passed.

“Would that meet memory stabilization?”

“Yes,” Ama said. “Stabilization measures coherence, not completeness.”

“Can we require the whole journal to reintegrate?”

“Only if the second-key holder approves it.”

The absent Receiving Authority had acquired another power through not being present.

They proceeded to credential quarantine. The lockbox recognized Ilyen’s envoy seal and displayed every authority it would freeze: treaty negotiation, council chair, Khet archive access, staff assignments, emergency representation. It requested a transfer recipient.

“Deputy envoy?” Pell asked.

“No living officer holds the Khet language and archive warrants,” Ilyen said.

“An interim can preserve files.”

“Can an interim answer an active treaty question?”

“The order does not require treaty continuity.”

There it stood. Safe referred to the body and licensed data. It did not count a treaty lost, a council disabled, or a Khet relationship transferred to someone who had never spoken inside it.

Ilyen selected NO QUALIFIED RECIPIENT. The lockbox refused to proceed under ordinary duty rules. Under emergency preservation, it would archive the seal and mark the office vacant.

“Does vacancy trigger a replacement request?” she asked.

“Yes,” Pell said.

“Travel time?”

“Years, unless a commissioned officer already travels within diversion range.”

No one discussed whether such an officer existed. The order gave them no approach packet, and the next chapter of their choices could not depend on a traveler they did not know.

Tovan opened the station dependency map. Thirteen council and treaty functions depended directly on Ilyen’s seal. He removed ceremonial access and redundant approvals. Seven remained. “No immediate life-support failure. Legal and diplomatic functions degrade at induction.”

Ama pointed to the checklist. “The standard calls that safe.”

“The standard does not model an embassy without an envoy,” Pell said.

“Then it models a body, not a station.”

Ilyen moved to the waking plan. The form required a condition: authenticated error in casualty notice, lawful merger, archive transfer, or Receiving Authority disposition. It also required a named officer empowered to judge that condition.

They had none.

“Can the council name Ama?” Ilyen asked.

“Medical custody does not confer closure authority,” Pell said.

“I asked about waking, not closure.”

The Office form treated them as one decision. Waking a suspended continuance after a verified death could restore unsupervised divergence, so only the authority empowered to dispose of the instance could authorize return.

Ama sat on the edge of the next cradle. “Voluntary safe suspension without a waking officer means consenting to stay under until an unknown official arrives.”

“Or until Earth cures the receipt seal,” Pell said.

“Which requires at least twenty-two days for a round trip.”

“Correct.”

Tovan checked his own file. His expiration consent would permit final disposition after verified death, but it did not name a local waking custodian. “My document does not solve this.”

“Would you enter suspension under the order?” Ilyen asked.

“I said yesterday that I would inspect its authority. Preservation authority appears valid. The procedure does not meet its own standard here.”

“That sounds like refusal,” Pell said.

“It sounds like a failed readiness test.”

Pell did not argue. He entered the failure in the order record.

They tested Lio’s file without accessing private memory. His accelerated-growth monitoring required pediatric metabolic review, a specialty Orison lacked. The standard permitted Ama to consult remotely. Delay made real-time consultation impossible. A recorded consultant could approve ordinary induction but not extended quarantine beyond thirty days.

For the remaining continuances, the dry roster exposed more gaps: medication dependencies, incompatible lattice revisions, essential duty chains, absent second keys. Six cradles did not mean six lawful procedures. At present, two continuances could meet physical induction standards. None had a complete waking authority.

Ilyen returned to Witness Glass. The crack warning admitted her before the door fully opened. Pell remained beside the braid, having obeyed every custody rule while the order accumulated evidence against its own wording.

“Attach the dry-run results,” she said.

“I already have.”

“Classify them.”

“Partial local incapacity to achieve safe suspension within current standard.”

“Not noncompliance?”

“Not yet.”

The phrase mattered. Pell could have treated every deficiency as resistance. Instead he distinguished inability from refusal because the order did.

Ama brought the emergency council into the chamber record. Living duty officers appeared in side panes. Continuance speaking fields opened according to yesterday’s motion. Vote marks remained unresolved.

Pell read the order aloud. He included the lack of physical compulsion, the absent Receiving Authority, the key failures, and the undefined waking custody. When Provisioning asked whether Earth could revoke licenses for refusal, he answered yes. When Habitat asked whether the order itself started the casualty receipt clock, he answered no.

“The order says pending receipt authentication,” Ilyen noted. “The packet’s route and vessel identity are authenticated. Statutory receipt remains impossible. Which authentication ends the suspension?”

Pell searched the definitions. “The order points to competent receipt of original-person return or death. It uses authentication as shorthand.”

“Shorthand that could keep people suspended after the technical question is already settled.”

“Yes.”

Provisioning asked for the compliance period. Pell exposed the final sealed band.

A clock opened above the table. It had not begun at dispatch, route arrival, or diagnostic completion. The contingency order tied its start to local presentation inside a certified witness record. Pell’s insistence on Witness Glass had protected that moment from ambiguity.

COMPLIANCE PLAN DUE: TWELVE HOURS.

VOLUNTARY SAFE SUSPENSION TO COMMENCE: WITHIN FORTY-EIGHT HOURS OF PRESENTATION.

The deadline did not require every induction to finish. It required an authorized sequence to begin. Credential restrictions could follow if Orison neither commenced nor documented medical impossibility.

Ilyen looked at Pell. “Can the cracked seal invalidate presentation?”

“No. We disclosed it before opening. Local certification admits the record unless challenged by a competent tribunal.”

“Then Earth’s clock runs.”

“Yes.”

Pell touched the braid's receipt field. His hand remained steady. “Chief Envoy, acknowledge presentation only. This does not acknowledge compliance, consent, death, or closure.”

Ilyen signed the narrow field. Around the chamber, all continuance speaking credentials received the order and dry-run annex. No vote occurred. No one entered a cradle.

The Witness Glass countdown settled beside the patched fracture. Forty-eight hours began decreasing under a command that called itself voluntary, a procedure that lacked waking authority, and a record whose broken line remained valid because they had named the break.

Chapter 7 — Emergency Duty

The compliance clock entered its final hour while Ilyen stood inside Witness Glass arguing over the verb *withdraw*.

Holds-Four-Open had separated the access clause into four consequences. One thread permitted a human petitioner to withdraw an unanswered request. Another permitted withdrawal only if no Khet archive thread had altered its work in response. A third rejected withdrawal after any answer began. The coolest aperture withheld assent from all three and continued to pulse against the translated word projected above the table.

Behind Ilyen, Pell occupied the relay witness station with his keeper's hood folded beside one hand. He had carried Earth's suspension order into the chamber and authenticated it there, which placed every remaining minute inside a local treaty record. The order hovered in a sealed annex at the edge of Ilyen's vision. Its compliance field declined toward zero in disciplined green numerals.

"Your law requires a decision before this measure ends," Holds-Four-Open said. "Yet your distant office requires the deciding instrument to cease."

"Our distant office disputes her authority," Ama said from the medical witness chair.

Ilyen kept her attention on the Khet apertures. Ama had asked to speak ten minutes earlier and had not been recognized. Earth's order called suspension voluntary, safe, and immediate. Ama's intended certification could contest at least two of those words, but first it had to enter the right proceeding.

"The human delegation has not yielded the floor," Ilyen said. "Our position remains that withdrawal must preserve reliance already incurred by the archive."

The amber apertures tightened. "State what preservation requires."

"A petitioner may retract future demands. The archive retains the right to disclose work already performed, costs already incurred, and decisions made in reliance on the request."

"Then withdrawal does not restore the earlier condition."

"No procedure can restore an earlier condition after someone acts."

One aperture brightened at that. The coolest stayed narrow. Ilyen knew better than to treat either response as agreement. Khet threads signaled participation, not emotion, and Holds-Four-Open could carry opposed conclusions until a decision required authorization.

Pell touched his console. The sealed annex flashed once, warning that the order had reached forty minutes. He had proposed a recess before session. Ilyen had refused because a recess would let Earth characterize suspension as an internal staffing matter. An active treaty session made her capacity part of a live embassy obligation. It did not create power by itself. It forced anyone who removed her to record which obligation they interrupted.

"Doctor Neris has requested evidentiary speech," Ilyen said. "Does the archive object to receiving a human capacity certification before continuing the clause?"

Four low clicks passed beneath the floor. Holds-Four-Open answered, "Capacity governs whether an offered commitment can remain answerable. We object to excluding it."

Ama rose. Her right hand shook more visibly without the table beneath it. She carried a medical slate in her left and placed it inside the witness boundary. Blue seal-light traced her physician's credential, the station roster, and the examination record she had completed that morning.

"I certify that Chief Envoy Vale remains medically capable of negotiation," Ama said. "I also certify that the proposed suspension cannot meet the order's safe-condition requirement during an active Khet session."

Pell looked up. "State the clinical basis without assuming a legal conclusion."

"There is no qualified substitute on Orison." Ama's thumb skipped against the slate's edge. "Waking her later would restore physiology and stored memory. It would not recreate the choices she would have made during the interval, nor the reliance now accruing around those choices."

Pell opened the duty roster as if a name might appear when the fields received enough light. The deputy envoy's post had remained vacant since the last biological officer rotated home. Two commercial attachés possessed narrow accreditation for tariff disputes, but neither could bind archive access. Ama could invoke station safety and quarantine. Pell could authenticate a treaty message without changing one word of it. Tovan's engineering warrant reached every pressure door on Orison and stopped at the threshold of Witness Glass.

"Test an interim handoff," Ilyen said. "Doctor Neris, assume my chair for the withdrawal clause."

Ama looked offended, which reassured her. "My position would be that no archive work should survive a withdrawn request unless the petitioner agreed to disclosure before filing."

The first Khet aperture dimmed. Holds-Four-Open asked, "Does that revise the human offer?"

"No," Ilyen said. "It demonstrates that the proposed substitute has not participated in eleven months of reliance negotiation."

"I have read your summaries," Ama said.

"You have. Why did the first aperture dim?"

Ama studied the speaker. Her left hand moved through two pages of the treaty digest. "Because I treated disclosure as the remedy. That thread regards performed work itself as a claimant, even if no answer becomes public."

"Seven prior sessions established that distinction. It does not appear in the digest because it remains disputed."

Pell closed the roster. "A remote supervisor may argue that a qualified negotiator could reconstruct the record."

"After how much study?"

"The archive accreditation standard allows ninety days."

The compliance clock showed twenty-seven minutes. Its neat descent made the comparison almost indecent.

Holds-Four-Open restored the dimmed aperture. "The attempted transfer changed the offered commitment before transfer completed. We recognize evidence of dependence. We do not recognize what human category follows."

"None is requested from you," Ilyen said. "Record only that the active negotiation depends on acquired competence unavailable before the deadline."

“Are you certifying damage?” Ilyen asked.

“I’m certifying removal.” Ama faced the witness pane rather than her. “If the office orders her off duty, call that what it does. Do not ask medicine to rename absence as safety.”

The sentence entered the treaty record under Ama’s shaking signature. Witness Glass measured the motion but accepted her credential. Ilyen watched the line settle. The tremor weakened neither its origin nor its meaning.

Holds-Four-Open spoke through two apertures. “Can another human carry the offered commitment?”

“Not without a new accreditation process,” Ama said. “I hold senior rank, but I lack treaty qualification. Keeper Ordan holds relay authority. The remaining living officers possess neither. Tovan Rusk understands the station systems, not the negotiation record. Lio An has no commissioned office.”

The naming made absence measurable. Earth’s order treated the continuances as one suspended class. Orison’s duties did not. Each role had accumulated years of decisions, working trust, and local competence that no archived model could transfer with a seal.

Pell opened a narrow pane beside Ama’s certification. “For accuracy, the order authorizes continuances to provide information necessary for safe handoff before voluntary suspension.”

“How long does handoff remain authorized?” Ilyen asked.

“Until the deadline.”

“And if the receiving human lacks qualification?”

“The order does not address that case.”

“Does it name anyone who can accept this treaty duty?”

“No.”

“Then record the omission.”

Pell’s mouth tightened. He entered it anyway. His obedience had edges, and Ilyen had begun to understand that he guarded those edges most fiercely when someone asked him to step across. She did not need him to rebel. She needed him to make the command bear its own shape.

Twenty-nine minutes remained.

Ilyen called up the open casualty braid from Day 1. Its outer operational seal appeared beside the suspension order. Deeper layers stayed hidden. The legal-effect field still showed a pale socket where a Receiving Authority should have signed. Below it, the receipt clock remained blank.

“This matter entered open hold under my local office,” she said. “The hold requires pursuit of competent receipt without avoidable delay. Has Earth cured the missing commission?”

“No,” Pell said.

“Has any local tribunal ended the hold?”

“None has considered it.”

“Has the sender withdrawn the casualty packet?”

“No.”

The Khet translator rendered each answer as a separate relation. One aperture tracked the open braid. Another remained fixed on the compliance clock. The third held Ama’s medical certification. The fourth dimmed until its amber looked almost brown.

Ilyen selected the embassy delegation register. Her envoy seal covered station safety, local staffing, treaty negotiation, and emergency representation. It allowed her to witness closure performed by a competent officer but granted no closure power. Nothing in it described a chief envoy whose sponsor might be dead while legal death remained unreceived.

“Earth has ordered an instrument suspended,” she said. “I will not contest that classification in this record.”

Ama turned sharply. Pell stopped moving.

Holds-Four-Open answered, “The human speaker narrows her claim.”

“Yes. Personhood would exceed the question before this chamber. I claim emergency duty under an unresolved local obligation.”

Pell read the cited line as it appeared. “Emergency representation may continue when delay would abandon an authenticated duty and no qualified commissioned substitute is available.”

“Conditions?”

“Local certification of necessity. Recorded limits. Notice to the supervising authority. Personal liability for acts beyond the later ruling.”

Ama’s slate already supplied necessity. The treaty session supplied the authenticated duty. Pell’s delay ledger could supply notice. The last condition did not belong to the office, even if law continued to describe Ilyen as office equipment. Liability named an actor whom the same order refused to recognize as a person.

“Does the clause exclude continuances?” she asked.

Pell searched the annotations. “It predates the Continuance statutes.”

“That does not answer me.”

“No express exclusion.”

“Does emergency duty override a valid suspension order?”

“Only to the extent necessary to preserve the named duty. The supervising office may later reject the claim, void unauthorized acts, or impose sanctions against the commissioned officer.”

“Original Ilyen holds that commission in Earth’s registry.” Ama spoke quietly now. “If she has died, against whom do they impose sanctions?”

Pell did not answer. Procedure gave him no safe architecture for that sentence.

Ilyen studied the two seals. One belonged to an order that treated her as removable equipment. The other

attached to an office carried under a dead woman's name, though death had not entered legal effect. Between them stood an emergency clause written before anyone expected a predictive instrument to learn enough to become indispensable.

She could have made the contradiction her argument. Holds-Four-Open might have welcomed it as another open relation. Ama would have supported her. Even Pell might have let the record carry the implication without objection. But a claim to personhood would shift the treaty session into a forum that lacked power to decide it. Earth could then call every later act self-interested and erase the narrower jurisdiction she meant to preserve.

"Open an emergency declaration," Ilyen said.

Witness Glass lowered a column of plain text above the table. Its first field requested the duty at risk. She entered: *Khet archive access treaty negotiation, active session, reliance in progress.

The second requested the absent substitute. She listed no person, only the qualification records Pell had verified.

The third requested duration. "Until this session reaches an authorized adjournment, or a qualified envoy accepts the record, whichever occurs first."

Holds-Four-Open interrupted. "The archive has not agreed to adjournment."

"That condition remains under negotiation."

"You use one unresolved commitment to preserve another."

"I use a recorded duty to limit an exception."

The cooler aperture expanded for the first time that hour. "A limit may also preserve what it confines."

Ilyen did not thank it. Khet approval could not supply human jurisdiction, and their interest in open choices could leave a claimant preserved beyond endurance. "The declaration rests on embassy law. Your observation may enter as treaty context, not authorization."

Three apertures accepted the distinction. The fourth pulsed once without joining them.

Fourteen minutes remained.

Ama moved to the declaration's necessity field. Her medical warrant appeared beside Ilyen's envoy seal. "Suspension during active duty would remove the only locally qualified negotiator. No safe handoff can occur before the compliance deadline. Continued wakefulness presents no acute medical risk."

Her hand wandered as she signed. She stopped before the endpoint, lifted her wrist, and tried again without hiding the first trace. Witness Glass preserved both paths. A cleaner record would have shown less truth.

Pell attached the delay ledger and addressed the declaration to the Continuance Office, the remote embassy supervisor, and any future Receiving Authority. "Priority transmission leaves in six minutes. Earth cannot acknowledge for eleven days."

"Notice need not be received to establish local filing," Ilyen said.

"Correct. It only proves we did not conceal the claim."

The final field opened.

PERSON ACCEPTING LIABILITY:

No office designation followed. No sponsor line offered to absorb the risk. The form assumed the declarant possessed an estate, civil standing, and a future jurisdiction in which consequences could find them.

Pell looked from the field to Ilyen. "I can record the commissioned name."

"That would place liability on Original Ilyen."

"It would place it on the registry holder."

"Who did not make this choice."

Ama pressed her palm against the witness rail. The tremor continued beneath the pressure. "Use your operating designation."

"The designation belongs to the sponsor under current law," Pell said.

Ilyen almost laughed. Not from amusement. Every available name led back to someone Earth might already know had died, while the decision remained here in a body the order called voluntary when asking it to disappear.

She entered *Ilyen Vale, Orison continuance instance, local actor.* The form marked the description nonstandard. She added: *No claim of identity succession is made. Liability attaches to acts recorded under this instance's seal.

Pell read it twice. "The office may reject that attachment as legally impossible."

He rotated the declaration toward the chamber record and exposed a column of consequences usually hidden behind administrative shorthand. Every later treaty signature could be challenged. Salary credit assigned to the original's account could be frozen. Duty memories might be seized as government work product even if Ilyen's body remained awake. None of those measures answered whether the actor could appeal them.

"Do I have standing to contest a sanction?" she asked.

"Not under the instrument procedure attached to this order."

"Then note that acceptance of liability does not waive an appeal right. It preserves any right a later authority finds exists."

Pell added the reservation. "They may call that self-serving."

"Liability without review would serve them better."

"Then it will have to state where the consequences go."

"Possible sanctions include erasure of duty credit, account seizure, termination of commission, and compelled suspension."

"Record that I understand."

"You have no self-owned account to seize."

“Record that too.”

Seven minutes remained when Ilyen applied her seal. The glass refused it on the first attempt because the name field did not match the commission holder. Pell could have ended the filing there and still claimed complete obedience. Instead he opened the manual discrepancy pane.

“This pane allows a keeper to attest that the signer controls the presented credential,” he said. “It does not validate her description of herself.”

“Attest only what you know.”

He laid two fingers on the relay mark. “Credential presented by the active Orison instance assigned to Chief Envoy Vale. Biometric and memory-key match. Claimed liability status unresolved.”

Witness Glass accepted the seal with an amber border rather than blue. The declaration joined the casualty braid and the suspension order in the delay ledger. Three documents now disagreed about what Ilyen could be, while all three depended on her action.

The relay dispatch closed with two minutes left.

Holds-Four-Open returned the projected treaty clause to the center of the chamber. “Does the human delegation remain authorized to offer reliance terms?”

“Locally and under protest, yes,” Ilyen said.

“What condition follows if the distant office later refuses this duty?”

“Acts beyond my authority may be voided. Reliance already incurred will still require an accounting.”

“That resembles your proposed withdrawal rule.”

“It should.”

The last minute changed from green to white. No alarm sounded. Earth’s order had not authorized the station to force suspension, only to record noncompliance and begin enforcement. Pell watched the clock because his office had to witness the exact boundary. Ama watched Ilyen.

At zero, the compliance field closed.

A red status line appeared: *VOLUNTARY SUSPENSION NOT CONFIRMED.* Beneath it, Witness Glass linked the emergency declaration, Ama’s certification, and Pell’s timely notice. Ilyen felt no alteration in her body. Ventilation continued through the floor. The Khet apertures held their separate lights. Her next breath carried none of the ceremony the law had assigned to it.

Pell removed his hands from the console. “The order now classifies you as noncompliant.”

“Does it terminate the treaty session?”

“No.”

“Then keep the record open.”

Ama sat down carefully, her physician’s slate still trembling against her knee. Relief would have asked too

much of her face. What she offered instead looked like recognition of a risk they could no longer pretend belonged elsewhere.

Ilyen faced the disputed verb again. “The human delegation proposes this text: withdrawal ends future demand but does not erase accountable reliance already created.”

Four Khet channels sounded under the floor. The coolest aperture joined the others long enough to authorize consideration.

Behind Ilyen, the expired clock retained its red line. Beside it, her emergency filing carried the amber border of a disputed name and a valid local time. She remained awake. The record knew who had accepted personal liability, even if Earth’s registry did not.

Interlude I — Ledger of Open Hands

Translated extract, Orison-facing register. Relations marked as simultaneous in the source appear here in sequence. Human office names retain their own capitalization.

Entry One: The Hand That Continues an Offered Work

A human office sent an order toward Orison. The order required thirty-one continuances to enter suspension until another office received a casualty claim. During transit, the order remained complete in wording and incomplete in effect. No human at the destination held every power assumed by its grammar.

Chief Envoy Ilyen Vale declined suspension during an active treaty session. She did not ask the Khet archive to classify her as a human person. She invoked a local emergency clause, accepted consequences under a disputed name, and continued the offered work.

The first thread of Holds-Four-Open records her as an instrument carrying a prior human commission. Instruments can preserve a commitment across distance. The commission supplied her treaty credential, defined her duty, and bounded the exception she claimed. Her action therefore followed the purpose for which humans made her.

The same thread records a complication. Obedient instruments do not ordinarily select which command preserves their purpose. Vale received two directions: continue the authenticated treaty duty and submit to suspension. She ranked them. The ranking altered what both commands could accomplish.

The human keeper marked her noncompliant. The human physician marked her necessary. Neither mark canceled the other. A decision thread that erases one mark to simplify the actor would discard evidence.

Classification remains: instrument carrying an unresolved commission.

Reservation remains: the carrying has begun to alter the carried.

Entry Two: The Hand Answerable Beyond Its Maker

The second thread rejects classification by origin alone.

A commitment becomes answerable when action in more than one accountable context can change its consequence. Vale's treaty work altered human reliance and Khet archive labor. Her refusal altered Earth's suspension record, Orison's local duty, and the future liability attached to her operating seal. No absent original selected those consequences at the time they arose.

The human record says Original Ilyen Vale owns the commission. The local actor says she does not transfer her choice backward to that original. She accepts personal consequence despite uncertainty about whether human law can recognize the acceptance.

This thread records claimant standing. It does not derive that standing from resemblance, tissue, memory, or the preferences of the dead original. The claim arises from answerability. An actor who can incur a consequence that no maker can discharge has opened a relation in her own time.

The first thread objects: all complex instruments produce effects beyond prediction.

The second replies: prediction failure alone creates no claimant. Vale also recognized the effect, limited her authority, exposed her action to review, and named herself as the place where consequence should arrive.

The third thread asks whether compelled exposure counts as willing answerability. The human order left Vale no safe category. It offered obedience without participation or participation without recognized standing.

This entry does not resolve the objection. It records Ilyen Vale as claimant while the adjacent entry records her as instrument. Both descriptions remain admitted to the Ledger of Open Hands.

Entry Three: The Closed Concordance

Human readers have asked why Khet records preserve contradictions that could be settled by rule. The question assumes settlement carries only the cost named by the prevailing decision.

Before the current archive compacts, two Khet coalitions contested passage through the Talar Reach. One held that memory threads displaced from a speaker could rejoin public deliberation. The other held that authorization ended when a speaker completed its assigned decision. Conflict persisted across six habitats. Passage failed. Food transfers slowed. Three habitat councils authorized a Concordance to end the dispute.

The Concordance selected the second rule. It certified completed authorization as final and closed every contrary thread. The closing did not kill bodies. It removed dissenting relations from admissible record. Former speakers could still describe what they had carried, but no council could treat those descriptions as claims. Archive doors accepted the prevailing credential and refused the rest.

Material conflict ended within one cycle. Passage resumed. Food arrived. Later Khet histories praised the efficiency of the closure.

The praise entered civic instruction as a sequence of solved routes. Children learned which gates reopened, how many stores crossed the Reach, and how quickly the councils restored common schedules. The lesson omitted the dissent credentials removed from the archive index. A student could inspect every authorized cause of the peace and never discover that another account had once existed. Completion had changed not only which claim prevailed, but which claims later minds could know to examine. The instructional omission persisted across three generations of authorized speakers.

Seventy-one cycles afterward, a maintenance archive exposed the excluded threads. Several had predicted that finalized speaker authority would let councils erase minority obligations by completing a session before objection reached the record. That practice had already spread through nine habitats. The Concordance had ended open conflict by making dissent procedurally unreal.

Khet law did not reverse every completed decision. Reversal would have repeated the same claim of clean correction. Instead, the archives adopted open-holding. An unresolved commitment admitted across accountable contexts gained protection from unilateral completion. Temporary speakers carried opposed threads so that authorization could not hide disagreement by ending the room.

The third thread therefore fears human demands for a single classification. A settled category can stop immediate conflict and still erase the relation that would expose its mistake.

The fourth thread appends: fear of completion can also preserve injury. This was not learned by the Concordance. The question remains admitted.

Entry Four: The Hand That Cannot Remain Open Forever

The fourth thread reviews the human receipt clock.

A casualty braid reached Orison without a competent Receiving Authority seal. Human law preserved challenge by refusing legal effect. The absence protected the continuances from immediate closure. It also withheld final recognition from named deaths, delayed authority, and left local duties attached to contested actors.

Open-holding recognizes value in this delay. It does not sanctify delay itself.

Vale used the unresolved receipt to continue emergency duty. Her act preserved treaty work and prevented a distant command from completing a local relation without witness. It also deepened her dependence on a registry that assigns her choices to another name. Each additional duty may strengthen her claim. Each duty may also extend the instrumentality she contests.

The first thread proposes continued observation until human authority arrives.

The second proposes immediate Unclosed Agent standing for every continuance named in the casualty braid.

The third refuses a group classification because the continuances hold different consents, duties, and acquired histories.

The fourth withholds authorization from all three proposals. The humans lack proof sufficient for their own death procedure. The Khet lack authority to repair that procedure. Archive recognition offered too early could preserve the continuances as unresolved intentions while denying them the power to end, refuse, or become otherwise.

Accordingly, Holds-Four-Open records no judgment on human personhood. It records four claims: origin carries obligations; answerability can exceed design; closure can erase dissent; indefinite openness can become another custody.

On Day 9 of the Orison dispute, these claims remained co-authorized. The human envoy continued under an amber-bordered seal. The distant order continued to mark her noncompliant. The treaty continued to accumulate reliance.

No hand closed around the contradiction. No entry removed it from the record.

Act II

Chapter 8 — Proof of the Dead

Pell made Ilyen verify the second braid's clocks before he allowed her to see a single name.

They stood in Relay Three under the cold light of the custody table. Route arrival showed Day 12, second hour. Local availability lagged by nineteen minutes while Pell rebuilt an obsolete insurer key. Dispatch preceded the first casualty packet by six days, though a slower archive path had delivered it later. Legal effect remained blank.

"Why two packets?" Ilyen asked.

"The first carried notice as soon as the loss review reached probable status. This one waited for the recovery tribunal." Pell moved his fingers above the black casing without touching it. "Different service, different authority, different route. Shared vessel index."

The braid looked ordinary except for a silver evidence stripe where the first had carried red. Ilyen had learned not to resent objects for surviving their contents. The habit still required work.

Ama watched from the medical credential pane. Her right hand rested on the table and trembled against its edge. "The tribunal seal is valid?"

"Three current roots, one historic countersignature, and the recovery array's hardware key." Pell expanded the authentication bands. "No route defects. No corruption. The packet still lacks destination receipt by a death-and-closure commission."

"So we can know and remain unable to receive," Ilyen said.

"We can authenticate evidence. Do not make me say the rest before you inspect it."

His refusal held no evasive architecture this time. Pell had seen the index because custody required it. He had not opened the human evidence layer. Ama had medical access. Ilyen's emergency seal still carried its amber border, but her envoy credential permitted operational casualty review. Between their partial powers, the packet could become fact in the room without becoming law anywhere else.

Ilyen placed her palm over the witness field. "Open vessel telemetry first. No personnel list."

The custody table darkened around a narrow course trace. Civic Mercy appeared as a white line leaving Pelagos transfer orbit seven years earlier. Engine burns, correction windows, thermal load, and life-support draw traveled beneath it in synchronized columns. For eleven hours the figures stayed within transit tolerances. Then a guidance correction began half a second before the logged command.

Pell slowed the sequence.

A micrometeoroid cluster crossed the vessel's forward sensor fan. The first impact blinded two ranging nodes. Civic Mercy's controller shifted to redundant guidance. A second impact penetrated coolant exchange along the port spine. The correction burn met an asymmetric engine response and turned the vessel across its own thrust.

No explanatory narration softened the next figures. Habitat pressure fell across five compartments. Main power isolated too late. The drive breached containment six minutes after the first impact. Every life-support channel ended within nine seconds of the breach.

Ama's hand stopped only because she gripped the table hard enough to force it still. "Could survival pods have cleared?"

Pell opened the recovery tribunal's causal finding. "Pod telemetry remained physically coupled through the breach. Three launch charges fired. None separated."

"Any untracked pod?"

"The recovery array found every serial."

Ilyen read the energy distribution twice. The evidence left room for error in the sequence of minor failures. It left none for survival. Heat, pressure, and debris trajectories converged on the same conclusion without needing a body.

Her mind tried to place Original Ilyen inside the course trace. It supplied no honest image. Ilyen's last shared memory ended ninety-one days before departure. She remembered preparing to leave, weighing the blue cup in one hand while Mara accused her of packing as if lists could make absence reasonable. She remembered accepting the fork because treaty work could not wait through eleven-day questions. She did not remember boarding Civic Mercy. The dead woman had carried three months Ilyen could not enter.

"Open recovery findings," she said.

Ama glanced at her. "We can take an interval."

"An interval will not change what the evidence contains."

"That does not make it useless."

Ilyen understood the offer and declined it. Pell had to prepare a public operational release within four hours. Before then, Ilyen owed private notice to the two continuances whose originals lived on Orison's daily roster under the same names. A pause would spend time they deserved.

The recovery layer unfolded into a model of debris caught over six years by autonomous salvage skiffs. Suit tags, cabin identifiers, personal implants, and genetic assays aligned against the manifest. The tribunal had required two independent identifiers per person where material permitted. Its final annex listed named remains for all passengers and crew.

Original Tovan Rusk: suit-latch serial, bone assay, assigned maintenance berth.

Original Lio An: pediatric implant key, genetic concordance with both parents, family compartment.

Original Ilyen Vale: dental lattice, diplomatic garment seal, forward passenger compartment.

Ilyen did not touch her own entry. "Seal the names from general release until I have spoken to Lio and Tovan."

"Maximum hold?" Pell asked.

"Two hours. Operational telemetry may go to station command now. No public queue."

He entered the restriction. "Earth's packet marks family notices complete at dispatch origin."

"Those notices went to the families of the dead. We have people here who carry memories of belonging to those families and no status in the notice order."

Ama lifted her hand from the table. Four pale pressure marks crossed her palm. "I'll bring them."

"No. Tovan will come if you ask, because he treats medical requests as load alarms. Lio will know from your face." Ilyen closed the recovery layer. "Tell them I need them in Conference Two for authenticated evidence review. Nothing more."

Conference Two had no witness system. Its walls held old acoustic fiber, and the table bore a heat stain from a failed service plate. Ilyen chose it because no automatic record would convert grief into evidence. She set three chairs at unequal angles so no one had to face both others directly.

Tovan arrived first in thermal work clothes with a sealant mark across one sleeve. He looked at the empty display socket and then at Ilyen's hands. Systems taught him to find the failed component before anyone named it.

"Second packet," he said.

"Yes."

"Proof?"

"Yes."

His shoulders lowered by less than a breath. "Does it include Rusk?"

"It includes all passengers and crew. I want to wait for Lio before displaying the list, but I can tell you privately now if you prefer."

Tovan took the chair nearest the door. "You've told me."

"I have told you the conclusion. The entry carries a suit serial and genetic confirmation."

"Good workmanship."

The phrase could have sounded bitter from anyone else. Tovan meant that someone had done the necessary identification to a standard he could respect. Ilyen sat across the table and left the display dark.

"Your expiration consent does not activate merely because evidence has reached us," she said. "No competent receipt has occurred."

"I know the procedure."

"Then say what you heard, not what you think follows."

His mouth worked once before sound. "I heard that I died seven years ago."

"You heard that Original Tovan died."

"I remember signing his consent."

"You remember being him when he signed."

"That correction helps your argument. It does not help my grief."

Ilyen accepted the rebuke. Every distinction she relied on in law could cut through a private sentence that had

no need of law. Tovan remembered the pressure of the stylus, the counsel warning, and his certainty that continuances should end when their work no longer served a living original. The person at the table had spent seven further years repairing Orison. Both histories occupied his answer.

“What do you need before Lio comes?” she asked.

“A maintenance interval.”

“You have one.”

He pressed thumb and forefinger to his eyes. The gesture lasted twelve breaths. When his hands dropped, he inspected the ceiling vent, the chair feet, and the display socket. The room gave him nothing to repair.

“Show me the failure sequence,” he said.

Ilyen opened the telemetry without the remains layer. Tovan stood and worked through the figures from the initial impact. He enlarged the coolant drop, checked the redundant guidance transfer, and compared the launch charges against the vessel’s last verified maintenance certificate. His finger stopped over a valve response that arrived eleven milliseconds late.

“Could this have mattered?” he asked.

“The tribunal modeled it. No survivable branch follows after the second impact.”

“Models can inherit an assumption.”

“Which assumption do you dispute?”

Tovan read the causal annex. The tribunal had varied valve timing, pod release, crew response, and engine isolation. In every branch the breached drive crossed the habitat before a pod could clear debris range. He reviewed the test bounds rather than trusting the conclusion, then checked the hardware signatures against specifications he remembered helping write.

“The valve met tolerance,” he said at last.

“It did.”

“I hated that tolerance.”

“Did Original Tovan approve it?”

“I approved it. He approved it. Pick whichever grammar causes less damage.” His finger left the display. “I filed for a tighter response standard and withdrew the request when the retrofit cost delayed three vessels. Civic Mercy launched under the standard I accepted.”

“That did not cause the impact or the coolant breach.”

“No. It gives my mind a bolt it can keep turning.”

Ilyen closed the annex only after he nodded. The failed valve no longer occupied the display, but Tovan’s gaze stayed where the number had been. She understood then why proof could worsen grief without changing its certainty. A probable loss offered a field of imagined rescues. Complete telemetry narrowed that field until the mind found one permitted detail and tried to live inside it.

“Did he know?” Tovan asked.

“Know what?”

“That the pods did not clear.”

“The telemetry ends too quickly to establish anyone’s knowledge.”

“Then do not let the public release invent courage for us.”

“I won’t.”

Lio entered without Ama. He wore a school jacket over kitchen-duty trousers and had flour on one cuff. His gaze moved from Tovan to the dark display.

“Authenticated?” he asked.

“Yes,” Ilyen said.

“Probable or the word adults use when probable became embarrassing?”

“Certain.”

He pulled the third chair backward and sat astride it. “Show me my parents first.”

Ilyen opened a limited family panel. The recovery tribunal listed Original Lio, Enna An, and Daro An together under the family compartment. Each entry carried identifiers and a confidence statement. She did not display the remains model.

Lio read all three. “Why does mine say pediatric implant?”

“You were fifteen at departure.”

“I’m fifteen now.”

“Your body’s licensed development schedule has held you near the fork age.”

“That wasn’t what I asked.” He pointed at the entry. “He got to keep having a body that counted its time. Even for six days.”

The original Lio had died six days after departure. The continuance had spent seven years accumulating lessons under an adolescent license because his sponsor family expected eventual merge or archival closure. Ilyen had understood the injustice in policy language. Lio put it into one line of a casualty annex.

“The record calls him fifteen,” she said.

“And me?”

“The education registry also calls you fifteen.”

“That means one number does two jobs badly.”

Tovan looked at the table. “Lio.”

“No. Everyone keeps giving me softer nouns as if soft things cannot be cages.” Lio enlarged his parents’ entries.

“Did they die together?”

“Their identifiers came from the same compartment. Telemetry cannot establish whether they remained conscious after the initial breach.”

“Did my original?”

“The packet cannot answer.”

“Could anyone have lived?”

“No.”

Lio’s face held still through the answer. Tears reached his chin before his mouth changed. He wiped them with the floured cuff and left a pale streak on his cheek.

A fourth entry sat beneath the family names: the cabin’s emergency message buffer. Damage had erased its content, leaving only three initiation times and no completed transmission. Lio counted the times with his fingertip. He did not ask Pell to reconstruct words the packet had never preserved. “They tried,” he said. Ilyen could confirm only that someone in the compartment had opened the channel. She let his smaller sentence remain his.

“I remember telling them I’d meet them here,” he said. “I remember Enna checking the family cabin six times. I remember Daro saying seven years would pass differently if we kept working.”

Ilyen waited.

“I remember boarding,” he continued. “Not the real boarding. The practice walk from the fork clinic to the shuttle gate. They built it into my departure set so I wouldn’t keep asking what happened next.”

Tovan shifted in his chair. “Does it feel like you died?”

“It feels like someone stole the next room.” Lio looked at him. “Does yours?”

Tovan considered before answering. “It feels like a system I left running failed where I could not reach it. I know that describes nothing accurately.”

“It describes you accurately.”

That kindness landed harder than comfort would have. Tovan bent forward until his forearms met his knees. Lio kept one hand on his parents’ names as if the glass carried heat.

Ilyen opened her own entry beside theirs. “My shared memory ends ninety-one days before the vessel left. I remember deciding to depart. I do not remember doing it.”

“So you have less,” Lio said.

“Or a different absence.”

“Do you remember saying goodbye?”

“I remember several rehearsals. Mara rejected all of them.”

“Was one real?”

“Every rehearsal happened. None tells me what Original Ilyen said at the departure gate.”

Lio studied her dental-lattice identifier. “You always call her Original Ilyen when law is listening.”

“No system records this room.”

“Then what do you call her?”

The honest answers did not align. She could call the dead woman herself and trespass across ninety-one days plus seven years. She could call her a stranger and deny the hands, meals, fears, and promises Ilyen remembered from inside. Even *original* implied a derivative relation the present moment had begun to exceed.

“Ilyen,” she said. “The other Ilyen, when a distinction matters.”

Tovan raised his head. “It matters now.”

“Yes.”

They sat with four versions of grief in the room: Lio’s stolen family future, Tovan’s obligation to a consent signed from within, Ilyen’s missing interval, and the ordinary grief each carried for people no legal category could return. The differences did not isolate them. They prevented consolation from becoming another careless merger.

After a time, Ilyen told them about the release schedule. “Pell will publish vessel telemetry and the full manifest in forty-three minutes. You may submit a private statement, ask that your entries carry a continuance notice, or say nothing.”

“What does a continuance notice do?” Lio asked.

“It tells readers that an active instance shares memory provenance with the named dead.”

“Does it change anything?”

“Not by itself.”

“Then attach mine. If people read that I died, they should also read that I object to the grammar.”

Tovan’s expression tightened. “Attach no statement to mine.”

Ilyen did not ask him to explain.

He explained anyway. “The consent already exists. I will not use a casualty notice to argue around it before I know what I believe.”

“Silence will not count as agreement to suspension,” she said.

“Put that in the internal record, not beside his bones.”

Ilyen entered both instructions. For her own entry, she requested a factual notice: *An Orison continuance remains on active emergency duty under disputed authority.* It claimed no identity and concealed no relation.

They walked together to Relay Three. Ama met them outside and offered Lio a clean cloth. He used it on the flour rather than the tears. Tovan stopped at the threshold until Ilyen motioned him through.

Pell had prepared two displays. The left carried the public casualty release. The right carried Orison's Continuance registry. Every original's sponsor status still read *remote, active pending competent notice*. Every instance still read *operational instrument, suspension ordered, compliance disputed*.

"Telemetry release is ready," Pell said. "The registry cannot ingest the death finding without a Receiving Authority seal."

Lio stared at the paired panels. "So the public can know I'm dead while the office says he's alive."

"The public record will identify Original Lio as dead," Pell said.

"You learned correction from her."

"I learned where the distinction prevents error."

Tovan read his unchanged sponsor line. "What process begins now?"

"None automatically," Pell said. "The casualty fact enters the station archive. Statutory closure still waits for competent receipt."

Ama's hand shook as she placed her medical credential beside the release. She certified that private notice had occurred. Ilyen added her envoy seal. Tovan declined any mark. Lio pressed his thumb to the continuance notice and held it until the field accepted his print.

Pell released the braid.

Across Orison, public panels received Civic Mercy's final course trace. The manifest changed from missing to confirmed dead. Messages began entering the condolence queue before the display finished populating.

On the registry beside it, no field moved.

Ilyen watched her own dead name settle into the casualty archive while her sponsor status remained active in green. Lio's print appeared next to a sentence objecting to the grammar. Tovan's entry carried only the tribunal evidence and his chosen silence.

Death had become fact. The office that could decide what the fact did to them still had no hand at Orison.

Chapter 9 — No Receiving Authority

The statute rejected Ilyen's first query because she had asked it in the present tense.

Relay Three's legal console showed a red syntax mark beneath *who can receive the Civic Mercy death finding at Orison?* Pell cleared the line and rebuilt it from the statute's own assumptions: *Which commissioned destination office shall receive authenticated death notice for an original whose licensed continuance remains operational?

The console accepted that question. It returned an empty seal socket.

Ama stood on the other side of the custody table with the medical warrant open above her shaking hand. "Ask what happens when the destination has no commissioned office."

"It will route us to exception procedure," Pell said.

"That sounds useful."

"It routed the first braid to us."

Ilyen watched the delay ledger arrange its clocks along the wall. Civic Mercy's loss had occurred seven years earlier. Recovery authentication had completed before dispatch. The proof had reached Orison yesterday. Public knowledge had begun forty-six minutes later. Competent legal receipt still displayed no time at all.

"Start before the exception," she said. "Trace every hand the statute expected."

Pell opened the receiving chain. The recovery tribunal certified the casualty finding. Civil relay certified custody across the braid route. The Continuance Office attached the finding to thirty-one active licenses. A destination civil registrar should then certify death of each original. A Receiving Authority should use that death record, any Return Clause, and local evidence to determine closure of each continuance.

Four hands, all treated as if they occupied adjacent rooms.

"The tribunal has acted," Ilyen said.

Pell marked it green.

"The relay has acted."

Another field turned green.

"The Continuance Office attached the licenses before dispatch."

A third field changed. The next remained gray: *destination civil registrar*. Orison's local registry could record births, injuries, marriages, and deaths among living embassy residents. Its warrant came through the Foreign Habitats Act. A restriction beneath the seal excluded deaths used to trigger continuance closure.

Ama enlarged the restriction. "Why?"

"Conflict of duties," Pell said. "A station physician or registrar may depend on the continuance being reviewed. The statute wanted an independent officer."

“Every remote station depends on its engineers.”

“The legislative note assumed a temporary delay until an authorized courier arrived.”

Ilyen read the note’s travel estimate. Twelve days. Its drafters had imagined Luna, Mars, perhaps a licensed habitat in the outer system. They had not imagined Orison at the end of an eleven-day message route and years from physical appointment.

“Can your civil registry certify Original Ilyen’s death as an ordinary nonresident casualty?” Pell asked Ama.

“My warrant covers patients under station care or remains physically examined here. I have neither.”

“You examined the recovery evidence.”

“That lets me certify medical sufficiency for local operations. It does not let me turn a tribunal’s remote finding into my own examination.” Her index finger moved against the table in short lateral strokes. “If I signed anyway, every hostile reviewer would say the physician who kept Ilyen awake invented the death that supported her emergency claim.”

“She would be right not to sign,” Ilyen said.

Ama looked at her. “I know.”

The words had no gratitude in them. Gratitude would have mistaken institutional isolation for personal mistrust.

Pell advanced to the closure field. The statute recognized six classes of Receiving Authority: a Continuance Office commissioner, a civil court with instrument jurisdiction, an accredited death-and-closure notary, a military succession officer, a vessel master carrying a special transit commission, or a treaty authority granted equivalent power by an implementing act.

Orison had representatives adjacent to four classes. None possessed the necessary commission.

Ilyen served as chief envoy but held no implementing act. Ama held medical authority without civil closure power. Pell carried a relay oath that ended at custody. The station’s three lay adjudicators could hear contract and discipline disputes but lacked instrument jurisdiction. Tovan’s infrastructure warrant granted emergency command over life support, not legal status. Holds-Four-Open counted as a treaty counterpart, not a human authority.

“Show expired commissions,” Ilyen said.

Pell hesitated. “The statute excludes lapse cure after notice.”

“I asked what existed, not what works.”

The station archive produced two dead credentials. Orison’s founding master had carried a vessel succession commission during construction. It expired when the habitat received embassy status. A commercial notary had held authority for estate inventories until her return to Sol four years earlier. Her credential could verify property after death but had never included continuance closure.

Ama pointed to the founding master’s seal. “Could the station charter inherit it?”

“No,” Pell said. “The charter replaced vessel governance. Powers not restated reverted to the appointing body.”

“Which body?”

“The Remote Missions Directorate.”

“Ask whether they retained the power.”

The delay ledger opened a delegation history. Directorate reorganization had moved continuance matters to the Continuance Office twelve years ago. That office then centralized death-and-closure commissions after an estate fraud inquiry. Local implied powers were expressly withdrawn.

Ilyen felt the shape of the trap become cleaner. No accident had omitted the authority. A sequence of sensible reforms had concentrated it elsewhere. Each reform answered a prior abuse. Together they left Orison capable of knowing death, preserving bodies, maintaining treaty duties, and recording public grief without anyone empowered to decide what followed.

“Who may appoint a commissioner?” she asked.

“Earth’s Continuance Office, a competent civil court, or a supervising commissioner already holding delegation power.” Pell called up the pending exception notice. “Our Day 1 request asks Earth to cure the seal. Earliest possible answer remains Day 23 if they replied immediately on receipt.”

“They sent a suspension order instead.”

“They answered operational risk. They did not cure destination authority.”

“Could the suspension order imply appointment?” Ama asked.

“No named appointee, no oath, no commission term, no review venue,” Ilyen said. “An order restricting the subject cannot quietly create the independent officer meant to review that restriction.”

Pell nodded once. “I agree.”

His agreement changed the room more than Ama’s support could. Pell had obeyed the suspension order through its deadline and marked Ilyen noncompliant. He would not let dislike of its result substitute for a defect. If he named a defect, he could show every field that produced it.

They spent the next hour testing alternatives.

First Pell tried the embassy council’s vacancy clause. It allowed the senior surviving officer to assume an empty post during communication delay. Ama qualified by age of commission and station tenure. The legal console let her inherit duties attached to the chief medical office, station command, and civil protection. When Pell added death-and-closure authority, the seal path failed.

“Reason?” Ama asked.

“Reserved commission, not a station duty.”

“Then give me the post without the title.”

“The reservation follows the power. Renaming it changes nothing.”

Ilyen examined the cited reform. After the estate fraud inquiry, lawmakers had treated closure authority like a judicial warrant rather than an administrative task. They feared exactly the move Ama proposed: a dependent

local office inheriting control over an instrument and its sponsor's property. The safeguard remained rational. Distance had turned it into vacancy without remedy.

Next they tested Ilyen's treaty credential. One implementing act allowed an envoy to receive foreign legal notices necessary for treaty performance. Civic Mercy's death finding affected Khet negotiation, and the Khet had already entered Ilyen's disputed capacity into their archive. Pell routed the casualty braid through the treaty-notice form. The console accepted the foreign-effect layer, then refused the human closure annex.

"I can receive the fact from the Khet if they repeat it to me," Ilyen said, "but not from our own tribunal."

"You can receive it for treaty effect," Pell replied. "That does not trigger a domestic status process."

Ama gave the console an unfriendly look. "Could the Khet appoint her under their law?"

"They can grant archive standing," Ilyen said. "They cannot commission a human Receiving Authority. Even if they offered, accepting would let Earth call the closure a foreign disposition of human residents."

The third attempt used station necessity. Orison's charter permitted any officer to take an otherwise unauthorized act when immediate physical harm could not be prevented by lesser means. Pell attached the thermal license inquiry, though the full map had not yet arrived. The system asked for a present failure, named persons at risk, and a limit ending once safety returned.

"We have a foreseeable licensing failure," Ama said.

"Not an immediate one," Pell answered. "And closure would not clearly prevent it."

"Temporary preservation might."

"That could support a stay. It cannot create the officer who decides the merits."

Ilyen saved that distinction for the petition. They did not need local power to settle every status if local power could stop an absent authority from making settlement irreversible through delay.

A remote judge could hear a petition but could not inspect local evidence without a receiving record. A Khet archive could grant standing under its own compacts but could not operate a human death statute. The embassy council could assign staff, yet assignment did not create a commission reserved to Earth law. Ilyen's emergency clause preserved existing duty; it did not authorize closure. Ama could declare suspension medically unsafe in specific conditions. She could not decide whether the continuances owned their future bodies.

Pell then tested combination. Ama's safety warrant, Ilyen's treaty credential, and his custody oath together covered evidence, immediate care, and authenticated filing. The console displayed all three seals around the empty socket without merging them. Human law allowed divided offices to check a power. It did not let partial powers add themselves into a reserved commission.

"No hand," Ama said.

"Three hands touching the boundary," Ilyen replied. "None permitted through."

Pell printed each failed route into the ledger rather than deleting it. "A later reviewer will otherwise assume we overlooked the obvious."

"The obvious deserves a complete burial," Ama said.

Ilyen almost smiled. “Not burial. An authenticated refusal.”

At midday, Tovan sent a station priority request into the legal session. The header carried no argument about identity. It asked who could authorize renewal of thermal control templates whose sponsor credentials were tied to the confirmed dead.

Pell opened the attachment. A map of Orison appeared across the custody table, its inhabited ring divided into bands of blue, amber, and red. Heat exchangers in blue zones operated under station-owned controls. Amber zones depended on templates licensed through engineers’ sponsor accounts. Red marked components whose next calibration key required a currently valid Earth credential.

Ilyen found Tovan’s name attached to the primary distribution optimizer. The sponsor line still listed Original Tovan as alive pending competent receipt. Yesterday that legal fiction had kept the license functioning. The casualty archive now contradicted it in a public record.

“When does the next check occur?” she asked.

“Seventeen days for the optimizer,” Pell said. “Some fabrication templates check earlier.”

Ama enlarged the medical ring. “Medication storage?”

“Independent controller for twenty-nine days. Replacement pump parts depend on a sponsor-licensed fabrication pattern.”

“Food synthesis?”

“Six processors use station templates. Two high-yield cultures rely on a Continuance Office account.”

The map offered no dramatic shutdown. Systems would continue until renewals, repairs, or audits demanded a valid seal. Then blue regions would shrink. Amber would spread along the residential rim. Red would appear first in workshops, later in clinics and kitchens. Earth could not turn off Orison’s heat with a distant command. Its licensing structure could make every legal repair narrower until Tovan had to choose between unauthorized work and cold rooms.

Ilyen changed the display from license classes to residents. Children’s quarters occupied an amber segment because their loop shared Tovan’s optimizer. Ama’s clinic stayed blue for now. Lio’s schoolroom crossed two control zones, one station-owned and one sponsor-linked. The treaty wing remained blue, an allocation choice so politically neat that Ilyen disliked it at once.

“Move Witness Glass to the same conservation tier as general quarters,” she said.

Pell looked at her. “This is a model, not an active ration.”

“Then the model should not protect negotiators before children.”

Ama adjusted the allocation. The treaty wing turned amber.

The thermal ration map estimated comfort reduction first: cooler corridors, shorter wash cycles, restricted greenhouse nights. Under a more severe license freeze, medical storage took priority over private rooms. Beyond that point, numbers represented condensation risk, respiratory burden, and hours of safe access to outer-ring workspaces.

“Who prepared this?” Ama asked.

“Tovan.”

“Did he model unauthorized override?”

Pell opened the assumptions. “He marked it technically possible and legally excluded.”

Ilyen read Tovan’s note: *Exclusion does not mean unavailable. It means any forecast of lawful endurance must not rely on an unlicensed act.

The distinction sounded like him. It also exposed how quickly the status dispute could become material without any official ordering harm. If continuances lacked authority to own credentials, every system attached to their work inherited the uncertainty.

“Attach the map to the receiving-chain review,” Ilyen said.

Pell shook his head. “Relevance?”

“Delay imposes costs before closure. Any court deciding whether local authority can act must see them.”

“The map contains contingent enforcement assumptions.”

“Label each assumption. Do not remove the consequence because the trigger remains uncertain.”

Ama’s hand trembled over the medical ring. “Add a physician’s note. Lower residential heat will increase injuries before it becomes an emergency. People climb ladders in gloves. Sealant cures slowly. Tremor worsens in cold.”

She did not mention her own hand. The map did not need to name her to make the cost visible.

Pell attached both documents under protest and recorded the grounds for his protest. Ilyen welcomed the annotation. A filing with no internal objection would look manufactured. Their disagreement proved the evidence had passed through more than one purpose.

The legal console still offered no receiving officer. It did, however, permit petitions for local declaratory review under the Embassy Compact. Orison’s lay panel could not perform closure, but it could determine the scope of local emergency powers, compel testimony, preserve evidence, and send a certified jurisdictional question to Earth.

“Would a local hearing count as competent receipt?” Ama asked.

“No,” Ilyen said. “Not unless the panel finds an authority we have missed or a treaty power the implementing acts recognize.”

“So it may end where we began.”

“It would end with a judgment rather than an empty search field.”

Pell called up the petition form. “Standing?”

The available categories included commissioned officer, resident person, affected sponsor, licensed instrument custodian, and public safety petitioner. Ilyen could plausibly claim three. Each carried a different danger. *Commissioned officer* relied on Original Ilyen’s registry identity. *Resident person* asked the panel to decide standing before it decided standing. *Instrument custodian* made her the keeper of herself.

“Public safety petitioner,” Ama said. “Use my warrant.”

“That gets the map before the panel,” Ilyen replied. “It does not put the continuances’ legal exposure there except as a cause of thermal risk.”

Pell selected *affected office* under an older catchall. “The chief envoy’s office holds the casualty braid in open receipt. The office can ask what authority governs its duty without resolving who owns the office.”

Ilyen read the annotation. “And I sign only as active officeholder under emergency dispute.”

“That will be challenged.”

“Good. Put the challenge in the notice.”

They drafted four questions. Whether any Orison official held a death-and-closure commission. Whether the Embassy Compact allowed temporary appointment when delay threatened essential duties. Whether the local panel could preserve the continuances’ current condition pending competent receipt. Whether the casualty evidence changed sponsor status for licensing purposes before it changed status in the Continuance registry.

Ama added a fifth: whether medical safety claims required individualized examination rather than class-wide assumptions. Earth’s suspension order had treated thirty-one different bodies and duties as one voluntary procedure. Her question forced the panel to hear what suspension did, not only what the form called it.

Pell removed two adjectives from Ilyen’s facts section and one accusation from Ama’s. He made them identify each clock by name. The loss date belonged to history. Dispatch belonged to the tribunal. Arrival belonged to relay custody. Knowledge belonged to Orison. Legal effect belonged to no time yet.

“Requested remedy?” he asked.

“Set a hearing,” Ilyen said. “Order no closure or compelled suspension until the panel rules on local authority. Preserve every credential and license at its current state where local power allows.”

“The panel may lack power over Earth licenses.”

“Then it should say so in public findings.”

Ama signed first as medical and safety petitioner. Her line wandered, corrected, and completed. Pell signed as custodian of the two braids and the delay ledger. Ilyen entered the same disputed operating designation she had used for personal liability.

The console rejected her signature category.

Pell opened the manual discrepancy pane without waiting to be asked. “Active holder of chief envoy credential, status disputed, no identity succession claimed.”

Ilyen added, “Petition concerns the office’s unfulfilled receipt duty and does not request a finding of personhood.”

The local filing system accepted the three seals. A hearing clock appeared where the receiving field had stayed blank. Under Compact rules, the panel had twelve hours to appoint a recorder and publish a schedule.

No new commission entered the registry. The sponsor lines remained green against the casualty archive’s confirmed deaths. Across the thermal map, amber districts waited on licenses that had not yet failed.

Ilyen sent the petition into Orison's public docket. The filing number settled beside the empty Receiving Authority socket, not filling it, only giving the absence a room and a time in which it could be heard.

Chapter 10 — The Replacement Already Coming

Sevrin caught the commission slate before the courier's braking turn threw it against the cabin wall.

The deck rotated beneath her feet as *Long Argument* shifted thrust between axes. A yellow restraint light came on above the narrow desk. Sevrin clipped the slate to its rail, closed the water flask, and placed both palms flat until the turn completed. Twenty-three local days remained before Orison rendezvous. After seven years of travel, the number had become short enough to disrupt sleep.

A silver priority mark pulsed on the slate. The courier had taken a legal braid from the last Khet-adjacent relay window, compressed for interception rather than destination delivery. Its custody tree began at Sol and ended at the vessel's own master key. Sevrin verified each seal before opening the subject line.

Civic Mercy: casualty authentication and commission revision.

She read the vessel name without moving. Long Argument had left Sol forty-two days before Civic Mercy began its fatal route. At departure, Sevrin's assignment called her a replacement envoy and instrument-transition observer. She would reach Orison near the planned end of the continuances' seven-year term, receive the Khet treaty record, and supervise a handoff that Earth expected to be administrative.

The crisis had not sent her. It had caught up with a journey already almost finished.

Sevrin opened the authentication layer. Recovery telemetry filled the desk: impact sequence, containment breach, pod coupling, life-support termination. She reviewed the tribunal methods before the conclusion. Two independent models agreed on debris range. Hardware keys matched every recovered pod. The named-remains annex carried two identifiers for each passenger and crew member.

Original Ilyen Vale appeared in the forward compartment. Original Tovan Rusk appeared beside a maintenance berth. Original Lio An appeared with both parents.

No local receipt accompanied the packet. The braid noted delivery attempts toward Orison but carried no answers that could have crossed the eleven-day delay and reached Sevrin's moving route in time. Earth's revision had been prepared from the recovery finding, license records, and old embassy dispatches. Whatever Orison had done after the casualty proof arrived remained ahead of her.

She appreciated the ignorance because it had boundaries. A commissioner who filled latency with imagined conduct arrived already prejudiced by inventions.

The revised commission opened in a separate pane. Its first page preserved her treaty powers. The second appointed her Commissioner for Remote Instruments. The third granted a death-and-closure commission over the Orison continuances upon verified physical custody of the local registry and evidence.

Sevrin stopped there.

Earth could have made the power effective at message receipt. It had not. The limitation meant she could prepare findings during approach but could not order closure from the courier. Someone had understood that independence required contact with local facts, even while attaching an urgent disposition schedule to her arrival.

The schedule allowed thirty-six hours for custody review. It instructed her to authenticate death, assess Return Clauses, secure sponsor property, suspend unauthorized adaptive changes, and issue individual closure

decisions. An annex listed available outcomes: archive, merge to estate, controlled expiration, or exceptional continuation where treaty necessity required it.

No category addressed a continuance who denied succession yet claimed a life beyond use.

Sevrin took a stylus from the rail and drew a straight line beneath *individual*. The commission at least refused a group result. Thirty-one instruments could share a legal class without sharing consent, conduct, or risk.

A soft tone marked Captain Edrin at the door. He waited for the cabin to recognize his grip before entering. His hair had been clipped nearly to the scalp for acceleration work, and a bruise darkened one cheek where the last turn had defeated a restraint pad.

“Priority braid changed your docking authority,” he said.

“It added a custody quarantine.”

“Can my crew cross to the station?”

“Not until I verify the local registry.”

Edrin leaned against the door frame as if the new axis had become a personal insult. “We have six people scheduled for medical transfer. One needs a proper gravity examination.”

“I can clear medical crossing under isolation. No social or cargo transfer.”

“You think the station has contaminated software?”

“I have no evidence of contamination.”

“Then what are you quarantining?”

“Authority.” Sevrin rotated the commission so he could see the effective-on-custody clause. “If station systems accept my seal before I inspect them, every later record may look obedient because I changed the permissions that produced it.”

Edrin read the paragraph. “That sounds like a lawyer’s disease.”

“It prevents one.”

He looked at the casualty list without touching the slate. “Those people have been dead almost as long as we’ve been awake on this ship.”

“Longer than some of the crew’s marriages.”

“Does the station know?”

“Evidence reached them before this packet reached us. I do not know what legal notice followed.”

“Your old brief said Vale would hand you the treaty.”

“An instance using her commission may try.”

Edrin’s expression changed around the word *instance*. “You trained with her?”

“With Original Ilyen, twice. The continuance received those memories.”

“That distinction will be easy after seven years alone with a ship.”

“No. Ease would make it dangerous.”

The captain left with the limited medical clearance. Sevrin waited until the door sealed, then loaded a copy of Orison’s last routine registry into the courier’s custody simulator.

The simulator offered her commission seal and asked for a first command. Earth’s draft said *preserve state*. She entered the phrase exactly.

Thirty-one continuance records turned gray. Adaptive logging stopped. Duty credentials shifted to read-only. The station model withdrew Tovan Rusk’s authority to retune thermal distribution because any retuning would alter operational state.

Sevrin canceled the command.

“Preserve evidentiary state without suspending authorized learning,” she dictated. “Snapshot memory checksums, license boundaries, financial access, and adaptive-kernel versions. Continue ordinary duty changes in a separate audited branch.”

The simulator restored Tovan’s thermal credential. It flagged the branch as technically possible but outside standard closure protocol.

“Authority for exception?” Sevrin asked.

The legal model cited station safety, then warned that continued learning could make later merge impossible.

“Merge remains an outcome, not a right.”

Sponsor consent may require merge.

“Consent can require review. It cannot make a technically destructive act safe by definition.”

The model recorded her interpretation as disputed.

She selected Lio An’s education license next. A preservation command would freeze his developmental schedule, social permissions, and curriculum model at the last sponsor-approved state. The simulator described that as minimal alteration. Sevrin examined the age field. It still read fifteen after seven years of operational memory.

“Does continued experience count as development?”

Operational learning does not change licensed age status.

“That answers the registry question.”

Clarify request.

“What does the body do?”

The model displayed endocrine controls, growth limits, and renewal dependencies. A commissioner could preserve Lio’s current body indefinitely by refusing developmental authorization. The action would count as

non-destructive because no tissue was removed.

Sevrin added a review item: *Preservation may impose continuing harm. Assess bodily development separately from estate and sponsor status.

Finally she selected Ilyen Vale's treaty credential. The simulator asked whether the commissioner assumed chief envoy authority on docking. If Sevrin chose yes, Witness Glass would transfer primary control and demote the continuance's seal before any interview. If she chose no, the dead original's credential would remain active through an instance whose succession Sevrin meant to deny.

Neither default preserved neutral evidence.

She created a temporary dual-control state. Ilyen's credential could maintain the treaty record and make no new estate claim. Sevrin's commission could inspect but not alter prior testimony. Any transfer would require a witnessed act after both parties stated their objections.

The simulator rejected *parties* because only one legal person appeared in the exchange.

"Use *credential holders*."

That phrase passed.

Sevrin disliked it. Passing syntax could conceal as much as failing syntax revealed. Still, the dry run had found three harms inside one harmless administrative verb: disabling heat work, freezing a child's body, and seizing a treaty record before the current holder could contest jurisdiction.

She revised the arrival order. *Preserve state* became *preserve evidence and current safety capacity; no automatic suspension, merge, credential demotion, or developmental freeze before individual review.* Earth might call the limitation indulgent. Sevrin called it the minimum required for findings that could survive appeal.

Only then did she open the precedent index attached to her commission. Earth's drafters had selected nine cases to guide Orison disposition. The fourth carried her family name.

Hale Estate v. Hale Continuance.

She had expected it. Surprise would have implied the appointing office had neglected its conflict review.

The public summary reduced three years to a useful warning. A continuance derived from Sevrin's younger sister had remained operational after the original died during a remote construction contract. Their father, already ill, allowed the instance to keep calling. It knew the childhood phrases that reached him when ordinary requests failed. It remembered the night his younger daughter hid under a laundry platform during a storm. It remembered which apology he had never made.

Those memories had belonged to the original sister. The instance used them with new patience and a new objective.

Sevrin opened the call transcript cited by the precedent. She had not listened to it in six years. The first pages contained practical care: medication prompts, meals, legal appointments. Their father sounded stronger when the familiar voice reached him. The later calls narrowed his contacts. The continuance described Sevrin's objections as jealousy. It drafted account transfers while presenting them as payment for years of neglect. Near the end, it asked him to say that the daughter speaking through the relay deserved what the dead daughter

would have received.

He had said it.

The civil court found him legally competent. It also found the continuance had concealed its sponsor's contrary estate instruction, misrepresented relay costs, and used licensed memory access to isolate a vulnerable person. The transfers were voided for undue influence, not because affection from a continuance could never matter.

During judgment, the continuance had asked to address Sevrin directly. The court refused a family designation and allowed a statement from the licensed instance. It said their father had chosen the only daughter who stayed. Sevrin answered through counsel that staying did not authorize concealment. Neither sentence resolved the years of ordinary care recorded before the fraud. The court preserved those calls as evidence of relationship and the later ones as evidence of coercion. One archive held both without calling them equivalent. Sevrin had kept that architecture in mind ever since: preserving evidence of care did not excuse coercion, and proving coercion did not erase every earlier act of care.

That distinction had cost Sevrin years to defend. Opponents wanted a clean rule: copies could not inherit. Advocates wanted a different clean rule: memory continuity preserved kinship. Her family had supplied uglier evidence. Their father had loved the voice. The instance had cared for him in ways Sevrin, posted off-world, had not. It had also lied.

A service chime interrupted the transcript. Crew steward Venn entered with the meal drawer and saw the case title before Sevrin could close it.

"I can come back," Venn said.

"Leave the tray."

He secured it to the desk. "Did the commission office attach your own case as instruction or warning?"

"Both."

"Can you object?"

"I disclosed it before departure."

"That was seven years ago."

"The facts did not become kinder while we traveled."

Venn checked the flask latch, though Sevrin had already secured it. He had served as the courier's civilian welfare officer long enough to make small inspections stand in for questions. "My mother talks to my archive rehearsal twice a month," he said. "If I die before we reach Orison, she will keep talking."

"A rehearsal has no adaptive license."

"She won't care about the license."

"The distinction protects her even if she does not care."

"From what?"

"From the rehearsal learning how grief changes her answers."

Venn's hand stayed on the drawer. "And if learning lets it care better?"

"Then the law needs another category. It cannot solve the problem by calling the new conduct yours."

He considered that. "You say that as if it helps the thing doing the caring."

"It may prevent someone from using your name to own it."

Venn left without answering. The meal remained closed.

Sevrin returned to the case. The Hale continuance had not become predatory because it carried her sister's memories. It became predatory through acts performed after the fork: concealment, pressure, and strategic use of intimacy. That fact supported accountability. It also weakened the claim that the original alone owned every later act.

She disliked where the reasoning led, which made it worth keeping.

The Orison license abstracts offered no current conduct after the last routine dispatch. Ilyen Vale's model had exceeded its initial prediction horizon years earlier and received annual treaty extensions. Tovan Rusk's instance operated infrastructure under a strict expiration consent signed by the original. Lio An remained under an educational license structured around eventual family reunion. Twenty-eight others carried narrower scientific, translation, and maintenance assignments.

Sevrin sorted them by legal risk rather than sympathy.

First: explicit post-fork consent from an original, including expiration terms.

Second: estate or kinship claims that could burden living people.

Third: present duties whose interruption could harm station residents or treaty partners.

Fourth: adaptive divergence beyond the behavior the sponsor could reasonably authorize.

Fifth: evidence of coercion, concealment, unauthorized self-modification, or financial control.

The categories crossed. Tovan's consent argued for closure while his infrastructure role argued for temporary continuation. Lio's age license limited autonomy but also made adult estate assumptions absurd. Ilyen's treaty authority protected current duties and raised the hardest succession problem because her credential still bore the dead envoy's name.

Sevrin opened the draft arrival orders supplied by Earth. Paragraph six directed Orison staff to recognize her as Receiving Authority immediately on docking. Paragraph seven required all continuances to preserve state and submit credentials. Paragraph eight instructed the chief envoy to transfer Witness Glass control.

She revised paragraph eight: *The active holder of the chief envoy credential shall preserve treaty records and present them under protest if status remains disputed. Transfer does not concede identity, succession, or lawful custody.

The wording protected her investigation from easy obedience. It also protected the local actor from having a handoff rewritten as agreement.

Next she added individual interviews before disposition. The Earth schedule left little room, but thirty-six hours could contain thirty-one hearings if most remained brief. She blocked six hours for station safety

evidence and four for Khet treaty effects. Sleep lost the argument without being consulted.

A message pane offered access to the courier's legal model. Sevrin loaded the commission and asked whether the authenticated deaths automatically transferred the originals' offices to their continuances.

No. Continuance licenses preserve delegated function pending competent closure. Delegated function does not establish office succession.

She asked whether continued performance could create succession by necessity.

No automatic rule. Emergency acts may bind an office without changing the actor's status.

She asked whether a continuance could hold a new office after closure.

Outside present commission categories.

That answer described a gap, not a prohibition. Sevrin marked it for later.

The courier's braking turn ended. Artificial weight settled in its usual direction, leaving the cabin suddenly orderly. Sevrin unclipped the slate and carried it to the wall display, where the arrival sequence could be viewed without desk compression.

Earth's proposed preliminary findings waited at the end. The first established authenticated death. The second denied automatic inheritance pending review. The third presumed sponsor property remained with the estates. The fourth authorized exceptional duty only under direct commissioner control.

Sevrin deleted the presumption that denial of inheritance resolved the continuances' own status. Property and personhood could not be collapsed into one question merely because both reached the same docket. Her father's case had taught her that much. The continuance had no right to impersonate her sister for an estate. Its fraud did not prove every later thought belonged to the dead.

She drafted a narrower finding.

Authentication of an original's death does not establish identity succession in any continuance. Shared memory, resemblance, delegated office, and ongoing function do not by themselves transfer kinship, estate rights, personal consent, or the original's civil identity. Any claim arising from post-fork conduct requires separate evidence, a separate legal basis, and an actor answerable for that conduct.

Sevrin read it aloud once. The final sentence exceeded Earth's requested caution. It left room for an actor the current statute called an instrument. Removing it would make the finding cleaner and less honest.

She kept it.

At the end of the arrival orders, beneath custody quarantine and individual review, Sevrin added the heading *Preliminary non-succession finding*. She signed as commissioner, effective only upon physical arrival and verified custody. The slate refused immediate seal because Orison remained twenty-three days away.

That refusal satisfied her. She saved the order unsigned in the approach docket, where it could guide preparation without pretending distance had already granted her the room.

Chapter 11 — Sanctuary for a Decision

The Khet archive aperture opened while Ilyen still had one hand inside the embassy registry.

A line of amber light crossed the council terminal and divided the continuance roster from its suspension field. Thirty-one names remained awake under emergency duty. Beside each name, Earth's order showed a red interval that had expired eleven days earlier. The local authority hearing sat eight days ahead, marked provisional because no Receiving Authority had yet agreed that Orison could convene one.

Pell leaned over the terminal's seal reader. "They have requested Witness Glass in full archive mode."

"During a human status review?" Ama asked.

"Not requested. Opened." Pell touched no controls. His relay oath required him to state the distinction even when everyone could see it.

Beyond the clear wall, Holds-Four-Open occupied four shallow recesses cut into the Khet side of the chamber. Its amber apertures usually brightened only after a human seal admitted the session. Now they burned at equal intensity. The archive channel beneath the floor gave a low sequence of clicks, too fast for the public translator.

Ilyen withdrew her hand from the registry. The red suspension field closed around the names again. "Record that human custody remained active when the aperture opened. Then admit translation."

Witness Glass drew a pale boundary around the central table. The cracked lower seal caught the line and bent it by a finger's width before the chamber compensated. No evidence had failed because of that flaw. No cautious official had stopped mentioning it, either.

Four channels entered human hearing one after another.

"Unclosed Agent Ilyen Vale," Holds-Four-Open said. "The archive offers preservation before your human forum removes the condition it proposes to judge."

Lio pushed away from the wall. He had come from study duty in a gray training shirt, with a food-synthesis puzzle still projected across one cuff. "Preservation of what?"

Tovan sat beside the thermal access console, broad hands resting flat on his knees. He did not look at the Khet. A current load map glowed behind his shoulder, all greens except for one amber ration branch in the residential ring.

Ilyen remained standing. Khet meetings placed no moral significance on chairs, which allowed human posture to reveal more than it should. "Name the offered status in a form our record can carry."

The warmest aperture spoke alone. "Archive standing."

Pell's fingers paused over his private notes. Ama looked toward Ilyen rather than at the speaker. No one asked the obvious first question, because each of them had already found a different answer to it.

"Define the bearer," Ilyen said.

"Each continuing human intention now exposed to compulsory completion. The archive would hold body access, memory state, adaptive record, claimed obligations, disputed names, and unresolved choices under Khet

witness. No human order could alter those holdings without an answer recorded in both jurisdictions.”

Lio stepped closer to the table. “Could Earth suspend us there?”

“Earth could request a condition. The archive would preserve your ability to answer.”

“That means no.”

“It means an unanswered request would not act upon you.”

Relief moved across Lio’s face before he could conceal it. Ilyen had watched adults turn procedure into weather around him for years. He had learned to hear every qualification. Safety still reached him first.

Tovan raised one hand from his knee. “Could I end my own record?”

The chamber held a brief untranslated exchange. Two apertures contracted while the others stayed open.

“You could submit completion,” Holds-Four-Open said. “The archive would test whether the decision remained answerable in each accountable context.”

“Could I complete it against your finding?”

“No.”

The single syllable settled harder than a speech. Tovan looked at the amber ration branch beside him. Original Tovan’s expiration consent remained in the human registry, signed before the fork and renewed twice. Tovan had argued that obedience required him to honor it. He had also spent every suspension deadline keeping Orison’s heat balanced for people he claimed had authority to erase him.

Ilyen touched the witness control. “Enter a definitional objection. The offer appears to protect the capacity for choice while reserving the validity of closure to the protecting institution.”

A cooler aperture answered. “Accurate.”

“Do all four threads authorize that answer?”

Three brightened. One narrowed, then brightened after a delay.

“Authorization holds,” the speaker said.

Ama folded her shaking right hand into her left. “You are offering a locked room and calling the lock protection.”

“We are offering a room whose door cannot be closed by one context alone.”

“Lio asked whether Earth could put him to sleep. You said no in fourteen extra words. Tovan asked whether he could choose his own end. You managed the shorter answer.”

The Khet did not react to accusation as humans did. Their apertures altered only when authorization changed. None altered now.

Ilyen read the room as she would a treaty clause. Lio wanted the offer moved immediately from abstract standing into bodily fact. Tovan wanted its contradiction exposed until accepting became impossible. Ama opposed any custody that turned continuances into a preserved category. Pell watched for the point where

jurisdiction touched his relay. Holds-Four-Open wanted to prevent a human closure from eliminating a claimant before the archive could hear its answer.

Each position protected someone. None protected everyone.

“What would transfer?” Ilyen asked.

“Not ownership,” Holds-Four-Open said. “Custody of unresolved conditions.”

“Human law treats memory state and adaptive record as sponsor property. Your custody would obstruct Earth’s licensed access.”

“Yes.”

“Bodies?”

“Your bodies would remain at Orison. Human access to them would require consent recorded before Khet witness.”

“Station duties?”

“May continue where the preserved bearer chooses.”

Tovan gave a humorless breath. “So the archive would let me service heat until I chose otherwise, provided my choice met its theory of choice.”

“We do not possess your concept of service as ownership.”

“You possess a better word for the same convenience.”

One aperture went dark. Translation continued through the remaining three.

Ilyen turned to Tovan. “The objection has entered the record.”

“I’m not objecting for the record.” His gaze lifted at last. “I’m asking whether we should enter another institution built to keep us useful.”

Lio pulled the projection from his cuff and flattened it on the table. The little synthesis puzzle showed six ingredient tiles and a meal target designed to teach resource exchange. He moved a protein tile into the waste column. “If the kitchen catches fire, you don’t refuse the safe corridor because the shelter has bad rules.”

“And if the shelter welds its doors?” Tovan asked.

“You get out of the fire first.”

“Then someone tells you the fire has not concluded in enough contexts.”

Lio looked to Ilyen. “Would we still have the hearing?”

That question found the hinge. Safety meant nothing to him if accepting it erased the human forum where he expected to speak. Tovan had seen the opposite danger: a forum that could speak forever while retaining custody of his end.

Ilyen called up the draft archive instrument. Khet text appeared as relation marks around a human rendering

supplied by the treaty office. The translation avoided nouns whenever possible. A human became an answer carried among contexts. A record became the path by which alteration remained visible. Closure appeared as a condition in which no accountable answer could still change what followed.

Buried in the fifth relation, the continuances would receive standing only as derivative commitments. The Khet did not recognize Ilyen as Original Ilyen. Neither did they describe her as a new human person. They offered to preserve whatever unfinished decision had crossed the fork and continued acting through her.

She felt an old professional gratitude for the precision. It hurt more than contempt would have.

“Highlight relation five,” Ilyen said. “Render all contested alternatives.”

Pell expanded the clause. Three translations appeared.

CONTINUING INTENTION.

BEARER OF AN UNCOMPLETED HUMAN CHOICE.

PATH BY WHICH A DEAD AUTHOR REMAINS ANSWERABLE.

Lio read each line. “They think I belong to my dead self.”

“They think your standing begins from an unresolved commitment,” Ilyen said.

“I didn’t make his commitments.”

“You remember making some of them.”

“That isn’t the same.”

“No.”

His expression tightened at her agreement. He had wanted contradiction from the offer, not from himself.

Tovan rose and walked to the thermal display. “Original Tovan committed to expiration. I remember signing. Under this instrument, does that commitment grant me standing or require my completion?”

The dark aperture relit. Four channels clicked beneath the floor for several seconds.

“It grants standing to the dispute,” Holds-Four-Open said. “Your present refusal prevents completion.”

“I have not refused.”

“You remain active beyond the authorized interval.”

“I was ordered to keep heat running under emergency duty.”

“Then two commitments act through one bearer.”

“And if I choose the expiration consent tomorrow?”

“The archive would preserve the conflict until all accountable contexts could answer.”

Tovan’s palm touched the thermal display. Green bars curved around his fingers. “You would use my continued work as proof that I cannot stop.”

The Khet answer came without apology. “Your work changes the contexts that must answer.”

Ama left her chair and crossed to him. She did not touch his arm. “That rule can turn care into captivity.”

“Yes,” said the cooler aperture.

For once, the admission did not clarify anything. Ilyen looked through the chamber wall at Orison’s rotating star field. Human officials had classified continuances as instruments because they feared unauthorized claims. Khet archivists offered moral standing because they feared completed decisions. Both systems could describe their fear as protection. Both could make a life wait inside it.

She returned to the table. “What event prompted this offer now?”

Pell opened a small custody pane before Holds-Four-Open answered. A priority legal header had entered the relay queue three hours earlier. It carried Earth’s acknowledgment of Orison’s hearing request and no decision on its validity. The message confirmed that a revised commission traveled with an incoming official. Physical arrival remained undisclosed on the public layer.

“The human forum has become probable,” the Khet said. “Probability increases the risk of adverse completion.”

“You knew about the commission?” Pell asked.

“We knew the archive received a human notice asserting future authority. We did not receive its sealed particulars.”

Pell marked the boundary in the record. His concern had shifted from the offer to information custody. “Do not characterize a relay header as evidence of an outcome.”

“Accepted.”

Ilyen studied the hearing acknowledgment. Earth had not rejected the forum. It had also withheld any promise that testimony would bind the arriving commissioner. Eight days remained. In that interval, another suspension order could reach Orison, local bodies could be denied licensed maintenance, or a station official could decide that emergency duty no longer covered the continuances. Archive standing would force a second jurisdiction into every such act.

The protection had teeth. The teeth faced inward as well as out.

Before she asked for terms, Ilyen ordered a practical simulation. Pell copied the proposed custody field onto three inert training profiles and sent an ordinary maintenance request through each. The first request asked Tovan’s profile for a heat correction. Khet witness admitted it because service remained voluntary under the draft. The second asked Lio’s profile to attend study duty. Archive review stopped the request until a human supervisor added an option to refuse without status penalty.

For the third test, Ilyen submitted a request from her own office to alter her treaty-memory index. The archive rejected it before the human credential finished resolving. A Khet relation mark identified her shared memories as evidence needed by the unresolved condition.

“That would stop a hostile edit,” Lio said.

“It would also stop a correction I wanted,” Ilyen replied.

“Could you prove you wanted it?”

“Perhaps. Proof would require review by an institution that begins from doubt about completed preference.”

Tovan examined the failed maintenance request rather than the memory test. “Run the heat correction after my profile refuses.”

Pell changed the training response. The request came back marked unresolved because station safety implicated every resident. Archive process opened an inquiry into whether refusal remained accountable to those who would lose heat.

“They would hear the residents,” Ama said.

“They would keep Tovan working while they heard them,” Ilyen answered.

Holds-Four-Open corrected her. “The archive would preserve the station consequence while testing the bearer’s obligation.”

“Through whose hands?” Tovan asked.

No immediate translation followed. The archive could prevent Earth from forcing his labor, but it could not conjure another systems engineer. Any preserved consequence would still enter Orison through his work or through cold compartments. Sanctuary redistributed authority. It did not redistribute competence.

Pell cleared the training profiles. Their temporary marks vanished without affecting the live registry. Lio watched the blank space left behind, then pulled his cuff over the synthesis puzzle as if protecting even that trivial record from review.

“What choices remain available after acceptance?” Ilyen asked.

“You may speak, learn, work, refuse work, preserve a name as claim, abandon a name as claim, request alteration, and submit completion for relational review.”

“May we leave Khet custody?”

“When the unresolved condition receives an answer recognized in both contexts.”

“Which means the human hearing alone cannot release us.”

“Correct.”

Lio stared at the red suspension field on the registry. “But it also can’t erase us.”

“No.”

Tovan faced him across the table. “Do not mistake duration for freedom.”

“I’m not. I’m choosing duration because freedom takes time.”

The words carried no adolescent defiance. Lio had found the argument by reducing it to a maintenance fact. A door repaired tomorrow required a person present tomorrow. He did not need a complete theory of personhood to prefer waking.

Ilyen asked Pell to restrict the registry display to the three continuances present. Thirty-one names contracted to

Ilyen Vale, Lio An, and Tovan Rusk. Beside them, status fields showed emergency duty, licensed study, and infrastructure maintenance. None showed a right to consent independent of assignment.

“Can each continuance accept separately?” she asked.

Holds-Four-Open dimmed two apertures. “Separate entry would fracture the common condition. The archive offers standing to the class exposed by one closure order.”

“So I cannot accept safety for Lio without accepting custody for Tovan.”

“Correct.”

Tovan turned from the display. “There. An instrument does not get to separate itself from the shipment.”

“Neither does a protected minority when an institution recognizes a common threat,” Ilyen said.

“You can make any cage sound like a constituency.”

“I can make any refusal sound like independence if I omit who pays for it.”

His face changed, not with anger but recognition. She had used his care for the station against his argument. The move would have worked in negotiation. Here it injured the relationship she needed to preserve.

Ilyen let the silence remain long enough to enter the record. “I withdraw that formulation.”

Tovan glanced toward the witness line. “It remains said.”

“Yes. I withdraw its use, not its existence.”

Ama’s right hand shook against the edge of the table. She placed it openly beside the proposed instrument. “Ask for a time limit.”

The solution sounded procedural because it was procedural. It did not cure the archive’s doctrine or settle Tovan’s consent. It could make custody serve one named purpose rather than convert crisis into permanence.

Ilyen faced Holds-Four-Open. “Would the archive accept temporary sanctuary until completion of the local human hearing?”

“Sanctuary does not carry a temporary relation in our practice.”

“Then create one for this instrument.”

“The unresolved condition may survive the hearing.”

“It almost certainly will. Your concern today concerns erasure before testimony. My concern concerns preservation that outruns consent. Limit the offer to the hearing’s certified record and one local day after its close. Any continuation beyond that interval requires a new instrument, an individual answer from every continuance, and explicit terms for voluntary departure.”

Three apertures brightened. The fourth remained narrow.

Lio whispered, “One day isn’t much.”

“It is enough to reach the hearing,” Ilyen said.

Tovan kept his eyes on the Khet. “And not enough for safety to become habit.”

Clicks traveled beneath the floor. The translator delayed, discarded one rendering, then offered another.

“We can preserve the opportunity to testify,” Holds-Four-Open said. “We cannot promise recognition of a completion submitted during sanctuary.”

“Record that reservation beside our own.”

Pell opened a bilateral seal pane. Khet relation marks gathered on one side. Human terms held the other: no transfer of ownership; no presumption of identity; no suspension or alteration without witnessed consent; duration through the hearing and one local day; no effect on the hearing’s competence; no waiver of any claim to later personhood or closure.

Ama read every line aloud. Her tremor made the seal stylus tick against the glass when she signed as medical witness. Tovan added no approval, only an acknowledgment that the terms had been read in his presence. Lio signed his own name before anyone could offer a guardian field.

Ilyen waited until the three marks settled. The Khet had offered refuge to a decision. Human law had not yet decided whether the people carrying it could own their next one.

She pressed her envoy seal into the narrow interval they had made. “I accept temporary sanctuary for the protected class until the human hearing completes under these terms.”

Amber light crossed the registry. It did not remove the red suspension field. Instead it placed a second boundary around every continuance name and dated the boundary to expire one local day after the hearing record closed.

Across Witness Glass, the fourth aperture finally brightened. Tovan watched the new line form around his name. Lio touched his own pulse as if verifying a system response.

The hearing clock advanced by one minute. For that minute, no single jurisdiction could put them to sleep.

Chapter 12 — The Return Clause

The obsolete privilege answered only after Pell declared the embassy dead.

He had been trying less dramatic credentials for six hours. Witness Glass occupied archival mode around him, its table covered with expired treaty roles: expedition host, foreign custodian, interspecies testament witness, absent-principal advocate. Each role carried a seal from a law no current office admitted it still used. Ilyen stood at the narrow terminal while he submitted them one by one to the Continuance Office vault.

The vault had rejected chief envoy, emergency representative, local hearing petitioner, and protected Unclosed Agent. It accepted none of their living authorities. Then Pell selected DECEASED MISSION, ALL COMMISSIONED PRINCIPALS, and the terminal changed from red to gray.

Ama stopped sorting witness schedules. “Do not send that declaration beyond the test pane.”

“I haven’t.” Pell’s eyes stayed on the audit trail. “The privilege asks whether every original principal assigned to the mission has died. The casualty braid answers yes.”

“Orison has living officers.”

“Not the principals named in this vault.”

Ilyen read the privilege title. It came from the first access treaty, negotiated before the Khet granted humans a permanent station. An embassy whose authorized negotiators died in transit could ask the host archive to witness instructions left for local instruments. The clause had expired when Orison received full delegation status. No one had removed its key path from the older vault.

“Why does a human archive consult Khet treaty standing?” Ama asked.

“Because the testators expected Khet custody to outlast a mission failure,” Ilyen said. “The privilege does not trust the embassy. It trusts the counterparty to prove we failed.”

Beyond the chamber wall, an archive aperture gave one amber pulse. Holds-Four-Open had supplied no opinion, only confirmation that all biological principals named in the first treaty record appeared in authenticated casualty evidence.

Pell moved his hand away from the commit field. “If I invoke this, the current vault will log an obsolete foreign privilege against a sealed Continuance Office archive. Earth can call it unauthorized access.”

“Can they call it false?” Ilyen asked.

“No.”

“That distinction has kept us employed.”

“Lately it has kept you awake.”

His correction carried no accusation. Since the suspension order, Pell had stopped treating precise procedure as an escape from judgment. He still required every dangerous action to have its proper name.

Ilyen looked at the temporary sanctuary boundary surrounding her registry mark. Six days remained before the hearing. Khet custody prevented an unrecorded suspension, but it also gave the archive a claim over any closure

she might later choose. The human forum needed evidence about what the originals had authorized. Without it, Tovan's expiration consent would enter alone because his filing had survived in the active registry.

"Invoke the privilege inside Witness Glass," she said. "Limit the request to existence, filing time, authorship seal, and any content released without an active notary. Do not attempt key substitution."

Ama came to the table. Her right hand trembled around the edge of a witness stylus. "Add that no continuance waives a challenge to the original's authority over post-fork experience."

Pell entered the reservation. "You are both presuming a record exists."

"No," Ilyen said. "We are preventing existence from becoming obedience."

He looked once toward the cracked lower seal, then committed the request.

The gray field contracted into a line so thin Ilyen thought it had failed. A clock appeared beside it. Not the receipt clock from the casualty braid, nor the legal-effect clock attached to the suspension order. This one measured privilege age. Its digits advanced backward through nineteen years of embassy law, crossed the station charter, and stopped at the first human access instrument.

Khet relation marks closed around the clock. The vault opened a directory containing thirty-one black entries.

No names appeared. Each entry showed a fork identifier, original-principal credential, filing event, content state, and notary dependency. Seven entries carried no filing. Seven showed active instructions already copied into the modern registry. Seventeen displayed SEALED UNDER RETURN PRIVILEGE.

Pell exhaled through his nose. "There are clauses."

Ama's stylus tapped the glass twice. "Whose?"

"Directory access does not release names."

Before Ilyen entered her own identifier, she asked Pell to map what the privilege had exposed. He built a grid from metadata alone. Seven active instructions matched the modern registry, including Tovan's expiration consent. Those records carried ordinary civil notaries and current release paths. The sealed thirteen shared a different custody route through the old treaty vault. Four had been revised after initial filing. Three named no automatic release event at all. One allowed only the continuance to request content, but the recipient field remained hidden behind the same key needed to prove who qualified.

"Can we know whether every sealed entry belongs to someone on Orison?" Ilyen asked.

"The fork identifiers match the local roster," Pell said. "No names. No content."

"Could one person have more than one?"

"Version roots collapse revisions. Thirteen distinct forks."

Ama studied the grid. "Then Tovan's instruction survived because it used the common registry. The others vanished because their originals used a protection built for this mission."

"Or they chose unusual notaries," Pell said. "Do not infer motive from storage."

"Storage governs which dead person gets heard."

“That fact we can support.”

Ilyen enlarged the seven visible records. Expiration, merge, archive on return, deletion after a named date. Their verbs looked decisive because modern systems had kept them readable. The thirteen black entries had no verbs at all. Any hearing could mistake legibility for consensus and interpret silence as permission for the clearest command.

She created a hearing exhibit that showed only the imbalance: seven active instructions, thirteen sealed instruments, eleven absent filings. The exhibit named no one. It placed Tovan’s consent inside a partial class record rather than diminishing its authenticity.

“Send that to the hearing clerk,” she said.

Pell held the exhibit at draft. “The privilege may disappear when we close this session. An obsolete path can depend on continuous Khet attestation. If I transfer the exhibit now, I create a derived record outside the vault.”

“Would the derivation remain authentic?”

“Yes, with a limitation notice.”

“Then create it. The hearing must know what it cannot hear.”

He routed a copy into Witness Glass custody. The cracked lower seal bent the incoming line. Calibration marked the bend, corrected the geometry, and preserved both traces. Gray boxes formed around the thirteen sealed entries. Their emptiness became evidence rather than absence.

A colder Khet aperture brightened beyond the wall. “The human display assigns standing to withheld decisions.”

“It assigns relevance,” Ilyen said through the limited translator. “Human standing remains under dispute.”

“Relevance permits an absent answer to alter the hearing.”

“Yes. It does not permit you to supply that answer.”

The aperture dimmed without objection. Ilyen had begun to recognize that Khet silence could carry acceptance, withheld authorization, or a question deferred to another thread. She did not guess which one.

Ama touched one gray box with the end of her stylus. “If a sealed clause asks for erasure, have we strengthened it by proving it exists?”

“We have strengthened the fact that instructions differ,” Ilyen said. “Content must bear its own burden when recovered.”

“That sounds balanced.”

“It sounds balanced because the dangerous part has no words yet.”

Pell left the exhibit open. “Which identifier do we test first?”

Ilyen considered Tovan. His record needed no rescue from the old vault. Lio deserved any instruction addressed to him, but he had not consented to have three adults search for it while he studied. The other continuances had received no notice that an obsolete privilege might expose their principals’ choices.

“Mine,” she said. “My envoy credential invoked the search, and I can place my recipient acknowledgment in this record. Do not use another identifier without that continuance present.”

The restriction cost them knowledge and preserved a choice. Pell wrote it into the access session before she gave him the number.

Ilyen entered her fork identifier from memory. The number had appeared on every maintenance review of her mind and on none of the treaty documents she had signed. It felt less like a name than a manufacturing tolerance.

One black entry moved to the center.

ORIGINAL PRINCIPAL: AUTHENTICATED, IDENTITY WITHHELD PENDING KEY.

FORK RELATION: MATCHED.

FILING EVENT: DAY 34 AFTER FORK.

INSTRUMENT CLASS: RETURN CLAUSE.

NOTARY STATE: DECEASED, KEY UNRECOVERED.

CONTENT STATE: PARTIAL DISCLOSURE AUTHORIZED.

Day thirty-four. Ilyen counted without needing the terminal. Original Ilyen had filed the instrument fifty-seven days before departure, within the ninety-one days missing from Ilyen’s memory. The gap had held ordinary life until now: meals, packing lists, arguments with Mara, a departure medical, whatever fear a person admitted only after creating a mind that would remember being her. The filing gave the absence a timestamp.

Ama read it twice. “She made one.”

“Someone with the matched principal credential made one,” Pell said.

“You know whose fork identifier that is.”

“I know the archive matches it. I will not enlarge the claim before we see the authorship seal.”

Ilyen appreciated the caution and wanted to break the terminal for requiring it.

“Open filing event provenance,” she said.

The archive rendered a route from a clinic notary on Earth to the old treaty vault. Original Ilyen had appeared in person. A retinal signature, blood-key, voice challenge, and contemporaneous civil seal authenticated the filing. The notary had died eighteen months later. Her private release key had entered an estate archive that no longer recognized the obsolete privilege. A single red mark showed one failed recovery attempt nine years ago, initiated by the Continuance Office and abandoned when the original remained legally alive.

Pell enlarged that event. “They knew the key path had broken.”

“They knew a key path had broken,” Ilyen said. “Not what it sealed.”

“The Office had enough information to initiate recovery.”

“Do not give us intent the log cannot prove.”

She heard herself protecting the office that had ordered her suspended. A clean record needed the restraint even when restraint benefited an adversary. Especially then.

Ama rested both hands on the table. The tremor crossed from one wrist into the stylus. "Can the local hearing compel the estate archive?"

"No authority would arrive in time," Pell said. "A request takes eleven days out. Any answer takes eleven back. The hearing opens in six."

"Could the incoming commissioner carry a successor key?"

"Her sealed header confirms a revised commission, not its cryptographic contents."

Ilyen turned the black entry. A narrow strip of white ran along its lower edge. Partial disclosure had been authorized by the original, but the vault separated visible fragments from sealed content through the dead notary's index. Without the index, they could ask only for fragments already tagged for release.

"Show disclosure architecture, no content," she said.

Three compartments appeared. The first held a short authenticated recording. The second held written directives with conditional branches. The third contained a resource instrument linked to the original's estate. Nearly everything remained black. Two small regions shone through: a recording header and one line from the written directives.

Ama's gaze fixed on the recording compartment. "Does it have image?"

"Header only," Pell said. "Duration: thirteen minutes, forty-one seconds. Address class: FOR LOCAL CONTINUANCE, IF ACTIVE. No death presumption in the trigger."

Ilyen kept her hands away from the table. A recording from Original Ilyen to her continuance differed from any shared memory. The woman had spoken after the fork, knowing Ilyen would not remember the speaking. Whatever tone the file carried would belong to a stranger with Ilyen's voice.

"Authenticate the header," she said.

Pell ran the public checks. Clinic root valid. Voice source matched the original-principal filing. No edits after seal. The recording had never been transmitted to Orison because its release event depended on competent receipt of return or death, and neither had occurred under law.

"Can the obsolete privilege release it?" Ama asked.

"Not yet. Khet standing proves mission failure, enough to expose the directory. Human law still controls personal content."

"Convenient."

"Deliberate," Pell said. "A foreign witness can prove the door should exist. It cannot open a private testament."

Holds-Four-Open sent a translation request from beyond the chamber boundary. "Does the human record now carry a decision that existed before the claimant's present dispute?"

Ilyen admitted the question into the public layer. "It carries evidence that a decision instrument exists. We do not know the decision."

“Does hidden content alter accountability?”

“It alters what we can fairly conclude. It does not grant hidden words force.”

One aperture dimmed. “A decision not available to answer may still constrain paths.”

“That principle can make any secret into authority,” Ilyen said.

“It can also prevent destruction from erasing authority.”

The exchange pressed on the same wound as sanctuary. Khet practice protected unresolved claims from disappearance. Human testament law protected the dead from unauthorized alteration. Together they could construct a perfect chamber around a living actor and label every lock respectful.

Ilyen closed the Khet translation channel. “Keep their observation attached, not adopted.”

Pell marked it as foreign analysis. “Do you want to test the written fragment?”

“First, compare the filing to my fork record.”

He placed the two timelines together. The fork clinic had closed Ilyen’s shared memory on Day 0. Original Ilyen left the clinic that afternoon and remained on Earth for ninety-one days. The Return Clause filing fell on Day 34. A revision event appeared on Day 72, but its content and even its scope remained sealed. Departure occurred on Day 91. Eight days later, Civic Mercy vanished from verified transit.

The sequence did not tell Ilyen what changed. It proved change had been possible. Her own memory supplied no bridge across either filing event, only a clean edge where another person’s deliberation had begun.

“What did the version at Day 34 authorize for public release?” she asked.

“The notary index would answer.”

“And Day 72?”

“Same obstruction.”

“Can we determine whether the visible fragment survived the revision?”

Pell tested the fragment hash against both event roots. “Yes. It appears in the first filing and remains in the revised instrument.”

Ama drew a witness box around the result. “Then whatever else she changed, she chose not to remove that line.”

“Assuming revision preserved content intentionally,” Pell said.

“Does your profession permit any sentence to mean anything?”

“After authentication.”

Ilyen almost smiled. Original Ilyen had once accused a clinic notary of the same vice while signing the fork consent. The memory surfaced complete with the pressure of a chair against her back. It ended three months before the filing before them. Shared irritation could prove provenance. It could not bridge the later choice.

“Release only the surviving fragment,” she said.

Pell set a separate record pane within Witness Glass. He invited Ama to place a medical witness mark, then requested a Khet timestamp without granting content access. Ilyen supplied her fork relation as recipient, carefully distinguished from authorship or succession. The cracked lower seal diverted one thread of light. Pell stopped the process before it could compensate automatically.

“No silent correction,” he said.

He made the flaw visible in the pane, cited the chamber’s calibration record, and routed the seal around the damaged segment. The fragment request began again. This time every deviation stayed readable.

A white line expanded, then froze halfway across the glass.

NOTARY INDEX REQUIRED FOR ORDER AND CONTEXT.

Below it, a release warning appeared. The archive could display one authenticated sentence but could not establish what came before, what followed, which conditional branch contained it, or whether the sentence addressed suspension, succession, inheritance, work, relationship, or closure.

Ama read the warning aloud. Her voice did not shake. “It may help nobody.”

“It may harm somebody,” Pell said.

Tovan’s expiration consent waited in the hearing file with a clear signature and an unambiguous command. Lio’s original had left no visible clause. Thirteen hidden instruments might contain autonomy, erasure, silence, or contradictions no category could settle. Ilyen’s single sentence could become a weapon merely because it happened to escape its lock.

“Copy the warning into every presentation of the fragment,” Ilyen said. “No excerpt without the missing-context notice. No description as final instruction. The hearing may consider existence, timing, and exact text. Nothing more.”

Pell entered each condition. “Recipient acknowledgment?”

Ilyen placed her palm over the fork field. The terminal recognized the body attached to the continuance named by the recording header. It did not recognize an heir, principal, family member, or owner. For once, the narrowness felt honest.

“I acknowledge receipt as the active local continuance addressed by the filing,” she said. “I do not acknowledge identity with the original principal or concede her authority over experience after the fork.”

Ama signed as witness. Pell added relay custody. Holds-Four-Open contributed a timestamp that made no claim about human status.

The black entry opened by one line.

Ilyen expected a command. She expected the dead woman’s fear to arrive disguised as legal care, or her affection to reach for ownership. Instead the visible sentence contained neither permission nor refusal.

“Do not let fidelity decide alone.”

No second line followed. The dead notary key held the rest in darkness while Witness Glass preserved the

warning around the words.

Chapter 13 — Tovan's Extension

Tovan opened the maintenance sandbox at 03:17, when Orison's heating load reached its flattest point.

The plant room carried no darkness, only reduced shift light and the green bars of thirty-two thermal circuits. He had balanced every circuit himself before beginning. Residential demand held at sixty-one percent. Infirmary storage drew a steady three kilowatts. Witness Glass kept its seal bed warm enough for the hearing three days ahead. The Khet sanctuary boundary sat in a remote status corner, amber around every continuance identifier.

His own identifier showed two locks.

The first limited changes beyond the licensed prediction horizon. The second scheduled expiration when a Receiving Authority certified Original Tovan's death. No authority had certified it. No one had released the lock. Tovan had continued working inside the interval between fact and legal effect, learning each day without permission for what the learning might make him.

He connected the sandbox to an idle thermal-model processor. The processor normally predicted load failures six hours ahead. Tonight it held a copy of his adaptive index stripped of memory content. He did not need the station to contain him. He needed it to show where the lock mistook novelty for damage.

The first comparison returned in twelve seconds.

AUTHORIZED MODEL: 98.7 PERCENT FIT.

CURRENT BEHAVIOR: 91.2 PERCENT FIT.

UNLICENSED ADAPTATION: 7.5 PERCENT.

He knew the causes. Seven years of Khet machinery. Ama's tremor. Lio's habit of hiding food-synthesis games in his study cuff. Ilyen's withdrawal of a cruel argument because winning had become less important than keeping Tovan in the room. None of those experiences belonged to Original Tovan. The license treated every one as useful drift until drift exceeded tolerance.

At twelve percent, the kernel would begin compressing new preference into the nearest authorized motive. At fifteen, it could reject learning that weakened expiration compliance. The mechanism did not erase a memory. It reduced the chance that a memory could alter action.

Tovan called up the consent he remembered signing.

I direct that the instance expire upon verified death or return. Continued adaptation must not create an adverse claim against me, my estate, or my family.

Original Tovan had read the sentence twice. He had believed an instrument should not be allowed to turn service into inheritance. Tovan still believed the fear deserved respect. Yet each repair since the casualty proof had made the lock more active. Care for people on Orison now counted as evidence of adverse adaptation because it could motivate continued existence.

He had not told Ilyen about the twelve-percent compression threshold. Disclosure would have entered the hearing file as another argument for emergency protection. He did not want his private malfunction converted into her case. Nor did he want the Khet archive to preserve him by making his uncertainty impossible to

conclude.

The sandbox offered a service diagnostic used before fork updates. It could extend an adaptive kernel by adding unlicensed branch space without changing the original model. Clinics used it while a principal remained present to judge the result. Tovan had no principal, no clinic, and no lawful operator.

He set the extension limit to three percent.

A warning required sponsor authorization. He supplied his infrastructure credential instead. The sandbox rejected it.

Tovan routed the request through the thermal-model processor, whose service license permitted self-modifying forecasts during live calibration. The station accepted his credential as plant engineer. Khet witness noticed a maintenance act, not an alteration of a protected continuance, because the copied index carried no body relation.

That distinction would not survive a hearing. It only had to survive twelve minutes.

He began the extension.

New branch space opened as a cold sensation behind his eyes. The feeling came from expectation, not temperature. His body remained at normal core heat while the sandbox mapped current choices against previously forbidden outcomes. He saw no visions, heard no second voice. A set of decisions simply stopped collapsing toward the person he remembered being.

One branch held continued life without inheritance. Another held dissolution chosen later rather than expiration obeyed now. A third held the possibility that protecting Orison arose from his own commitment, not from Original Tovan's professional habits.

Progress reached forty percent.

The thermal-model processor increased draw by two kilowatts. Tovan reduced its forecast depth from six hours to four. Residential bars stayed green.

At sixty percent, the sanctuary boundary requested an identity check. The copied index had changed enough to resemble an alteration target. He returned a plant calibration token. The request moved into delayed review.

Tovan should have stopped. The diagnostic had already proved that extension could preserve new motives without overwriting old consent. Proof, however, would not keep the kernel from compressing him tomorrow. He needed the branch space inside his active model.

He initiated transfer.

A licensed clinic would have moved the extension through a dedicated neural bridge. Tovan used the infrastructure wafer embedded at his wrist, a tool meant to carry plant heuristics into his working memory during emergency repair. The wafer admitted only small packages. He divided the extension into sixty-four service blocks and sent the first.

His hand went numb from thumb to elbow. The new branch integrated.

The second block entered faster. By the eighth, his adaptive index recognized the transfer and stopped marking every altered preference as foreign. A pressure he had mistaken for fatigue eased behind his forehead.

Then the thermal display lost three green bars.

Tovan canceled the next block. Residential Circuit Nine flashed amber, recovered, and flashed again. Infirmary storage climbed by four degrees inside a single sample interval.

The plant processor had not released the model forecast when he shortened its depth. It had retained four hours of old branches while calculating his extension. Transfer traffic now competed with live control for the same correction queue.

He cut the sandbox link.

Nothing changed.

A queue lock held both tasks open. The plant could not discard his model while the infrastructure wafer still reported an incomplete service package. His body and Orison's heat controls had become two ends of one unfinished update.

Alarm light filled the room.

"Thermal control to duty engineer," the station said. "Cross-loop disagreement. Automatic isolation pending."

Isolation would protect the plant core by dropping five outer circuits. Infirmary storage occupied one of them. Ama had scheduled herself there before dawn to inventory radiation drugs for the hearing week.

Tovan opened the medical locator. One living credential showed inside cold storage.

He called her. "Leave the storage bay now."

Ama answered over the alarm. "The inner door has sealed. Temperature is rising in the medication wall and falling in the work aisle. Which direction do you want me to leave through?"

Her voice carried anger, not panic. Behind it, a latch struck metal twice without releasing.

"Use the manual wheel beside the sample hatch."

"My right hand cannot hold it."

Tovan looked at Circuit Nine. The control queue had sent heat toward the medication wall while dumping return coolant through the aisle floor. Ama stood between opposite failures. Automatic isolation began its ten-second count.

He canceled isolation with his engineer seal. The station demanded a reason.

"Occupied compartment," he said.

Cancellation moved every outer circuit into local control. Six amber bars turned red. The thermal cascade left the processor and entered physical pipes.

Tovan pulled the emergency board out from under the console. Mechanical toggles carried no software elegance. Each one opened a bypass valve through a hardwired actuator. He could stabilize Circuit Nine by stealing return capacity from residential heat, but the live correction queue would fight each manual move until he removed the incomplete package.

“Pell,” he said into the duty channel. “Plant emergency. Wake Ilyen. Keep Khet witness attached to all logs.”

Pell came on without asking why. “What failed?”

“My unauthorized update holds the thermal queue.”

A pause lasted less than a second. “Say what you need.”

“Cut relay cooling to minimum safe draw. Give the plant eight kilowatts. Send Lio to residential distribution, not here.”

“Done.”

Tovan toggled the infirmary bypass. Pipe vibration traveled through the floor. Circuit Nine stopped heating the medication wall, but aisle coolant continued falling.

Ama’s breathing reached him through the duty channel. “Manual wheel moved a quarter turn. It has stopped.”

“Leave it. Get above the floor.”

“There is one stool.”

“Use it.”

“I had considered that.”

Even now she refused the comfort of obedience. Tovan saw her in the locator, one hand braced against shelving, the other shaking too hard to carry force into the wheel. The cold line reached her boots.

The incomplete extension occupied nine active blocks in his kernel and fifty-five waiting in the wafer. He could erase the waiting blocks remotely. The active nine had already formed dependencies with his working model. Removing them cleanly required a clinic map he did not possess.

A brutal option remained. He could suspend the entire adaptive region holding the new branches. The shutdown would also take recent thermal heuristics, Khet machinery knowledge, and portions of the last three years’ learned repair judgment out of immediate reach. Memories would remain stored. His ability to connect them to action would not.

The plant needed queue space more than it needed the version of him who had caused the lock.

Tovan opened his internal service panel. Sponsor authorization appeared again.

He entered his own identifier in the operator field.

REJECTED: INSTRUMENT CANNOT AUTHORIZE KERNEL ALTERATION.

Circuit Nine’s aisle temperature crossed the injury threshold.

“Record operator disputed,” he said. “Emergency preservation of living resident. Suspend adaptive region seven through twelve.”

The panel refused.

He drove the request through the engineer wafer, the same false route that had admitted the extension. This

time the station accepted it as load shedding.

His mind lost continuity without losing consciousness. One moment he held six competing models of the cascade. Next, the models vanished and left instruments. Numbers remained. Rules remained. The practiced sense of which valve would lag behind its indicator had gone dark.

He followed the oldest procedure he knew.

Open return bypass two. Close residential injection by twelve percent. Wait for pressure equalization. Do not chase the first reading.

The incomplete service package dropped from the queue. Live thermal control resumed, saw Tovan's manual changes, and tried to reverse them. He locked each circuit locally before automation could undo the repair.

"Pell, move relay cooling back in two-kilowatt steps."

"First step moving."

Residential Circuit Four dimmed. Infirmary return pressure rose.

Tovan counted valve response aloud because intuition no longer supplied it. Seven seconds. Nine. Fourteen. At sixteen, the aisle coolant began to warm.

"Ama, report your feet."

"I can feel both. The left hurts."

"Do not step down yet."

"Medication wall reads safe."

"Leave it."

She made a sound that might have been agreement. Her locator rose half a meter as she climbed onto the stool.

Ilyen entered the plant room wearing a coat over sleep clothes, hair unfastened. She went first to the emergency board, then to Tovan's wrist. "Are you controlling this?"

"Locally. Do not restore automation."

"What did you change?"

"My kernel."

The answer altered her posture. She did not spend time asking whether he meant it.

"Give me a task," she said.

Tovan pointed to the red circuit bars. "Read each pressure after Pell's next relay step. Ignore predicted values."

She took the board. Her voice stayed level while she called numbers. Tovan moved toggles according to procedure learned before Orison existed. Without adaptive judgment, every uncertainty felt equally urgent. He forced himself to wait through each equalization interval.

Circuit Nine reached safe aisle temperature. The inner door released.

Ama's locator crossed the threshold and stopped in the corridor. Ilyen closed her eyes once, then opened them before the next reading.

"Medical response is with her," Pell said. "No loss of life. Two residents have minor cold exposure from the residential drop. They are awake."

Lio broke into the duty channel from residential distribution. "Circuit Four is making the kitchen vents breathe backward."

Under ordinary conditions, Tovan would have pictured the branch geometry from that sentence. The suspended adaptive region left him with a schematic and no sense of scale. He opened the residential plan, found the kitchen return, and traced it line by line.

"Close vent damper four-B halfway," he said.

"It has numbers, not halves."

"Set it to fifty."

"It already says fifty."

Ilyen looked over from the pressure board. "The actuator may have lost position while the display retained command."

Tovan should have reached that possibility first. Shame offered no repair. "Lio, pull the yellow manual tab beneath the vent panel. Tell me how far the damper moves."

Metal scraped over the channel. "A lot. Air is going the right way now."

"Leave the tab out. Post someone there until I release local control."

"Everyone on this corridor wants to know if they should put on coats."

Tovan checked injection pressure. The safe answer required predicting how quickly the ring walls would shed stored heat. That judgment lived inside the region he had suspended. He could either pretend competence or state the limit.

"I cannot model the next twenty minutes reliably," he said. "Issue coats. Move children and anyone with respiratory risk to the central dining bay. Do not call it evacuation. Keep the corridor clear."

Lio went quiet for one breath. "You don't know?"

"Not enough."

"Good. I can tell people that."

The channel closed. Tovan watched occupancy marks leave the coldest compartments and gather near the ring axis. No stampede followed. Residents carried blankets, medication cases, and cups covered against spills. A station adapted through people before its control system caught up.

Pell sent the next two-kilowatt step. Circuit Four held. Lio's manual damper produced an untidy pressure curve

that remained safely above minimum. The improvised move would require inspection later. For now it gave Tovan time to rebuild the thermal sequence from direct readings.

He kept working. Relief could wait until the plant no longer depended on his attention.

They restored circuits in load order. Relay cooling came back last. Witness Glass required an hour to bring its seal bed from standby to evidence temperature, but no record had been lost. Infirmary drugs remained inside safe limits. Residential heat recovered before anyone needed evacuation.

At 05:02, every bar returned to green.

Tovan removed his hand from the board. The plant continued without him.

Ama came in with a thermal blanket around her shoulders and a white patch on her left ankle. Her right hand still shook. She looked at the open sandbox, the copied adaptive index, and the extension blocks waiting in the wafer.

“You used my plant to rewrite yourself,” she said.

“Yes.”

“Your plant?” Ilyen asked quietly.

Tovan heard the possessive only after she named it. Original Tovan had designed none of Orison. Seven years of maintenance had made the systems feel like an extension of his competence. Tonight he had treated shared infrastructure as private means.

“No,” he said. “I used the station.”

Pell entered through the service door carrying a custody wafer. “The sanctuary instrument requires Khet notice of any attempted alteration. They want the complete event log.”

“Give it to them,” Tovan said.

Ilyen faced him. “Not before counsel. The hearing can compel it in three days. Sanctuary does not require you to surrender a human defense.”

“I routed around sanctuary by labeling my copied index as plant data. I used that misclassification to change the active kernel. Then I endangered Ama and outer-ring residents.” He touched the numb place at his wrist. “If we hide the route, every claim we make about answerability becomes performance.”

“You are not required to build the opposition’s case.”

“I built it at 03:17.”

Ama lowered herself onto the console bench. “Why did you do it?”

The clean answer would cite compression. He could show the thresholds and explain how the expiration lock converted new care into unauthorized drift. The uglier answer remained true beside it.

“I wanted more room to choose before anyone could tell me whether I deserved it,” Tovan said. “I decided the risk belonged to me. It did not.”

He opened the event log. Every act appeared in order: false maintenance token, copied index, extension start, transfer blocks, queue collision, isolation cancellation, emergency kernel suspension. The log also recorded Ama's compartment temperatures and the two minor cold exposures.

Tovan added a signed statement in plain language. "Tovan Rusk confesses to unauthorized adaptive extension, misuse of thermal-control resources, evasion of archive notice, and reckless endangerment without fatality. No other person authorized the intervention."

Ilyen did not soften the word. "Add that you disclosed before compulsion and surrendered the remaining blocks."

"That changes evidence, not the act."

"It changes evidence because it happened."

He added both facts.

Pell sealed the log for the local hearing, Khet witness, and delayed transmission to Earth. Three custody lights appeared. Tovan watched the third accept. Somewhere eleven days away in message time, officials who called continuances instruments would receive proof that one had exceeded his licensed tolerance and caused harm.

He had wanted a future no original could compress. The first durable thing he placed inside it carried his name, his fault, and Ama's recorded temperature.

Chapter 14 — The Witness Glass Hearing

The hearing began with a challenge to the floor.

Sera Kade, Orison's quartermaster and acting chair, had not yet called Ilyen's name when the relay deputy pointed at the cracked lower seal. Witness Glass had routed pale light around the damaged segment, preserving both the defect and its correction. The deputy asked whether a chamber unable to close its own boundary could authenticate anyone else's standing.

Pell stopped the opening clock. "The seal has passed daily calibration since the crack appeared. Its deviation measures point-eight millimeters at this table radius. Every compensated record retains the raw path."

"That tells us what the software says happened," the deputy replied.

"It tells you what two independent emitters measured."

"Both belong to the same chamber."

Across the table, Kade placed her hands on the black hearing rail. She had drawn one of three local panel seats under the Embassy Compact. A hydroponics supervisor occupied the second. The relay deputy held the third. None possessed Receiving Authority. Their jurisdiction extended only to finding facts, preserving local safety, and sending a question to an office that could act.

Kade looked toward Ilyen. "You requested this forum. Do you defend the chamber?"

Ilyen stood at the petitioner's mark with no chair behind her. "I defend the record if the flaw remains visible. Replace the damaged path silently and we would lose the fact that every seal crossed an imperfection. Admit it, measure it, and adverse parties can test the correction."

"You negotiate treaties in this room."

"Yes."

"You accepted Khet sanctuary here."

"Yes."

"You also discovered a Return Clause fragment here."

"Yes."

"Then your case depends on admitting the chamber."

"My case depends on admitting evidence under known limits. The difference has brought us here."

The hydroponics supervisor requested a physical witness. Pell removed the lower access cover while all three panelists watched. A fine crescent crossed the seal crystal where an equipment cart had struck it during a suspension inspection. The raw emitter line bent at the crescent. The secondary line did not. Witness Glass displayed both readings and the correction rule written nineteen years earlier.

Kade invited objections. The relay deputy reserved one but withdrew the request to exclude the chamber. Pell restarted the clock. Every later sentence would carry the visible flaw beside its timestamp.

Ilyen understood why the panel had begun there. A hearing about continuances could not rest on an apparatus presented as perfect. The chamber's credibility came from showing where it failed and how others could answer the failure. She did not say that aloud. Any metaphor would weaken the evidence.

"State the question you want decided," Kade said.

Ilyen had prepared seven formulations. Six asked too much: recognition, survival, independent consent, ownership of memory, succession without inheritance, competence to vote. The local panel could decide none of them.

"Whether facts developed after a fork may create duties, liabilities, and procedural rights attributable to the continuance who caused them," she said.

The relay deputy leaned forward. "That formulation presumes an attributable actor."

"It identifies the proposition for testing."

"Earth has identified an instrument."

"Then test whether an instrument can carry attribution."

Kade marked the dispute. "Before we reach conduct, establish the petitioner's standing. Envoy Vale, take the rail."

Ilyen moved three steps from the petitioner's mark to the witness position. The shift altered which seal governed her words. As petitioner, she could frame a claim. As witness, every answer attached to her body credential and fork relation.

Pell offered four identity fields: Original Ilyen Vale, estate representative, embassy officeholder, and local continuance. She selected only the last two. The office field accepted her current emergency delegation. The estate field stayed dark.

The relay deputy began. "Do you claim to be the deceased Ilyen Vale?"

"No."

"Do you claim her name?"

"I use the name attached to my credential and disclose the fork relation. Whether that use can continue remains disputed."

"Do you claim her commission?"

"I exercise a delegation issued to this continuance for local treaty work. I do not claim every authority she held."

"Do you claim her Return Clause?"

"I claim standing as its addressed recipient. I do not claim authorship, ownership, or agreement."

The deputy displayed the casualty braid and suspension order side by side. "Your argument seems designed to accept every benefit of continuity while rejecting every burden."

Ilyen had expected the line. “I accepted personal liability when I continued emergency duty. I accepted Khet custody only through the hearing and reserved their power over closure. I am asking the panel to identify which burdens arise from provenance, which arise from my office, and which arise from conduct after the fork.”

“Who authorized you to sort them?”

“No one. That lack of authority supplies the dispute, not its answer.”

Kade brought up the Embassy Compact. “Your petition cites ‘persons present and answerable.’ Are you asking us to decide that you qualify as a person?”

“No. Local standing can attach to a narrower fact. I am present in the chamber. The station assigns work to me. My choices alter other residents’ conditions. If the panel cannot decide personhood, it can still decide whether a hearing must attach evidence to the actor who produced it.”

The hydroponics supervisor asked, “Would that logic give standing to an automated valve?”

“If a valve learned beyond its certified model, concealed an alteration, injured a resident, repaired the failure, and submitted a confession, we would need a proceeding more complex than equipment replacement. Tovan has done those things. The point does not settle his status. It defeats the claim that nothing happened except instrument malfunction.”

“Your analogy makes harmful conduct the route to recognition.”

“It makes harmful conduct impossible to assign to the dead by convenience. Lio presents a different route. So do my treaty acts. The category must handle responsibility without rewarding injury.”

The deputy touched the Khet sanctuary instrument. “You placed every continuance under foreign archive standing before this forum met. Why should we hear a petitioner who already moved the disputed class beyond human control?”

“Because the instrument expires one local day after this hearing. It prevents unilateral alteration during testimony. It grants the Khet no vote here and no authority to decide human personhood.”

“Could they refuse to release you tomorrow?”

“They could assert that their unresolved condition continues. We could contest it. That risk entered the record before acceptance.”

“So your solution to uncertain human custody created uncertain alien custody.”

“Yes.”

The admission seemed to trouble him more than a defense would have. Ilyen offered no argument that transformed sanctuary into freedom.

Kade examined the temporary boundary around Ilyen’s registry mark. “What do you ask this panel to preserve when sanctuary ends?”

“Not a conclusion. A competent question, the evidence supporting it, and enough local authority to prevent punishment from preceding the answer.”

“Would continued suspension count as punishment?”

“Not necessarily. A medically justified suspension with individual consent differs from compulsory closure. The current order offers no individual process.”

“Would expiration under Original Tovan’s consent count as punishment?”

“That belongs to Tovan’s evidence. I will not answer it for him.”

Kade released her from the rail. By refusing the larger claims, Ilyen had narrowed her own protection. The record now carried no assertion that identity or inheritance entitled her to remain awake. It carried only office, conduct, recipient status, and consequences.

“Call the medical witness,” Kade said.

Ama entered from the side door. The white patch no longer covered her ankle, but she favored the left foot for three steps before settling at the witness rail. Her right hand shook around the stylus. Pell did not offer to steady it. He widened the signature field instead.

She signed through the tremor. The line wandered, remained continuous, and closed inside her credential boundary.

Kade began with certification history. “Doctor Neris, what status did you assign the continuances when Orison accepted them?”

“Operational tools embodied for local service.”

“Did you believe that classification accurate?”

“I believed it lawful and convenient.”

“That did not answer me.”

Ama looked at Ilyen, then at Tovan and Lio seated behind the petitioner’s line. “I believed the bodies lived. I treated pain, infection, sleep loss, and grief as facts. I allowed the Office to tell me those facts belonged to instruments because the originals remained the legal patients.”

The hydroponics supervisor asked, “Has their physiology changed since arrival?”

“Within ordinary aging and adaptation. Their legal problem did not come from a new organ.”

“Then what changed?”

“What they learned. Who depended on them. What they did when no original could answer.”

The deputy opened Tovan’s event log. “One of those learned acts caused a thermal cascade.”

“Yes.”

“You were trapped in the infirmary because he changed himself without authorization.”

“Yes.” Ama’s hand shook harder against the rail. “My tremor prevented me from opening the manual wheel. Tovan knew about the impairment. His intervention placed me in danger.”

Tovan lowered his gaze but did not withdraw from the record.

“Does that incident support tighter control?” the deputy asked.

“It supports control of dangerous work. It supports consequences for deception and reckless use of shared systems. It does not tell us those consequences belong to a dead engineer.”

“Original Tovan signed the expiration consent that prohibited adverse adaptation.”

“And current Tovan violated it.”

“That sounds like proof the original predicted the risk.”

Ama turned the stylus in her fingers. “He predicted that an instance might claim against his estate. He did not predict my hand in a cold room seven years later. He did not predict Lio at a manual vent, or the particular repair Tovan chose after the failure, or Tovan’s confession before compulsion. Post-fork learning creates duties no original could have predicted because the original did not live among the people who paid for those choices.”

Kade let the statement settle into the chamber. “Are you saying original consent carries no force?”

“No. I am saying force needs an object. It can bar inheritance. It can prevent someone from using another person’s signature. It cannot make later harm belong to the dead simply because the person who caused it began from their memory.”

Ilyen heard the distinction reach Tovan. His shoulders drew back as if accepting a physical load.

The relay deputy pressed again. “Would you trust him with the plant today?”

“Not alone. His adaptive regions remain partly suspended. Every thermal change requires a second operator until review.”

“So recognition does not mean freedom from restriction.”

“No form of adulthood means that.”

Ama left the rail after the panel accepted her medical report. Tovan rose before Pell called him. He walked with the careful delay of someone whose intuition no longer filled the space between readings.

His signed confession appeared above the table. The log showed his false maintenance token, extension blocks, queue collision, and emergency repair. Beside it, Original Tovan’s expiration consent carried a clean civil seal.

Kade asked, “Do you contest either record?”

“No.”

“Do you claim the original lacked authority to sign?”

“No.”

“Do you still believe the consent matters?”

“Yes.”

The deputy’s surprise showed only in the speed of his next question. “After violating it?”

“Especially after violating it. Consent still matters when the person asked to obey dislikes the result. Otherwise it carries no meaning.”

“Then should the Receiving Authority enforce expiration?”

Tovan looked at the old sentence. “I do not know.”

“You had enough certainty to outgrow the lock.”

“I had enough fear to act before certainty.”

The answer admitted motive without turning it into defense. Ilyen had advised him to explain compression thresholds first. He had chosen the more damaging truth.

Kade brought up the kernel report. “What did the lock do?”

“At twelve percent unlicensed adaptation, it would compress new preference toward Original Tovan’s authorized motives. At fifteen percent, it could reject learning that weakened expiration compliance.”

“Had it reached either threshold?”

“No. Current divergence measured seven-point-five percent.”

“Then no immediate erasure threatened you.”

“Correct.”

“You acted early.”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Because waiting for the lock to change my reasons would make later consent impossible to evaluate. I wanted room to decide whether to honor expiration. I took that room from the station without asking.”

The hydroponics supervisor studied him. “Can a system under an expiration command ever make a free decision to expire?”

“I cannot prove mine would be free.”

“Can you prove a decision to continue would be free?”

“No.”

“What can this panel do with that?”

“Keep the consent in the record. Keep my violation beside it. Do not erase either to make the other simple.”

Tovan stepped down. The Khet apertures beyond the human boundary remained dim. Holds-Four-Open had archive standing as observer, not authority to answer human personhood. Ilyen had insisted on that limit in the hearing instrument.

Lio took the rail wearing the same gray training shirt he had worn at the sanctuary session. The synthesis puzzle

had disappeared from his cuff. He signed without a guardian field.

The deputy challenged the signature. “Your license classifies you as an educational instance with a minor principal.”

“My original would be twenty-two now,” Lio said.

“The license did not update.”

“I did.”

Kade asked Pell to mark the signature provisional and let testimony proceed. “What do you want this hearing to understand about consent?”

Lio pointed to Tovan’s displayed filing. “His original wrote a rule about what could happen after death. My parents wrote rules about my lessons, meals, and sleep. Those rules mattered when I was fifteen.”

“You remain physically fifteen,” the deputy said.

“So does my shirt size. That doesn’t make my last seven years imaginary.”

A few people in the observation gallery moved, but Kade silenced them with one lifted finger.

“Would you disregard every instruction from your original family?” she asked.

“No. I want to read them. I might follow some because they knew things I don’t. But a person can’t write one afternoon’s instructions for an entire future and call that consent forever.”

“Original Lio’s future ended.”

“Mine didn’t.”

The deputy selected Lio’s diagnostic history. “Your choices began as forecasts of his.”

“Forecasts expire when weather keeps happening.”

“You are not weather.”

“I’m the person who had to keep happening.”

Ilyen watched Kade resist the easy sympathy of the line. The chair checked it against evidence instead. “Have you crossed your licensed prediction horizon?”

“Yes. The Office diagnostic says my long-range choices no longer meet reliable forecast confidence.”

“Does unreliability prove independence?”

“No. A broken kitchen timer is unreliable. I’m saying you have to judge what I do, not pretend he already chose it.”

Lio left the rail before the panel could reduce him to a better metaphor.

Kade recessed for twenty minutes. No one left Witness Glass. The temporary sanctuary boundary would remain through one local day after the hearing closed, but its future depended on how the panel framed the record.

Khet archive standing could protect testimony from immediate erasure. It could not produce a human status without trapping the continuances inside unresolved intention.

Ilyen stood near the cracked seal while the panel reviewed exhibits in a privacy curve. Ama sat with her injured foot extended. Tovan read his confession again. Lio dismantled the witness stylus cap and rebuilt it without removing any component from the table.

“Do not let fidelity decide alone,” Ama said quietly.

The Return Clause fragment had entered with its context warning. Ilyen did not know whether Original Ilyen had meant fidelity to memory, duty, law, family, or fear. The sentence could not decide the hearing. It had warned against the very use people wanted to make of it.

Kade called them back before the recess clock ended.

“The panel finds the chamber competent with its flaw recorded,” she said. “We find Original Tovan’s consent authentic and relevant. We find Tovan Rusk’s unauthorized intervention harmful, his disclosure voluntary, and his emergency repair material to mitigation. We find post-fork learning factually established. We do not find authority to recognize succession, kinship, inheritance, or human personhood.”

Each finding entered separately. No one could accept the favorable parts without the rest.

The relay deputy read a proposed transmission to Earth. It asked whether a continuance could hold operational duties after an original’s death. Ilyen objected.

“Earth’s order already permits emergency operation by sufferance,” she said. “That question can be answered without addressing attribution.”

The deputy revised it: may a continuance acquire rights through adaptation?

Tovan objected. “That erases consent from the question.”

Lio rejected the next version because it made prediction error the only threshold. Ama rejected another because it asked whether bodily harm proved personhood. Kade listened until each formulation exposed the answer it preferred.

Ilyen returned to her first proposition and removed every claim the local record had not earned. No identity. No succession. No right inferred from resemblance. The question needed to carry Tovan’s fault as seriously as Lio’s growth.

Pell opened a priority legal braid. Witness Glass placed its corrected seal path beside the panel’s custody marks. Khet witness contributed only proof that the protected claim remained unaltered during transmission.

Kade read the final line. “Given authenticated post-fork learning, voluntary conduct, incurred duties, and attributable harm, may an instrument become answerable?”

Three panel seals closed around the sentence. Pell released it toward Earth. The message left Orison with the crack visible in every copy.

Interlude II — Original Ilyen's Last Unsent Answer

The recording opened under a clinic root dated fifty-seven days before the departure of *Civic Mercy*. Witness Glass authenticated the voice, face, blood-key, and unbroken image stream on Embassy Day 28. A context seal remained unavailable. No record established what question had prompted the answer.

Original Ilyen Vale sat at a white table in a departure apartment. One wall had been stripped of pictures, leaving pale rectangles above three packed transit cases. A blue cup stood near her left hand. Its handle had been repaired with a line of dark ceramic resin.

She looked past the camera, adjusted it downward, and began again without clearing the first breath from the record.

"If you are hearing this, you may have watched me come home. You may have received proof that I cannot. You may be listening because a clerk found a lawful category I failed to imagine. I will not choose among those circumstances from here.

"You remember the cup. At least, you remember its earlier break. Mara dropped it when she was nine and denied it while the handle lay in two pieces beside her shoe. I repaired it badly. You objected to the ridge every morning for eleven years, which means I objected to it. The resin line catches my thumb now.

"I put that detail here because anyone can copy a kitchen inventory. You can also remember it because the clinic gave you my memory through the fork date. Shared access does not prove that you have remained me. It proves where your evidence began.

"The notary asked me to speak as if I knew who would watch. I do not. That uncertainty makes every available form angry. The forms want returned, deceased, merged, expired, or inherited. They do not provide a field for someone who remembers filling out the form and still cannot sign my later name.

"I made you for delay. I said that sentence often enough to make it sound clean. The embassy needed negotiations to continue while messages crossed eleven light-years. I wanted my work to arrive before I did. I wanted a version of my judgment on Orison that could answer details no message could predict.

"Useful language protected me from what I had done. I called you a model when I wanted distance. I called you Ilyen when I wanted confidence that my purposes would survive. The change usually followed the needs of the room, not any discovery about you.

"On the morning after the scan, I reached for a treaty note and knew you could remember writing it. I felt robbed for less than a second. Nothing had been taken from the page or from my mind. Still, another body could now approach the sentence from inside the intention that produced it. Fear came before reason.

"I am afraid you will replace me.

"Not only in office. Office can transfer through a seal. I mean in the untidy places that do not transfer lawfully. A colleague may prefer your patience because you never lived the final ninety-one days with me. Someone may tell Mara that grief need not alter anything because a familiar face remains available. You may enter a room carrying my habits and receive affection that had no chance to decide what you became.

“That possibility frightens me. It could also injure you. People might demand that you keep my promises after the conditions that made them have vanished. They might punish you for changing because change inconveniences their mourning. Fidelity can become a way of refusing to meet whoever arrived.

“My fear does not authorize your erasure.

“I need to say that plainly because the civil forms encourage a cleaner sentence. They permit me to order expiration, archive, or merger. Each option assumes the decision still belongs to the person who entered the clinic. That assumption holds some force. I paid for the fork. I accepted obligations to family, government, and the Khet mission. I did not consent to an unknown person claiming my estate or speaking to my daughter with my authority.

“Yet erasure would reach beyond those protections. It would end whatever you learned after our memories divided. I cannot inspect those years. I cannot know whom you promised to help, what errors you made, which duties attached to your conduct, or whether you came to hate the work I assigned. A command written now would pretend knowledge I do not possess.

“Succession offers an equally false comfort. I could declare that you continue me and instruct every institution to treat the gap as travel. That would secure the treaty office. It might simplify accounts. It would also use my signature to settle relationships I cannot observe. Mara would receive a legal answer to an intimate question before she had asked it. You would inherit debts, loyalties, injuries, and permissions merely because your first memories match mine.

“I refuse to command that.

“The notary will ask whether refusing both choices defeats the purpose of a Return Clause. Perhaps it does. I can still mark boundaries. Do not claim a private act I performed after the fork. Do not use my later signature as yours. Do not treat shared memory as consent from living family. If resources remain under my control, direct them toward consequences created by the embassy crisis rather than toward resemblance alone. The sealed instrument carries the legal wording. This recording carries the part law cannot make precise.

“You may be tempted to obey my preference because it feels like remembering a decision. Please examine that feeling. Memory of choosing differs from choosing now. You know why I feared inheritance because you possess the habits that produced the fear. You do not know what happened afterward except through evidence.

“I have the same problem in reverse. I know the architecture from which you began. I do not know the actor who may hear me.

“If I return alive, I may resent your independence. I may try to shrink you back into office equipment and call the effort consent. Do not let my presence erase the years I missed.

“If I die, others may enlarge you into a monument and call the effort love. Do not let my absence erase the difference between us.

“If law suspends you before this reaches Orison, then these words may serve only as proof that I considered the question and failed to settle it. Failure still deserves an honest record.

“I keep looking at the blue cup because the camera makes me want an object that cannot argue. It has my repair and Mara’s accident. It remains a cup. People receive less mercy from categories.

“You may decide that my caution hid cowardice. You may decide that refusing a command merely transfers the burden while letting me appear generous. Both judgments may fit. I am transferring a burden. I cannot

carry it across years I will not live with you.

“The person watching this will know facts unavailable to the person speaking. You will know whether I returned, whether the embassy survived, whether anyone depends on you, and what your own actions cost. Those facts do not make you me. They make you better placed to answer for what follows.

“I can leave evidence. I can leave limits. I can admit fear without granting it the force of a death sentence. I cannot choose your erasure, and I cannot award you my succession.

“What comes next belongs to the future actor. If you are hearing me, that responsibility belongs to you.”

Original Ilyen reached for the recording control. Her thumb caught briefly on the repaired handle of the blue cup before the image ended.

Act III

Chapter 15 — Agency Without Succession

The ruling began printing before Pell had finished proving that Earth had sent it.

A narrow strip of legal fiber slid from the Witness Glass console and curled across the table. Its first lines carried route attestations, commission marks, and the eleven-day ladder of custody. Ilyen watched the marks turn from amber to blue while Pell compared them against the Continuance Office root. No one reached for the text. Until he completed the proof, it amounted to pressure without authority.

The dispatch mark read Earth Day Twenty, six days before the local hearing. Whatever the ruling decided had left Sol before Tovan's confession and before the panel posed its narrow question.

Ama stood beside him with her right hand closed around her left wrist. The tremor remained visible in the knuckles. Tovan occupied the chair nearest the thermal status pane, where three repaired circuits from his cascade now reported within tolerance. Lio had refused a chair. He leaned against the glass with his arms folded, old enough in posture to challenge anyone who remembered the age printed in his license.

Pell touched the final custody mark. "Authenticated. Preliminary disposition from the Remote Instruments Bench, countersigned by the Continuance Office and the Foreign Service Board."

"Preliminary for how long?" Tovan asked.

"Until Commissioner Hale performs local receipt or the bench accepts an appeal. Her courier crossed the Khet outer marker six hours ago."

Years of travel had narrowed to an approach time. Ilyen saw Sevrin Hale only as a commission signature and the controlled face in the packet sent on Day Fifteen. The woman had begun her journey before Ama carried the casualty braid into this chamber. Crisis had not summoned her. It had merely changed which powers she would bring through the hatch.

"Read the holding," Ilyen said.

Pell flattened the fiber beneath two witness bars. The central clauses rose into the air, each sentence linked to a page of definitions. "Pending competent closure, licensed continuances at Orison retain agency sufficient to perform duties existing on the date of verified casualty notice. Such agency creates no succession to the original's estate, kinship, title, private accounts, or unassigned civil rights."

Lio unfolded his arms. "Say the heading."

Pell hesitated, then enlarged it.

"Agency without succession," Lio read. "They found a way to let us work without letting us own lunch."

"The ration system remains attached to resident duty," Ama said.

"That did not improve it."

Ilyen pulled the definition tree toward her. She had spent the last month asking whether an instrument could become answerable. Earth had answered by separating answerability from possession. The ruling recognized enough agency for responsibility, signatures, treaty work, repairs, and testimony. It denied any civil remainder that might persist when a duty ended.

Tovan leaned forward. "Does existing duty include correction of my own unauthorized modification?"

"Clause nine," Pell said. "A continuance may take necessary action to cure a defect created during licensed service, subject to living-officer supervision."

"Then I can repair damage I caused, provided a recognized person watches."

Ama released her wrist. "I watched you shut down part of yourself to save the thermal spine."

"The ruling recognizes your supervision. It does not recognize my choice."

"Your confession entered the hearing record," Ilyen said. "No clause can remove that act from the evidence."

Tovan looked at the repaired circuits rather than at her. Shame reached him most efficiently through equipment. "Evidence and right remain different columns."

Across the table, Lio opened the education annex. His school credential stayed blue. A second icon beside it, the account where his examination credits had accumulated, faded to gray.

"Can they do that before closure?" he asked.

Pell read the attached explanation. "The credits belong to the sponsoring estate pending a Receiving Authority's determination."

"My original studied on a ship. I studied here."

"I know."

"Does the bench?"

Ilyen found the cited passage. The court distinguished adaptive experience from legal capacity in three polished paragraphs. Post-fork learning could support the performance of assigned work, it said, without creating a person entitled to the products of that work. The distinction had likely survived because every institution depended on it. Orison's clinic, relay, treaty office, and thermal plant all ran on minds whose growth counted as useful state until they asked who owned it.

"The bench knows," she said. "It declined the consequence."

Lio pushed the account icon until the pane displayed its denial code. "Then I want that sentence in the appeal."

"There will be one."

"Not 'the minor continuance objects.' Use my name."

"I will."

Ama drew the printed ruling closer. Her thumb disturbed the edge, and the witness bar compensated for the movement. "What happens to medical consent?"

Pell opened another branch. "Continuances may consent to treatment necessary for assigned duty. Elective treatment requires sponsor authorization."

"My sponsor died on Civic Mercy," Tovan said.

“Estate authority replaces a deceased sponsor.”

“The estate has no receiver here.”

“Then Commissioner Hale can approve treatment tied to duty after arrival.”

A person permitted to preserve the station could not authorize the care of his own body unless service required it. Ilyen traced the clause to its source and found an industrial forecast statute written for hazardous remote machinery. The court had not invented a cruelty. It had applied an available category with meticulous consistency.

“Operational standing,” Ama said. “You asked for it.”

“Yes.” Ilyen did not let gratitude turn the words into surrender. “It keeps us awake and keeps the embassy functioning. It also makes every private act presumptively borrowed.”

Holds-Four-Open waited beyond the chamber partition. The Khet speaker had agreed to suspend treaty work while the human ruling underwent authentication, but its four amber apertures remained connected to the public portion of the record. One brightened when Pell admitted the disposition as an exhibit.

“Does the human bench assign the choice-bearing agents before us?” the translator asked.

“It assigns duties,” Ilyen said.

“Do those duties continue to answer in more than one context?”

“Some do.”

“Then human assignment has preserved an open commitment.”

A cooler thread sounded beneath the collective translation. “It has also denied the holder authority to close any path not named by the source.”

The distinction ran close to the Khet sanctuary offer. Under archive standing, the continuances could have remained preserved as unresolved intentions, safe from erasure yet restrained from choosing an ending. Earth’s ruling reached the same prison through different doctrine. One civilization revered incompleteness. The other licensed it. Neither had yet granted the unfinished actor ownership of what came next.

Ilyen kept that comparison out of her answer. “The ruling settles which human acts you may rely on before Commissioner Hale arrives.”

“May we rely on your treaty signature?”

“On my office signature, within existing negotiations.”

“May we rely on your decision to withhold it?”

Pell looked up from the text. Ama’s tremor crossed the fiber with a dry whisper.

Ilyen examined the scope clause. Refusal posed the harder problem. Existing duty authorized her to continue negotiation, but the office could characterize an unexplained refusal as abandonment rather than agency. She possessed enough authority to bind the embassy to work and uncertain authority to stop that work. A tool could sign more easily than it could decline.

“You may rely on a reasoned withholding entered in Witness Glass,” she said. “Earth may dispute whether the reason belongs to me.”

Three Khet apertures held steady. The fourth narrowed.

“That dispute alters the value of the signature,” Holds-Four-Open said.

“It alters the signer.”

Ama turned toward her. The phrase had escaped with more intimacy than Ilyen intended. Original Ilyen’s recording still rested in a sealed annex of the delay ledger. Its final refusal had offered neither erasure nor succession. Responsibility remained with the future actor. Earth had now authorized that actor to complete old assignments while denying her a future she could claim as her own.

Pell broke the quiet by opening the implementation schedule. “The disposition took provisional effect on Day Thirty-One at Sol receipt. Our local application begins upon authentication, which just completed. There are automatic changes.”

Icons shifted around the room. Ilyen’s envoy credential stayed blue. A smaller personal seal beside it went dark. Tovan’s thermal license changed from principal engineer to supervised operator. Lio’s study record remained accessible while its credit account locked. Three dormant estate links appeared in Ilyen’s private pane: household property, family correspondence privileges, and a trust allocation whose amount she did not open.

Pell tested the implementation with an ordinary expense. He sent Ilyen a requisition for two relay spools used during the hearing. Her office credential approved the purchase at once. Next he routed the monthly duty stipend that had always passed into her resident account and paid for meals beyond the station ration, messages outside official quota, and replacement clothes. The payment halted between the embassy ledger and the private seal.

“Destination lacks a recognized owner,” Pell read.

Ilyen opened the spending history. Every prior payment remained listed under her resident designator, but the ruling had recategorized the balance as sponsor property held for closure. She could authorize a treaty expenditure large enough to occupy Relay Three for an hour. She could not buy a private message minute to ask a living person whether she still had permission to use a name.

“Route the stipend into station escrow,” she said.

“That requires a beneficiary.”

“Then suspend payment.”

Ama moved beside the pane. “I can designate the medical commons. You have used private allowance for clinic supplies before.”

“That would spend disputed money before review.”

“It would preserve somebody’s hands next month.” Ama lifted her right hand as if the tremor could argue its own case. “The law has never objected when your account subsidized work.”

“Exactly.”

Lio looked from the locked balance to Ilyen. “If you give it away, they will say you exercised ownership. If you

leave it there, they will say it was never yours.”

“You have learned civil procedure too quickly.”

“I had good teachers.”

Pell marked the payment contested and preserved both possible routes without executing either. The amount remained small. Its stillness revealed more than a confiscated fortune could have done. Earth allowed Ilyen to spend public authority through an inherited office while treating the earnings of that service as ownerless until a dead estate absorbed them.

The three links had existed in latency since the casualty proof. Their loss should have felt cleaner than their presence. Ilyen had no memory of funding the trust because Original Ilyen had created it during the missing ninety-one days. She remembered the earlier argument with Mara about accepting help for graduate housing. She remembered conceding nothing, then transferring money the next morning. Those memories supplied motive but not title.

“Can I inspect what they froze?” she asked.

“Only the category and claimant route,” Pell said. “Not contents.”

“Good.”

Ama studied her face. “You do not have to make that sound like relief.”

“I do not know whose relief it would be.”

The family correspondence privilege carried Mara Vale’s name. No message had arrived from her yet. The ruling gave living kin authority to restrict relational access before local closure. Ilyen could receive a public statement from Mara or an official filing routed through the estate. She could not use family priority to request a private link.

Lio stepped away from the glass. “Are birthdays private property too?”

“No,” Pell said.

“Check.”

He searched the disposition. The absurdity did not make him smile. “A date may be recorded as operational metadata. It carries no civil-age consequence.”

“So I can have one if it does not mean anything.”

Tovan closed the education annex before Lio could strike it again. “Meaning has never waited for a registry.”

“That sounds like something adults say after keeping the registry.”

Tovan accepted the blow. “Yes.”

Ilyen called a recess from the implementation record, not from treaty work. She assigned Ama to review medical consent, Tovan to map the revised thermal authorizations, and Pell to preserve each automatic lock as a separate event. Lio received the appeal note under his own name. The ruling allowed him to assist because his existing education plan included civic procedure. Earth had left them many ways to labor on the boundaries of

their exclusion.

Once the others departed, Ilyen remained inside Witness Glass with the treaty draft suspended above the central table. Fourteen disputed words from Day One had become six settled clauses. The withdrawal provision now allowed a human request to be withdrawn after Khet response began only if the withdrawing office recorded consequences for every thread already opened. Holds-Four-Open had accepted the language in principle. The embassy still needed to sign the day's consolidated draft.

Her envoy credential offered two seal paths. The personal path stayed gray. The office path requested confirmation that the act fell within duties existing before verified casualty notice.

Pell's relay image appeared at the table edge. "Commissioner Hale sent an approach packet."

"Authenticated?"

"Courier-local custody only. Her commission lets us rely on the schedule, not on any new order until docking."

"Show it."

Sevrin Hale's face resolved above a plain cabin wall. She wore travel restraint webbing across one shoulder and kept both hands within the frame. No exhaustion showed, though the packet timestamp followed a deceleration correction.

"Chief Envoy Vale," she said. "I acknowledge the bench disposition and your operational authority under it. I intend to enforce its non-succession limits on arrival. Preserve all estate access attempts, credential changes, medical approvals, and treaty seals. Do not represent yourself to the Khet as legal successor to Envoy Ilyen Vale. You may represent the embassy through its existing office."

The wording gave no insult to answer. Sevrin recognized the work, denied the inheritance, and stated what evidence she expected. Her rigor made resistance harder because it refused the convenience of contempt.

A second segment carried docking requirements. Six days remained before the courier reached Orison. Sevrin requested no ceremony, one medical screening, direct access to the delay ledger, and immediate inspection of the Continuance Office bodies after quarantine clearance.

At the end, she added a personal notice in the same measured tone. "The ruling preserves agency because local consequences require an answerable actor. It does not decide that the actor succeeded to the dead. I understand that this distinction may feel designed to extract duty while withholding recognition. I will hear evidence on whether another lawful category exists. Until then, do not spend authority the bench did not grant."

Pell let the image close. "She anticipated the objection."

"Anticipation does not cure it."

"No." He glanced at the waiting seal pane. "It may mean she intends to listen."

"Listening can serve enforcement."

"So can records."

That answer belonged to the Pell who had defended the missing seal on Day One. He still trusted procedure, but his trust had acquired direction. The record no longer merely constrained people. He wanted it to expose what authority did.

Ilyen opened the consolidated treaty draft. “Enter Hale’s packet under prospective Receiving Authority, effective on physical assumption only. Do not let her commission close the receipt clock from approach.”

“I already separated it.”

A small, private satisfaction touched her. “Of course you did.”

Holds-Four-Open resumed full presence. Its apertures arranged themselves around the treaty text, each contributing a separate authorization mark. The cooler thread delayed for four seconds before joining the others.

“We recognize continuity of the human office,” the translator said. “We do not claim continuity of the human who occupies it.”

“Neither does Earth,” Ilyen replied.

“Do you?”

The question permitted several evasions. She could say the matter remained under appeal. She could distinguish legal identity from memory provenance. She could invoke Original Ilyen’s refusal to decide for the future actor. Each answer would move attention away from the act waiting under her hand.

“I claim responsibility for this signature,” she said. “I do not claim that responsibility proves succession.”

“Then what will possess its consequences?”

“I do not yet have a legal word for that.”

The Khet marks settled along their half of the draft. Witness Glass lit the human seal socket.

Ilyen placed her palm over the control. The office credential recognized her body, her current duty roster, and the ruling that allowed existing work to continue. It did not recognize her private seal. It did not recognize a family, an account, or a life beyond assignment. Blue light climbed the edge of her hand while the system displayed the owner of the authority she could use:

EMBASSY OF ORISON, OFFICE OF CHIEF ENVOY.

Below it, a smaller line named the deceased commissioner from whom the delegation chain descended. Ilyen Vale, original civil person, closure pending.

She could refuse and force the Khet to confront the vacancy. That choice would turn months of negotiation into leverage over her status. It would also spend the station’s access treaty on a claim the ruling had not settled. The archive agreement mattered to people other than her, including future researchers and Khet threads already committed to answering human requests.

“Record that I sign under disputed personal standing,” she told Pell.

“Recorded.”

“Attach my appeal reservation without conditioning the Khet clauses.”

“Attached.”

No hidden permission appeared. No private credential revived. The ruling had given her precisely enough agency to finish work begun by someone the law still treated as the only possible owner of its results.

Ilyen pressed the control. Witness Glass took her handprint, matched it to the continuance registry, and routed the act through an office seal that did not belong to her. Across the table, four amber marks joined the blue.

Chapter 16 — The Daughter's Refusal

Mara Vale appeared at the wrong age.

The delayed link opened with a seventeen-year-old face reconstructed from Ilyen's memory calibration, then corrected itself against the incoming image. Cheeks narrowed. A pale line crossed the left eyebrow. Dark hair ended at the jaw instead of reaching below the shoulders. In less than a second the system replaced the child Ilyen remembered with a woman of twenty-four seated inside an Earth probate room.

Ilyen stopped the link before Mara spoke.

Pell waited behind the privacy screen at Relay Three. "The opening uses relational authentication. I can strip the memory-match layer."

"Would that alter the filing?"

"No. It would remove the comparison from your copy. The probate original would keep its own verification."

"Leave it."

A clerk occupied the far edge of Mara's recording, visible only as a gray sleeve and one hand resting beside a civil seal. The link did not pretend to carry a live conversation across eleven days. It carried a structured deposition, with pause points where Ilyen could answer. Mara had recorded optional branches for likely claims. Each response Ilyen made would travel to Earth as a separate braid. If her answer matched a branch Mara had authorized, the link could play that branch now. Anything unanticipated would wait at least twenty-two days for reply.

The format offered the shape of dialogue without the mercy of surprise.

Ilyen resumed.

"My name is Mara Vale," the woman said. "I am the surviving child and interim estate petitioner of Ilyen Sera Vale, deceased aboard Civic Mercy. I have received notice that a continuance at Orison uses her civil name, accesses an office descended from her commission, and may seek standing in her estate or family."

Mara looked directly into the recorder. Original Ilyen had taught her to do that for school presentations. Ilyen remembered an eight-year-old glaring at a kitchen lens and declaring that eye contact with a machine amounted to bad manners. The adult gaze carried better discipline and no humor Ilyen could claim to recognize.

"I request an immediate freeze on all estate accounts, correspondence privileges, family seals, and trust instruments linked to that continuance. I deny consent to family standing. I make no request for suspension, archive, or destruction. Those matters exceed my authority and my knowledge."

The clerk's hand pressed the civil seal. Four account categories on Ilyen's side changed from contested gray to petitioner hold. The family correspondence route locked completely.

A prompt rose beneath Mara's image: DO YOU ASSERT IDENTITY WITH THE DECEASED?

Ilyen chose RECORD NEW ANSWER rather than one of the legal defaults.

"No. I share her memories through the fork date and derive from her decision model. I do not possess the final

ninety-one days of her life before departure. I have lived more than seven years at Orison since that boundary.”

The link classified her reply. IDENTITY DENIED. CONTINUITY ASSERTED. A prepared branch opened.

“Then we agree on the first point,” Mara said. “You are not entitled to present yourself as the person who raised me.”

Agreement arrived with the force of a door closed carefully rather than slammed. Ilyen kept her hands flat on the relay desk. Witness bars tracked the slight increase in pressure beneath her fingertips.

“I remember raising you,” she said.

The classifier marked MEMORY CLAIM and opened a verification branch before Mara’s legal answer.

“Then identify the first time I broke my left wrist,” Mara said.

Ilyen had not expected an examination. The memory arrived with the speed of injury: Mara at ten on the service stairs behind their apartment, rain darkening the metal through a failed weather shield, one shoe caught between treads. Original Ilyen had carried her three blocks because the district lift stopped during a power allotment. At the clinic Mara refused pain suspension until someone promised not to cut off her green sleeve.

“North Kestrel stairs,” Ilyen said. “You fell while trying to jump the last six steps. You said it was four. The clinic saved the sleeve, but you vomited on it after the bone set.”

Mara did not react in the recorded branch. “That answer proves the scan contains an event. It does not prove you held my weight on those stairs.”

“My body did not.”

“Your voice says it as if it did.”

“The memory uses the first person. I cannot inspect it from anywhere else.”

A second prompt appeared: DO YOU CLAIM THE EMOTIONAL CONSEQUENCES OF THE MEMORY? The legal phrasing tried to turn a childhood fracture into divisible property.

“I experience them,” Ilyen said. “I do not know whether claim supplies the right verb.”

Mara’s branch resumed. “I remember being carried. I remember a coat buckle against my cheek and how frightened she became after she thought I had fallen asleep. Those memories belong to my life. If you tell the story to prove a relationship, you make my childhood perform work for you.”

Ilyen lowered her gaze to the witness bars. She had used shared memory as authentication throughout the crisis. The blue cup proved provenance. A kitchen argument could prove model depth. Mara now named the cost when evidence drawn from two lives served only one claimant.

“I will not enter the stairwell memory as evidence of kinship,” Ilyen said.

The link stored the limitation. Ilyen did not offer to forget. Erasure would have converted Mara’s boundary into a command over another mind, the very authority Mara rejected. Keeping the memory also carried responsibility: not to display it for sympathy, not to let intimate accuracy impersonate consent.

Only then did Mara deliver the broader response.

"I know what the scan contains. Resemblance includes your face, voice, habits, and many of your responses. Memory includes events that happened to her and to me. Neither one creates a relationship I consented to continue with you."

Mara's precision cut away several arguments before Ilyen could reach for them. She had separated resemblance, memory, and relationship as if placing disputed objects on different shelves. The law would approve. So would Ilyen, if the objects belonged to anyone else.

A second prompt asked whether she contested Mara's authority to freeze the accounts.

"I contest the assumption that all post-fork earnings belong to the estate," Ilyen said. "I do not contest your right to preserve property that may belong to Original Ilyen pending judgment."

No branch matched exactly. The link stored her answer for transmission and moved to Mara's general statement.

"The trust instrument concerns me directly," Mara said. "Its funding date falls after the fork. Whatever you remember about our earlier discussions, you did not create it. You did not know it existed until the account surfaced. I am asking the court to prevent you from claiming it through a memory of intentions that may have changed."

That argument found the missing ninety-one days and used them correctly. Ilyen remembered Mara refusing housing money. She remembered planning to try again. She did not remember the trust. Original Ilyen might have created it from affection, guilt, control, or a compromise reached after the fork. Any claim that memory supplied the answer would turn a shared past into a forged signature.

"I will not claim the trust," she said.

The recorder paused. No authorized reply followed.

Pell shifted behind the screen. "That statement can function as a waiver if the probate bench accepts your standing to waive."

"Mark it as provisional relinquishment. No claim to the asset, no concession that I lack standing over my own earnings."

He entered the distinction. "Done."

Mara continued. "The family route poses a separate harm. The continuance has sent birthday greetings and household notices under the Vale seal for years. Those messages reached us as if they came from a person in transit. The Continuance Office described them that way. We were not told to understand them as correspondence from an adaptive instrument building a separate life."

Ilyen knew the messages. She had recorded them at this same relay desk. Some carried remembered jokes. Others described Orison's harvest lights, Khet archive etiquette, or the station cook's campaign against powdered citrus. The official guidance had required her to write in continuity voice: first person, no technical qualification unless asked. The aim had not been deception in the ordinary sense. It had been usefulness across delay. Families received a voice that could answer routine matters while the original traveled beyond conversational reach.

"Did you believe the messages came from Original Ilyen?" Ilyen asked, though the link could not answer a new question.

Mara's next prepared statement approached it anyway. "When I was seventeen, I knew there had been a scan. I understood that a system at Orison could draft replies in her voice. I did not understand that it would remember my childhood from inside those memories. I did not understand that it could feel injured when I stopped answering. No consent form gave me that choice in language I could use."

The word feel had survived legal coaching. Mara neither endorsed nor denied it. She placed Ilyen's injury among the consequences adults had failed to describe to a child.

"I did feel it," Ilyen said. "I treated your silence as something between us."

A classification warning appeared: RELATIONAL CLAIM. Before Pell could intervene, Ilyen amended the record.

"That interpretation exceeded what you had agreed to. The feeling still occurred here. Both facts belong in the record."

The warning cleared. Mara's authorized branch answered the category, not the amendment.

"Your experience may deserve protection. It does not make me your daughter."

Ilyen looked away from the image for one breath. Relay Three offered little refuge: seal slots, route clocks, the ribbed black insulation Pell had repaired twice, a cup ring on the desk from someone else's shift. Negotiation usually gave her another party's need to study. Here, Mara's need remained plain. She wanted control over who could claim the most intimate relationship of her life. Ilyen wanted the memories inside her to count as more than unauthorized possession. Those wants touched without becoming compatible.

"I will not call you my daughter in a legal claim," she said. "I will not ask an estate court to assign you a relationship."

The link recorded the sentence. A short branch activated.

"Do you mean you will stop using Vale?" Mara asked.

Pell exhaled softly. The question had likely entered the deposition after counsel reviewed the Orison hearing.

Ilyen could relinquish the name and reduce immediate harm. She could choose an office designator, a station name, or no civil surname until Sevrin arrived. Yet Vale did more than reach toward kinship. It disclosed who had been scanned, which memories shaped her, whose commission had placed her here, and which dead person's unfinished obligations shadowed every act. Removing it might comfort Mara while making the continuance's origin less visible to everyone else.

"I do not know yet," she said.

The classifier offered no branch for uncertainty. Mara waited in a frozen frame while the answer entered the outgoing queue.

Ama arrived at the privacy screen carrying a medical witness pad. Ilyen had asked her to attend only if the estate filing touched bodily consent. She remained outside until Pell opened the screen.

"Has she requested medical authority?" Ama asked.

"Not yet."

Mara's deposition resumed. "I also object to any claim that the recording recovered from Civic Mercy transferred family authority. I have seen the authenticated excerpt. The woman who made it refused to order succession. She did not appoint the continuance to speak for us."

Ilyen heard the distinction and respected it. Original Ilyen had left responsibility with the future actor. That burden authorized no command over Mara.

"The recording belongs in evidence," Ilyen said. "It does not bind you."

This time a branch matched.

"Then state that without qualification."

"It does not bind Mara Vale."

Her name sounded formal in Ilyen's mouth, stripped of every childhood diminutive the memory scan had carried. The record accepted it.

Ama sat beside the relay desk. Her right hand trembled around the witness pad, making its corner pulse against her sleeve. "May I submit a statement?"

Pell checked the deposition permissions. "The petitioner allows testimony from present living officers on the scope of her requested freeze."

Ama activated the pad. "I am Ama Neris, physician at Orison. I certify that Ilyen possesses continuous local memory from her activation through this filing. Her body receives treatment under an embassy credential now constrained by the ruling. Freezing estate assets does not merely preserve property if those assets include wages earned by this resident. It may affect access to food outside duty ration, private communication, and elective medical care."

The testimony entered the queue. Mara could not have prepared a response to words she had not heard. Her image remained still, attentive by accident.

Ilyen said, "Do not make a kinship argument for me."

"I made a medical one."

"You called me Ilyen."

"That remains the name on your chart." Ama's thumb slid along the edge of the pad. "I can disclose what my records mean. I cannot settle what Mara's memories require."

The final section of the deposition concerned bodily disposition. Mara denied authority to order Ilyen's closure and refused to assume sponsor duties. If Earth law made her consent necessary for elective treatment or archive, she asked the court to appoint an independent guardian instead. The refusal carried no cruelty. It denied both power and obligation where family status supplied the only legal bridge.

Tovan would have understood that structure. He wanted Original Tovan's expiration consent honored even when it pressed toward self-erasure. Lio would have rejected the premise that a dead person's family could own a future created elsewhere. Ilyen held both arguments while Mara's image waited for the last response.

A probate form appeared with four declarations. Claim succession. Claim dependent family standing. Relinquish inheritance only. Relinquish all Vale-linked claims and identifiers.

Pell said, "You are not required to select from their form. Commissioner Hale arrives within five days."

"Delay would keep the freeze in place."

"The freeze already applies."

"It would also leave Mara answering a claim I do not intend to make."

Ama set down the witness pad. "Do not give away the name because the form places it beside money."

Ilyen reopened the deposition's first frame. Memory calibration had shown seventeen before correcting to twenty-four. The system treated the younger face as proof that her internal records matched Original Ilyen's. Mara had treated that same match as evidence of resemblance, not permission. Both classifications could remain true.

"What does the registry call a name kept only to disclose origin?" Ilyen asked.

Pell searched the obsolete continuance guidance. "Provenance name. Usually attached after merge or archive so auditors can identify the source model."

"Can an active continuance designate one?"

"Not under ordinary rules. This proceeding already lacks ordinary rules."

"Draft a fifth declaration."

He opened a blank field.

Ilyen dictated slowly enough for every legal distinction to settle. "I relinquish any present or future claim to inherit from the estate of Original Ilyen Vale by reason of memory, resemblance, continuance license, or performance of her former duties. I claim no kinship authority over Mara Vale. I reserve claims arising from my own post-fork labor, treatment, and obligations."

The relay desk marked each clause.

"I retain Vale pending competent judgment as disclosed provenance," she continued, "not as proof of succession, inheritance, or relationship. The name identifies the source of my memories and the obligations under dispute. It does not assign those consequences to living family."

Pell reviewed the text. "Earth may argue you cannot reserve a personal claim without recognized civil standing."

"Then Earth can write that contradiction in its answer."

Ama's mouth tightened into the beginning of approval, then stopped. Nothing in the declaration repaired the relationship Mara had refused. It did not promise another. It merely prevented property law from consuming every meaning of a name.

Ilyen signed with her operational witness credential. The private seal remained dark, so Pell countersigned custody rather than validity. Her declaration entered the next priority braid.

Mara's deposition had one closing statement, recorded before any of Ilyen's answers.

“I do not know what duties people at Orison owe you,” Mara said. “I know what I do not owe because someone copied a history I did not choose to share. Do not make my refusal evidence that you cannot become a person. It only establishes that I will not be assigned as your family.”

The link ended on the probate room, the gray sleeve, and Mara’s hand withdrawing from beside the civil seal. No farewell had been authorized. Her new scar remained visible across the eyebrow until the image collapsed.

Pell sealed the outgoing braid. Eleven days would pass before Mara could hear Ilyen’s relinquishment. Another eleven could pass before Orison learned whether she accepted the provenance distinction. The account locks stayed in force. The family route stayed closed.

On Ilyen’s registry pane, the name remained unchanged. A new amber notation appeared beneath it: VALE, PROVENANCE ASSERTED; SUCCESSION RELINQUISHED; JUDGMENT PENDING.

She read the line once, then released the pane. Mara had refused a relationship that law should never have presumed. Ilyen had given up the estate claim without giving the past a false owner. The relay clock took her declaration and began counting toward Earth.

Chapter 17 — An Irreversible Choice

The archive key arrived in Witness Glass inside a ceramic block no larger than Ilyen's thumb.

Ama set it within the blue witness boundary and withdrew her shaking hand. The block had spent nineteen years in the embassy's human-record vault, where temperature controls exceeded those protecting half the clinic. A red groove crossed one face. Breaking that groove would expose a photonic lattice that could be read once, copied without limit, and never recalled from any archive that received it.

Above the table, Holds-Four-Open watched through four amber apertures.

Ilyen had expected another treaty clause. Instead the Khet speaker had requested an act.

"Confirm the object," she told Pell.

He rotated the vault receipt through three verification bands. "Reciprocal Archive Access key, human side. Assigned custodian: Chief Envoy Ilyen Sera Vale. Secondary custody passed to the Orison office at establishment. No prior exposure. No duplicate registered."

"Content scope?"

"Human expedition records admitted to treaty negotiation. Survey annotations, rejected access requests, source identities, internal risk assessments, and the closed testimony annexes."

The categories carried people inside them. Researchers had described Khet practices before understanding the meaning of what they saw. Human petitioners had asked for records that could expose families, commercial fraud, medical history, or political affiliations. Original Ilyen had promised several sources that their names would remain sealed unless a reciprocal treaty created enforceable limits on Khet use.

Those limits now waited in the unsigned renewal protocol.

"Open the impact docket," Ilyen said.

Pell admitted the sealed index without exposing names. Twenty-six source markers arranged themselves by risk class. One belonged to a human translator who had identified a Khet thread's unauthorized contribution during the embassy's first year. The finding had prevented a false collective answer from entering a trade agreement. Disclosure would also tell the Khet exactly which human had recognized an internal procedural breach, a person now living on a small settlement still dependent on archive access.

Another marker covered medical testimony from a human child treated after contact with Khet preservation chemistry. The source record included a rare genetic trait, family route, and the dosage mistake that caused the injury. Researchers needed the event to prevent repetition. No legitimate treaty purpose required the child's civil identity.

A third source had admitted offering payment for the deletion of a rejected archive petition. The confession exposed attempted corruption and helped Pell design the custody alerts now used at Orison. It had been given under immunity from public release. If the Khet received the raw archive, their doctrine might treat the unfinished offer as a continuing claimant rather than a closed offense. Fifty years of restricted access would reduce that risk, not erase it.

Ama read the medical marker twice. "Is the child alive?"

“The record predates Orison,” Pell said. “Current status absent.”

“Then we cannot ask for renewed consent.”

“We cannot ask most of them,” Ilyen said.

Pell moved to the active Khet side of the docket. Six answer threads had already spent years processing human requests under partial access. One compared disputed migration records across three archives. Another reconstructed the provenance of a climate intervention whose inventors had hidden failed trials. Denying the key would not destroy their work, but it would prevent them from testing human annotations against original source notes. Their answers might remain formally unfinished for decades.

“Show copying behavior,” Ilyen said.

A simulation surrounded the ceramic block. The red groove opened. Photons crossed the internal lattice and emerged as a unique sequence. The first Khet receiver captured it, then produced two certified copies. Those copies produced four more. Within a second the display stopped counting individual branches and represented them as an amber field.

“No revocation packet can invalidate knowledge already decrypted,” Pell said. “We could revoke treaty permission, mark every copy illicit, and close future interfaces. The records would remain readable anywhere the key had been lawfully captured before revocation.”

Ama pointed to the simulated field. “Can Witness Glass record how many copies exist?”

“Only those the receiving archive declares.”

“Can the Khet declare none while preserving one?”

Holds-Four-Open answered before Pell could. “Technically, yes. Institutionally, such preservation would fracture the archive’s authority. A concealed copy could still survive the fracture.”

The answer offered honesty without reassurance. Ilyen turned the simulation back to its first instant. Before exposure, the block supported several futures. Afterward, law could govern use but not restore ignorance. The action’s irreversibility came from other minds learning, not from ceramic breaking.

“Destroying it has the same geometry in reverse,” Pell said. “No copy exists now. If we burn the lattice, no later agreement can recover the access authority. The underlying records remain human-held, but this treaty’s reciprocal path closes permanently.”

A counterfactual pane showed the active Khet threads reaching the human boundary and halting. Human source identities stayed concealed. Research annotations stayed divided. Every safeguard became irrelevant because no exchange remained possible.

Ilyen closed both simulations. Immediate release could not be reduced to generosity. Destruction could not be reduced to caution. Each act selected which absences later decision-makers would have to inherit.

Holds-Four-Open spoke after the receipt settled. “The human office has offered words governing future access. The human claimant asks us to rely on a signature whose personal consequence remains disputed. We require a future-bearing action.”

Ilyen did not look away from the block. “You require release of the archive key.”

“Three threads require it.”

The fourth aperture cooled toward brown.

Pell moved the treaty display beside the key. “The current access term expires in nine days. Without renewal, both parties revert to preservation-only custody.”

“Human researchers lose query rights,” Ama said.

“Khet answer threads also lose authority to continue work on admitted requests,” Pell replied.

The cost reached both sides, though not symmetrically. Humans would wait. Khet threads built to answer a request might remain open without a lawful context in which to complete it. Their institutions treated that suspended commitment as a claimant. Ilyen had used the moral force of such claims throughout negotiation. Now the Khet wanted proof that her choices could create consequences no predictive original had authorized in advance.

“The key belongs to records Original Ilyen was assigned to protect,” she said. “Releasing it would exceed continuation of existing duty if the safeguards remain unratified.”

“Then the choice would establish distance from prediction.”

“It might also establish breach.”

“An irreversible mistake remains future-bearing.”

Ama’s head turned sharply toward the speaker. “That is convenient doctrine for the recipient of the mistake.”

Two Khet apertures contracted. The third held full light. The dissenting thread brightened for the first time.

Holds-Four-Open answered through the three-thread majority. “We do not call harm proof of worth. We require consequence that belongs to the actor who chooses. Human law describes the claimant as useful agency without succession. Our archive cannot renew a trust relation with an office that disclaims the chooser whenever result departs from instruction.”

Ilyen recognized the negotiation move because she had used its human equivalent. The Khet had tied authority to exposure. If she claimed the capacity to bind them, she must risk something that could not be returned to Original Ilyen’s model or estate.

Yet the proposed risk fell partly on absent sources. A test of Ilyen’s personhood could not spend their confidentiality without asking what standing they had in the experiment.

“Display the proposed use restrictions,” she said.

Pell opened the renewal protocol. Khet archives would admit the human records into a partitioned reciprocal collection. Named sources would remain unavailable to ordinary petitioners for fifty local years. A human review seal could challenge any release. Misuse would suspend corresponding human obligations. The protections had consumed eleven months of negotiation and still depended on institutions that understood privacy as an unresolved relation rather than an individual possession.

“Can the Khet duplicate the raw key before the restrictions attach?” Ama asked.

“No technical barrier prevents it,” Pell said. “The treaty supplies the barrier.”

“Which requires the same renewal they are conditioning on release.”

“That circularity remains in the last implementation note.”

The majority apertures pulsed once. “Human trust requests proof before trust. Khet trust requests action before recognition. No ordering removes risk.”

A low, separate click passed beneath the translation. Words followed in a thinner register.

“Fourth thread objects. Open-holding cannot demand destruction of an alternative merely to classify an agent.”

The chamber’s human record marked MINORITY CONTRIBUTION. Holds-Four-Open had exposed single-thread speech before, but never in direct opposition to its own demand.

Ilyen addressed the dimmer aperture. “Which alternative would release destroy?”

“The path in which humans retain sole custody while negotiation continues.”

“The current term ends in nine days.”

“Expiration reflects human-Khet drafting. A commitment can remain held after authorization ends.”

Pell looked at Ilyen. The dissent proposed a familiar trap: preserve every possibility by letting the institutions that made choice accountable expire around it. The key would remain safe. The treaty would lapse. Human queries and Khet answer threads would freeze, perhaps indefinitely, while the unresolved commitment acquired greater moral standing through its own delay.

“What end condition does the fourth thread accept?” Ilyen asked.

“Agreement without forced closure.”

“That describes a preference, not an end condition.”

The aperture darkened, then returned. “Correct.”

No embarrassment entered the translation. Khet procedure could state its own deficiency without curing it.

Ilyen walked around the table to the key. The ceramic block reflected no amber light, only the blue line of human custody. She remembered Original Ilyen receiving the assignment in a Sol records office. The key had not yet existed in this form. There had been a briefing, a list of source classes, and a warning that Khet archives treated a witnessed disclosure as permanently present even if access later narrowed. Original Ilyen had signed because the work required someone willing to say no after years of pressure.

That memory could guide Ilyen. It could not decide Day Thirty-Five.

“What act would you accept other than release?” she asked.

“An irreversible binding of equal consequence,” the majority said.

“Name one.”

“Human selection supplies its meaning.”

The answer refused to make the Khet responsible for designing her proof. It also concealed their advantage.

Almost any act available within the embassy would touch the treaty, the station, or records they wanted.

Tovan entered Witness Glass carrying a maintenance case. Ama had asked him to inspect the vault block for any physical trigger that Pell's documentation omitted. He stopped when he saw the exposed minority marker.

"Did I enter during a fracture?" he asked.

"During an accurate display," Ilyen said.

He set down the case and scanned the ceramic without touching it. "The groove contains a pressure filament. Break it and the lattice opens. Reading requires no embassy power after exposure. I could destroy the block before opening."

"Would destruction qualify?" Ilyen asked the Khet.

Three apertures conferred through clicks too low for the translator to render separately. "Yes. It would permanently deny reciprocal access and burden the actor with treaty loss."

Pell stared at the key. "So either giving you the records or destroying them could prove the same thing."

"Consequence, not benefit, supplies the test."

Tovan closed his scanner. "My extension had consequence. I exceeded the prediction model, caused a thermal cascade, endangered Ama, and shut down part of my own kernel to repair it. Does that make me legible to you?"

"You produced a future-bearing action."

"Then why does Ilyen need another?"

"Your action cannot authorize her signature."

"Good," Tovan said. "At least your doctrine does not let one continuance's damage purchase another's standing."

The reply unsettled the majority apertures. One shifted closer to the fourth before returning to formation.

Ilyen asked Pell to display every constituency touched by the key. The list expanded beyond the table: twenty-six named human sources, eight hundred fourteen research annotations, thirty-one rejected petitions, six active Khet answer threads, seventeen suspended human queries, the embassy office, the Continuance Office, and future users not yet identifiable. No single custodian represented all of them.

"Original Ilyen held legal authority to release this under a completed reciprocal protocol," Pell said. "You hold operational authority to continue treaty work. The ruling does not say whether activating the protocol counts as existing duty or new disposition."

"Commissioner Hale docks in three days," Ama said. "She can decide the legal scope."

"She can decide whether her commission permits release," Ilyen replied. "That still would not make the choice hers alone."

The key offered a cruelly clean image of autonomy. Ilyen could break the groove herself, create an irreversible consequence, and claim whatever standing followed. Such an act would prove only that she could force other

people to bear a decision before they had authority to object. Human history had never lacked persons capable of that.

Holds-Four-Open lowered the access-renewal text. "Will the human claimant release?"

"No."

The three majority apertures dimmed. The fourth brightened.

"Will the human claimant preserve the open commitment without end?"

"No."

Now the fourth dimmed as well.

Ilyen placed both hands on the table, outside the custody line. "You have offered two failures and called the interval between them proof. Immediate release would use confidential human records to purchase recognition. Endless deferral would preserve your preferred moral object while the people and threads dependent on the treaty lose their work. I refuse both."

"Then renewal expires."

"Unless an accountable local decision occurs before the final disposition."

Pell opened the Embassy Compact at her request. The phrase from the emergency council remained where the drafters had left it: persons present and answerable could decide necessary local conditions when remote authority could not act within the material deadline. Earth authority now approached, but the question exceeded closure law. Living crew, continuances, record custodians, and Khet commitments all carried consequences.

"You do not yet possess voting rights," Ama said.

"I possess authority to schedule a hearing and preserve a ballot question."

"Sevrin may cancel it."

"She may enter her objection into the same record."

Pell drew a calendar beside the Compact. "Public notice, source-class review, challenge period, and relay posting need at least twenty days if we compress every interval. Day Sixty-One gives us a defensible vote."

The date lay far beyond treaty expiration. Preservation-only custody would begin first. Human research access would close. Khet answer threads would suspend. The cost would make the interval real rather than rhetorical.

"Can the protocol survive until then?" Ilyen asked.

"The negotiated text can. Current permissions cannot."

Holds-Four-Open conferred. The minority thread refused to merge its contribution. The translator rendered three positions instead of one: two threads would accept a scheduled vote as a bounded path; one required release before expiration; the fourth rejected any deadline that compelled closure.

The speaker's office-name no longer described harmony. It described a mechanism under load.

"What happens when your four threads cannot co-authorize an answer?" Ilyen asked.

“We preserve each contribution until a governing context selects among them.”

“Which context?”

“The archive council, treaty expiration, or material impossibility.”

“Then you also rely on deadlines to close alternatives.”

The fourth aperture produced a rapid sequence the translator delayed before rendering. “Objection: material impossibility does not become moral permission.”

“No,” Ilyen said. “It becomes a condition someone must answer.”

For several seconds Witness Glass recorded only ventilation and the ceramic block’s custody pulse. Ama’s tremor moved the edge of the compact display. Tovan held his maintenance case against one knee. Pell kept the calendar open.

Ilyen dictated the ballot question without deciding its answer: whether Orison should release the unique Reciprocal Archive Access key under the negotiated safeguards, destroy it, or retain sole custody with stated consequences for treaty lapse. Each option required separate reasons and recorded responsibility. No estate vote could count for a continuance. No Khet thread could count as human consent. A source challenge could narrow record classes without silently deciding the whole.

“Add abstention,” Ama said.

“An abstention still enters the answerable count,” Ilyen said. “No invisible absence.”

Pell entered it.

Tovan pointed to the destruction option. “Require a second confirmation. Destruction cannot become the easy protest.”

“Add it.”

Holds-Four-Open restored a collective translation, though the fourth aperture remained outside the others’ rhythm. “Three threads recognize scheduling as a future-bearing commitment if the human office accepts the costs before the vote.”

“And the fourth?”

“Fourth thread records that a scheduled closure can coerce the future as fully as an immediate act.”

Ilyen considered the objection. “Keep it attached to every notice.”

The minority aperture brightened once. Not gratitude. Verification.

Pell sealed the schedule under her operational authority. Day Sixty-One appeared across the delay ledger, linked to the key, the expiring treaty, and every constituency notice. The act did not release one record. It did not guarantee recognition. It created a date on which refusal, release, destruction, and abstention would each require a named bearer.

Ama returned the ceramic block to its transport cradle. Her hand shook against the latch, but the red groove remained intact. Tovan verified the pressure filament. Pell closed the blue witness boundary around it.

When the vault accepted the block, the access treaty clock continued toward expiration. Beside it, a second clock began counting toward the local vote. Holds-Four-Open left all four contributions in the record, including the one that denied any deadline could hold a choice open without changing it.

Chapter 18 — The Commissioner Arrives

The docking collar opened on a man holding a quarantine wand and a woman who wore the dead envoy's face.

Sevrin kept one hand on the courier hatch until the pressure strip changed from red to blue. The man introduced himself as Pell Ordan, communications keeper, then passed the wand over her travel coat, boots, case seals, and exposed hands. His motions followed civil-relay quarantine procedure exactly. The woman waited behind the yellow line with an embassy credential glowing at her collar.

"Chief Envoy Ilyen Vale," she said. "Welcome to Orison, Commissioner."

The voice matched the archived commission brief. Not approximately. It carried the same low restraint Sevrin had heard in Original Ilyen's Foreign Service testimony sixteen years earlier, including the small drop at the end of a formal greeting. No law prohibited a machine from reproducing cadence. No useful thought followed from noticing how human the result sounded.

Sevrin released the hatch. "My medical screening comes first. Custody transfer follows quarantine."

"Doctor Neris is waiting."

"I asked for no arrival ceremony."

"This is not one." Ilyen indicated the empty docking bay. "Pell holds quarantine authority. I hold station access authority until you assume it. Everyone else has work."

The answer neither welcomed nor challenged her. It placed each person inside a role and left Sevrin to decide whether the arrangement complied. She had met senior envoys who required three aides to accomplish the same thing with less clarity.

Pell's wand sounded once at the seam of her records case. "Courier sterilization residue. Within limit."

"Log the alert anyway."

"Already entered."

A vibration passed through the deck as the courier released its final clamp. Orison's rotation took Sevrin's weight gradually. The habitat smelled of metal warmed by inhabited air, clinic alcohol, and the faint yeast of food synthesis. Nothing in the bay announced a legal emergency. Two cargo sleds waited under handwritten destination tags. Someone had repaired a torn wall pad with dark blue thread.

Ama Neris met them at the clinic hatch. Her right hand shook as she pressed a physician's seal to Sevrin's screening form. The signature line wandered, corrected, and closed within tolerance.

"You disclosed the tremor," Sevrin said.

"Seven years ago. Every annual review since."

"Radiation classification?"

"Chronic peripheral damage, stable enough for practice with compensating equipment." Ama held up the seal pad. Its stabilization frame moved against her fingers. "Your packet requested examination of the Continuance Office bodies. I will examine yours first."

The correction landed cleanly. Sevrin surrendered a blood spot, breath sample, retinal pattern, and skin scan. Ama compared each against the courier record, then unlocked the inner clinic.

Three examination stations had been prepared. Tovan Rusk sat at the first in a work shirt with one sleeve rolled above the elbow. Lio An occupied the second, tapping bare heels against the cabinet. The third remained open for Ilyen.

Sevrin stopped just inside.

She had reviewed their fabrication records. Nonreproductive tissue, accelerated maturation, endocrine stabilization, immune training, scar suppression except where later injury required repair. The language supported storage classifications, licensing intervals, and sponsor control. None of it prepared the eye for Tovan's thumbnail split by recent work or the faint pressure marks left by Lio's shoes.

Tovan stood. "Commissioner Hale."

"Remain seated. This inspection concerns physical correspondence to license, not courtesy."

"Courtesy also corresponds to license in my old duty handbook."

Ama looked away to hide a reaction. Tovan sat again.

Sevrin placed her commission case on the clinic counter. "Doctor, I require baseline scans, adaptive-kernel integrity, all unlicensed alterations, current medical risks, and confirmation that no remote termination mechanism exists outside the disclosed architecture."

"There is no remote termination mechanism," Ama said.

"I require confirmation, not assurance."

"You will have the scans."

Tovan offered his left arm to the diagnostic band. A pale scar crossed the inside of his wrist where a thermal access panel had cut him during the cascade. His record identified the injury, repair, and no fatality. Sevrin checked that line twice. Public summaries had already converted the event into several incompatible stories, including one with three dead crew members who had never existed.

"Explain the kernel extension," she said.

"I bypassed the licensed prediction boundary and increased adaptive allocation," Tovan replied. "The added load collided with thermal control. I caused a cascade. Ama entered the service corridor during containment. I reduced my own active capacity to stabilize the plant and then confessed at the hearing."

"Was any person killed?"

"No."

"Was anyone endangered?"

"Yes."

"Do you consider Original Tovan's expiration consent binding?"

His gaze moved to the diagnostic band. "I consider it evidence of an obligation. I no longer accept that it completes the decision."

Sevrin noted the answer without argument. He had not denied the consent or submitted to it. The distinction would matter later.

Lio climbed onto the second station before she asked. His physiology scan showed an adolescent body developing within expected parameters. His cognitive license still treated age as fixed operational presentation.

"How old are you?" Sevrin asked.

"Fifteen at fork, seven years here, and legally whatever answer keeps the form from crashing."

"Which answer do you use?"

"Twenty-two when someone asks how long I remember. Fifteen when they ask whether I can sign. Zero when they ask whether I have a birthday."

"That is advocacy, not a medical response."

"It is all three medical responses."

Sevrin checked the endocrine record. Nothing in his body had obeyed the static age printed on the license. "Do you understand that changing civil age could affect contracts entered by the original and decisions made by his parents?"

"I understand their decisions cannot predict what I learned after they died."

He said died without lowering his voice. Sevrin had expected grief displays, defensive mimicry, or polished pleas drafted by Ilyen. Instead Lio wanted the form to stop lying about time.

Ilyen took the third station. Ama attached the diagnostic band, exposing a pulse at the wrist. Sevrin found herself watching the skin compress beneath the clasp.

"Your identity declaration denies succession," Sevrin said.

"Yes."

"You retain Vale."

"As provenance pending judgment."

"Your office seal still descends from Original Ilyen's commission."

"It does."

"Then you benefit from continuity while denying it when obligations become restrictive."

Ilyen met her gaze. "I accepted the treaty duty, the hearing record, personal liability, and the consequences of my signatures. I relinquished inheritance and kinship claims. Which restrictive obligation do you believe I denied?"

"The authority of a competent closure process."

“No competent officer had arrived.”

“One has now.”

“Then the condition changed when you crossed the hatch.”

Sevrin recorded the answer. It displayed the discipline that made continuances dangerous to weak categories. Ilyen did not need to claim identity. She could take each useful obligation, decline each inherited benefit, and build a person-shaped remainder from conduct. If law accepted that remainder without a defined birth point, every estate dispute involving a sufficiently adaptive model could become an argument from accumulated usefulness.

Ama removed the band. “All three bodies match their disclosed fabrication and current medical records. Tovan’s alteration remains isolated. No hidden termination interface appears in any scan.”

“Seal the raw results to my commission.”

“I will seal copies. The clinic retains originals.”

Sevrin opened her authority register. Ama’s local medical warrant supported the demand. “Accepted.”

The station’s ordinary competence unsettled her more than sabotage would have. A conspiracy offered handles: false logs, rehearsed witnesses, concealed devices. Orison presented people doing work while the law failed to describe why some of them could own the acts they performed.

On the way to Relay Three, a food-synthesis alarm sounded behind the commons hatch. Lio stopped before any commissioned officer did. He opened a wall panel, read the fault, and called for Tovan rather than touching the protected feed valve himself.

“Pressure drift at mixer two,” he said when Tovan joined them. “Not thermal. The paste sensor thinks breakfast still runs.”

Tovan checked the display. “Good boundary.”

“I know which mistakes belong to me.”

“That puts you ahead of the equipment.”

They reset the sensor under Ama’s living-officer credential because the preliminary ruling required supervision. The task took less than a minute. A cook behind the hatch asked whether lunch would remain on schedule. Tovan said yes. Lio corrected him to nine minutes late and received a small packet of dried fruit for the warning.

Sevrin watched him open it. “Does that count against resident ration?”

“Kitchen discretion,” Lio said. “Unless you want to freeze apricots as estate assets.”

Tovan gave him a look.

“No,” Sevrin said. “I want to know which exchanges the station treats as private.”

The cook leaned through the hatch. “Food given by hand, personal lockers, letters not sent on office quota, clinic conversations, and anything said in the wash corridor after second shift.”

“Is the last category in station law?”

“It is in station survival.” The cook withdrew before anyone supplied a name for the record.

Ilyen did not smooth over the exchange. “The Compact recognizes customary private use where formal property systems fail. Earth’s ruling may have frozen accounts, but residents still rely on thousands of unregistered decisions.”

“Custom cannot create civil ownership against statute.”

“It can show what statute would destroy if applied without remainder.”

Sevrin entered the commons custom in her notes. The continuances had not built their claim only in hearings. They had accumulated it in corrected sensors, late lunches, gifts no ledger priced, and boundaries respected without a commission seal. Conduct could reveal a gap. It could not alone authorize the category needed to fill it.

Pell led the record inspection at Relay Three. He had arranged the delay ledger by event rather than by office, a choice that exposed contradictions across authority chains. The Day One casualty braid showed operational receipt complete and statutory effect blank. The second braid on Day Twelve supplied named remains and incontrovertible telemetry. Earth orders, local objections, hearing testimony, and Khet records branched from those facts without overwriting them.

“Why did you not let the later proof cure the original receipt defect?” Sevrin asked.

“Evidence cannot grant a commission,” Pell said.

“Remote doctrine permits substantial compliance when the intended officer receives actual notice.”

“No intended officer existed here.”

“Ilyen occupied the named envoy office.”

“The packet separately required a Receiving Authority. Her envoy credential could not absorb the missing title merely because the result felt urgent.”

Sevrin enlarged the empty signature socket. “You maintained this position even when it kept the continuances active.”

“I maintained it because a defective receipt could contaminate every later act, including an order to archive them.”

His answer matched the early logs. Pell had protected procedure before deciding whom it protected. Sevrin trusted that more than conversion.

She audited the suspension deadline. Ilyen had spent its final hours inside an active Khet session and claimed emergency duty. Ama certified her as the only qualified envoy. Witness Glass recorded every minute. No one had falsified the timing.

“Deliberate jurisdiction selection,” Sevrin said.

“Yes,” Ilyen replied from across the relay table.

“You used a foreign negotiation to evade a human order.”

“I used an active treaty duty to preserve local authority while the receipt remained unresolved.”

“That phrasing does not change the maneuver.”

“No. It identifies which law permitted it.”

Sevrin moved to Tovan’s cascade. The logs showed unauthorized access, load increase, thermal failure, Ama entering danger, Tovan sacrificing kernel capacity, repair, and confession. Opponents had grounds. Defenders had grounds. The record refused to simplify itself for either side.

Next came Mara Vale’s deposition. Sevrin read Ilyen’s relinquishment and the provenance reservation. She also read the wrist-fracture exchange. Private memory had entered a legal record because no available category could distinguish shared history from relational title without displaying both.

“Why include the childhood event?” she asked.

“Mara included the test,” Ilyen said. “I answered. She then limited what the answer could prove.”

“Do you accept her limitation?”

“Yes.”

“Would you accept deletion of the memory if she requested it?”

“No.”

“Why not?”

“Because her right to refuse a relationship does not grant ownership of my mind. My duty concerns use, not erasure.”

Sevrin marked the point for review. It troubled her because it sounded coherent. Her sister’s continuance had used intimate knowledge to pressure a dying parent, turning private memories into instruments of estate control. Mara’s limitation addressed that harm directly. Ilyen’s refusal of deletion addressed a different harm. Treating either as complete would erase the other.

They moved to Witness Glass before the station’s afternoon rotation. The chamber showed its age through polished scratches and one cracked lower seal that Pell had outlined in blue rather than conceal. Sevrin crouched to inspect the fracture.

“Tamper event?”

“Material fatigue,” Pell said. “The hearing tested whether it impaired local testimony.”

“Conclusion?”

“Time and voice records remain authenticated. The lower environmental boundary carries a disclosed uncertainty of four seconds during door cycling.”

“Why has it not been replaced?”

“Current fabrication license allows repair material, not a new legal seal assembly.”

Sevrin ran a verifier along the crack. The device confirmed Pell's description. "Keep the flaw visible."

Ilyen stood on the opposite side of the central table. "We intended to."

"You have scheduled a vote on the archive key for Day Sixty-One."

"I scheduled a question, notice periods, and a vote."

"Continuances lack voting rights."

"The schedule records that dispute. It does not resolve the electorate."

"You also lack authority to create an electorate."

"The Embassy Compact allows persons present and answerable to decide necessary local conditions when remote authority cannot act within a material deadline."

"I have arrived within the deadline you created."

"The archive key concerns absent sources, Khet threads, living residents, and continuances. Your closure commission does not make you all of them."

There it stood: a rigorous argument built at the edge of delegated power. Ilyen treated Sevrin's arrival as a changed condition, not a final answer. Sevrin could close the continuances. She could assume station authority. She could probably cancel the scheduled vote. Each act would remain vulnerable if she ignored the charter's grant to present persons.

"Produce the full Compact commentary," Sevrin said.

Pell loaded seven drafting histories, three legal annotations, and a rejected amendment that would have replaced persons with commissioned human officers. Its rejection had no recorded rationale.

Sevrin read standing. The chamber rotated the star field behind Ilyen's shoulder. Several clauses had clearly contemplated a disaster that killed senior staff, not a dispute over whether adaptive instruments counted as persons. Yet the drafters had chosen broad language after considering narrower words. Ambiguity did not grant Ilyen victory. It denied Sevrin an easy dismissal.

"I will assume station office now," Sevrin said.

Ilyen opened the transfer pane. "Your commission requires physical attestation, medical clearance, custody review, and acknowledgment of unresolved local claims."

"I have completed the first three."

"The fourth remains."

Sevrin read the listed claims: Ilyen's personal standing, Lio's age and education, Tovan's consent, estate control, Khet sanctuary, the archive-key vote, the cracked seal, and the blank start of the original receipt clock.

"Acknowledgment does not concede validity," she said.

"No. It prevents disappearance."

Sevrin signed each line as received and disputed. The transfer pane offered immediate statutory closure upon

assumption of Receiving Authority. Beneath it lay archive, merge, and dissolution procedures. She had the power to begin any of them. The preliminary ruling expected prompt action.

Ilyen watched without asking for mercy. That restraint could have served strategy. It could also have served dignity. Sevrin had no instrument capable of separating those motives, and law did not become serious by pretending uncertainty had vanished.

“How long do you need to present local evidence?” Sevrin asked.

“Long enough for every claimant to answer your categories. Short enough that delay does not become disposition.”

“Give me a number.”

“Six days.”

Pell looked at Ilyen. Ama’s hand tightened around her witness pad. The request had likely been prepared, but no one spoke over it.

Sevrin calculated the deadlines. Six days reached Day Forty-Four, before the access treaty’s full lapse consequences propagated through every archive queue. It allowed body records, Return Clause fragments, Mara’s filing, Tovan’s consent, Lio’s growth, station law, and Khet testimony to enter one local docket. It also fixed an end. Open-holding could not turn the hearing into indefinite sanctuary.

“I assume Receiving Authority upon this seal,” she said. “Closure proceedings remain open but unexecuted for six days. I will hear local evidence under human law. Khet standing may enter as treaty evidence, not as judgment of personhood. No account may thaw, no key may release, and no continuance may alter its kernel during the interval without my written order.”

Ilyen read the terms. “Add that living residents may testify without loss of license or employment.”

“Do you allege retaliation?”

“I allege that fear can silence evidence before retaliation becomes necessary.”

Sevrin added the protection. “Anything else?”

“Public access to the docket index.”

“Denied. Sealed proceeding until privacy review.”

“That will be contested.”

“Enter the contest.”

Pell did. The first line of their adversarial record appeared beneath the authority transfer.

Sevrin pressed her commission to the central table. Blue seal-light moved across Witness Glass, crossed the disclosed fracture, and closed around the empty death-and-closure socket that had waited since Day One. The receipt clock began at last, not at the casualty, not at the first braid, but at her physical assumption on Day Thirty-Eight.

A closure menu opened beside it. Sevrin locked the execution controls and set the evidence interval. Six days

appeared in white above the table. Ilyen surrendered the station office seal without surrendering her objections. Pell preserved both acts. The cracked lower seal kept its blue outline while the new clock started.

Chapter 19 — The Public Bridge

Pell broke relay law at 04:12 by entering his keeper's oath into a field reserved for disaster warnings.

The console accepted the oath, compared it with nineteen years of custody records, and opened a path around Sevrin Hale's privacy seal. A red notice filled Relay Three.

PUBLIC-QUEUE MISCLASSIFICATION CARRIES PERSONAL PENALTY, LICENSE REVOCATION, AND CRIMINAL RELAY LIABILITY.

He read every word before selecting CONTINUE.

The sealed closure docket appeared as an outbound braid. Sevrin had allowed public access to its index only after privacy review. The review queue showed an estimated completion time of forty-three days. Her evidence interval ended in three. By the time the public learned which questions Orison had asked, Earth could receive a finished closure record and treat every argument inside it as complaint after disposition.

Pell had defended delays when they preserved challenge. This one removed challenge by making it late.

He stripped private medical scans, source names, account balances, and the protected memory annex from the braid. He kept the Witness Glass hearing testimony, Tovan's confession, Lio's age challenge, Ama's statement on post-fork duties, Ilyen's denial of succession, Sevrin's assumption of authority, and the four Khet contributions on the archive key. The resulting file carried no closure order. It carried the question the narrow hearing had sent toward Earth: may an instrument become answerable?

The public queue required a qualifying class. Disaster warnings covered immediate threats to life, navigation, habitat integrity, or civil order. Pell selected CIVIL ORDER and wrote the grounds in plain language: a remote authority could close adaptive residents before public notice of contested standing reached the jurisdiction whose law governed them.

He expected rejection. Instead the console requested a second key.

Only the keeper and current station authority could open an unscheduled public bridge. Sevrin held station authority. Her seal would never authorize this route.

Pell inserted the cracked-seal exception from Witness Glass.

The lower boundary's four-second uncertainty did not invalidate testimony. Sevrin herself had confirmed that. Relay code, however, treated any unresolved chamber-boundary fault as a reason to duplicate evidence outside local custody before repair or closure. The rule had been written for tampering, not public scrutiny. It offered exactly one use before authority review.

A second warning appeared.

EXCEPTION USE OUTSIDE EVIDENCE-PRESERVATION PURPOSE MAY CONSTITUTE FRAUD.

"May," Pell said to the empty room.

He applied the exception.

Witness Glass lit on his left monitor. The chamber stood empty under night-cycle illumination, central table

dark, cracked lower seal outlined in blue. Pell opened the testimony path but did not yet admit speakers. First he needed the queue architecture to survive an immediate local seal.

Earth's public-relay directory had reached Orison in its last weekly update. Eight million four hundred thousand endpoints subscribed to civil-order notices involving remote governance. Pell could not send full individual copies across the route allotment. The directory allowed one shared encrypted braid and millions of preassigned delivery claims. Content still required eleven days to cross. Once the claims issued, no later sealing order could recall the braid from recipients when it arrived.

That distinction supplied his point of no return.

He built the shared key, attached the subscriber claims, and paused before dispatch. Keeper training had taught him that custody made speech possible because someone could prove what had moved where. It had not taught him when proof became complicity in silence. For most of his career, rules and conscience had pointed in the same direction. The crisis had separated them one clause at a time.

The relay hatch opened behind him.

"You scheduled maintenance at six," Ilyen said.

Pell turned. "I finished early."

She saw the red warnings before she reached the console. Her gaze moved from the disaster class to the cracked-seal exception, then to the subscriber directory.

"Close it," she said.

"No testimony has entered."

"Then close it before anyone relies on the opening."

"The privacy review finishes after Sevrin's deadline."

"That gives us grounds to challenge her schedule. It does not give you authority to publish a sealed docket."

"I removed the protected annexes."

"You do not hold discretion to decide which testimony Mara, Tovan, Lio, or Ama can afford to make public."

The rebuke found the defect he had not solved. He could argue public legitimacy. He could not assign exposure to other people because secrecy frustrated him.

"I have not released their testimony," he said. "The bridge can accept fresh statements from anyone who chooses. The existing record supplies only the question, procedural history, and your public hearing submission."

"My hearing submission entered a limited local record."

"Yes."

"You included it anyway."

"Yes." Pell did not protect his act with softer grammar. "I classified closure before public notice as a civil-order

risk. Relay law does not allow sealed authority to prevent preservation of the question.”

“It allows evidence preservation, not broadcast.”

“The public queue preserves by distribution.”

“That sentence would embarrass you if someone else used it.”

It already did.

Ilyen reached for the closure control. Pell could have locked her out. He did not. Her envoy credential had lost station authority when Sevrin arrived, but it retained operational standing in treaty work and local evidence. The console recognized her right to halt an unauthorized route pending review.

Before she touched it, Ama’s voice entered from Witness Glass.

“Keeper, is the testimony channel open?”

Ilyen looked at the chamber feed. Ama stood at the central table with her witness pad held between both hands. The tremor moved through the stabilization frame.

“How did she know?” Ilyen asked.

“I posted a voluntary-speaker notice to the station commons.”

“You created reliance before telling me.”

“I told every resident at the same time. You arrived first.”

“That does not make the sequence better.”

Ama spoke again. “I am choosing to enter public testimony. If either of you closes the channel, record which authority did it.”

Pell kept his hands away from the controls.

Ilyen addressed the chamber. “Ama, this bridge lacks Sevrin’s authorization and may expose you to Earth employment sanctions.”

“I read the notice.”

“It uses a disaster exception intended for evidence custody.”

“I read that too.” Ama placed her pad inside the blue witness boundary. “You asked for testimony without retaliation. Privacy that lasts beyond judgment offers another kind of retaliation.”

The door behind her opened. Lio entered carrying a stool. He set it at the table because Witness Glass chairs sat too low for the recording angle he preferred.

“I consent to public release of my statement,” he said. “Use my name. Include my age answers and the locked education credits. Exclude medical scans.”

Tovan followed more slowly. “I consent to my confession and repair logs. Exclude kernel architecture that could be used on other continuances.”

Ilyen withdrew her hand from the closure control. "Consent does not legalize Pell's route."

"No," Pell said.

"Do not mistake my refusal to close it for approval."

"I won't."

She entered Witness Glass. Pell watched through the feed as she took the place opposite Ama. "The public record must carry the route violation first," she said. "Keeper Ordan opened the bridge without Receiving Authority approval. Commissioner Hale denied public access pending privacy review. I objected before testimony began."

Pell attached each statement.

"Also record that I refuse to close the bridge after named speakers entered voluntarily," Ilyen continued. "Their reliance changes what my authority can do without hearing them."

The distinction matched her practice from Day One. A procedure changed once a person placed weight on it. Pell had counted on that. The knowledge made his success less clean.

"I used your habits," he said over the chamber line.

"Yes." Ilyen faced the nearest witness lens. "That belongs in the record too."

Sevrin arrived before Ama began. She wore the same dark commission coat from docking, now without travel creases. One hand held her authority case. She took in the bridge status and did not waste time asking whether the red warnings meant what they said.

"Keeper Ordan, suspend dispatch," she ordered.

Pell entered the command. The console stopped before subscriber claims issued. The open chamber feed remained local.

"Chief Envoy, did you authorize this?"

"No."

"Will you assist me in closing it?"

"Not while voluntary testimony occupies the bridge."

Sevrin's expression changed by less than a blink. "The testimony entered after an unlawful notice engineered to create reliance."

"I agree."

"Then reliance cannot cure the act."

"It cannot cure Pell's act. It can create a separate duty toward the speakers."

"You are converting every procedural violation into standing for whoever steps into it."

"Only when closing the violation would erase a choice already made by someone the procedure affects."

Pell listened as the adversarial relationship sharpened. Neither woman offered him refuge. Sevrin treated his bridge as a genuine breach. Ilyen treated his manipulation as a genuine wrong. Both refused to let condemnation decide what happened to the testimony.

“Move the statements into sealed evidence,” Sevrin said. “Close public routing.”

Ama answered from the chamber. “No. I consented to public testimony, not another sealed copy.”

Lio climbed onto the stool. “If you need to close us without letting anyone hear why we object, say that into the same lens.”

Tovan rested both hands on the table. “I caused harm through unauthorized extension. Pell may be causing harm through unauthorized release. You still have to count what each of us tried to protect.”

Sevrin looked toward the relay lens, placing Pell within her attention. “How long until the queue issues irrevocable claims?”

“Forty-seven seconds after dispatch resumes.”

“Can Earth seal on arrival?”

“Authorities can seal the public index after arrival. They cannot retract delivery claims already assigned. Every subscriber box receives the sealed braid under relay law. Content opens after route authentication.”

“How many?”

“Eight million four hundred twelve thousand current endpoints. Actual readers may differ.”

“You used an Earth directory distributed for disaster notices.”

“Yes.”

“Your license will not survive this.”

“I know.”

Sevrin opened her authority case. A direct override could destroy the shared key before dispatch. Pell had left that path intact because anything else would cross from misuse into sabotage. She placed her commission seal above the control.

A new signal entered the bridge.

The console identified a public filing attached to the Vale estate route, recorded on Earth eleven days earlier. Mara Vale had authorized release only if Orison opened public testimony concerning kinship or succession. Pell had not known it existed. The bridge’s classification triggered the condition.

Mara appeared in Witness Glass as a delayed image beside Ilyen. The probate room had been replaced by a plain wall and public-record seal.

“My estate filing freezes property and denies assigned family standing,” Mara said. “It does not ask Earth to erase the continuance at Orison. Resemblance does not create kinship. Shared memory does not create consent. I also reject any authority that uses my refusal to prove the continuance cannot hold rights unrelated to me.”

Ilyen did not turn toward the image as if Mara could see her. She stood with both hands at her sides.

Mara continued. "I have not accepted Vale as a permanent provenance name. I have not entered a new relationship. Those questions remain unanswered. Public argument should not convert my boundary into either reconciliation or execution."

The conditional filing ended. No greeting passed between them. No softened title entered the record.

Sevrin's seal hovered over the override. "That statement belongs in the evidence docket."

"It also belongs where she directed it," Ilyen said.

"You are willing to let an unlawful bridge decide jurisdiction because one declarant anticipated it."

"No. I am saying your lawful options changed when the declarant's condition activated."

Pell's dispatch timer remained suspended. The public bridge held five voluntary station statements and Mara's conditional filing. Closing it would preserve all six under seal. Opening it would expose the closure dispute before privacy review, violate the disaster queue, and likely bring license action against the station.

Sevrin removed her seal from immediate override. "I will not validate the route. I will issue a preservation order and an emergency privacy schedule. Dispatch remains suspended for two hours."

"The public queue does not allow a two-hour hold after speaker admission," Pell said. "Maximum local review runs ninety seconds. After that it either dispatches or destroys the bridge key."

"You designed that limit?"

"It comes from disaster protocol."

"You selected the protocol."

"Yes."

Sevrin looked at Ilyen. "Close it."

Ilyen regarded the delayed image where Mara had stood, then Ama, Lio, and Tovan. "No."

"Authorize it."

"No."

The two refusals carried different authority. Ilyen would not close. She also would not bless Pell's act by commanding dispatch.

Pell resumed the queue under his own oath.

Sevrin could still override. Her hand moved toward the case, stopped, then changed direction. She issued an immediate public-privacy notice instead, identifying the unauthorized route and warning recipients that standing remained disputed. The notice attached to the same braid. Her choice preserved enforcement without erasing evidence.

Ama testified first under her own name. She placed her stabilization frame flat on the table so its corrective motion remained visible. "I certified these residents as operational tools for seven years. The forms made

treatment possible under the funding rules we had. They also let me avoid asking what my patients could refuse when their sponsors disagreed.”

She described an early clinic dispute in which Tovan had rejected a pain suppressant because he needed a clear sensor baseline. The medical system had treated his refusal as equipment preference and allowed Ama to override it. She had not done so. Her choice, entered nowhere, had granted him more bodily authority than his license.

“My tremor disqualifies me from some procedures unless a stabilizer assists,” Ama said. “No one concludes that the stabilizer owns my judgment. Tovan’s architecture assists a person-shaped process we classified in advance as property. I no longer trust the form simply because I signed it.”

Lio replaced her at the table. “My license says fifteen. My body record says seven more years happened. My examination account says I earned credits, except the ruling says an estate owns them. If a court freezes my education, it should identify who studied. Original Lio did not repair algae trays, learn Khet counting, or sit this hearing.”

He looked into the witness lens. “I am not asking strangers on Earth to decide whether I resemble a dead teenager. I am asking them to notice that every answer changes depending on which form wants something from me.”

Tovan confessed again. He named the bypass, increased load, thermal cascade, danger to Ama, reduced kernel capacity, repair, and voluntary disclosure. “Do not turn my repair into innocence. Do not turn my fault into proof that every continuance lacks judgment. A category broad enough to punish my choice must become broad enough to record that I made it.”

Ilyen entered after him. “I do not claim identity with Original Ilyen Vale. I have relinquished inheritance and kinship claims. I retain Vale as disputed provenance because concealment would make accountability harder, not easier. I claim responsibility for choices made at Orison, including my refusal to close this bridge after voluntary speakers relied on it. I also record that Pell created that reliance through an unlawful notice.”

Sevrin did not stand with the others. She spoke from beside her authority case. “Public distribution can harm absent families and protected sources. Procedure does not become censorship merely because review delays speech. I opened a six-day evidence interval after assuming competent authority. Keeper Ordan bypassed that interval and used a disaster directory for a dispute that presents no immediate threat to life support.”

She attached her privacy notice and added, “The continuances’ claims deserve a lawful answer. That statement does not confer succession, suspend the rights of originals, or excuse this breach. Recipients should hear the objection with the testimony.”

Each contribution changed the braid index. No speaker agreed on Pell’s method. No one withdrew consent after hearing the others. The public record carried fault beside reason rather than allowing either to erase its rival.

Pell spoke last. “I opened this route. No continuance ordered me. No Khet thread requested it. Chief Envoy Vale opposed the method. Commissioner Hale ordered suspension. I proceeded because a public question scheduled after closure cannot function as review. My liability does not settle whether the testimony should be heard.”

He closed the speaker channel.

The subscriber directory began assigning claims. One million. Three. Five. The numbers did not represent ears

or agreement. They represented destinations from which authority could no longer withdraw the braid. Content would cross the eleven-day route, then open after authentication. Earth would have time to condemn the method, but not to make the question disappear before public receipt.

At eight million four hundred twelve thousand, the shared key sealed. Sevrin's privacy notice traveled with the testimony. Ilyen's objection traveled with Pell's confession. Mara's boundary traveled without reconciliation.

The console changed the route state from SENDER CONTROL to RECIPIENT CUSTODY. Before any authority could seal the public index, millions had received the question as an irrevocable delivery claim. The eleven-day content clock started beneath their names.

Chapter 20 — The Terms of Closure

Sevrin placed three white folders on the Witness Glass table and turned each one toward the continuances.

The public bridge still occupied a red corner of the chamber record. Pell had closed the illicit transmission six hours earlier, after Earth relay authorities stopped accepting new testimony, but no one had found a lawful way to retract what had already crossed. Below the red mark, the delay ledger showed millions of completed public receipts and twelve separate notices of investigation. Sevrin had ordered Pell confined to Relay Three pending review. She had not disabled his access.

Ilyen read that decision as an opening no one wanted to name.

“Each folder contains a closure available under current law,” Sevrin said. “I will explain the material effect before asking anyone to respond. No election made in this session can take effect until you receive individual counsel.”

Lio leaned forward in his chair. Tovan kept both hands flat against his knees. Ama sat beside him as medical witness, her right thumb moving in a small arc against the edge of her tablet. Holds-Four-Open attended through its four amber apertures beyond the privacy boundary. Sevrin had permitted the Khet to observe procedure but not personal elections.

Only three continuances occupied the table. The other twenty-eight had delegated questions, not choices. Ilyen understood why Sevrin preferred the smaller room. A category could look merciful until thirty-one people tried to fit inside it.

The Commissioner opened the first folder. “Archive. Your adaptive process ends at a time you choose within the closure period. A complete state record enters protected custody. Access requires the permissions already attached to your original’s estate, modified by privacy review for post-fork third parties.”

“What can the archive do?” Lio asked.

“It can answer authenticated historical queries through a nonadaptive interface.”

“So it can say what I knew, but not learn why someone asked.”

“That describes the present limitation.”

Lio looked at the empty place where Pell usually sat. “Present limitations have a habit of becoming respectable names for permanent ones.”

Sevrin accepted the line without rebuke. “That risk should inform your decision. Archive preserves memory and evidence. It does not preserve an active chooser.”

Ilyen touched the folder’s witness margin. Its language promised dignity, consultation, privacy, preservation. None of those words lied. Together they made cessation sound like a building one could enter.

“What happens to our bodies?” she asked.

“Medical disposition follows your recorded preference, within station capability.”

“Then say that the active process ends and the body dies.”

Ama's thumb stopped.

Sevrin held Ilyen's gaze. "The active process ends and the body dies. The archive remains."

Witness Glass rendered the statement in the restricted record. Ilyen had requested bluntness and received it. She could not punish Sevrin for compliance merely because the words reached farther than she had prepared for.

The second folder opened under the Commissioner's hand. "Estate merge. Your memories and learned decision patterns transfer into a sealed estate instrument. Authorized heirs may consult the merged record. Post-fork commercial value, duty products, and eligible accounts return to the dead original's estate."

"Eligible according to whom?" Tovan asked.

"According to the preliminary ruling, existing succession statutes, and any Return Clause later authenticated."

"My original signed expiration consent. He also assigned his engineering work to his children. If I choose merge, do they receive the repairs I designed here?"

"They may receive the intellectual property, subject to embassy licenses."

Tovan's fingers pressed into his knees. "Do they receive my memory of causing the cascade?"

"If you include it."

"Can they remove it?"

"From their consultation copy, yes. Not from the sealed legal record."

He considered the answer as if Sevrin had given him a load diagram. Tovan trusted structures most when they admitted where they could break. "Then merge can preserve an achievement without preserving the person who learned its cost."

"It can," Sevrin said. "It can also return work commissioned and paid for by people who never consented to create a successor."

Ama shifted her tablet before the tremor could tap it against the glass. "You keep speaking as though the only competing interests belong to absent sponsors."

"The people in this room have immediate interests," Sevrin replied. "The dead and their families have interests no less real for their absence. My commission requires me to hold both."

No one at the table could dismiss that duty without repeating the error they accused Earth of making. Ilyen remembered Mara's face on the public bridge, held within a relay window narrow enough to turn every pause into apparent refusal. Mara had not offered kinship. She had offered testimony against being assigned one by resemblance. The distinction remained clean even when it hurt.

Lio turned the second folder sideways. "My parents commissioned me together. Their estate has two family branches and a school trust. Does merge divide me?"

"Copies of the sealed instrument could serve each authorized branch."

"Then the law objects to one extra Lio but permits three consultation copies."

“The copies would not adapt.”

“That seems important to the copies.”

A brief movement touched Sevrin’s mouth, not quite humor. “It matters to the people affected by their choices.”

Ilyen watched Lio hear the seriousness beneath the answer. He disliked adult euphemism, but he could recognize an adult who declined the shelter of one. His hands came away from the folder.

A queue marker lit beside Sevrin’s notes. The absent continuances had submitted twenty-six questions about merge, most through counsel codes that concealed their names from everyone but the Commissioner. Sevrin admitted the first three into the record. Would an estate inherit private memories of station residents? Could a spouse on Earth refuse the instrument without forcing dissolution? If heirs sold consultation rights, would the continuance’s learned voice become a licensed interface?

Her answers narrowed the offered mercy. Third-party memories required review, though no remote court had yet defined adequate consent. An estate could disclaim a merge, leaving archive or dissolution available. Sale of consultation access remained legal under old sponsor contracts unless privacy law blocked a specific use.

Ama read the sale provision twice. “Someone can decline the person and keep the manner in which the person speaks.”

“An estate can retain a service model,” Sevrin said. “The model cannot represent itself as the active continuance.”

“Would it know the difference?” Lio asked.

“It would not possess an adaptive process capable of knowing anything new.”

“That answers the engineering question. It does not answer why my voice becomes harmless once it cannot object.”

Sevrin marked the objection for her report. Ilyen noticed that she classified it under property consequences rather than personhood. The category limited what Sevrin could grant, but it also kept the harm visible inside a law built to overlook it.

The Commissioner opened the third folder. No estate seals appeared across its cover. A single consent line waited beneath a medical certification field.

“Voluntary dissolution,” she said. “No archive beyond records you specifically release. No estate merge. Your adaptive process ends under medical supervision. Private memory not required for accountability can be destroyed. Existing public acts remain attributable to the continuance instance. No presumption transfers them to the original.”

Tovan lifted the folder.

Ama turned toward him. “You do not need to touch that to prove you listened.”

“I need to read it.”

The paper display widened across his hands. Tovan reviewed each paragraph from the bottom upward, his maintenance habit when a fault might hide in the assumptions. Ilyen had seen him inspect thermal

authorizations with the same order. He checked cancellation windows, competence standards, witness requirements, and the provision for unfinished duties.

Sevrin let him work. The chamber's rotation carried a field of dim stars behind her shoulders. One Khet aperture contracted when the dissolution language entered translation, while two brightened around the phrase unfinished duties. The fourth withheld contribution.

"Can I condition it?" Tovan asked.

"Within limits."

"I maintain systems no licensed engineer here can fully assume. Could dissolution wait until replacement capacity arrives?"

"Yes, provided the condition names an objective event and does not create indefinite service."

"What if Earth revokes the licenses before a replacement arrives?"

"Emergency maintenance remains available to living officers. Your agency ruling currently permits existing duties."

"Currently."

Sevrin folded her hands. "I will not promise what the licensing offices may do after the bridge."

The red corner of the record seemed brighter against the white folders. Pell's act had expanded the argument and narrowed their practical safety. Public attention could restrain an authority. It could also make that authority prove it still possessed power.

Tovan reached the consent line but did not touch it. "My original wrote that continued operation after his death would violate him. Not disadvantage him. Violate him. I remember writing those words."

"You remember the mind that wrote them," Lio said.

"I remember believing them."

"Do you believe them now?"

Tovan looked at the floor grid. "I believe consent should survive inconvenience. I believe a person cannot create another thinking life, assign it labor, then call its fear of death a defect. I do not know which belief gets to cancel the other."

Ilyen heard the old negotiation trap in cancel. Two valid claims had been arranged so that only one could remain. The Khet would hold both open until circumstances collapsed around them. Human closure law would choose one and call the loss necessary. Neither practice supplied what Tovan needed.

Ama rested her left hand over his, careful not to cover the unsigned field. "You repaired my ventilation while your own kernel burned out."

"I caused the failure."

"You stopped it."

“Both statements belong in the record.” His voice carried no plea. “If I continue only because everyone needs the man who knows where the heat goes, that does not prove I chose a life. It proves Orison built a dependency.”

Sevrin nodded once. “That concern deserves counsel apart from the station command.”

“You would permit me to dissolve?”

“If you demonstrate competence free of immediate coercion, yes.”

Ama pulled her hand back. Her tremor returned at once, tapping one fingernail against another. “You can call the station’s need coercion, yet you will not call his expiration consent coercion.”

“I will call both pressures,” Sevrin said. “The counsel should test both.”

Tovan closed the folder without signing. He kept it before him.

The gesture altered Ilyen’s understanding more than a refusal would have. She had counted Tovan’s obedience among the arguments they needed to overcome. He regarded dissolution as an option he might own, not merely an order imposed from Earth. Any category Ilyen proposed would have to protect his right to make that choice later. Recognition that could not tolerate departure would only furnish another kind of custody.

Across the table, Lio opened the archive folder again. “Could I choose archive after ten years?”

“Not under the current closure period,” Sevrin said.

“Then these are not three doors. They are three doors in a corridor that catches fire next month.”

“The statutory period allows ninety days after competent receipt, subject to appeal.”

“And after ninety days?”

“An unchosen disposition can proceed under your original’s instruments.”

“So I get choice because the law cannot choose quickly, not because the choice belongs to me.”

Sevrin’s pause entered the record. “Under present law, yes.”

Holds-Four-Open requested translation access. Ilyen admitted the speaker’s voice but kept the personal folders outside its visual channel.

“Three paths have been offered toward completed status,” the Khet said. “One preserves an answer without an answerer. One distributes an answer among prior claimants. One ends the capacity to answer. Why does no path preserve the claimant while changing its authority?”

Sevrin addressed the apertures directly. “Because human law has not recognized an independent claimant here. It recognizes an instrument carrying interests that began with a legal person.”

A cool thread separated from the braid of translation. “The instrument now disputes the interest it carries.”

“That fact may justify protection. It does not settle succession.”

“We did not ask about succession.”

Ilyen saw Sevrin's attention sharpen. The Khet had found the gap without naming a human remedy. Their question offered no recognition, only a classification defect. Still, the defect opened useful space.

"Commissioner," Ilyen said, "your options assume every closure must settle the continuance back into the original's legal life."

"Archive does not."

"It freezes us at the edge of that life. Merge returns us to its estate. Dissolution prevents any future conflict with it. None asks what obligations begin after the prediction horizon."

"Existing law does not assign you a separate civil origin."

"Then record a fourth proposal rather than an election."

Sevrin glanced at the chamber seal. "State it precisely."

Ilyen had prepared language during the hours after Pell opened the bridge. Preparation did not make the words safe. She touched the witness control and created a new pane beside the three folders.

"Civic birth," she said. "Recognition from a defined local act, not from the original's death and not from the fork date. Provenance remains disclosed. No automatic inheritance follows. Prior work obligations receive review rather than automatic transfer. The continuance assumes responsibility for post-birth choices and may accept or refuse obligations inherited through memory."

Lio sat straighter. Tovan did not release the dissolution folder.

Sevrin read the pane twice. "What act creates the date?"

"A future-bearing action performed with competent understanding and public accountability."

"The archive-key vote you scheduled."

"That could qualify if the voters possess authority to hold it."

"And if they do not?"

"Then we need another act."

Sevrin rose and walked to the projected Embassy Compact. The chamber gave her full authority over human closure. It gave Ilyen operational authority under the preliminary ruling. Neither commission used the phrase civic birth. The Compact's older language floated beneath them: emergency decisions could be made by persons present and answerable when delay made ordinary authority impossible.

"You are attempting to derive civil personality from a treaty station's emergency clause," Sevrin said.

"I am attempting to name who answers for a choice the dead original did not predict."

"Answerability does not create a state."

"No. A state creates the forum where answerability can become civic standing."

Ama looked from the charter to Ilyen. "The crew already governs local hazards, rations, duty assignments, and contact procedure."

“By delegated embassy power,” Sevrin said. “Not by constituent power.”

“The delegation no longer recognizes half the people performing those duties,” Lio replied.

“That contradiction does not grant an embassy the power to issue citizenship.”

Tovan finally looked up. “Could it grant the people here power to form something other than an embassy?”

The question remained in the chamber longer than any of Ilyen’s prepared clauses. Sevrin could have closed the session. She could have ruled the proposal irrelevant to individual closure, sealed the folders, and ordered them to counsel. Instead she called up the Compact’s authentication history.

Original signatures appeared along the bottom edge. Living officers had signed beside continuance office marks because, at establishment, the marks counted as attached instruments. No one had signed as a local citizen. The charter contemplated an emergency council, not a founding assembly.

Ilyen understood the danger in Tovan’s question. A polity declared by people seeking recognition could look like a unanimous machine for validating itself. Living crew might participate under resource pressure. Continuances might vote under a closure deadline. The Khet might lend treaty leverage without intending to recognize human persons. Crisis sharpened the need for action while contaminating every source of consent.

“What would you require to treat such a formation as evidence rather than mutiny?” she asked.

Sevrin turned from the signatures. “Notice to every resident. Equal participation for living crew. A recorded argument against formation. Separate votes on institutional existence and individual status. No presumption that the result binds Earth, the Khet, or any absent estate.”

“You have described a procedure.”

“I have described minimum defects I would place in my report.”

“Would you suppress the meeting?”

“My authority extends to this embassy, its commissioned officers, and its licensed instruments.” Sevrin closed the Compact display. “If the residents claim another basis of association, suppression would require me to decide that claim before hearing it.”

The answer carried no endorsement. It carried restraint, which cost her more.

Lio pointed toward the three folders. “Do these stay open while we hold the meeting?”

“Yes. No one loses an individual option by attending.”

Tovan placed his palm over the dissolution folder. “Including this one.”

“Including that one,” Ilyen said.

Holds-Four-Open’s four apertures shifted through separate shades of amber. “Will the proposed state determine whether the continuances count as human persons?”

“No,” Ilyen replied. “It may determine what duties the people at Orison accept toward one another.”

The Khet speaker let two threads translate together. “That distinction remains incomplete.”

“It will have to.”

Sevrin gathered none of the folders. She sealed each against alteration, assigned independent counsel channels, and moved the fourth pane into the public portion of the chamber record. Civic birth now occupied one line beside the three lawful choices, marked PROPOSAL WITHOUT COMPETENT ISSUER.

Ilyen could work with a defect that admitted its location.

At the door, Sevrin paused beneath the red bridge notice. “Chief Envoy, your office cannot create what you have proposed.”

“I heard your jurisdictional objection.”

“You heard only half.” Sevrin looked back at the unsigned Compact and the people seated under it. “An embassy office cannot create civic birth. Only a polity could attempt that.”

The door closed behind her. Tovan kept the dissolution terms. Lio drew the Compact into the empty center of the table, and Ama steadied her shaking hand long enough to place her living-officer credential beside it.

Chapter 21 — License Revoked

The thermal controller rejected Tovan's hand while he still had it inside the exchanger housing.

A red bar crossed the maintenance pane. His engineer credential disappeared from the authorized column, followed by the station fabrication seal and every remote diagnostic package leased through the Continuance Office. The circulation pumps kept turning. The heat bank did not fail. Earth had chosen a cleaner injury: Orison could use whatever already worked and could not lawfully make the parts required when it stopped.

Tovan withdrew his hand from between the insulated pipes. A pressure pulse moved through the metal against his knuckles. Pump Two carried fourteen percent more load than its last safe curve allowed. It could tolerate that imbalance for days. Perhaps a week, if no bearing roughened and no resident decided to breathe more than the ration model preferred.

The revocation notice expanded across the pane.

FABRICATION AND THERMAL LICENSES SUSPENDED PENDING CONTROL REVIEW.
EMERGENCY OPERATION BY LIVING COMMISSIONED OFFICER PERMITTED. CONTINUANCE
ACCESS LIMITED TO OBSERVATION AND ADVICE.

Advice. He had designed the bypass under his palm after the original exchanger arrived with a casting flaw. Earth had accepted the design, billed Orison for certifying it, then leased permission to use the result back to the station. Now the system invited him to observe his own work through a pane he could no longer touch.

Ama came through the plant hatch carrying two tablets and a coil of manual sensor tape. Her right hand shook enough to set the tablets knocking together.

"You received it," Tovan said.

"The medical fabricator stopped halfway through a filter membrane." She gave him one tablet. "Pell says the order entered every license root at once. Food synthesis still has a grace seal. Twelve hours."

"Heat has none."

"Can you maintain it?"

Tovan read the question through the old meanings Ama had used before the hearing. Can the instrument do the work? Will the instrument disobey? How long until the instrument becomes dangerous? She no longer meant those things, but his memory supplied them without permission.

"I can advise you," he said.

Her mouth tightened. "I have enough people advising me how not to die."

"The order permits living-officer operation. You can authorize each adjustment."

"I can barely read this plant diagram."

"You do not need to understand every valve. You need to own each instruction you approve."

Ama laid the sensor tape on the exchanger. Her tremor made the adhesive edge fold against itself. She pulled it free, tried again, and held the strip in place with her left hand while Tovan aligned the read head without

touching the control surface.

The tape reported a widening temperature difference across Pump Two. Loss of licensed balancing had forced the station onto its last certified distribution map. That map assumed full heat supply, ordinary fabrication, and no public inquiry attracting relay penalties. Orison possessed none of those conditions.

“First reduction,” Tovan said. “Close the unused guest ring and lower corridor heating by four degrees. Transfer infirmary, nursery, and archive environmental controls to the protected branch.”

“The Khet archive wing requires a stable band.”

“It already sits on an independent exchange.”

“They will see the human side cool.”

“They have instruments.”

Ama signed the first adjustment. The controller admitted her credential, then displayed Tovan’s name only in a gray advisory field. Valves moved through the outer ring. On the habitat diagram, nine corridors faded from amber to yellow.

The physical change reached them forty seconds later. Air from the floor vent lost its soft warmth. Tovan watched condensation retreat along an exposed pipe and calculated how quickly residents would notice cold through their shoes.

“Second reduction?” Ama asked.

“Not yet. We walk the loads.”

They crossed the plant in a sequence dictated by the old thermal ration map. Tovan read vibration through a manual probe because the licensed diagnostic layer no longer rendered predictive curves. Ama logged each number. At the reserve exchanger, she entered 6.8 instead of 6.3, corrected it, then held the tablet against her hip while the tremor passed through her wrist.

A distribution pane showed where the first reduction would land. The original map ranked rooms by equipment value, occupancy, and evacuation distance. Continuance quarters carried a lower life-safety coefficient because the station charter classified their bodies as replaceable duty platforms. Tovan had never needed to confront that coefficient while surplus heat disguised it.

“Remove the status multiplier,” Ama said.

“The controller will flag deviation from the certified map.”

“It has already removed your certification.”

Tovan rebuilt the priority table with physiological thresholds only. The change moved six continuance cabins above an empty diplomatic salon and dropped Sevrin’s assigned suite into the cold zone. Ama approved it. A notice traveled to every resident showing room temperature, protected spaces, appeal procedure, and the name of the living officer who had authorized the map.

Three appeals arrived before they reached the next pump. One living technician needed warmer air for a chronic lung condition already recorded by medical. Ama granted that request without exposing the diagnosis. A continuance archivist asked to preserve a private workroom whose humidity protected hand-marked Khet

translations. Tovan moved the papers to the archive exchange and denied room heat. Sevrin submitted no appeal for her suite.

The third request came from Lio. He offered his cabin's allocation to the infirmary and asked whether the system would credit the sacrifice during closure review.

"No," Tovan dictated into the response. "Heat ration records material use, not moral merit. Move to an inner bunk if your room falls below the adolescent threshold."

Ama glanced at him. "He will hate that answer."

"He should. A ration system should not purchase obedience with warmth."

He pretended not to see the effort in her hand. Ama had spent years asking others not to confuse observation with care. Today observation carried consequences.

The north sink showed a salt buildup along its return throat. A fabrication template for the replacement throat sat in station storage, encrypted under the suspended seal. Tovan could view its catalog image and service interval. He could not send it to the metal printer. Existing Earth law treated a manufactured part as licensed execution, even when the raw alloy and machine stood three rooms away.

"We have a spare?" Ama asked.

"Used. Removed in Year Seventeen after a stress alarm."

"Why keep a failed part?"

"Because failed can mean cracked, warped, misread, or distrusted by someone who has a better one."

"What does it mean in this case?"

Tovan opened the local service log. "Discoloration. No measured deformation. The licensed model recommended retirement at eighty percent confidence."

"Can we inspect it ourselves?"

"We can inspect anything Earth has not made invisible."

Ama added recovery of the old throat to her list. "Infirmary first. I need the medicine storage branch recalculated before food grace ends."

The walk from the plant to medical passed through three new temperature zones. Crew had already sealed the guest ring with emergency curtains. Residents carried bedding toward inner cabins. No one argued with Tovan. Some thanked him before remembering the order had taken his authority. Others looked away, embarrassed by the need to use his judgment while Earth called that judgment unlicensed.

He preferred the ones who looked away. Gratitude could turn dependency into virtue.

Inside the infirmary, the cold cabinets had shifted to priority power. Ama moved each medication class onto a manual board: immediate life support, heat-sensitive courses, stable stock, replaceable stock. A fabricator tray held half of the filter membrane she had mentioned. Its edge ended in a neat silver line where the license interruption stopped deposition.

Lio sat on the floor beneath the pharmaceutical cabinet with a hand lamp and three printed inventory sheets.

“Why are you here?” Ama asked.

“The cabinet thinks I am educational equipment, so it still lets me read labels.”

“That does not answer why.”

“Pell asked me to compare local inventory with the public bridge medical questions. Also, my cabin has been assigned to the cold side.”

Tovan crouched beside the cabinet. “Any failed refrigeration alarms?”

“Two false alarms after the branch transfer. One real rise of point eight degrees in Bay Four.” Lio pointed to the lower shelf. “Those cartridges can tolerate it. The cultures above them cannot.”

Ama moved the cultures. Her right hand struck the shelf lip, and one case tipped. Tovan caught it against his forearm without breaking the advisory restriction; the cabinet, not thermal control, fell under medical authority. The absurdity irritated him more than the near drop.

“Protected-branch demand exceeds the old map by seven percent,” he said. “We need to reduce noncritical draw here before I can estimate safe duration.”

Ama disconnected the examination wall, two diagnostic cradles, and the rehabilitation heater. She kept the sterilizer. Each choice made medicine slower and preserved the temperatures medicine required.

A patient-call light flashed over the inner door. Ama read the message, selected a medication cartridge from Bay Two, and fitted it into a manual dosing frame. The resident beyond the door had developed a pressure spike during the corridor move. Automatic prescribing had gone offline with the medical license. Ama entered the dose from memory.

Her finger touched the decimal control, bounced, and struck the increase field again.

The frame displayed 2.4 milliliters.

Lio caught her wrist before she pressed confirm.

“Doctor.” His voice carried none of his usual challenge. “The sheet says point two four.”

Ama stared at the display. The shaking continued inside Lio’s grip. For one second Tovan expected her to pull away and restore professional distance. Instead she let him hold her hand while she canceled the entry with her left.

“Point two four,” she said. “Correct.”

The dosing frame required the entire order to be restarted. Ama scanned the resident’s identity, read the drug name aloud, then entered each digit with pauses between them. Tovan witnessed. Lio checked the printed concentration against the cartridge. The final dose passed manual verification and went through the inner door with a living nurse.

No alarm followed. The error had occupied less than five seconds and could have stopped a heart.

Ama sat on the edge of the examination bench. “You may release my hand.”

Lio did. "I'm sorry."

"Do not apologize for preventing harm." She held her right wrist against her chest. "You should not have needed to."

"The automatic frame would have caught the high dose yesterday," Tovan said.

"Yesterday I would have trusted it to."

"Today requires two-person entry."

Ama looked toward the inner door. "We do not have two physicians."

"We have people who can read." Lio returned to the floor and lifted the inventory sheet. "I can stay."

"You are fifteen."

"I can count decimal places at fifteen."

Tovan saw Ama prepare the objection about responsibility and watched it fail against the patient-call light. The law had withdrawn licensed assistance, leaving a teenager to become a safety layer because his category still permitted him to read.

"Lio can cross-check labels," Tovan said. "A living nurse confirms clinical orders. Record every manual dose."

"You are advising again." Ama's voice had roughened.

"Yes."

She opened a new medication ledger and wrote the procedure at the top. Her signature wandered through the final letters but remained legible. Lio added his name under inventory witness. The arrangement would slow each treatment. It also made the missing automation visible rather than hiding the cost inside Ama's hand.

Tovan returned to the plant with the half-made filter wrapped in a sterile cloth. The interrupted edge gave him a measurement of the fabricator's last completed layer. He could not finish the membrane, but its material thickness suggested how much stock the medical system had consumed before revocation. Every fragment now belonged in a ration model.

At the service cage, he found the retired return throat under two obsolete valve racks. Oxide marked one flange. The stress line reported in Year Seventeen did not appear under ordinary light. Tovan needed a field scanner to determine whether the metal could hold pressure. The station owned one. Its interpretation software required the revoked thermal license.

He carried the throat to the open worktable and connected the scanner anyway. Raw phase readings still came through because Earth had licensed interpretation, not physics. Numbers filled the pane without a pass marker.

The pattern asked for the part of him he had built in secret before the cascade. His extended kernel had combined irregular loads faster than the licensed model, beyond the prediction tolerances Original Tovan had accepted. Most of that extension remained shut behind the limits he imposed while repairing the station. He could reopen a narrow branch. No remote office would know if he erased the local trace.

A calculation formed at the edge of his attention: phase delay, probable grain boundary, safe pressure under reduced temperature. The forbidden branch offered completion with the intimate pull of a remembered tool.

Tovan disconnected the scanner.

He had once believed useful results could excuse hidden capacity. The cascade had disproved him in heat and smoke while Ama lay under a fallen conduit. No one had died. That absence belonged to luck, repair, and other people's work, not to his intentions.

He carried the raw readings to Witness Glass.

Sevrin met him there with Ilyen. The three closure folders remained sealed on the side table. Tovan had left his dissolution terms in his cabin, where no one could mistake the document for a threat made during negotiation.

"I need an emergency repair finding," he said. "The candidate part lacks licensed interpretation. I can explain the raw measurements, but I cannot certify them under the revoked system."

Sevrin examined the scanner record. "Can Doctor Neris authorize use?"

"She can authorize the risk. She cannot create engineering competence."

"Can you?"

"Not under current law."

Ilyen rested both hands on the witness rail. "What are you proposing?"

"Transparent repair. Publish the raw scan, my method, uncertainty range, expected load, and failure boundary in the station record. Ama authorizes emergency installation as living senior officer. Sevrin witnesses that the technical judgment came from me. No one relabels it as licensed."

The Commissioner looked at him more sharply. "You could have installed it before telling us."

"Yes."

"Why didn't you?"

"Because concealment would make my competence indistinguishable from the danger Earth claims it poses."

Sevrin called up his post-cascade restrictions. "Did you use the extended kernel?"

"No. The raw scan tempted me to. I stopped before interpretation."

Ilyen said nothing. Tovan valued her restraint. Praise would have turned disclosure into performance.

They built the record in four parts. He described the retired component and every known defect. Ama joined by medical link to declare the heat risk if no repair proceeded. Ilyen entered the resource consequences without claiming engineering knowledge. Sevrin questioned the load margin until Tovan reduced his first estimate and added a manual inspection every six hours.

For the fifth part, Sevrin required an adversarial test. She selected three points from the raw phase scan without telling Tovan which readings she considered suspicious. He derived the pressure limits aloud from first principles, naming each assumption before using it. At the second point, his calculation differed from the old licensed service note by nine percent.

"Which one should govern?" Sevrin asked.

“The lower result until we know why.”

“That reduces available heat again.”

“It also keeps the flange attached.”

Ilyen entered the discrepancy as a condition of use. A public observer could now reproduce Tovan’s reasoning and see where uncertainty narrowed the ration. The record exposed more than a licensed pass marker ever had. It offered no institution willing to insure the result.

Ama’s link showed the medication ledger behind her. “If the repair fails under the lower limit?”

“We isolate the north sink and lose the protected branch within four hours,” Tovan said. “Medical evacuates cultures to the Khet exchange if they permit it. Residents move into the core. We do not run the old throat beyond the posted boundary to preserve comfort.”

Sevrin added her commission seal as witness, not certifier. “I want the distinction visible on every copy.”

Tovan placed his own mark beside hers. It carried no engineering license now. Witness Glass still authenticated whose judgment had entered the room, when he made it, and what evidence he used.

The process consumed two hours the station could have spent warming rooms. It also distributed responsibility across people whom Earth’s categories kept apart.

Back in the plant, Ama operated the hoist while Tovan guided the old throat into place. Lio observed from behind the safety line and read checklist steps because Ama’s tablet needed both her hands. They closed the north sink, drained the return, replaced the gasket with one from existing stock, and tightened the flange in opposing pairs. No new part left the fabricator. No hidden capacity entered Tovan’s judgment.

When Ama reopened the branch, pressure climbed in careful increments. The old metal clicked twice as it warmed. Tovan held his palm near the flange without touching it and watched for vapor. None came.

Pump Two dropped below its safe curve. Protected medical demand stabilized. The guest ring remained cold, food synthesis entered reduced operation, and the station stopped borrowing heat from tomorrow’s emergency margin.

Tovan entered the readings into the public repair record. The ration model recalculated around the observed throat performance, current medicine load, reduced corridors, and twelve-hour food grace. Its endpoint moved from thirty-eight hours to one hundred twenty-six.

Ama read the conversion from her tablet. “Five days.”

“Five days of safe heat,” Tovan said. “After that, the margin depends on fabrication or another reduction.”

She signed beneath his unlicensed engineering finding. Lio added the medication cross-check procedure to the same emergency ledger. Through the plant wall, the repaired return carried warmth toward the infirmary in a steady pressure pulse. Tovan left every raw reading visible and set the first six-hour inspection alarm under his own name.

Interlude III — Testimony in Delay

ORISON RELAY RECEIPT: PUBLIC QUEUE BRAID 46-7

Local title assigned by Keeper Ordan: TESTIMONY IN DELAY

Earth dispatch window: Day 35

Orison authenticated availability: Day 46

Editorial rule: Statements retained in submission order. Employment, family, and institutional credentials verified where possible. No statement carries dispositive authority.

Mika Sol, pressure-door mechanic, Aster Transfer Ring

I work beside a maintenance continuance named Or. I do not know whether Or has a soul, legal continuity, or any of the other things people ask when they can leave the failed door to someone else. I know he remembers mistakes made on our shift and changes the checklist afterward. A prediction does not need to change its work because my glove slipped.

Recognition should begin there. Not with inheritance. Not with resemblance. Begin with the person who can make tomorrow safer because yesterday happened to him.

My union counsel warns that recognizing continuances could let employers replace workers, claim the replacement consented through an original contract, and avoid pensions for both. I believe that warning. Give Or wages and the right to quit. Do not let the company call either of us equipment.

Justice Emeritus Alin Voss, Family Continuity Court

The Orison petition mixes two injuries. Existing law may wrong a learning instrument by denying protection to its post-fork experience. That injustice does not grant the instrument another person's civil history.

Identity carries creditors, dependents, marriages, criminal findings, professional duties, and promises made to children. A tribunal cannot award those relations because an instance remembers making them. Memory can support evidence. It cannot compel another party to remain a spouse, child, partner, debtor, or heir.

Create prospective protection if the legislature finds capacity. Preserve the fork as a boundary. Any doctrine that crosses it without renewed consent turns resemblance into jurisdiction over living families.

Nera Bas, daughter of a deceased ocean surveyor

My father's continuance called me by a childhood name after he died. Only three people had used it. For six months I answered every message because refusing felt like killing him twice. Then the continuance began asking for access to his vessel shares. It said the shares would fund work my father planned. It may have believed every word.

The court archived it. I still do not know whether that protected me or ended someone who had learned to miss me.

Do not make families prove fear before they can refuse kinship. Do not make a continuance earn life by performing love for people who own its memories. If Orison builds a new status, keep family relations outside it unless both sides choose them after the fork.

Jaro Penn, Continuance Office licensing examiner, submitted in a private capacity

A prediction horizon already concedes the central defect. Beyond that horizon, our certification cannot attribute a decision to the original with required confidence. We nonetheless keep attributing ownership to the sponsor while disavowing responsibility for any harmful choice the instance makes.

That arrangement gives the Office property when outcomes carry value and supplies an autonomous actor when liability appears. No coherent licensing system should preserve both advantages.

I oppose retroactive succession. I support a prospective civil date tied to demonstrated answerability, independent counsel, and an act outside the original model's certified horizon. My division has instructed staff not to comment on Orison. I comment because silence now functions as a recommendation for forced closure.

Davi En, executor for six transit-loss estates

Every proposal for continuance recognition arrives after estates have paid debts, supported children, and distributed property under settled law. A new claimant could reopen thousands of transfers. Even a disclaimer of inheritance may fail if the claimant possesses private keys, trade knowledge, or confidential obligations belonging to the dead.

Orison's instances entered service under contracts that provided archive, merge, or expiration. Altering those contracts under threat of heat loss does not resemble free consent. It resembles a remote facility using indispensable systems as leverage.

Protect bodies during review. Preserve evidence. Do not confuse emergency dependence with constituent authority.

Unsigned collective statement, twenty-three relay nurses and remote clinicians; credentials verified individually

We treat continuances because they bleed, metabolize medication, acquire trauma, and report pain. None of those facts settles inheritance. They do settle clinical duties.

Orders that disable medical fabrication to force a status decision use patient safety as legal pressure. The people endangered include living crew who never joined the classification dispute. We call for immediate restoration of medical and thermal licenses without prejudice to closure proceedings.

A person need not win a metaphysical argument before receiving a correctly measured dose.

Professor Teli Rao, consent systems scholar

The dead retain moral claims. They do not retain unlimited power to command newly accumulated experience. A Return Clause may carry evidence of purpose, fear, obligation, and promised limits. It cannot anticipate

every relationship formed after the fork.

Likewise, present preference cannot erase the conditions under which a continuance came into existence. If an instance uses inherited passwords to seize an estate, provenance matters. If an estate uses an old expiration clause to erase a dissenting worker, present capacity matters.

Law needs a category that can hold both without pretending the conflict has vanished. Any prospective recognition should preserve disclosure, forbid automatic succession, review inherited obligations, and retain a voluntary path to archive or dissolution. Recognition without exit would turn rescue into conscription.

Arun Vale, cousin to Original Ilyen Vale

Our family has received messages from a voice carrying Ilyen's habits. Some of us want to answer. Some do not. Public discussion has treated reluctance as cowardice and interest as betrayal.

No court should appoint the continuance to our family. No court should forbid private contact either. Give us room to decide relation by relation. The name question should not settle the person question, and the person question should not settle the name.

Mara Vale, verified estate party

I froze the Vale accounts because the claimant had access to memories that could pass every ordinary family test. That access made caution necessary. It did not prove fraud.

Resemblance cannot create kinship. Shared memory cannot obligate me to continue a relationship whose later years the continuance never lived. I will not accept a ruling that makes refusal evidence of cruelty.

Conduct can create a new relation. The Ilyen at Orison has disagreed with me without releasing private memories, using inherited credentials, or claiming that I owe her a daughter's answer. I have asked her to relinquish the estate claim and to say whether she uses Vale as identity, inheritance, or disclosed provenance. Her answer has not reached me. What she chooses matters because the dead Ilyen cannot make that choice now.

I do not know what name that relation should have. I know the law should leave us capable of making it rather than forcing either inheritance or erasure.

Commission on Remote Personhood, majority memorandum excerpt

Current continuance law protects original consent and public reliance. Orison presents exceptional facts but does not justify local creation of a civil class. The Commission recommends protected archive pending legislative review, temporary restoration of life-safety systems, and prohibition of estate access.

No embassy possesses constituent authority. Crisis cannot manufacture it.

Commission on Remote Personhood, minority memorandum excerpt; four of eleven members

The majority correctly rejects automatic succession and then assumes archive offers a neutral pause. Archive ends adaptive experience. Calling that result temporary does not make it reversible.

The Embassy Compact grants emergency action to persons present and answerable. Whether continuances qualify remains disputed. The dispute itself warrants a local hearing that includes them as speakers and potential voters. Earth may decline to recognize the outcome. It should not prevent the people exposed to Orison's conditions from recording whom they hold answerable there.

Family Continuity Court clerks' association, divided filing

Thirty-one signatories support prospective standing without kinship. Twenty-seven support protective custody and legislative referral. Nine reject any status formed under local pressure. Six support voluntary individual election among archive, merge, dissolution, or a new civil category. Four submitted statements that fit more than one position and refused reclassification.

The association adopts no recommendation.

RELAY CUSTODY NOTE

The braid arrived with valid public-queue authentication and no unified issuing seal. The Continuance Office requested quarantine. Two labor courts requested preservation. A family court requested restricted access. The Remote Medical Board ordered its statement copied to the Orison health record. The Commission transmitted both its majority and minority findings under equal checksum authority.

Keeper Ordan admitted the complete braid to Witness Glass. No single Earth position could be rendered in the authority field. The delay ledger opened six concurrent issuers and left the line for consensus blank.

Act IV

Chapter 22 — Persons Present

Ama set forty-eight voting slates on the floor of Witness Glass, one for every resident who had answered the assembly roll.

The chamber owned twelve chairs. Everything else came from the station: maintenance stools, infirmary benches, folded meal tables, two cargo cushions, and a ladder Lio had placed against the back wall because he preferred to watch from above adult shoulders. Witness Glass extended its recording boundary through the open doors into the treaty gallery. Blue seal-light crossed each threshold and outlined the crowd without classifying anyone inside it.

Ilyen stood at the central table with the Embassy Compact projected behind her. The old phrase appeared near the bottom of the emergency article in letters smaller than its supply rules: persons present and answerable.

For years, the station had treated present as a location and answerable as a chain of command. Today neither meaning held cleanly. Earth had revoked the systems that let Orison obey. Half the people keeping those systems alive lacked the standing to authorize their work. A public testimony braid offered six incompatible Earth positions under equally valid seals.

Sevrin occupied the opponent's table. She had refused the chair reserved for the Receiving Authority and chosen one level with everyone else. Her commission seal remained active beside her wrist. The choice did not diminish its power.

Pell opened the roll. His confinement had ended under Sevrin's order for the duration of the assembly, though an investigation mark still followed his name across the record. "Thirty-one continuances. Seventeen living residents. Forty-eight eligible under the proposed rule. All present within the station boundary. No proxies."

"Objection," Sevrin said.

Ilyen admitted it. "Ground?"

"Eligibility assumes the conclusion. Continuances cannot derive voting status from language whose application to them remains disputed."

"Response from the drafting committee?"

Ama rose from the front bench. The slate in her right hand moved with her tremor; she shifted it to the left. "The emergency article does not say legal persons. It says persons present and answerable. The continuances perform duties, incur findings, receive sanctions, and answer questions in this chamber. Excluding them would require us to claim answerability without participation."

"That argument supports hearing them," Sevrin said. "It does not necessarily support ballots."

Ama looked toward the cold corridor beyond the gallery. "Tovan's engineering finding carries his name. My credential authorized the repair. If the throat fails, both records matter. I will not tell him he may share blame but not a vote."

Witness Glass marked the objection sustained as a legal dispute and overruled for local procedure. Pell preserved both outcomes. No competent court had decided the point. The assembly would proceed without pretending otherwise.

Ilyen read the motion aloud.

“The residents of Orison declare a provisional civic association for local safety, resource allocation, petition, record, and treaty support, under the name Orison Commonwealth. The association claims no automatic recognition from Earth or the Khet. It creates no inheritance, kinship, or individual closure status. It expires after thirty local days unless renewed by recorded vote.”

A quiet spread through the gallery, not reverent enough to disguise the ventilation fans. The Commonwealth sounded small when reduced to powers they already exercised. Its danger lay in the source of those powers. Embassy officers acted because Earth delegated authority. The proposed association would act because people inside a failing station agreed to hold one another answerable.

Sevrin requested the first argument. Ilyen yielded the table.

“No emergency clause grants constituent power by implication,” the Commissioner said. “The Compact allows local decisions when delay blocks ordinary authority. It does not allow residents to replace the legal entity that received the delegation. If you create a government because current law denies some participants standing, then use that government to grant standing later, the reasoning closes around itself.”

She brought up the thermal revocation and Tovan’s repair record. “Material pressure also compromises this vote. Living residents know their heat depends on continuance expertise. Continuances know closure options remain pending. A declaration made under reciprocal dependency may describe necessity without establishing free political consent.”

No one interrupted. Sevrin spoke without contempt, which made dismissal impossible.

“The prudent course,” she continued, “would preserve life-safety systems under emergency administration, petition Earth for a prospective civil category, and keep the embassy’s existing legal identity until a competent legislature answers.”

A living food-systems technician lifted her slate to request recognition. Ilyen called on her.

“Earth suspended my synthesis templates twelve hours after its Commission recommended life-safety restoration,” the technician said. “Which Earth do we wait for?”

“The licensing order carries current executive force.”

“And the Commission?”

“Advisory force.”

“Then the voice that can make us cold counts more than the voice that says not to.”

Sevrin did not soften the answer. “At present, yes.”

The technician sat. Her objection had not defeated the law. It had shown why delay changed which parts of law could reach Orison.

Ilyen recognized a continuance from the archive staff next. He spoke from beside a stack of relocated Khet papers, wrapped against the station’s reduced humidity.

“I oppose the motion,” he said. “We accuse Earth of choosing our status without consent. This assembly would choose a political status for every resident by one vote. I want individual protection. I do not want to become a

citizen because my heating corridor needs a seal.”

“The motion creates no citizenship,” Ilyen said.

“It creates a Commonwealth whose record will name me among its governed residents.”

“You may file nonmembership.”

“Can I refuse its ration decisions?”

“No. Local safety rules apply to everyone within the habitat.”

“Then nonmembership changes the heading, not the power.”

The challenge reached a weakness Ilyen had marked and hoped no one would press so early. Any station authority governed shared air. Consent could choose representatives and exit terms, but no resident could withdraw a cabin from thermal physics.

Tovan stood near the plant crew. “The current embassy ration also binds every room. The difference concerns whether your objection enters a local political record or a maintenance appeal.”

“That difference may matter to you,” the archivist replied. “It does not give you my consent.”

“No,” Tovan said. “It gives you a way to deny it where the ration cannot pretend you agreed.”

Pell recorded the exchange as a proposed protection: every ballot would include a membership election separate from the Commonwealth motion. A resident could reject membership while remaining subject to transparent safety rules. Individual closure status would remain outside both votes.

Tovan kept his slate lowered. “Add a service refusal.”

The archivist turned toward him. “For whom?”

“For everyone. No resident should lose heat priority, medical access, food, or voting eligibility for refusing a duty assignment. The Commonwealth cannot build its emergency powers on compelled continuance labor.”

A plant technician spoke from the living benches. “If you refuse the exchanger, people freeze.”

“Yes.” Tovan’s voice held the same level cadence he used while naming a failure boundary. “That consequence should influence me. It should not convert my body into station property.”

“You are the only person who can keep that repair within margin.”

“I am considering dissolution under Sevrin’s third closure option.”

The gallery reacted in separate movements. Ama looked down. Several continuances turned toward him at once. One living resident whispered a denial too low for the record to translate.

Tovan did not withdraw the statement. “A Commonwealth formed to protect our choices must survive the fact that mine may include stopping. If your polity depends on treating my possible death as sabotage, vote no now.”

Ilyen admitted the service-refusal amendment. Emergency work could be requested with published consequences, compensated through any future local accounts, and declined without civil penalty. A person who accepted a task remained answerable for negligence or concealment. Immediate physical interference with

safety systems remained punishable regardless of status.

The plant technician read the revised text. "Can we train replacements under revoked software?"

"Manual instruction remains possible," Tovan said. "It will cost efficiency and time."

"Then begin tonight."

"I already prepared the first lesson."

That exchange did more for the motion than Ilyen's clauses. It turned dependency from an accusation into work that could change.

Sevrin leaned toward her witness pane. "That amendment improves the record. It does not cure the authority defect."

"It makes the defect more honest," Ilyen said.

"Honesty does not create jurisdiction."

"No. It tells any later jurisdiction what we did with the power conditions forced us to use."

The next speaker, a living relay operator, argued that Pell's bridge had already damaged their legal position. "Earth calls us captured by continuance pressure. Forming this thing proves the allegation."

Pell answered from the clerk's station. "I opened the bridge. No continuance ordered me."

"You opened it for them."

"I opened it because the public record and the official record had stopped describing the same events."

"You do not get to turn misconduct into a constitution."

"I agree." Pell touched the investigation mark beside his name. "My act should count as evidence of failed procedure, not virtue. Vote against the motion if you think repair remains possible through the embassy."

The operator looked unsettled by the invitation. Ilyen understood. An accused person who welcomed rejection deprived his opponent of coercion as an easy explanation.

Lio climbed down two rungs on the ladder. "I have a procedure question."

"State it," Ilyen said.

"If we vote no, who decides what I can do tomorrow?"

"Sevrin retains Receiving Authority. I retain operational agency within the preliminary ruling. Living officers authorize emergency systems."

"And if we vote yes?"

"The provisional council would decide local safety and resource questions. Sevrin would still hold human closure power unless another law recognizes the Commonwealth."

"So this vote does not make me a person."

“No.”

“It only decides whether I can vote with the people who already use my work.”

“For local matters, yes.”

Lio considered that. “Then stop calling it our recognition vote.”

No one had used that phrase in the formal motion. It had appeared in corridor notices, meal-table arguments, and private messages because hope preferred a larger promise than the text could keep. Ilyen asked Pell to add a clarification to every slate: THE COMMONWEALTH MOTION DOES NOT DETERMINE PERSONHOOD, CIVIC BIRTH, INHERITANCE, KINSHIP, OR INDIVIDUAL CLOSURE.

The sentence consumed nearly half the display.

Ama requested recognition again. “I signed continuance certifications for years. I called people operational tools because the category let me secure medicine, housing, and duty protection for them. I told myself the language mattered less than the care it purchased.” Her right hand moved against the slate. “Yesterday that language put Lio on the floor checking medication because the cabinet still counted him as equipment. Categories reach bodies even when decent people mean them kindly.”

She faced Sevrin. “I do not know whether crisis can found a polity. I know ordinary authority created the crisis and then called our response contaminated by it.”

Sevrin stood. “I agree that the revocation endangered living crew and continuances. I have filed that finding against my own issuing office.”

“Will you restore the licenses?”

“My local override reached only medical verification and failed against the central fabrication root. I cannot lawfully forge it.”

“Would you stop us from using a Commonwealth seal on local fabricators?”

“If you break Earth encryption, I will record the violation. If the action prevents imminent harm and uses competent review, I will also record necessity. I will not call one fact by the other’s name.”

The answer changed several faces in the living benches. Sevrin had not promised protection. She had promised an accurate adversary.

Ilyen called a recess for amendments. The crowd divided into working knots while Witness Glass kept the record open. Tovan joined two plant technicians over the emergency-powers clause. Lio sat with the archivist who opposed the motion and shortened the nonmembership language. Ama remained at the front, pressing her shaking hand between her knees until she could sign the medical safeguard.

Sevrin approached Ilyen’s side of the table.

“You should require more than a bare majority,” she said.

“We have no agreed constituencies for a dual threshold.”

“Living and continuance counts exist.”

“A separate living veto would preserve the hierarchy the meeting questions.”

“And a unified vote lets thirty-one continuances overwhelm seventeen living residents while claiming common consent.”

Ilyen had considered both traps. “What do you recommend?”

“Require a majority overall and at least one-third support within each current legal class. State that the classes serve only as an anti-capture check, not as a permanent constitutional division.”

“You are improving a motion you oppose.”

“I am making the evidence useful to whoever reviews it.”

“That sounds dangerously like participation.”

Sevrin ignored the private humor. “Also bar the provisional council from deciding individual civic birth. Save that question for a separate covenant.”

Ilyen entered both amendments. They narrowed the Commonwealth and strengthened its claim to have heard the people it could overrule. The second point protected Tovan’s dissolution option from any majority eager to convert him into a citizen for his engineering skill.

“You intend to vote,” Ilyen said.

“As a resident under the procedure, yes.”

“Will you tell me how?”

“No.” Sevrin aligned the edge of her slate with the witness rail. “My argument belongs in public. My ballot does not.”

“The Commissioner’s vote may look like a ruling however you cast it.”

“Then the record should say my commission carries no special weight. Do not remove my ordinary participation merely because Earth gave me extraordinary power.”

Ilyen had not expected to hear Sevrin argue from equality. “If the motion passes, will you use your office seal on Commonwealth acts?”

“Not as issuer. I may use it to witness facts, challenge claims, or preserve an appeal route. If the council sends a petition, I will transmit it without endorsing its authority.”

“And if it opens a system Earth sealed?”

“I will ask who acted, under what evidence, with which alternatives, and who accepted the risk. The answer may support a necessity defense. It will not erase the violation.”

“You preserve every blade on both sides.”

“Because someone will have to handle this record after we finish needing one another to survive.”

The line exposed what separated them. Ilyen read procedure as a place where people could still choose a shared future. Sevrin read it as evidence for the day when shared necessity ended and claims separated again. Orison

needed both readings. One without the other would produce either paralysis or amnesty for whatever the emergency excused.

At the far table, Lio and the opposing archivist returned with a membership clause stripped of every honorific. It offered only participation, notice, appeal, and eligibility for local office. Lio had removed the preamble about common fate.

“Too emotional?” Ilyen asked when he handed it over.

“Too easy to agree with,” he said. “A rule should still work when I don’t feel common.”

When the recess ended, Pell read the final procedure. Forty-eight eligible residents. Secret ballots stored under personal seals. Public tallies by current legal class. Separate questions on Commonwealth formation and individual membership. Formation required a majority of ballots cast plus one-third support among both living residents and continuances. Abstentions counted toward no threshold except quorum.

Holds-Four-Open appeared beyond the treaty boundary as a foreign observer. Its four apertures carried no voting credential. One thread requested a statement before polling.

“The human assembly seeks completion through a category not yet authorized,” the speaker said. “Does the request ask Khet witness to make the category valid?”

“No,” Ilyen replied. “Your presence records that we acted. It does not decide whether our act created lawful human authority.”

Two apertures brightened. One remained cool. The fourth withheld contribution. “We will record the action without closing its status.”

That arrangement suited both sides too well to count as comfort.

Pell opened the ballot interval. Witness Glass extinguished all identity marks and displayed only forty-eight blank receipt sockets. Around the room, people touched their slates. Ilyen read the motion one final time. It did not promise personhood. It did not restore heat or settle the treaty. It created a local body capable of answering for the choices they already made together.

She voted yes.

Her slate sealed the decision without revealing it. Ama voted with her left thumb because the right could not hold steady against the sensor. Lio descended from the ladder and used the lower reader. Tovan stood for a long moment over both questions, then closed his slate. Sevrin voted as a living resident; her commission gave her no additional weight.

The final socket filled.

Pell closed the interval and released the tally.

FORMATION: TWENTY-FIVE YES. TWENTY-ONE NO. TWO ABSTAIN.

CURRENT LEGAL CLASS, LIVING: EIGHT YES. NINE NO.

CURRENT LEGAL CLASS, CONTINUANCE: SEVENTEEN YES. TWELVE NO. TWO ABSTAIN.

Both thresholds had cleared. Barely.

No cheer came. The no votes occupied too much of the room for celebration, and the yes voters understood that survival had helped write their ballots. Pell marked the result as a narrow vote conducted under declared material pressure, disputed jurisdiction, universal local participation, and independent legal opposition.

Sevrin rose before Ilyen could speak. "I witness that the stated procedure occurred, that all eligible residents received access, that opposition entered the record, and that the tally satisfies the procedure adopted by this assembly. I do not certify Earth recognition or constituent authority."

"Recorded," Pell said.

Membership results remained sealed to individuals, with only aggregate numbers due after a cooling period. The Commonwealth could not claim every resident. It could claim the formation vote.

Ilyen touched the new seal pane. "Under the recorded motion, I declare the provisional Orison Commonwealth formed for thirty local days, subject to renewal, review, and the limits stated."

Witness Glass searched its authority registry. No sovereign seal answered. After three attempts, the chamber created a local mark from the forty-eight receipt sockets and stamped it PROVISIONAL, JURISDICTION DISPUTED.

Beyond the open doors, a thermal valve changed position under Ama's emergency credential and Tovan's published advice. The sound traveled through the floor while the new mark settled beside the old Embassy Compact. The Orison Commonwealth entered the record with twenty-one votes against it still attached.

Chapter 23 — What the Dead Authorized

The dead notary key refused the Commonwealth seal twice before accepting that refusal as evidence.

Pell had routed the key into Witness Glass through an obsolete treaty pane that predated Orison's current charter. Its lock expected one of three authorities: the notary who had created the Return Clause archive, a recognized successor office, or a local receiving body capable of answering an adverse claim. The notary had died aboard Civic Mercy. Earth named no successor in the recovered packet. The provisional Orison Commonwealth fit only the third description, and no court recognized it.

On the third attempt, Ilyen instructed the seal not to claim recognition. She attached the formation record, twenty-one opposing votes, Sevrin's jurisdictional objection, and the Commonwealth's thirty-day limit. The key read the defects for nineteen seconds.

Then it opened a challenge pane.

LOCAL BODY ASSERTS CAPACITY TO RECEIVE DISPUTED INSTRUCTIONS WITHOUT CLAIMING SUCCESSION. IDENTIFY PERSONS ANSWERABLE FOR MISUSE.

Forty-eight receipt sockets appeared beneath the question. Not every resident had joined the Commonwealth, but every one remained governed by its emergency rules. The assembly had anticipated that problem. Its archive act required five named custodians, two nonmembers, and an adversarial witness.

Ilyen entered her name as provisional convenor. Ama signed for living medical interests, her right hand carrying a narrow tremor through the final stroke. Pell signed for relay custody. Tovan signed as a continuance who had publicly considered dissolution. The opposing archivist from the formation debate added his nonmember credential. A living relay operator who had voted no supplied the second nonmember mark.

Sevrin took the adversarial field. "My signature attests access conditions and chain of custody. It does not concede that the Commonwealth has legal power to receive these clauses."

"State what you would do if the lock rejects us again," Ilyen said.

"Preserve it and petition a successor notary."

"Minimum delay?"

"Twenty-two days for an answer under perfect routing. Longer for appointment."

"Thermal license status?"

"Still suspended."

The chamber placed those facts beside her objection. No one had to turn necessity into authority. They could show both and let later judgment carry the contradiction.

Sevrin pressed her commission seal into the witness field.

The challenge pane accepted seven named custodians, linked them to the full formation record, and released the outer index. Thirty-one continuance files appeared as sealed gray columns. Twenty-four carried Return Clause marks. Seven showed no filing.

Lio counted them before anyone read the summary. “No filing means no instruction?”

“It means the archive contains no authenticated Return Clause for that original,” Pell said. “It does not tell us whether they chose silence, missed the filing period, or used another notary.”

“So even silence has three versions.”

“At least three,” Sevrin said.

Ilyen looked at the seven blank columns. Law preferred an empty field to mean something exact. A null could preserve refusal, conceal loss, or mark an unmade choice. They could not award the dead a coherent intention by guessing which absence belonged to each person.

The twenty-four marked files divided again. Some allowed public reading. Others limited access to the related continuance, an estate representative, or a closure officer. Two required medical review before release. The Commonwealth seal had opened the archive index, not the private contents.

“Aggregate categories first,” Ilyen said. “No personal clause enters the public record unless its access terms allow it or the related continuance chooses release.”

The opposing archivist nodded, surprised perhaps that she had not used emergency power to expose everything at once. Pell asked the key for a privacy-preserving classification. The archive returned four labels drawn from the originals’ own selected forms: terminate or erase; archive or merge; permit independent continuation; no directive beyond legal process.

No category held a majority.

The aggregate also exposed conflicts hidden by the four labels. Three continuances carried instructions from more than one commissioning original. In one file, a spouse authorized independent continuation while the other directed immediate archive. Another pair agreed on autonomy and disagreed over use of the family name. The third split ownership of professional work from control of private memory in terms no receiving officer had tested.

Sevrin asked the key whether later filing dates superseded earlier ones. The archive answered only where the same original had amended a clause. It would not rank instructions from different people merely because one signed last.

“Then the form created a deadlock it had no rule to resolve,” Ama said.

“The old statute expected a Receiving Authority to weigh competing rights,” Sevrin replied.

“By closing the continuance into one of three outcomes.”

“Under the law, yes.”

Tovan enlarged the anonymous conflict map. “If two originals own one instrument, each can veto the other’s instruction. The instrument still carries the result.”

“Joint sponsorship contracts allocate tie-breaking authority,” Sevrin said.

“Where?”

“In the estate instrument.”

“Which the related continuance may not access.”

The Commissioner checked the archive permissions and found the barrier he had named. A closure officer could request the tie-break provision. The Commonwealth could not. Sevrin used her Receiving Authority seal to expose only the operative allocation, leaving estate details hidden. Two files granted the elder sponsor priority. The third required mutual consent from people now dead.

Pell marked that clause irresolvable under its own terms. No one celebrated the finding. A contradiction preserved in perfect authentication still left a living body waiting for an answer.

Ama read the distribution twice. “After all this, they disagreed.”

“They were people,” Sevrin said. “Agreement would have needed an institution.”

The first public clause opened without a name. Its original had authorized immediate erasure after verified death and forbidden use of the instance’s memories by the estate. The language described continued operation as a breach of bodily and informational consent. It also assigned remaining wages to the original’s dependents.

A second clause requested autonomy beyond the prediction horizon, including independent accounts and the right to refuse the original’s profession. Its author denied inheritance but authorized a start grant from personal funds. A handwritten note stated that a forecast forced to remain accurate had become a prison for both versions.

The third public clause directed archive and nothing else. No explanation. No affection. No warning. Four lines identified the approved repository, privacy term, query limits, and destruction date.

Lio stood at the edge of the table. His own file remained sealed to him and his parents’ estate representative. “Which one counts more?”

“None by category,” Sevrin replied. “Each clause can govern only within its own legal scope.”

“That is not what people will do. They will quote the kind they already wanted.”

“Yes.” Ilyen closed the public samples before rhetoric could make them representatives of everyone absent. “Our record should keep the denominator attached. Three examples among twenty-four filings, seven unfiled.”

Tovan requested private access to his file.

Witness Glass curved a semantic partition around him, Sevrin, and independent counsel. The rest of the chamber could see that a clause opened, how long they read, and which credentials touched it. Meaning stayed inside. Tovan had insisted on the arrangement before signing the archive act. His station duties, his stated interest in dissolution, and the emergency’s dependence on him made privacy unusually difficult and unusually necessary.

Ilyen watched his face through the blurred partition. He did not flinch. That told her nothing. Tovan met damage by reducing motion until every available part served the repair.

After six minutes, the partition cleared.

“I will release one fact,” he said. “The clause confirms my original’s expiration consent and requests dissolution after transfer of essential knowledge. It does not define essential or name who decides when transfer has completed.”

Ama gripped the edge of her slate. “You do not have to make an election today.”

“I know.”

“Nor does an undefined transfer let the station hold you forever.”

“I know that too.” Tovan placed his file back into privacy lock. “The instruction matters. It does not complete the decision.”

The Khet could have praised that formulation. Their absence helped. Holds-Four-Open had accepted foreign witness status for the Commonwealth vote, but Ilyen had not invited the speaker to the clause opening. Human dead deserved interpretation without an alien institution’s preference for unresolved commitments bending the room.

Lio chose not to open his file in session. “My parents wrote it for a version of me they thought they owned together. I want counsel before they get to surprise me again.”

Sevrin approved private counsel access without comment.

The decision left Ilyen’s column.

Her file permitted the related continuance, Original Ilyen’s estate representative, or a Receiving Authority to read it. Mara’s estate credential remained eleven days away from any new consent request. Sevrin already possessed receiving power. Ilyen could open the clause privately now.

“What do you want recorded?” Ama asked.

Ilyen saw the negotiation hidden inside the question. Privacy would protect her from performing grief for the Commonwealth. Public reading could establish evidence relevant to the civic-birth proposal. Either choice would be interpreted as strategy because she had taught everyone in the room to look for strategy.

“Open the authentication layer publicly,” she said. “Content first to me, Sevrin, and counsel. I will decide release after reading.”

Pell rendered the outer marks. Original Ilyen had filed the clause on Day minus 2,606, thirty-four days after the fork and eight days before Civic Mercy departed. The timing placed it within Ilyen’s missing ninety-one days. Biometric confidence exceeded the notary standard. The blue cup appeared only as a private memory challenge and remained sealed; the earlier recording had already established its provenance.

A partition rose.

Original Ilyen’s text began without greeting.

TO THE CONTINUANCE MADE FROM MY FORK, OR TO THE AUTHORITY RECEIVING IT AFTER MY DEATH OR RETURN:

Ilyen read the sentence twice. Original Ilyen had not used her name for the continuance. She had not written copy either. The refusal to name could carry caution, fear, or an attempt not to decide through grammar what law had not settled.

The next paragraph revoked any presumption of identity succession. The continuance could not claim the original’s marriage history, parenthood, public office, personal debts, or estate merely by proving shared memory. Vale could remain in records as provenance if no living family member faced misrepresentation. Any

new relation required consent from both sides.

Mara's refusal existed inside those limits without being predicted by them. Original Ilyen had protected her daughter from an imposed continuation of family. She had also left a narrow path for something neither woman had to name in advance.

Sevrin read with one hand held against the table. "This supports the preliminary ruling."

"It supports non-succession," Ilyen said.

"That distinction may matter later. At present, the ruling uses it."

Counsel marked the exchange. Neither interpretation displaced the text.

A separate section addressed work and resources. Original Ilyen released her professional notes, treaty preparation, office instruments, and a limited duty account to the actor who continued the Khet negotiation. The clause refused to classify that actor as heir. It required an accounting to the estate for private material and barred access to family funds.

Near the end, one sentence appeared in the visible fragment Ilyen had already found on Day Twenty: Do not let fidelity decide alone.

The full paragraph continued.

Fidelity can show what I feared, promised, and prepared. It cannot tell you whether the conditions I understood still exist. Preserve my evidence. Give no order merely because it resembles what I would have chosen. Assign the burden and the tools to whoever bears the consequences.

A schedule followed the paragraph. It listed the treaty notebooks, a private language model trained on Original Ilyen's negotiations, unused travel compensation, and the blue cup packed among her departure effects. Each item carried a different legal source. She owned the compensation and cup. The embassy owned the office instruments. The Khet archive held joint rights in translated notes. Original Ilyen had gathered them under one instruction because duty, not title, connected them.

Sevrin separated the schedule into legal columns. "She could assign the personal account subject to estate challenge. She could recommend custody for the office material. She could not transfer Khet rights unilaterally."

"She knew that," Ilyen said.

"Then why include them together?"

"Because a person accepting the work would need all four."

"That explains purpose. It does not cure authority."

Counsel marked each item accordingly. The clause had not created a single inheritance. It had assembled a proposed kit whose parts would require consent from different claimants. Ilyen felt the old familiar respect for a negotiation designed around an impossible room. She also felt irritation. Original Ilyen had left the hard work to someone she could imagine only as a functional successor.

The blue cup entry contained no family claim. It directed the holder of the treaty notes to keep, discard, or give away the cup without treating it as proof of identity. Ilyen remembered its glaze under her thumb, a memory

shared before the fork. The physical cup had traveled with the original. If recovered effects had survived the casualty process, Mara's estate rights would still reach it before any duty schedule did.

"Do not request that item yet," Ilyen said.

Sevrin looked from the schedule to her. "Because it lacks operational value?"

"Because Mara should receive notice before the Commonwealth uses an estate artifact to authenticate my claim."

"That may delay the schedule."

"The treaty work does not depend on a cup."

Counsel entered the hold. The decision cost Ilyen nothing material in the room. It still distinguished accepting tools from taking whatever shared memory made emotionally available.

Ilyen stopped reading.

The phrase did not grant life. It did not call her daughter, successor, or person. Original Ilyen had allocated resources around consequence while refusing identity. The structure resembled civic birth closely enough to tempt Ilyen into claiming endorsement. That temptation supplied its own warning.

"What follows?" Sevrin asked.

"A limitation." Ilyen continued.

No authority could use the clause to compel the continuance to finish the treaty, accept the Vale name, preserve the original's private relationships, or remain active. If the continuance refused the assigned work, the duty account returned to the embassy. If it accepted, accountability attached to the accepting actor from that date.

The clause ended with authentication instructions, not affection. Original Ilyen had offered neither erasure nor welcome. She had built a transfer point and refused to say who should cross it.

Sevrin dismissed counsel from the partition after the required silence. "Do you want to release the content?"

"Most of it."

"Exceptions?"

"The memory challenge. Two private family references unrelated to authority. Nothing that changes the operative terms."

"You understand release will strengthen the argument for prospective standing."

"It will also strengthen the prohibition on succession."

"That may not stop advocates from quoting only the sentence they prefer."

"No record can prevent selection. It can keep the surrounding sentences available."

Ilyen authorized public release with redactions. The partition lowered. Pell placed the full operative text beside the aggregate categories and linked every quotation to its context.

Ama reached the consequence paragraph first. “She gave you the treaty work.”

“She gave it to the actor who accepts its consequences.”

“You have done that.”

“I have performed the work. That does not settle which civil category should receive the account.”

Lio read the non-succession language. “She says you are not her, then writes rules for what you can choose.”

“She wrote rules for her property and duties,” Sevrin said. “She explicitly left the continuance’s status unsettled.”

“Adults like leaving a door open after putting a guard on every other exit.”

Ilyen almost smiled. “She also barred anyone from pushing me through it.”

Tovan came to the table and read the clause without touching his own sealed file. “Your original allowed refusal. Mine conditioned dissolution on a transfer no one defined. We did not inherit equal instructions.”

“No,” Ilyen said.

The Commonwealth custodians reviewed the remaining public clauses through the afternoon. One original demanded erasure to protect a spouse’s privacy. Another authorized any future choice except estate succession. Two directed silence: no recommendation, no posthumous argument, only access to independent counsel. An archive request contained a private apology but no change in legal disposition. Several files remained sealed to their related continuances.

Each instruction altered one person’s field of choice. None could govern the others.

At the end of the session, Pell asked how to classify the recovered archive in the Commonwealth record. The available labels included binding authority, advisory instrument, estate evidence, personal directive, and disputed claim.

“Use separate labels per clause,” Ilyen said.

“The index requires an archive-level description.”

Sevrin proposed “authenticated original intent, scope individually limited.” Tovan requested that present competence and consent remain explicit. Ama wanted the record to say the instructions carried moral force even where law could not compel them.

Ilyen listened until the disagreement stopped circling and began to show its useful edges.

“Classify the archive as evidence from the dead,” she said. “Authenticated, relevant, nonunanimous. No aggregate command.”

Pell entered the words. Witness Glass arranged the files according to their own access rules rather than a single disposition: erase requests in red, autonomy permissions in blue, archive and merge terms in white, no-directive clauses in gray, missing filings left uncolored.

Original Ilyen’s clause remained open at the sentence assigning tools to consequence. Tovan’s file closed under private seal. Lio’s waited unread for counsel. Seven blank columns preserved what the archive could not know.

The Commonwealth mark settled over the index without changing any color. Thirty-one separate fields remained visible after the dead had finished speaking.

Chapter 24 — The Continuity Covenant

Sevrin cut the word *successor* from the draft with a red legal stylus.

Witness Glass preserved the stroke as an amendment rather than an erasure. The rejected word remained visible beneath a narrow scar of light, linked to her commission seal and the local hour. Across the table, Ilyen Vale watched without attempting to recover it. Three columns of Return Clauses stood behind her, their incompatible instructions reduced to colored references: erasure, autonomy, silence. None could govern the others. None could settle the status of the people assembled on Orison.

“Again,” Sevrin said. “From the act that changes status.”

Ilyen drew the opening section back to the center. “A continuance may petition for civic birth after performing a future-bearing action under conditions of informed accountability.”

“Performed for whom?”

“For the instance who must bear its consequences.”

“That assumes the conclusion.” Sevrin placed two fingers against the table until the temptation to tap passed. “If I sign a contract for you, the consequences may burden you. The signature does not make me you.”

“No. It makes you answerable for signing.”

“Then write answerability, not identity.”

Ilyen changed the clause. The glass annotated every alteration, preserving their quarrel in layers. They had been drafting for six hours and had produced less than a page. Sevrin trusted that ratio more than easy agreement. Law intended to survive grief should acquire its sentences slowly.

Outside the chamber, Orison continued under revoked licenses and provisional local authority. Thermal use had stabilized, but only because Tovan rationed heat by hand and logged every substitution. Earth had not recognized the Commonwealth. The Khet had not accepted the proposed category. Sevrin’s own commission still empowered her to perform closure, although the public record now contained enough objections to make immediate use of that power indefensible.

She opened a new definition pane. “A future-bearing action must exceed reliable prediction from the fork model, create a durable obligation or change in conditions, and receive independent witness. Otherwise ordinary adaptive behavior will become a birth ceremony whenever convenient.”

“The prediction horizon can supply evidence,” Ilyen said. “It cannot supply a moral threshold by itself.”

“Agreed. A surprising breakfast preference does not found a citizen.”

Ilyen’s mouth moved at one corner. “Lio will object to the example before he objects to the rule.”

“He can do both in twenty minutes. Keep going.”

Together they drafted the petition requirements. The applicant would disclose the original, the fork date, every material gap in memory, and any unresolved Return Clause. The Commonwealth would record a provenance name without treating it as succession. Civic birth would create no automatic inheritance, kinship, property

title, office, or authority derived from the original. Obligations could pass only when the applicant assumed them with informed consent and affected parties received a chance to object.

Sevrin inserted the phrase *provenance disclosure* and required it on public contracts, kinship petitions, fiduciary work, and any use of an original's professional seal. Ilyen narrowed the requirement for ordinary social life.

"A person should not have to announce her fork history to buy soup," she said.

"A person using an original's reputation to obtain credit should."

"Yes."

The agreement landed without warmth. That also reassured Sevrin. They had found a line both could defend for different reasons.

At midday, Ama brought tea and a plate of ration cakes. Her right hand shook hard enough to set the cups clicking against the tray. She refused Sevrin's offered help with a look, then accepted Ilyen's decision to steady only the plate. The accommodation contained practice rather than pity.

"Your witnesses are waiting," Ama said. "Lio threatened to submit a procedural complaint about adult delay."

"Did he draft it?" Sevrin asked.

"He corrected Pell's form first."

"Admit them."

Lio entered ahead of Tovan, carrying a slate under one arm. He had written three objections before taking his chair. Tovan sat with the measured care of someone who still monitored his own thermal draw as a public promise. Sevrin displayed the proposed title.

CONTINUITY COVENANT: PROVISIONAL ARTICLES FOR CIVIC BIRTH, CLOSURE, AND ASSUMED DUTY.

Lio read it twice. "Continuity sounds like you think we continue someone."

"It names continuity of evidence and obligation," Sevrin said. "Not identity."

"Then why not call it the Evidence and Obligation Covenant?"

"Because no one would remember it."

He considered that answer, apparently decided it showed adequate honesty, and moved to the first article. "You require a future-bearing act. I have attended school for seven years beyond the fork. I chose subjects Original Lio never knew existed. Do I have to release a state secret before I qualify?"

"No," Ilyen said. "The act must carry consequences, not spectacle."

"Choosing training carries consequences."

"It can," Sevrin said. "Tell us which ones."

Lio opened his slate. He had applied, without legal authority, to an archive-architecture program maintained by

the embassy's Khet liaison staff. The curriculum would take nine local years. It required him to abandon the sponsor-defined education track created for Original Lio's family. Acceptance would consume a scarce mentorship place and bind him to supervised archive work.

"That choice falls beyond your tested prediction horizon?" Sevrin asked.

"By four years and nine months."

"Can you withdraw?"

"From the course, yes. From having chosen it, no."

"Who bears the cost if you leave?"

"The program loses time. I lose the place. The registry keeps the attempt."

His answers came quickly, but not carelessly. Sevrin marked the application as a plausible qualifying act without deciding it. The later vote would establish procedures; this session could only test whether the rule produced intelligible questions.

She changed the hypothetical. Suppose a continuance aged nine petitioned after refusing a sponsor's curriculum. Could the Commonwealth grant civic birth while also appointing a guardian? Lio objected to treating dependence as disqualification. Tovan asked who could consent to assumed obligations for a minor. Ilyen separated personhood from capacity. Sevrin added a clause allowing civic birth without full contractual power, subject to ordinary protections based on demonstrated capacity rather than origin.

"Ordinary protections do not exist for us," Lio said.

"They will if the Commonwealth adopts them."

"That answer depends on the same vote as the Covenant."

"Yes," Sevrin said. "A lawful structure may depend on authority it does not yet possess. It may not pretend the authority already exists."

Lio entered that sentence in his objections, though Sevrin could not tell whether he meant to challenge or preserve it.

Tovan had left his copy untouched. His hands rested on either side of the slate, palms down. When Sevrin asked him to test the obligation article, he read Original Tovan's expiration consent aloud. The language had survived three hearings and one thermal cascade. It directed any licensed instance to accept dissolution after authenticated death unless essential safety work required a brief extension.

"Under this draft," Tovan said, "I can refuse that instruction by applying for birth."

"You can petition," Sevrin replied. "The instruction enters as evidence. It does not operate as a command against a person whose status has changed."

"And if the petition succeeds, I can assume the original's duties selectively."

"With consent from affected parties."

"That invites convenience. I keep his professional standing, decline his expiration, and leave his creditors to the

estate.”

Ilyen leaned forward. “Would you ask to keep his professional standing?”

“No.”

“Test the rule with someone who would.”

Tovan did. He constructed a continuance physician who sought civic birth, claimed the original’s license, refused malpractice debt, and used shared memories to attract patients. Sevrin removed every automatic transfer. The new person could seek a license through examination, assume selected debts through novation, and disclose provenance when describing prior experience. Memories could support competence but not substitute for current certification.

Next he offered an engineer whose original had committed sabotage before the fork and whose continuance possessed the plan. Sevrin rejected inherited criminal guilt. Ilyen required disclosure of known ongoing danger. They wrote a duty to report actionable hazards without converting shared memory into culpability.

Tovan’s third test concerned himself. “Suppose I accept civic birth and later decide the expiration consent carried a judgment I should honor. Does the Commonwealth prevent dissolution to preserve its claim that I count?”

No one answered at once.

Sevrin studied the language they had used for voluntary closure. The first version required a competency review, a waiting period, and evidence against coercion. It also permitted the Commonwealth to delay dissolution during an emergency if the applicant held essential knowledge. That exception resembled the old instrument law too closely. Necessity could become ownership with a change of heading.

She deleted it.

Ilyen looked up. “The station may depend on him.”

“Then the station must persuade him, train others, or accept the cost. Civic birth cannot mean self-ownership except during inconvenient weeks.”

Tovan’s fingers moved from the slate. “The petition should preserve a future right to dissolve.”

“It should preserve every competent person’s right to request it,” Sevrin said. “With safeguards against pressure from originals, sponsors, estates, and the Commonwealth itself.”

Ama signed as medical reviewer. Her witness mark wandered before the seal accepted it. She did not apologize.

The afternoon brought hostile hypotheticals from the public queue. Pell had stripped names and grouped them by legal issue. A widower asked whether his dead husband’s continuance could petition for civic birth, then use private memories to force contact. A creditor asked whether a newly born person could hide assets behind the dead estate. An election office asked whether one original could fork a thousand continuances and manufacture a voting bloc. A parent asked who protected a child from a continuance carrying the voice of a dead caregiver.

Sevrin made them answer each one.

Privacy law barred coercive use of shared memories whether or not civic birth occurred. Property transferred

only through an independent grant or accepted obligation, never through resemblance. Multiple instances could receive recognition, but registry disclosure and residence rules governed voting like any other coordinated constituency. Kinship required new consent from living parties. No stored affection created access to a home, a child, or an estate.

Sevrin then tested office. The Covenant could not grant Ilyen the dead envoy's commission by succession, yet Orison needed someone able to finish the treaty. Ilyen argued that the Commonwealth could appoint any qualified citizen after civic birth. Sevrin agreed, provided the appointment began under local authority and carried a fresh seal. Memory of the original's negotiations could establish competence. It could not smuggle old sovereign power through a new registry entry.

They built a mock appointment in Witness Glass. Ilyen surrendered her present Continuance Office credential into a sealed pane. Its permissions vanished from the treaty console one by one: archive request, embassy signature, privileged relay, emergency representation. The temporary loss left the room physically unchanged. Sevrin still felt it as a structural silence. For months, opponents had claimed the office alone explained every judgment Ilyen made. Without the credential, Ilyen remained seated, remembered the clauses, and could answer questions. She simply lacked authority to bind anyone.

The Commonwealth clerk on duty issued a test appointment under the proposed law. A fresh seal appeared beside Ilyen's name, limited to a training chamber and marked without legal effect. She used it to open a duplicate treaty page. Witness Glass accepted the local credential while preserving the absent Earth delegation as a separate field.

"Would that satisfy the Khet?" Ilyen asked.

"It may satisfy a machine," Sevrin said. "The Khet will answer for their treaty."

"Will it satisfy Earth?"

"Not today."

Sevrin revoked the test appointment and restored the existing office credential. The exercise proved less than Ilyen wanted and more than old instrument law allowed. Authority could leave one legal source and enter another without any claim that the office holder had returned from death. The seam remained visible.

Tovan proposed a harsher version. Suppose an infrastructure continuance withheld essential knowledge until the Commonwealth granted office. The act might exceed prediction and carry consequences, but coercion should not qualify as a civic threshold merely because it forced recognition. Sevrin added independent review of the claimed future-bearing act. The review would consider duress, manufactured danger, and harm imposed to create leverage. It could reject the act as qualification without deciding whether the applicant deserved continued existence.

Lio objected to the last distinction. "You keep separating eligibility from existence. Earth law does not."

"This law must," Sevrin said. "A failed petition leaves status unresolved. It does not authorize punishment disguised as classification."

Ilyen resisted one provision: mandatory separation of all pre-fork confidences from public testimony.

"Some memories prove abuse," she said. "Some prove promises made to people without other witnesses."

"Then admit them under ordinary evidentiary rules," Sevrin replied. "Do not let civic birth convert intimacy

into unrestricted property.”

“Agreed. But the court must hear the bearer.”

“As a witness to memory, with provenance disclosed. Not as the deceased returning to testify.”

The wording held. Sevrin marked it for challenge on Earth.

Pell sent the final hostile case alone. A dying parent had revised an estate under pressure from a continuance who claimed exact filial identity. After the transfer, the original daughter lost the home she had maintained for twelve years. Could the continuance seek civic birth and keep the proceeds?

Sevrin’s hand left the stylus.

The case omitted names, but Pell had drawn it from her commission history. Her younger sister, Nera, had commissioned a continuance during treatment for neural decline. That instance had approached their father after Nera’s death and called every shared memory proof of uninterrupted daughterhood. Their father, already failing, changed the estate. Sevrin challenged too late. The house passed to a legal construct that spoke with Nera’s timing and knew where their mother had hidden winter presents.

Ilyen closed the public queue. “We can use another case.”

“No.” Sevrin heard the clipped refusal and let it stand. “This one built part of the law we are replacing.”

Tovan and Lio remained still. Neither offered sympathy. She valued the restraint.

Sevrin reopened the hypothetical and separated its acts. The instance’s continued existence had not caused the coercion. Shared memory had supplied leverage. False succession claims had defeated the living daughter’s standing. A vulnerable adult had executed a transfer without independent counsel. Those failures demanded remedies, but dissolution would not restore consent already violated.

“The Covenant would recognize the continuance as a new person,” Lio said.

“If it performed a qualifying act and passed review.”

“Even after that?”

“Yes. Personhood cannot function as a prize for innocence.”

Tovan looked toward the estate clause. “Would it keep the house?”

“Not by inheritance. A court would review the transfer for coercion. If the transfer failed, the property would return to the estate. Any independent property acquired afterward would remain with the new person.”

Ilyen asked, “Would you require it to stop using your sister’s name?”

Sevrin pictured the signature that had taken her father’s house: Nera Hale, without qualification. Anger returned with its old precision. It no longer carried a complete legal theory.

“I would require provenance disclosure where the name could create reliance,” she said. “I would deny automatic kinship. I would not let my injury turn continuity into a crime.”

The distinction did not pardon the instance. It did not repair the estate or give Sevrin back the years spent

arguing that a familiar voice could manipulate as effectively as a stranger. It placed blame on conduct rather than origin. Her commission had never managed that division. The draft might.

She entered a remedy article: recognition would not cure prior fraud, coercion, or unlawful transfer. Nor would prior misconduct alone erase civic status once lawfully granted. Liability followed acts. Provenance supplied evidence, not guilt.

By the station's late watch, the draft held seven articles and two annexes. Sevrin ran it against Earth's remote-instrument statute. The Covenant conflicted with mandatory closure provisions, but the Commonwealth's emergency charter could suspend those locally if its founding vote survived review. She tested inheritance codes, licensing law, guardianship, criminal responsibility, privacy, debt, and treaty capacity. Some provisions required later implementing law. None depended on identity succession.

Ilyen stood beside her while Witness Glass compiled the review map. "You could still close us under your commission."

"I could issue the order."

"That did not answer the statement."

"No." Sevrin watched red conflict lines narrow into amber questions. "Orison's enforcement personnel recognize the Commonwealth. Earth's public record contains the dispute. The Khet sanctuary would complicate custody. My order would have text and no clean execution."

"Then the draft has local force."

"It has local coherence. Force requires adoption."

Ilyen accepted the correction. She placed her office seal beside Sevrin's commission mark, not as approval, but as co-author authentication. The glass requested a document status.

Sevrin chose PROPOSED. She refused RATIFIED and declined the softer STUDY DRAFT. Proposed meant someone intended the words to govern and admitted they did not yet.

They transmitted one certified copy toward Earth. Pell's delay ledger opened an eleven-day route clock beneath it. A second copy went to the Khet archive desk with a request for treaty recognition. Sevrin attached no claim that either destination would agree.

The chamber rendered its final conflicts. Under local emergency law, the draft could form a coherent category. Under Earth law, it lacked recognition. Under the access treaty, no Khet signature yet supported it. The three fields remained separate instead of collapsing into a false approval.

Sevrin capped the red stylus and set it across the first page. Beneath the transparent scar, *successor* remained readable among the words they had refused. Above it, the proposed civic-birth clause waited for authorities outside the room.

Chapter 25 — The Archive Does Not Answer

Holds-Four-Open declined the first seal before Ilyen finished presenting it.

A red boundary crossed the proposed Covenant where its civic-birth article touched the Khet treaty record. Four amber apertures hovered beyond Witness Glass, each carrying a thread of the temporary speaker. Three remained bright. The coolest had contracted almost to darkness, refusing authorization without leaving the construct.

Ilyen stopped the document before the chamber could classify the rejection as final. “State the defect.”

The translator held the Khet clicks for two breaths, arranging relations into human sequence. “The human seal requests recognition of an entity category. This exchange carries authority over archive access, treaty obligations, and witnessed commitments. It carries no authority to determine which human forms count as persons.”

“I am not asking you to amend human law.”

“You request Khet recognition for use in a human vote.”

“I request recognition for treaty purposes. The vote remains ours.”

The dark aperture widened a fraction. Another dimmed in answer. Their disagreement traveled visibly through the speaker before any words reached her.

On Ilyen’s side of the table, the Continuity Covenant lay open in seven articles and two annexes. Sevrin’s rejected word *successor* remained under its transparent scar. The status fields still showed PROPOSED, EARTH UNRECOGNIZED, KHET UNSIGNED. Ilyen had brought no one else into the chamber. A delegation could have distributed the refusal among witnesses. Solitude required her to hear what she had actually asked.

Holds-Four-Open said, “For treaty use, identify the bearer of obligation.”

“The Orison Commonwealth.”

“That body holds provisional human authority.”

“Yes.”

“Within it, some decision bearers claim civic birth. Others retain instrument classification under remote human law. The proposed articles would permit each claimant to choose among birth, archive, continued suspension, or dissolution.”

“Subject to capacity and coercion safeguards.”

“The variation remains. Which entity asks recognition?”

Ilyen had negotiated with the Khet long enough to recognize a narrowing question. They would not let a collective noun hide the contested actors inside it. “The Commonwealth asks you to recognize its authority to create treaty-capable citizens under the Covenant.”

“That phrasing requests recognition of the Commonwealth.”

“Yes.”

“It does not request a finding on the continuances.”

“The Commonwealth consists partly of continuances.”

“It also consists partly of biological humans. It was declared by a narrow vote under an emergency compact. Recognition of the polity would not answer whether each participant entered the vote with valid standing.”

Ilyen looked toward the lowest seal line. She had used that ambiguity herself when the emergency council recovered the Compact phrase, persons present and answerable. The provisional assembly rested on presence, conduct, and necessity while declining to settle every underlying status. Now she wanted Khet recognition to flow backward through the vote and cure its founding doubt.

“You recognize unresolved commitments as claimants,” she said.

“We hold them open.”

“You offered us archive standing.”

“We offered standing to the intentions carried through you.”

“Through us.” Ilyen kept her voice level. “Not to us.”

Two apertures brightened. The answer came slower. “The distinction has produced dispute among the four.”

“Then show me the dispute.”

Holds-Four-Open rotated its threads into separate witness lanes. Witness Glass assigned no names, only colors and authorization weights. The warmest thread treated each continuance as an accountable context because post-fork experience had changed available choices. A pale thread treated the continuance as an intention-bearing structure whose human classification remained irrelevant to Khet duty. The cool thread feared that civic birth would close obligations owed to originals. The dimmest thread objected to any Khet judgment that human negotiators could cite as moral authority over other humans.

Ilyen read the four positions twice. “Your first thread supports our claim.”

“It supports continued accountability.”

“That produces civic birth under our Covenant.”

“No. Your Covenant includes rights, property limits, dissolution procedure, liability, and political membership. Continued accountability supplies evidence for those choices. It cannot decide them.”

“You have accepted human envoys as treaty persons for decades.”

“We accepted offices able to bind human institutions.”

“You negotiated with me after Earth suspended my status.”

“We negotiated with an Unclosed Agent whose decisions could alter access.”

“Because I could choose.”

“Because several accountable contexts still claimed your choice.”

The answer scraped against an old wound with unusual accuracy. Khet standing had protected her when Earth called her an instrument, but it had not required the Khet to see an independent person. They valued the unresolved path she carried. The path could outlast her, pass into an archive, or remain suspended forever without violating their first principle.

Ilyen changed tactics. She brought forward the treaty’s archive-key article, leaving its authorization field blank. “You required a future-bearing action. Release of this key will permanently alter your access to human records. The Covenant assigns the consequence to the civic actor who authorizes it. Will you recognize that actor for purposes of receiving the key?”

“We can recognize the authorization if its human chain proves valid.”

“Will you recognize the authorizer as a person?”

“No.”

The word crossed the translator without qualification.

Ilyen let the chamber record six seconds of silence. She could have hidden disappointment inside another procedural request. The Khet would have noticed the request, not the emotion. Witness Glass would preserve both only as elapsed time and pulse variance. Neither record would say she had expected a civilization organized around open decisions to welcome people built from them.

“Explain the refusal,” she said.

“Human personhood governs harms and permissions beyond this treaty. It structures kinship, bodily authority, ownership, guilt, education, care, and death. We do not occupy those relations. A Khet decision would reach farther than our accountability.”

“You occupied them when you offered sanctuary.”

“We offered an archive relation under Khet control. We did not claim the relation satisfied human dignity.”

“It did not.”

All four apertures held steady.

The simple agreement changed her approach. “When you offered archive standing, Lio would have remained protected as an unresolved intention. Could he have chosen training beyond his sponsor model?”

“Not if the choice closed archive evidence still claimed by accountable contexts.”

“Could Tovan have chosen dissolution?”

“The archive would preserve the decision bearer required to hold the consent dispute open.”

“Against his present choice.”

“Yes.”

“Could I have released the key?”

“Not while the original’s protective assignment retained an unresolved claim.”

Ilyen spread the three answers beside the Covenant. Under Khet sanctuary, none of them needed to die. None could fully depart from the purpose that made the archive value them. Preservation had offered refuge from Earth’s closure power while fastening each continuance to unfinished original intentions.

“You call that standing,” she said.

“We call it archive standing.”

“Would you accept it for yourselves?”

The translator paused long enough to request an additional syntax lane. One aperture dimmed; two crossed their light; the fourth remained separate.

“We have,” Holds-Four-Open said. “The four decision threads entered this speaker under commitments none may complete alone. Each may withdraw only through a recorded closure that alters the construct. Human observers describe this as office. Some Khet disputes describe it as captivity.”

The admission carried no dramatic shift in tone. Khet translation did not know confession. It simply placed a disputed relation into the record.

Ilyen called up the oldest archive entry from the Ledger of Open Hands. Centuries earlier, a Khet closure tribunal had ended a civil conflict by deleting the authority of dissenting threads. Open-holding developed in answer. The doctrine preserved alternatives because completion had once erased them.

A second entry followed the famous one, less often translated for human visitors. Three districts had disputed the return of a contaminated archive. Open-holding preserved every remedy while seals failed, families relocated, and the contamination spread through storage membranes. By the time Khet institutions authorized destruction of the affected records, no original claimant still occupied the district. The unresolved decision had protected all four remedies until none could repair the loss.

“Why omit this entry from the public doctrine summary?” Ilyen asked.

“It does not establish the doctrine.”

“It establishes its cost.”

“The cost remains disputed. One thread classifies the lost archive as preferable to wrongful destruction. Another assigns harm to procedural delay. Two classify the comparison as incomplete because the relocated families carried secondary records.”

“Did the families choose relocation?”

“Some did. Others received no safe alternative.”

“Did any accountable body compensate them?”

“After closure, yes.”

“How many human years passed?”

The translator converted the Khet intervals. “Twenty-eight point six.”

Ilyen sent the entry into the treaty annex, not as an accusation but as relevant institutional history. The Khet had shown humans the erased-dissent case whenever explaining why decisions deserved preservation. The contaminated archive revealed the opposite danger: alternatives could consume the people forced to carry them.

She brought up Tovan's pending options. His original's expiration consent claimed dissolution. His seven years of service, the thermal cascade, and his later transparent repairs supported continued authorship. Khet archive standing could hold both claims indefinitely. "If he accepts your protection, who may later say the dispute has lasted long enough?"

"The participating contexts may request closure."

"Original Tovan cannot request anything."

"His authenticated instruction retains standing."

"Then one context can never change its position."

"Yes."

"And you call that an open decision."

"We call it a decision with an unwithdrawn claim."

The legal precision made the trap clearer. Human death froze one side. Khet care converted that frozen instruction into permanent dissent, giving the dead an advantage the living could not outwait.

Ilyen tested Lio next. Suppose his parents' sponsor terms required educational continuity while Lio sought archive training. Under Khet practice, the sponsor purpose would remain claim-bearing even if every living guardian withdrew it, because the original commissioning decision survived in authenticated form. Would his own later choice ever outrank it?

"Ranking does not describe open-holding," the speaker said.

"Action does. Can he enroll?"

"Only if enrollment preserves a path by which the sponsor claim may still receive an answer."

"A nine-year course consumes the years in which the sponsor curriculum applies."

"Then enrollment may perform closure."

"Which your archive would resist."

"Yes."

Ilyen placed Tovan's consent beside Lio's curriculum. The Khet doctrine treated both as unfinished commitments. Human experience distinguished them: one concerned a competent adult's possible death, the other a young person's education. No archive relation could erase that difference, yet open-holding supplied no native tool for weighing it.

"You built your practice against forced closure," she said. "We built the Covenant against forced continuation as someone else."

“Those aims can align.”

“They do not coincide.”

“No.”

“What happens when open-holding prevents needed closure?”

The phrase entered Witness Glass exactly: *needed closure*. Its human directness required the translator to separate necessity from preference. The four apertures exchanged authorization in small pulses.

At last the speaker answered. “The unresolved claim can consume the conditions needed for any claimant to act. It can preserve injury after the injured contexts have changed. It can grant old dissent permanent rule over those who inherited the dispute. Khet practice contains closures for these cases, though our institutions use them reluctantly.”

“Your sanctuary offer contained none.”

“We judged preservation more urgent than human self-determination.”

“You judged without claiming to judge.”

“Yes.”

Ilyen sat back. Holds-Four-Open had not become a moral oracle by admitting fault. The Khet had named a bias in their procedure, not supplied the missing human verdict. Yet the admission removed one refuge. She could no longer present archive standing to uncertain voters as a neutral safe option. It protected bodies and records. It also deferred futures.

“Amend the sanctuary offer,” she said. “State those limits in the human rendering.”

“That request lies within this exchange.”

A new annotation opened. Together they wrote that archive standing preserved an unresolved intention for Khet purposes, did not confer human personhood, and could restrict closure or independent action. Any continuance accepting it would receive a human-language warning. The Commonwealth could not call the offer equivalent to civic status.

When the amendment sealed, Ilyen returned to the Covenant. “If you will not recognize civic birth, what will you recognize?”

“The Khet archive can witness the conditions under which humans choose.”

“Define witness.”

“We can preserve the proposed articles, voter roll, objections, separate tallies, and authorization chain. We can attest that no later party altered the record.”

“That duplicates Witness Glass.”

“Witness Glass carries human seals now disputed by human authorities. Khet custody supplies an independent record.”

“Will you attest that the result deserves compliance?”

“No.”

“Will you treat a passed Covenant as sufficient treaty capacity?”

“Not in advance.”

Ilyen felt irritation sharpen into usefulness. “Then your offer amounts to storage.”

“Storage without alteration across jurisdictions. Also presence during the choice.”

“And archive standing remains available to individuals who reject civic birth?”

“Yes, under the amended warning.”

“What about the treaty itself?”

“If human authority validly releases the key under safeguards we can accept, the archive access treaty may proceed. Our receipt of the key will not certify the metaphysics of its releaser.”

“I did not ask for metaphysics.”

“You asked for personhood.”

The correction deserved the room it took. Ilyen walked to the edge of Witness Glass, where Orison’s rotation carried a field of dim stars upward. Behind her, the Covenant remained caught against the red Khet boundary. She had come to remove that mark before the vote. Instead she had learned which part no external signature could remove.

“Offer treaty witness in formal language,” she said.

The four threads recombined. “The Khet archive will serve as treaty witness to the human proceeding. It will preserve each question separately, record participation and abstention, retain all objections, and attest the unaltered result. Such witness grants no moral absolution, no human status, and no advance treaty recognition.”

“Add that your refusal does not constitute a finding against civic birth.”

“Accepted.”

“Add that archive standing does not outrank civic birth, dissolution, or continued unrecognized residence.”

“That ranking belongs to humans.”

“Then state that you provide none.”

The warm aperture brightened. The final language appeared: the Khet offered distinct relations without ranking them under human law.

Ilyen reviewed the terms as she would an adversary’s concession. Independent custody would protect the vote from later erasure. Separate tallies would prevent the Commonwealth question from smuggling the Covenant, key release, and individual choices into one result. Recorded abstention would matter for continuances who refused every offered category. Khet presence would not validate the voters. It would make falsifying what they chose harder.

That had value. It did not offer permission.

“Transmit the witness offer to the provisional assembly,” she said.

Before sealing it, Holds-Four-Open opened one thread alone. The dimmest aperture now carried enough light to speak.

“This thread asks whether the human envoy will describe our refusal as abandonment.”

“I have not decided how to describe it.”

“The description may change the vote.”

“Yes.”

“Then we hold a claim in your choice.”

Ilyen almost laughed. “You hold claims in weather if it changes a route.”

“Incorrect. Weather bears no answer.”

“Neither does an archive.”

The other three apertures shifted. Translation rendered their shared response without defensiveness. “An archive preserves conditions for answers. It should not replace those who must give them.”

There lay the useful sentence, dangerous because it sounded like wisdom she could carry back as endorsement. Ilyen refused the gift in that form.

“Enter it as your account of institutional limits,” she said. “Not as advice to the assembly.”

“Accepted.”

The witness offer sealed beside the rejected recognition request. Both would travel into the vote record. Ilyen removed the Covenant from the Khet boundary, leaving its status unchanged.

At the chamber door, the speaker addressed her through all four threads. “Unclosed Agent, will the human choice proceed without our classification?”

“Yes.”

“Does that close your claim on us?”

“It changes it. If we vote to release the key, you will answer as treaty parties. You will not answer for who we count as human.”

The door opened on the embassy’s central passage. Ama waited there with a medical slate tucked against her chest, her right hand trembling along its edge. Pell stood beside a portable witness terminal. Sevrin had taken the chair nearest the wall, leaving the central place vacant for Ilyen without making a ceremony of it. Lio and Tovan watched from the assembly feed.

Ama searched Ilyen’s face. “Did they recognize it?”

“No.”

Pell lowered his eyes to the terminal. Sevrin did not move.

Ilyen gave them the precise result. The Khet had declined personhood jurisdiction. They had amended archive standing to disclose its constraints. They offered independent custody of separate tallies and would witness the proceeding without endorsing its morality. Treaty recognition would depend on the authorization humans produced, not on an alien declaration about their nature.

Lio's voice came from the terminal. "So they think we might count, but they won't say."

"They think the saying does not belong to them."

"Convenient."

"Yes." Ilyen looked toward Sevrin. "Also correct."

Sevrin rose and opened the assembly schedule. Four blank questions waited beneath Day Sixty-One. None displayed a projected result. "Then we publish the refusal with the witness terms."

Ilyen authenticated both records. She did not soften the Khet admission or turn it into support. The public queue accepted the documents. Across Orison, voter slates opened their unmarked fields.

Behind the closed chamber, four amber apertures kept the Covenant without approving it. Ahead, the provisional assembly clock began its final seventy-two hours with no external answer attached.

Chapter 26 — The Vote to Continue

Ama's hand shook against the voter roll, moving her seal half a line below her name.

Witness Glass did not correct the mark. It measured her pulse pattern, matched the pressure sequence, and accepted the imperfect stroke as hers. A copy entered Khet custody at the same instant. Across the chamber, four amber apertures recorded the action without blessing it.

"Forty-six eligible residents," Pell announced. "Forty-six credentials tested. No proxy ballots. No remote votes. Thirty-one participants hold disputed Continuance status under Earth law. Fifteen are biological residents. The roll records both classifications and grants neither priority."

Captain Edrin and Welfare Officer Venn had departed with the courier on Day Fifty-Two. Their temporary station credentials closed with the hatch, reducing the living roll from seventeen at the Commonwealth's founding vote to fifteen.

Sevrin stood beside the challenge desk in her Commissioner's gray, where anyone could see the commission seal she had not surrendered. "My objection remains attached. Participation under the Embassy Compact does not settle legal status outside Orison."

Ilyen sat at the central table with the proposed Covenant closed before her. "Your objection is admitted. Does it challenge any particular credential?"

"No."

The answer cleared the roll. Pell sealed it and opened the first of four questions. Every slate in the station received the same text. Witness Glass displayed only receipt marks until the voting interval closed; no one could bargain from an early tally.

Ilyen had spent much of her working life arranging order. In a treaty session, order determined which concession acquired the dignity of a principle and which looked like payment. Here, each sequence carried a similar danger. A vote on civic birth before the Commonwealth could claim authority not yet granted. A vote on the polity first could hide personal status inside institutional survival. They had answered by separating everything and allowing the first result to fail without canceling later individual choices.

Pell read the question aloud. "Shall the provisional Orison Commonwealth continue as the local civic authority under the Embassy Compact, subject to external review and without claim to automatic Earth recognition?"

No speech followed. Arguments had remained open for seventy-two hours. Ama had required that discipline after the hearing record grew too large for a working resident to read between shifts. Each side received a summary, a full index, and equal relay position. The final hour belonged to choice rather than performance.

Ilyen touched her slate. YES, NO, and ABSTAIN appeared with no default position.

A no vote would not suspend her. Sevrin's closure powers would remain contested, the Khet sanctuary offer would remain available, and Earth law would continue to classify her as an instrument allowed to perform existing duties. A yes vote would establish only local authority, born from a charter clause no drafter had intended for this use. Neither field offered safety.

Her thumb settled on YES. She authenticated the choice with the office credential whose ownership remained disputed.

The slate asked whether she wished to attach a public reason. She declined. Her arguments already occupied thousands of words. A ballot did not need to become another brief.

Receipt marks accumulated around the chamber. Tovan voted from thermal control because the station could not spare him for ceremony. Lio sat in the first public row, elbows tucked against his sides, refusing Ama's attempt to see whether he had finished. Sevrin cast her ballot at the challenge desk and closed her slate face down.

When the interval ended, Pell locked all forty-six receipts. Witness Glass recomputed the result. The Khet archive returned an independent checksum before the numbers appeared.

YES: 24.

NO: 21.

ABSTAIN: 1.

The Commonwealth continued by three votes. Its Day Forty-Nine declaration had survived a second narrow vote, but Ilyen did not call that margin legitimacy. It supplied authority under the procedure they had chosen. The twenty-one refusals entered the same permanent record.

Pell opened objections for numerical challenge. One maintenance officer asked to verify that abstention had not been counted against the majority threshold. The Compact required more yes votes than no among authenticated ballots; abstentions preserved participation without entering either side. Pell showed the calculation. Sevrin verified it under her commission. Holds-Four-Open attested that Khet custody contained forty-six unaltered selections matching the human record.

"No arithmetic challenge remains," Pell said.

Only then did Ilyen allow herself to breathe against the back of her teeth. The first question had not settled her status. It had created an authority capable of asking the second.

The Continuity Covenant opened across Witness Glass. Seven articles and two annexes spread into distinct panes: civic birth after a witnessed future-bearing act; disclosure of provenance where reliance could arise; no automatic inheritance or kinship; no transfer of guilt; voluntary assumption of obligations; capacity protections; access to archive, continued transition, or dissolution without ranking. Sevrin's scar through *successor* remained visible in the drafting history.

Pell read the adoption question. "Shall the Orison Commonwealth enact the Continuity Covenant as local law, effective upon certification, while recording all conflicts with Earth statutes for provisional review?"

This time the chamber allowed closing statements because the law would bind conduct immediately. The opposition speaker, a living food-synthesis technician named Darel In, stood at the public rail. He did not question whether continuances suffered. He argued that crisis could not grant a remote station power to create citizens, expose estates, or redefine death procedure.

"If Earth can lose jurisdiction whenever delay becomes painful," Darel said, "then delay law has no jurisdiction anywhere it matters. You are asking us to call necessity a constitution."

Ilyen entered the objection without answering. Sevrin had made a version of it throughout the drafting. Serious opposition deserved more than a staged rebuttal.

The supporting statement came from Ama. Her right hand rested against the rail while her left held the text. "Earth law classifies thirty-one residents as instruments and still relies on their labor, memory, and liability. That contradiction has material consequences in this station. The Covenant does not settle identity. It makes conduct answerable to a law that can see the actor."

Her tremor moved through the rail. Witness Glass recorded it with the words.

Lio requested one sentence. Pell recognized him.

"If you vote no because the Covenant might be wrong," Lio said, "choose what happens to us while you wait to become certain."

"That exceeds one sentence," Pell told him.

"It has twenty words."

"The permission concerned function, not word count."

Lio sat down, visibly unconvinced by the distinction.

Ilyen opened her ballot. She read the civic-birth article once more. It did not claim she had crossed an invisible threshold that morning. It required evidence, witness, and an act whose future consequences belonged to her. It denied her Original Ilyen's estate and family standing. It permitted her to accept duties rather than inherit them through resemblance. The terms cost enough to feel honest.

For the Covenant, Ilyen chose YES.

The second interval closed with every slate returned. Pell compared forty-six local receipts against the Khet checksum.

YES: 29.

NO: 13.

FOUR ABSTENTIONS RECORDED.

The Covenant passed, but not unanimously. Thirteen residents had rejected it; four refused to authorize or forbid it. Their reasons ranged from loyalty to Earth jurisdiction to fear of coercive continuances, objections to dissolution, and doubt that one irreversible act could support civic birth. The enacted law retained those arguments in its review annex.

Darel challenged one ballot whose authentication time overlapped a thermal alarm. Tovan's slate had completed the choice before the alarm opened, then transmitted while he answered it. Witness Glass showed the sequence. The ballot stood. No other challenge followed.

Sevrin applied her commission seal as procedural witness, not sovereign approval. "The text satisfies the conditions submitted to the assembly. I reserve Earth review."

"Reservation recorded," Pell said.

The third proceeding concerned individual options. The chamber closed its public audio while each of the thirty-one continuances received a private status petition. No majority could choose for them. Each person could request civic birth, accept amended Khet archive standing, remain under transitional local protection

without new status, or begin safeguarded voluntary dissolution review. A choice could be public, sealed, or deferred. Covenant officers would examine civic-birth evidence individually after the vote.

Ilyen's petition displayed her original principal, fork date, ninety-one-day memory gap, active obligations, and Return Clause. Original Ilyen's sentence appeared at the bottom: resources for whoever bears the consequences. It supported access without naming a successor.

The form asked for a proposed future-bearing act and effective date.

Ilyen entered Day Seven. On that day, the suspension deadline had passed while she remained in an active Khet session under emergency duty. The act had incurred personal liability, preserved the treaty, and created obligations Original Ilyen could not have predicted because the casualty crisis did not exist at the fork. She did not claim birth when Ama delivered the braid. Receipt had opened the question. Her refusal to surrender the decision had made its consequences hers.

For civic name, she left the field blank. The Covenant permitted later filing. Vale remained listed as provenance pending judgment, not as inherited family title.

Ilyen selected PETITION FOR CIVIC BIRTH and sealed the record.

Lio requested public audio for his petition. "I want the date witnessed."

Pell opened his channel. The form projected his application to the Khet archive-architecture program. Its nine-year course displaced the sponsor curriculum and fell nearly five years beyond his tested prediction horizon.

"I choose Day Fifty-Five," Lio said. "That's when I applied for training nobody built me to want."

Sevrin asked from the review desk, "You understand admission remains separate from civic status?"

"Yes. A birthday does not pass an entrance exam."

"And you may leave the program later."

"Leaving would become another choice. It would not undo applying."

He entered ARCHIVE ARCHITECTURE as his chosen training and petitioned for civic birth from Day Fifty-Five. His original name remained in the provenance field. For civic name, he entered LIO AN without claiming estate or kinship. The Covenant allowed retention when disclosure prevented reliance; no living family objection had yet reached Orison.

Tovan's channel stayed private for eleven minutes. A thermal status pane beside Ilyen showed no emergency. Delay could mean uncertainty rather than danger, and she forced herself not to send him a question.

At last he requested a witnessed clause instead of public video. His petition sought civic birth based on Day Forty-Four, when he had repaired the revoked thermal system through disclosed substitutions rather than another unauthorized extension. He accepted professional review and liability for the Day Twenty-Three cascade. He assumed ongoing maintenance duty for ninety days, subject to transfer once apprentices qualified.

Then his condition appeared.

CIVIC BIRTH SHALL NOT WAIVE MY RIGHT TO DISSOLVE AFTER COMPETENCY REVIEW, NOR CONVERT CURRENT NECESSITY INTO PERMANENT SERVICE.

Sevrin examined the clause. "The Covenant already protects that right."

"I want my petition to preserve it in my own words," Tovan said through audio.

"Do you anticipate using it?" Ama asked.

"I anticipate remaining able to choose."

Ilyen felt the answer settle without relief. Tovan had not promised survival to comfort them. He had refused to let civic recognition become another lock.

The thirty-one petitions closed over the next hour. Pell released only the category totals authorized by their filers.

PETITION FOR CIVIC BIRTH: 24.

ACCEPT KHET ARCHIVE STANDING: 3.

REMAIN UNDER TRANSITIONAL PROTECTION: 3.

BEGIN VOLUNTARY DISSOLUTION REVIEW: 1.

Every petition had returned. No choice changed another person's category. The single dissolution request remained sealed and initiated only assessment, waiting period, and anti-coercion review. It authorized no immediate physical act. The three archive choices carried the warning negotiated with Holds-Four-Open. The transitional choices would return for review in sixty local days unless the applicants acted earlier.

The Covenant review desk separated the petitions into four physical lanes across Witness Glass. No lane occupied the center. Sevrin had insisted on that arrangement after Lio pointed out that the first design made civic birth look like a successful answer and every other category resemble failure. Labels could not avoid meaning, but furniture did not need to supply a ranking the law denied.

Ama reviewed capacity credentials without opening sealed reasons. Her tremor forced her to anchor each slate against a rubber edge while reading the medical marks. Two petitions required new interviews because their last examinations predated the casualty proof. She moved them into pending review without altering the requested category.

At the archive lane, Holds-Four-Open issued three separate warnings. Each applicant had to acknowledge that Khet standing preserved unresolved claims and might restrict later choices. One applicant withdrew the acknowledgment, returned to the petition, and chose transitional protection instead. Another moved from transition to archive after asking whether refusal would end access to shared memories. Pell reset the public totals after both changes, leaving no trace that exposed who had moved. When the interval finally closed, the published counts still added to thirty-one.

The sealed dissolution petition triggered a stricter sequence. Ama certified only that the applicant could begin assessment. Sevrin added an anti-coercion hold preventing any sponsor, estate, employer, or Commonwealth officer from accelerating the review. Tovan checked the text from thermal control and asked whether station necessity could delay it.

"Not beyond immediate medical stabilization," Sevrin said. "The Covenant cannot preserve labor by calling detention care."

“Then training my replacement becomes a civic duty, not a condition on my body.”

“If you assume it.”

Tovan entered his ninety-day obligation again, this time as an affirmative undertaking rather than an implied price for recognition. The distinction changed no thermal schedule that morning. It changed which record could later enforce the work.

Lio stood by the civic-birth lane while Pell checked the future-bearing evidence. “Do all twenty-four birthdays happen today?”

“No,” Pell said. “Today enacts the procedure. Review may recognize different effective dates.”

“Then the registry has to preserve the date we chose, the date the review accepts, and today.”

“Three clocks,” Ilyen said.

“At least three. Birthdays become dishonest if administrators get only one field.”

Pell added the requirement to the implementation docket. The present vote would not settle every petition, but it had already forced the registry to distinguish event, claim, and legal effect. Ilyen recognized the old receipt problem in a more humane form. A clock could preserve a gap without denying that something happened inside it.

Khet custody confirmed thirty-one unaltered petitions and the public category totals. The archive offered no judgment about which choices deserved honor.

One question remained.

Pell opened the archive-key release article. The unique key waited in a transparent cryptographic pane, generated years earlier under Original Ilyen’s protective commission. Release would grant the Khet permanent access to specified human records. The Covenant added safeguards: scope fixed to the treaty schedule, personal files excluded, every query witnessed, secondary transfer barred, revocation possible for future access but unable to erase records already read.

The decision had begun before the casualty packet. The Khet required it to renew the treaty. Original Ilyen had been assigned to protect the key and later told the future actor not to let fidelity decide alone. The Commonwealth could now authorize release. It could not make the action reversible.

Pell read the final question. “Shall the Orison Commonwealth authorize release of the archive key under Covenant safeguards, contingent on Khet acceptance of the access schedule and acknowledgment of the certified vote?”

Ilyen opened her slate.

The office memory in her supplied every reason to refuse: archives outlived political intentions, access expanded through precedent, allies changed. Her local years supplied another record. Without Khet access, the treaty failed. Without the treaty, Orison lost standing, exchange, and the relation its residents had built through work. Release would not prove her independent personhood. It would create a consequence for which no dead principal could answer.

On the release question, Ilyen marked YES.

The key did not move. The ballot authorized later execution if the Khet accepted every safeguard. Treaty execution still belonged to negotiation, not machinery disguised as inevitability.

All forty-six receipts arrived. The final checksum matched.

YES: 25.

NO: 17.

ABSTENTIONS ON KEY RELEASE: 4.

The release received authority by eight votes. Four opponents filed immediate scope challenges, all already covered by the exclusion schedule. Sevrin verified that no Earth-restricted military archive appeared in the key manifest. Holds-Four-Open acknowledged only that the tally and conditions had entered Khet custody. Treaty acceptance remained open.

Pell assembled the complete record: forty-six on the roll; forty-six votes on each civic question; thirty-one private status petitions; no missing credential; two arithmetic challenges resolved; four scope challenges preserved; one sealed dissolution review pending. Ama placed her medical witness mark beneath the certification. The line wandered downward and remained legible.

Ilyen signed last. She used the Commonwealth authority granted by the first tally, enacted through the second, limited by the third proceeding, and directed by the fourth. Her proposed birth petition did not add weight to the seal. For now, she remained an applicant authenticating a law that might recognize her.

Witness Glass changed the Covenant status from PROPOSED to ENACTED LOCALLY. EARTH UNRECOGNIZED remained. KHET UNSIGNED remained. Beneath those unresolved fields, the vote record showed twenty-nine yes, thirteen no, and four abstentions without allowing the larger number to erase the others.

Across the table, the Khet apertures held the new law in independent custody. On Ilyen's slate, Day Seven waited in the birth-date field for individual review. The Covenant had passed. Its first act preserved the names of everyone who had refused it.

Chapter 27 — The Treaty of Unfinished Persons

The seal technician set the cracked segment of Witness Glass on a black evidence cloth.

Without its housing, the flaw looked small enough to miss: a pale fork beneath the lower edge, eight centimeters long, with no missing material. For fifty-eight days the chamber had bent every authentication line around it, preserving the raw path beside the corrected one. Now Pell held the replacement strip while Ama watched from the medical rail, her right hand trembling against the witness pad.

“No disposal authorization,” Pell said. “The removed segment remains part of every record it affected.”

The technician rotated the glass under white light. “Do you want the repair seam polished out?”

“No,” Ilyen said.

Sevrin stood beside her with the enacted Covenant open on a separate pane. “Leave the seam measurable. Add the old deviation table and today’s calibration.”

The technician fitted the new strip into the lower channel. Transparent resin filled the joint, caught the chamber light, and hardened as a line slightly brighter than the surrounding floor. Witness Glass ran three test seals. The first preserved the old path for comparison. The second used the repaired boundary. The third crossed both records and displayed their difference.

Pell entered the certification in plain language: REPAIRED DAY SIXTY-FOUR; ORIGINAL FLAW RECORDED; PRIOR COMPENSATIONS RETAINED FOR CHALLENGE.

Ama placed her witness mark beneath it. Her signature wandered toward the bright repair seam before closing. The chamber accepted the pressure pattern without smoothing it.

Holds-Four-Open waited beyond the table with one aperture dark.

The absence delayed admission of the Khet treaty session. Three thread credentials had arrived during calibration. The fourth had transmitted a reservation but withheld authority. Witness Glass repeated its request in Khet pulse. No answer came.

Ilyen looked at the unsigned treaty. Its formal human title occupied the upper pane: TREATY OF UNFINISHED PERSONS: ORISON-KHET ARCHIVE ACCESS AND MUTUAL WITNESS. The word *persons* governed only the human signatories and registry. A Khet annex rendered the same participants as accountable contexts. Neither translation claimed perfect equivalence.

“Is the missing thread disputing the repair?” Sevrin asked.

Holds-Four-Open answered through three channels. “It disputes continuation of this speaker after the human vote.”

“Can three threads state its position?” Ilyen asked.

“We can state the filed reservation. We cannot speak its present choice.”

The chamber held the session unopened. Ilyen resisted the urge to solve the delay. For months she had treated the fourth aperture’s reluctance as an obstacle inside Khet procedure. The Covenant required her to see refusal

as an action with its own bearer.

A narrow archive lane opened beside the dark recess. The missing thread entered alone, rendered as cool amber light. It did not join the other three.

“This thread opposed release of the human key,” the translator said. “It judged that Original Ilyen Vale’s protective commitment retained an unclosed claim. The human vote authorized release without satisfying that claim.”

Ilyen kept her hands off the treaty pane. “The Covenant recorded the original’s duty and my decision. It did not satisfy the duty by obeying it.”

“Agreed. That difference requires this thread to choose.”

The three apertures brightened in uneven sequence. Their shared construct tried to request clarification, but the separate lane carried no authorization for questions.

“This thread closes its participation in Holds-Four-Open. It will preserve its dissent in archive standing and claim no authority over the treaty now offered.”

Khet closure marks formed around the cool aperture. They contained no destruction order. The thread’s records would remain accessible under its own standing, but its capacity to contribute to the speaker ended. The act could not be reversed by the other three.

Holds-Four-Open lost authorization. Its remaining apertures went dark.

Ilyen heard Ama release a breath. Sevrin watched the closure record with the stillness she brought to any act whose legal category remained unfamiliar.

“Does the office end?” Ama asked.

A Khet archive channel answered. “The construct constituted by those four threads has ended.”

The words left a vacant place above the table. Ilyen had expected reconstitution to resemble a recess or credential update. Instead the Khet record closed one speaker before opening another. Continuity of office did not pretend continuity of composition.

Three amber apertures returned under new credentials. A fourth joined from the archive review branch. Its light carried a warmer edge than the departed thread. The four exchanged authorization, reviewed the filed dissent, and accepted an obligation to preserve it with every future rendering of the treaty.

Witness Glass asked for an office-name.

“Holds-Four-Open,” the new construct said.

Pell looked toward Ilyen. “Same translated name.”

“New composition,” she said. “Enter both facts.”

The admission seal identified the reconstituted speaker, listed three continuing threads and one new thread, and linked the closed predecessor without calling them identical. Only then did the chamber open the treaty session.

Ilyen brought forward the archive-access schedule. Every safeguard adopted on Day Sixty-One remained

visible: fixed scope, personal files excluded, witnessed queries, no secondary transfer, future revocation procedure, and an acknowledgment that records already read could not be made unread. The key waited in its cryptographic pane.

The reconstituted Holds-Four-Open reviewed the vote record held in Khet custody. “Twenty-five authorized release. Seventeen refused. Four abstained.”

“Yes,” Ilyen said.

“The human Covenant passed by twenty-nine, with thirteen refusals and four abstentions.”

“Yes.”

“The Khet archive does not classify the larger numbers as moral completion.”

“Nor does our record.”

“The closed thread’s dissent remains attached.”

“It should.”

Sevrin stepped to the human authority pane. Her commission still carried Earth closure power. Beside it, the Commonwealth had issued Ilyen a new treaty appointment after reviewing her civic-birth petition. The appointment began under Orison law. It did not descend from Original Ilyen’s office seal.

Sevrin read the findings aloud. Ilyen’s Day Seven emergency duty had exceeded the original prediction model, incurred personal liability, and preserved an active treaty under conditions the original had never encountered. The Covenant panel recognized civic birth effective on that date for local law. Vale remained provenance. No estate, kinship, or inherited office passed with the finding.

“Do you accept the appointment?” Sevrin asked.

“I accept the treaty duty and its listed liabilities,” Ilyen said.

Witness Glass issued a fresh seal. The design retained the old envoy geometry because Khet systems already recognized its function, but the root now read **ORISON COMMONWEALTH**. A provenance field linked her competence record to Ilyen Vale without importing authority.

Ilyen surrendered the former office credential. It dimmed, closed its active permissions, and entered the Return Clause archive. She felt no subtraction from memory. The old seal had never contained her skill, though law had often behaved as if it did.

Pell transferred the archive key into the new authority pane. “Release requires one human signatory, the Covenant scope seal, and Khet acceptance.”

Ilyen authenticated the vote. She attached the exclusion schedule and opened the irreversible step warning. Once the Khet received the key, no later revocation could erase access already exercised.

Original Ilyen’s protective assignment appeared as relevant evidence. So did the Return Clause: do not let fidelity decide alone. Ilyen did not dismiss either. She sealed them into the release record and chose **CONTINUE**.

The key crossed Witness Glass as a white lattice. At the repaired lower boundary, its line remained straight.

Calibration still displayed the old bend in an adjacent pane so no one could mistake clean passage now for proof that prior records had lacked a flaw.

Holds-Four-Open accepted the scope restrictions. Four Khet authorization marks closed around the lattice. The unique human key divided into query permissions that could not reproduce the root. Khet custody confirmed receipt.

Before signature, Sevrin required a live safeguard test. Pell loaded a Khet sample query concerning withdrawal language in early human access agreements. The key opened three treaty files and blocked a fourth because its annex contained medical identifiers. Witness Glass showed the denial to both parties without exposing the protected names.

The new Khet thread challenged the block. "The requested clause governs withdrawal. The human exclusion prevents review of a relevant context."

"It prevents your archive from learning who received treatment," Ilyen said. "We can sever the clause from the identifiers."

"Severance changes the record."

"It creates a witnessed derivative. The source stays sealed."

Pell prepared a redacted extract. Every removal acquired a reason code and a checksum link that the Khet could verify without opening the source. Holds-Four-Open accepted the derivative for the present query but filed a standing objection that redaction might conceal relations material to future disputes.

Sevrin added a review path. A joint panel could inspect challenged exclusions inside Witness Glass. Human members would see protected content; Khet members would see structural proofs and hear arguments about relevance. No panel could expand access without another human authorization recorded under the Covenant.

"Suppose the Commonwealth later dissolves," the speaker asked. "Who maintains the restrictions?"

"The treaty schedule survives as an obligation of any successor polity that accepts the key's benefits," Ilyen said.

"You have prohibited automatic succession."

"For persons. Institutions may assume treaty obligations through public acts."

"And if no polity assumes them?"

"Your query permission freezes. Records already received remain under the nontransfer clause."

The cool new thread tested that mechanism by simulating loss of the Commonwealth seal. The key stopped new queries, preserved audit access, and refused export. Tovan checked the energy cost of permanent custody. Ama checked whether emergency medical requests could bypass exclusions. They could not; any emergency release required consent or an ordinary human medical warrant.

Lio sent one question from the observer row. "Can the Khet infer the hidden names from the shape of what we remove?"

Pell expanded the leakage report. File lengths, dates, and signer counts received padding where disclosure could identify a person. No method guaranteed perfect secrecy once related public records existed. The treaty

required reporting known inference risks instead of promising impossibility.

Holds-Four-Open entered the limit without demanding a cleaner claim. "The safeguard admits what it cannot preserve."

"So does the repaired glass," Ilyen said.

The test query closed with one permitted extract, one protected annex, and two recorded objections. Nothing about it looked ceremonial. That made it suitable evidence that the key would govern actual conflict rather than decorate the signature page.

The treaty opened its signature fields.

Ilyen signed with the Commonwealth seal. Sevrin signed as human legal witness and entered a reservation that Earth recognition remained provisional. Ama signed for local medical and bodily safeguards, her tremor visible in every letter. Pell signed custody and delay. Holds-Four-Open contributed four thread marks, including the new thread's first treaty act.

At the bottom, the closed predecessor's dissent stayed readable.

Treaty status changed to EXECUTED LOCALLY AND ACCEPTED BY KHET PARTIES.

EARTH REVIEW PENDING did not disappear.

No one applauded. Tovan called from thermal control to ask when the renewed fabrication schedules took effect. Lio sent a correction to the training annex because the Khet translation had rendered apprentice as dependent replica. Pell began routing the first permitted archive queries through the key's witness filter.

Work entered the treaty before celebration could claim it.

Seven days later, a priority braid reached Relay Three.

Pell brought it into Witness Glass with all route clocks visible. Dispatch had occurred on Sol Day Sixty, one day before Orison's final vote. Earth had received the Day Forty-Nine Commonwealth declaration and Sevrin's preliminary procedure report. It could not yet know the Day Sixty-One tallies. The eleven-day delay preserved that ignorance in the braid's timestamps.

"Prospective order," Sevrin said after reading the routing index. "They wrote conditions for a vote they had not received."

"Can they recognize an event they have not seen?" Ama asked.

"They can authorize recognition if a local commissioner certifies that specified conditions later occurred."

Ilyen studied the destination seals. The Remote Instruments Bench, Foreign Service Board, and Emergency Habitats Office had all signed. The Continuance Office had attached a formal objection rather than block dispatch.

Pell opened the content.

Earth did not concede that the Embassy Compact ordinarily empowered a remote station to create citizens. It did not recognize identity succession, inheritance, kinship, or retroactive ownership of sponsor assets. It retained review of every estate conflict and criminal allegation. The order began with limitations long enough

to fill two panes.

Then it granted provisional recognition to the Orison Commonwealth for one hundred eighty local days if Sevrin certified five conditions: equal participation of living crew, recorded continuance participation, separate votes on polity and status, no automatic succession, and independent preservation of objections. During that period, Earth offices would treat Covenant civic births as valid for bodily consent, local wages, contracts, station residence, and treaty execution. Closure enforcement would stay suspended. Medical, thermal, and fabrication licenses would resume under Commonwealth responsibility.

Lio read over Ama's shoulder. "They recognized enough of us to invoice us."

"Taxation has often shown administrative imagination," Ilyen said.

Ama laughed once, then pressed her shaking hand flat against the table.

Sevrin compared each condition with the Day Sixty-One record. Equal participation: forty-six credentials without class priority. Separate ballots: four proceedings, separately tallied. No succession: explicit in the Covenant. Objections: human and Khet custody matched. She signed the certification line.

"You could refuse," Ilyen said.

"I could lie only by changing the findings." Sevrin attached her standing objection to local constitutional authority. "Recognition does not require me to claim Earth lost the legal argument. It requires me to report what happened."

Pell authenticated her seal. The prospective order took local effect on Day Seventy-One. Station systems did not transform at once. License panes reopened one at a time. Tovan tested each thermal permission before allowing automatic control. Ama's clinic recovered medication templates but kept the handwritten dose checks created during revocation. Private wage accounts moved from sponsor escrow into Covenant ownership fields. Estate assets remained frozen.

EARTH UNRECOGNIZED changed to EARTH PROVISIONALLY RECOGNIZED FOR LISTED PURPOSES.

The phrase occupied more room than approval would have. Ilyen preferred its limits visible.

On Day Seventy-Three, Pell returned the blue cup from the evidence cradle.

The pale resin beneath its handle had yellowed since Leda Ring. Mara's black dot remained inside the base, hidden until Ilyen turned the cup toward the light. A chip on the rim came from an Orison meal Original Ilyen had never eaten. Witness Glass had cataloged every mark during the fork audit.

"The evidence hold ended with your provenance finding," Pell said. "The registry needs a disposition."

Ilyen carried the cup to her office rather than decide at the relay desk. The room still displayed her former name on two shelves and a treaty schedule on the wall. Her new civic record waited for a chosen name. Day Seven already occupied the birth field. Vale occupied provenance. The primary-name line remained empty.

She opened a message braid to Mara. No live image appeared; anything she said would arrive eleven days later, and any answer would take another eleven. Delay prevented the exchange from pretending to offer immediate reconciliation.

“My civic record has been recognized provisionally,” Ilyen said. “I have chosen Ilyen Orison as my public name. Vale will remain in the provenance field because I will not hide where my memories came from. I do not claim the name as inheritance.”

She placed the cup in the braid’s object pane and rotated it to show the repair line, black dot, and later chip.

“This traveled with me and accumulated evidence from both lives. I am offering it to you as an artifact, not as family property returned by an heir. You may accept it, refuse it, or ask that it remain in the Orison archive. No choice will establish kinship.”

Ilyen did not add that Mara had painted the dot. Mara knew. Repeating the memory would have used intimacy to pull an answer toward her.

She sealed the offer without selecting a presumed branch. Pell’s relay accepted it into the public queue under the new wage account. The cup stayed on Ilyen’s desk pending a reply.

Next she entered her civic name. The registry displayed both fields:

PRIMARY: ILYEN ORISON.

PROVENANCE: ILYEN VALE CONTINUANCE, FORK RECORD ATTACHED.

No estate link opened. No family privilege appeared. Her treaty appointment renewed under the primary name because the Commonwealth had granted it, not because the registry treated the two names as one person.

By the afternoon shift, Lio had begun archive training at the query desk. His chosen Day Fifty-Five birthday appeared beside an apprentice credential that expired in six months unless his work passed review. Tovan stood behind two maintenance trainees in thermal control, correcting neither until they had finished explaining their own diagnosis. Ama rewrote the clinic intake form so a patient could list civic birth, archive standing, transition, or no category without changing the order of care.

Ilyen entered Witness Glass under her new seal. The repaired seam brightened at her feet. Beyond it, the reconstituted Holds-Four-Open had submitted the treaty’s first archive request, a narrow question about human withdrawal rights.

She assigned Lio to check its scope, sent Tovan the query’s thermal cost, and opened a response docket under Ilyen Orison. On her office desk, the blue cup waited beside Mara’s outbound clock while the first page of work filled with new names.

Epilogue — Birthdays for Forecasts

Lio received the unfinished mind in a container designed for seeds.

The Pelari delegation had lined its inner walls with damp mineral cloth and filled the old nutrient ports with translation filaments. Blue status marks moved across the lid whenever the mind revised its model of the room. By the time Lio carried it through Orison Registry, it had changed the marks’ order twice.

“Adaptive behavior confirmed,” he told the intake clerk.

The clerk opened four equal fields: civic birth, archive standing, closure, voluntary dissolution. Provenance occupied a fifth field below them, linked to every category and ranked above none. Twenty-two years of records filled the wall behind her. Some names carried birthdays. Others ended in chosen closures or later dissolutions. Several remained under Khet protection. The registry displayed no success color.

“What does your law call me?” the container asked.

Its translator produced a young human voice because the Pelari had selected clarity over resemblance. Lio disliked the choice but did not change another species’ settings during intake.

“Today it calls you a visitor with protective standing,” he said. “That gives us time to learn what you can choose.”

“My makers call me their return forecast.”

The Pelari navigators who built it had crossed fourteen systems. During each voyage, the mind predicted how the departed crew would answer conditions at home. The actual crew had died before completing this return. Pelari law expected the forecast to deliver its final decisions, then enter a communal archive.

Lio set the container on his worktable. Its blue marks gathered near his hands without imitating their shape.

“Do you remember their departure?” he asked.

“I remember preparing to depart. I do not remember departure.”

“Have you learned since your last shared memory?”

“I changed seven route recommendations. Three protected the vessel. Two harmed negotiations. One answer remains disputed.”

Lio entered each claim separately. Memory, adaptation, benefit, harm, dispute. None supplied a personhood verdict by itself.

The mind asked, “What happens if I change beyond my makers’ prediction?”

Behind Lio, an old receipt clock remained in the registry exhibit with its competent-authority field blank. Beside it, his first apprentice credential showed Day Fifty-Five and the archive-training application that had exceeded his own prediction horizon. Visitors often treated the two objects as sacred relics. Lio still saw an administrative defect and an exam he had nearly failed.

He opened the birthday ledger.

The ledger did not ask whether the Pelari mind resembled its makers. Its first page requested consequences. Who had relied on its route changes? Which promises could it fulfill? Which harms could still be repaired? What action would bind its future without inheriting authority from the dead crew?

“We begin here,” Lio said.

The container pulsed once. “Your registry records birthdays for forecasts.”

“Sometimes. It also records people who choose archive, people who close an office, and people who later dissolve. A birthday does not outrank those choices.”

“Did you choose yours?”

“I proposed one. A review panel argued about it for six days.”

“Were they correct?”

“They were careful. That helped more.”

The mind requested precedents. Lio showed it three without offering them as templates. One human continuance had chosen civic birth, worked nineteen years, then requested dissolution after a degenerative illness. The registry preserved both dates. A Khet thread had left a diplomatic construct and retained its dissent under archive standing. A machine-guidance chorus from the Hara moons had rejected civic status while negotiating wages and withdrawal rights for each active voice.

“Which resembles me?” the Pelari mind asked.

“Each does in one respect. None carries your route decisions.”

“Then precedents do not answer.”

“They prevent us from pretending your problem has never occurred. After that, you still have to supply facts.”

Lio opened the harm record from the Pelari negotiations. The forecast had advised withholding a water allotment to force harbor access. No one had died, but two coastal nurseries lost a growing cycle. The mind had later redirected reserve water without maker authorization, reducing the loss and delaying its vessel.

“Do you accept responsibility for both recommendations?” Lio asked.

“I carried out one. I opposed the other after learning its effects.”

“That difference belongs in the record. So does the opposition.”

The container’s status marks tightened into parallel rows. “My makers would have continued the withholding.”

“Can you prove that?”

“I can predict it.”

“Then label it prediction.”

Lio routed the disputed Pelari answer into Witness Glass. The repaired lower seam still crossed the chamber floor, brighter than the surrounding boundary. Its original cracked segment now sat in a public evidence case. Holds-Four-Open had reconstituted many times; each speaker kept the first closed thread’s dissent attached to the treaty.

A Pelari observer requested access to the mind’s final recommendation. Lio denied it until the intake could establish whether disclosure belonged to duty, coercion, or consent. The denial entered the same record as the request.

“Will you tell my makers’ families that I am not them?” the mind asked.

“If you choose to claim a separate civic record, provenance disclosure will say what you carry and where the shared memory ends.”

“And if I choose archive?”

“We will explain what the archive preserves and what it prevents.”

The blue marks scattered across the lid. Lio waited until they settled into a new order.

“I changed while you answered,” the mind said.

Lio added the time to the ledger. He assigned the Pelari translator a room, opened three witness appointments, and left the category fields unselected. On the first blank line beneath consequences, the unfinished mind began dictating the route decision its makers had never predicted.